

Brief statement of
your decision

Optional. You may tell Mr. Mohr that Ms. True ranks highest of the three candidates, or wait to tell this in the terminal section. Your choice will depend on what you think Mr. Mohr prefers.

When you put these five elements into words and sentences, you might have an introductory paragraph such as one of the following:

On July 25 you asked that I prepare an evaluation of candidates for the position of your retiring teller. That analysis is complete, and the following report is my response. On the basis of four criteria (company test scores, screening of initial applications, personal interview with each applicant, and recommendations from references), 3 candidates have been chosen from the 15 who applied. In evaluating the candidates, I have placed major emphasis on (1) education and skills, (2) personal qualifications, and (3) probable permanency. In view of my analysis, Ms. True ranks high for consideration.

[For the reader who will resist your deductively stated decision, you may wish to move inductively, as in the following:]

Following these opening comments is the report you requested on July 25 concerning the evaluation of candidates for a teller as a replacement for the employee who is resigning. Four criteria were used in selecting the final candidates: company test scores, screening of initial applicants, personal interview with each candidate, and recommendations from references. Three of the fifteen applicants met these criteria: Ms. Helen True, Mr. James Mace, and Miss Beth Astor. Additionally, on the basis of their education and skills, personal qualifications, and probable permanency, these names come to you for consideration as probable employees with our bank.

Main Divisions of the Body or Text

You will use three main sections for your text—one for each criterion. You will study the working table and analyze the facts. If your reader wants all the details, you will include each table section or a variation of it within the text. Assume that you now decide to change the sequence of the sections within the table. “Probable Permanency” will be placed first; “Education and Skills,” second; “Personal Qualifications,” third.

The following discussion concentrates on the section labeled “Probable Permanency.” Your procedure for the other two sections will of course be similar. What are the most important facts you can pull from the table? Avoid saying in sentence form before or after a table everything that is already in the table; repe-

tition wastes time and is monotonous. After careful thought you might write a paragraph such as this to place before the table:

Ms. Helen True's experience and her previous job responsibilities show a background and future potential for a greater degree of permanence with our organization than either Mr. Mace or Ms. Astor. The following table shows that both Mr. Mace and Ms. Astor might have a greater tendency to leave, since they have less stable past employment records and they do not possess the excellent health that is preferable for the teller work.

After the table you might include such comments as:

Mr. Mace rates as a second choice. His two jobs in 6 years and good health are a better record than that for Ms. Astor. Also in his favor is the fact that he plans to make a career of working with people.

Terminal (Closing) Section

Clearly, you now face the decision of whether to choose a summary (condensation of information) or conclusions (evaluation and inferences). Adhere to Mr. Mohr's preference! Remember, he asked you to present your evaluation, but he clearly wants to make his own decision. Therefore, your terminal section should include conclusions, not merely a summary. Omit the recommendations.

The following illustration (Memo Report 4) shows one of several ways this completed report may be worded. It is presented on your bank's memo stationery, addressed to Mr. Gene Mohr, without his title as manager of the head office savings department. This title could, however, be included if company policy so dictates or when the organization is large enough to justify a title for clarification.

MEMO REPORT 4 *A personnel department officer's analytical report (with conclusions only) to a savings department director.*

MEMORANDUM [bank name]

TO: Mr. Gene Mohr DATE: March 15, 199-

FROM: [your name]

SUBJECT: Evaluation of Three Teller Applicants

Here is the report you requested concerning the choice of a replacement for your teller who is resigning. On the basis of information obtained from applications, test scores, personal interviews, and recommendations from references, I have selected 3 out of 15 applicants for your final consideration. Of these 3, I feel that Ms. Helen True best meets the job requirements of permanency, education and skills, and basic personal qualifications, as discussed below.

Probable Permanency

Ms. Helen True's background of experience and previous job responsibilities indicate potential for a greater degree of permanence with our organization than either Mr. Mace or Ms. Astor. The following table shows that both Mr. Mace and Ms. Astor have less stable past employment records and that they do not possess the excellent health that is preferable for the teller work.

Criterion	Helen True	James Mace	Beth Astor
Experience	11 years	6 years	3 years
Previous jobs	1 firm	2 firms	3 firms
Health	Excellent	Good	Fair
Attendance record	Excellent	Good	Fair (irregular in 2 firms)

Mr. Mace rates as second choice. His two jobs in 6 years and good health are a much better record than that for Ms. Astor. Also in his favor is the fact that he plans to make a career of working with people.

Education and Skills

On the basis of education and skills, Ms. Astor is an outstanding applicant. The table below provides facts in which Ms. Astor ranks consistently higher than the other two in education, grades, and skills.

Criterion	Helen True	James Mace	Beth Astor
Education	H.S. graduate; 1 year business college	H.S. graduate	H.S. graduate; 1 year university
Grade-point average	3.0 H.S.	2.6 H.S.	3.2 H.S.; 3.1 university
Arithmetic aptitude	Excellent	Good	Excellent
Typing	60 wpm	50 wpm	65 wpm
H.S. grade in machines	Grade B	Grade C	Grade A

Although Ms. True's results are not as high as those of Ms. Astor, she shows a more-than-adequate

proficiency in her skills. She should prove just as efficient and capable as Ms. Astor in a teller's position.

Personal Qualifications

Mainly on the basis of references from past employers, Ms. True has the personality that best fits the performance and image of the position. As the following table shows, she is the only applicant of the three who has excellent references with no additional qualifying statements by those references.

Criterion	Helen True	James Mace	Beth Astor
Dependability	Excellent	Good	Fair, but good worker
Compatibility	Excellent	Good	Fair; difficulty working with others
Appearance	Neat and well-groomed	Fairly neat; well-groomed	Very neat; well-groomed

The references of Ms. Astor are somewhat disturbing because of former employers' comments about her ability to get along with her coworkers.

Conclusions

1. Ms. Helen True is the best-qualified to fill your teller vacancy. She rates highest in degree of expected permanence and in personal qualifications for the job. Although her professional ability does not rank highest of the three applicants, she ranks second and indicates a more-than-adequate proficiency.
2. Mr. James Mace rates as a good second choice, mainly on the basis of his expected permanence and his compatibility. Although he does not rank as high on skill and grades as either of the other two applicants, his education and scores indicate that he can perform the job adequately.
3. Because of the questions raised in her references, I feel Ms. Beth Astor is definitely in third place among these three candidates for this position. Other less desirable factors are her "fair" health and the uncertainty of her permanency with our organization. Her outstanding professional ability is too greatly outweighed by these two factors.

While the above memorandum report does not specifically recommend that Ms. True be hired, Mr. Mohr could infer that recommendation. It is now his decision—in light of the presented analysis—to take final action.

Recommendation-Justification Reports

Persuasion is central to recommendation reports.

Many of your analytical reports will have a special purpose: to recommend a change or remain with the status quo (policy), support the idea that something is desirable or undesirable (value), or defend the accuracy of information (fact). Your report may be in response to a specific request, or it may be voluntary.

Consider the following four items when preparing sections of a problem-solution or recommendation report.

Introduction

Give thought to an opening line (somewhat like standing on a porch before entering a house); be precise as to the aim or purpose—this could be a restatement of the subject line—along with a brief authorization; and end with a brief statement on the report's organization (layout or road map of what you will cover) of included material. In a real sense you are laying the foundation for the report, getting started, holding attention.

Body (Text, Discussion)

Do not move too quickly toward a solution or recommendation. First, analyze the situation or problem. Second, do not presume that everyone agrees that a problem truly exists. Thus your opening information may include evidence on the current situation, along with undesirable effects. Only after you have proved the existence of a problem can you move toward a recommendation. Headings such as the following are popular in text sections:

- Current state of the problem
- Effects and causes of the problem
- Possible options to remove the problem
- Criteria in evaluating a solution
- Recommended solution (*if requester of report desires this*)

Terminal Section (Conclusion, Recommendation)

Be brief in this section. Include a short summary of major points and the recommendations, usually numbered consecutively.

Organizational Plans

Recommendation-justification reports may be organized in one of two ways. In the following examples, Memo Report 5 (deductive) and Memo Report 6 (inductive) can be used if the reader may react negatively toward a recommendation; in that case, present your facts first, then the recommendation.

Interestingly, not everyone will agree that a problem truly exists. Your task—even in the informative material in the body—is to suggest that there is a problem.

Know the wishes of your report requester: Does he or she want the recommendation up front or near the end? Most prefer up front.

The discussion section in any of these reports usually is 50 to 75 percent of the entire body.

MEMO REPORT 5 *A deductive plan; note up-front recommendation.*

TO: Board of Directors, [company name]
FROM: Dave Allen, Senior Vice President-
Tobacco Products
SUBJECT: Recommended expansion of [name] into
Western Samoa
DATE: June 5, 199-

RECOMMENDATION

PURCHASE THE EXISTING CIGARETTE FACTORY ON WESTERN
SAMOA AS PART OF OUR PACIFIC RIM EXPANSION PLAN

INTRODUCTION

The company produces and internationally markets tobacco products, packaged food, and distilled and brewed beverages. Last year [name] made \$1.209 billion on \$15.766 billion in sales.

Today's proposal is part of our overall plan to dominate Pacific Rim tobacco markets within 5 years.

PROPOSAL

Fact: Negotiations are currently in progress that will allow U.S. tobacco companies limited access to the Chinese market within 1 to 2 years.

Fact: 50% of Chinese males smoke—a market of 439 million customers, or almost twice the population of the United States.

Strategy: Develop a tobacco industry in the Pacific Islands that will foster indigenous consumption while developing sufficient capacity to supply the Chinese market.

Criteria: 1. Find a stable political and ecological climate.
2. Ensure a consistent supply of quality leaf.
3. Locate near major trade routes.
4. Develop a model easily adaptable to other islands.

THE ISLAND OF WESTERN SAMOA MEETS THE
ABOVE CRITERIA

BACKGROUND

[Included here is data on the country]

SATISFYING THE CRITERIA

1. Politically and ecologically stable . . .
2. Some leaf is already grown on Western Samoa . . .
3. Western Samoa is near several major shipping lanes . . .

RATIONALE FOR PURCHASE OF FACTORY

1. An existing factory and work force are already in place.
2. Small scale will allow for experimentation in the model.
3. Greater tobacco plants will stabilize economy.
4. Greater value of tobacco will provide more taxes.

The Company should enter into negotiations with the government of Western Samoa to purchase its cigarette factory. Using the Samoan model that we will build, *[company]* can island-hop to develop a strong tobacco trade in the Pacific Islands.

MEMO REPORT 6 *Recommendation for change in communication procedure (inductive plan).*

November 10, 199-

TO: David Bank, Unit Manager
FROM: Marianne Clauw
SUBJECT: Inefficient Communication Between Data Processing and Consulting Departments

As you requested on October 1, I have investigated the state of communication between the Consulting Department and the Data Processing (D.P.) Department. Six months ago our company formed an internal consulting department to interface between the D.P. Department and the departments that use data processing services.

Current Situation

Since the formation of the Consulting Department, the consultants have complained that their communication with D.P. personnel is inadequate. The recent relocation of the D.P. Department to Flint aggravated the problem since the consultants remain

in our Detroit office. The following are some problems that resulted.

Problems

1. The interoffice mail turnaround is approximately 3 days, which makes it inappropriate for urgent messages.
2. D.P. personnel are difficult to reach by phone because they are frequently away from their desks.
3. There is no message-taking procedure in the D.P. Department.
4. D.P. personnel state that they are unable to service user needs efficiently because the needs are not communicated in a timely fashion.

Conclusion and Recommendations

To provide efficient service to the user departments, timely communications between the consultants and the D.P. personnel are necessary. Implementing the following recommendations will facilitate quick and efficient communication between the departments.

1. Assign a receptionist to the D.P. Department to answer the phone, sort interoffice mail, and page persons who are called.
2. Strongly encourage all personnel to acknowledge phone messages and return phone calls the same day.
3. Institute special daily facsimile services to handle written communications between the D.P. Department and the Consulting Department. Also use facsimile machines daily to transmit documents between the Detroit consultants and the Flint D.P. personnel.

Guidelines for writing analytical memorandum reports are cited in Checklist 11.4 on the following page.

In summary, informational memorandum reports seek to inform; recommendation or analytical reports intend to either recommend or analyze.

LETTER REPORTS—INFORMATIONAL AND ANALYTICAL

Letter report formats are similar to traditional business letters, more often sent to persons outside the organization.

A letter report is simply a report in letter form; it is often used when sending information to a reader outside your organization. It includes:

- Date
- Inside address

■ Checklist 11.4 Analytical Memorandum Reports

1. Introduction

- a. Determine whether you are to recommend a solution or simply analyze a series of alternatives.
- b. Determine whether your reader desires the deductive (recommendation first) or the inductive (recommendation last) approach to reports.

2. Body (Text, Discussion)

- a. Use the suggestions for the seven-C principles discussed in Chapter 2.
- b. Use sentences about 16 to 20 words in length; sentences should consist of concrete nouns, few adjectives and adverbs. Paragraphs should be about seven typed lines in length.
- c. Use a structure similar to the traditional problem-solution format.

3. Terminal (Closing) Section

- a. If you are asked for more than one conclusion or recommendation, number them.
- b. If your evidence is well thought out, your conclusions should logically follow from that evidence.
- c. If you know or do not know the receivers of your report, end with courtesy: You would be willing to meet for further oral discussions.

- Salutation
- Body (the heart of the report)
- Complimentary close
- Signature
- Reference section

Often the letter report has a subject line, usually placed a line or two below the salutation. Its length may range from two to five (seldom more) pages. And it may have two purposes: informational or analytical.

We said that the general format of the letter report is like that of a letter. Its body (text, discussion) requires some special qualities.

1. *The first paragraph* may include some of the following elements found in an introduction:

Pleasant greeting and authorization (*mention date and name of person making request*).

Purpose, aim (*always*)

Problem, issues (*if problem exists*)

Conclusions, statement of results (*optional*)

Layout, road map, plan of presentation (*depends on length of report*)

■ Communication Probe

Certainly visuals can add to the clarity of complex statistics. Additionally, there is the question of style. And regardless of the form of writing—from succinct E-mail statements to short or long reports, style can impact the finished product. Disabuse yourself of the idea that the formats and rules of writing for clarity are new. They're not. You, and your authors, who write and communicate orally in the business world and elsewhere have a historical debt to the ancient Greeks and Romans. Although their world was primarily oral, we can learn the lessons of clarity, for reports and other forms of communication, directly from them. A significant source is *Essays on Classical Rhetoric and Modern Discourse*.

See two significant statements on the impact of rhetoric. Lunsford, A. (1976, October). Classical rhetoric and technical writing. *College Composition and Communication*, 27, 289–291; Halloran, S. M., & Bradford, A. M. (1984). Figures of speech in the rhetoric of science and technology. In R. J. Connors, L. S. Ede, & A. A. Lunsford (eds.), *Essays on classical rhetoric and modern discourse* (pp. 179–192). Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press.

Examples

- a. This note responds to your request of January 25 that I collect information on the plans of the German chemical company BASF expanding into Austria.
- b. In response to the Executive Board's request, our committee discovered six causes for high employee turnover in our foreign subsidiaries. Likewise, we considered four options to decrease the problem. One of those options is recommended for the board's consideration.
- c. Thanks for your recent fax; it was good to receive your greeting. We'll be happy to summarize our new advertising campaign—just approved—for this next fiscal year. That information is included in the following several pages.

Regardless of your reader, end politely, show a willingness to respond to further questions or to meet if that is desirable.

- 2. *The middle paragraphs* of the text should present objectively, without emotional appeals, all pertinent facts—both favorable and unfavorable. Sources and methods should be mentioned along with emphasis on findings or results. Headings, visual aids, and transitional sentences are also included wherever desirable.
- 3. *The last paragraph* brings the letter report to a pleasant, friendly close, as for letters. If you need to conclude or recommend, do so just before

the last paragraph. If appropriate, offer to discuss further or to come to the reader's office.

Informational Letter Reports

LETTER REPORT 1 *A staff report to the chief financial officer regarding issues concerning personnel turnover in the engineering department of a foreign subsidiary.*

Dear Mr. Powell:

You asked an ad hoc personnel committee here in New Zealand to address the question of how the high turnover rate in the engineering department is affecting our quality rating with the local chemical companies. Our committee has finished its review and submits the following report for your consideration.

Causes for Turnover

After four consecutive years of 20% turnover in the engineering department, we have determined that the main cause of the excessive turnover lies with compensation. . .

The following comparative table summarizes the major findings:

Salary Costs for Engineers, June 199-					
Company	Low	High	Width	Average Wage	Turnover
X	\$24,000	\$35,000	40%	\$30,000	20%
Y	\$25,000	\$38,000	52%	\$31,500	10%
Z	\$26,000	\$40,000	60%	\$32,500	7%
Market	\$25,333	\$39,333	55%	\$32,333	8%

Solving Issue of Engineer Turnover

A two-step method for reducing turnover may be considered. The first is to increase the average salaries engineers receive. Considering your goal for producing a quality product, we should offer a salary to the engineers above the market rate.

These alternative levels are: 3% above market, 5% above market, or 8% above market.

[Further details presented.]

A possible second step is to increase the average range of the salaries for the engineers. We suggest raising it from the current \$25,000-\$35,000 to a new level of \$30,000-\$43,000. This new range maximum will allow for salary increases to the four existing engineers who have reached their current range maximum.

Benefits of Accepting the Proposal

1. Save funds needed in recruiting, training, and overtime costs. *[Statistics included]*
2. Stabilize turnover in the engineering department.
3. Place our company in a position to allow it to achieve higher-quality ratings with the local chemical companies.
4. Allow us to more actively recruit qualified personnel for the engineering department.

Conclusion

Two options are presented for your consideration: (1) increase the engineering salaries from a current range of \$25,000-\$35,000 to \$30,000-\$43,000; (2) increase the average salary of the current engineers.

[One final paragraph concludes the letter, including courtesy comments and a willingness to respond to further questions.]

Analytical Letter Reports

Short reports from overseas are frequently in the form of a letter report, either as hard copy or E-mail.

Often used in letter reports is the problem-solution format. For example, an outside consultant to a company is asked to investigate an issue or a perceived problem. That final report may be submitted in letter-report form. You may also represent your company on an outside board and would write that group an analytical letter report in response to a specific request. One example of an analytical letter report (deductive in format) from an American overseas follows.

LETTER REPORT 2 *An American expatriate's analytical letter on problems faced in Germany; the salutation is "Dear Ted."*

You asked us in your fax of April 10 to tell you what problems the eight of us faced in adapting to

■ Communication Probe

It is clear that when ending (inductive) or beginning (deductive) a report with a precise recommendation, persuasion is involved. Analytical reports often involve a discussion of a problem, a review of options—or alternatives—and a recommendation. Alternatives can be used persuasively. For instance, writers intending to persuade, in a report or other persuasive document, can pose two alternatives, either of which is acceptable to the writer. The receiver, says one study, is likely to choose one of those two alternatives. Clearly, the receiver may also choose the unwritten option; that is, he or she may not like either alternative. Likewise, when laying out alternatives, it is useful to consider one highly positive alternative and several nonpositive, the writer giving more positive effort to the recommendation or alternative.

Gilsdorf, J. W. (1991, March). Write me your best case for . . . *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 53(1), 7–12.

work in Germany and to give you suggested changes in preparing Americans for an overseas assignment.

[Present here the core recommendation(s). Present problems if those are not known.]

Benefits

All of us feel that our productivity would improve if the preceding recommendations are accepted. Our families would more quickly become involved. We would know issues early. We would not be as surprised.

Ted, you asked for our brief statement on better preparing us as Americans to work in Europe. Although I wrote the letter, the ideas represent the thinking of the eight of us and our spouses. We look forward to your reaction and response.

SUMMARY

Short reports are basically of two types: informational and analytical. Although there may be overlapping between the two types, the former is more neutral, more unbiased; the latter is more analytical, more persuasive. Both types may be short, and both can be sent via the mails, faxes, or even E-mail. Regardless of the medium chosen, they possess a classical organization of introduction, body or text, and a terminal section. Just as their contents can vary widely, so too can their format and the visual appearance and placement of their headings. All depend on purpose, audience, problems, complexity of the subject matter, and other significant concerns.

■ Communication Probe

Both scholarly and trade publications are increasingly pointing out the merits of software packages in collecting data, organizing data, and reporting of that data, in reports. As companies downsize, there is a growing realization that software packages can do much of the data analysis prior to submitting a report. Professionals who are testing the various packages often come away awarding those packages high marks, often in human resource areas and financial data collection. There is little doubt that in long reports the use of the computer will become increasingly more prominent.

Hemmerick, S. (1995, May). Rave review for software. *Pensions and Investments*, 23, 30; Santosus, M. (1995, May). Personnel matters. *CIO*, 8, 44–52; The, L. (1995, May). On line analytical processing (ONLAP). *Datamation*, 41, 65–67.

A letter report carries its own meaning: a report sent in the format of a letter. Often this form is used when writers are outside the company, as in a foreign location. Increasingly, the letter report is used within companies.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Short Informative Report Sent Back to the Home Office.** Assume for the moment that you are stationed in a foreign country; you choose the country. Your vice president (more clearly than most) of International Marketing in the United States makes this request:

Please send me pertinent information concerning the economic state, the political situation, the competitive environment, and the labor market of country X. I need just a brief introductory report before we go into more detail. I would appreciate receiving that information within the next couple of days.

Using the above as a request, compose a brief report that responds to her questions. Additionally, your report should include the three basic parts of a report: introduction, body or text, and a terminal section.

2. **A Recommendation-Justification Report Sent Back to the Home Office.** You can, for this assignment, use the same country for assignment 1 above or select another country of your choice. Here are the requirements for this assignment:

Subject: Presenting a recommendation-justification memorandum concerning a foreign country investment

Goal of assignment:

1. To recommend whether a company (of your choice) should establish a subsidiary in a foreign country
2. To give evidence in your report of individual research and secondary information that clearly supports your final recommendation
3. To present copies of your memorandum to all members of the class

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Review of the Opening Letter of an Annual Report.** Select an annual report of your choice. You will note that in large corporations either the CEO or president—sometimes both—sign the opening statement within that annual report. It is written for stockholders and others interested in the corporation. Let's be honest: Some of those opening letters are the work of outside public relations firms, each trying to capture the intent of the executives signing the letter. Yet, the executives are responsible for both content and style.

Your task in an informative memorandum report is to do the following:

- a. Analyze the introduction; set your own criteria as to whether the opening statement captures the attention or interest of the reader.
 - b. Determine whether there is a clear specific purpose.
 - c. Is there a road map, an agenda, a layout included in either the letter or the complete annual report?
 - d. Are there clearly organized sections in the body of the report?
 - e. What kind of ending is given to the letter? Is there a summary, or is there an overt attempt to end with persuasion?
4. **Analytical Memorandum Report on Promotion of Colleague.** In the academic world of colleges and universities, several persons are asked to write short letters or memorandums evaluating persons within their own school or for persons outside. Even in the business world requests may come to you—as a member of the Human Resources (HR) Department—to write such an analysis. In fact, one of your authors has written several assessments of individuals in companies for which he has consulted, with the intent of offering an opinion on specific criteria. Those criteria vary from company to company. But the result is the same: Give an analysis of that individual's performance as measured against several criteria.

Your manager would like you to write a confidential analysis of an individual within your company. In some companies the criteria are vivid, in others not. Therefore, select your own criteria and submit an analytical memoran-

dum that ends with specific recommendations. In addition to your own criteria, you may wish to consider some of the following:

- Ability to perform his or her current job
- Capacity to get along well with superiors, peers, and subordinates
- Support for his or her communication abilities
- Willingness to perform high-quality work
- Control over time
- Evidence of creativity in solving problems
- Desire to continue working with the company

5. Rewrite of Savings Association Letter Report. The following letter report (answering an inquiry) is quite good. Your job is to make it even better. Assume the customer asked about all the topics mentioned; thus, keep all the ideas but improve the report in these five ways:

- a. Insert headings—second- and third-degree or third- and fourth-degree headings.
- b. Show more you-attitude.
- c. Change at least five passive verbs to active voice (and of course make whatever subject changes are necessary).
- d. Tabulate some listed details—for easier reading.
- e. Make any other minor changes desirable for good business writing.

Thank you for your request for information relating to INSURED savings accounts in this association. This reply includes facts concerning types of savings plans, security of savings, withdrawal of funds, and necessary forms for opening an account. I am also enclosing a copy of our latest financial statement and several pamphlets of general information that give you essential facts you desire about us and the savings accounts we issue.

We have two types of savings plans available—a passbook savings account and a 6-month savings certificate.

Briefly, an insured passbook savings account may be opened for any amount at any time. Upon receipt of your remittance, we issue to you our savings passbook with the amount credited inside. Additional sums may be added in any amount and at any time you desire. Interest earnings are credited to passbook savings accounts on March 31, June 30, September 30, and December 31 of each year. This is done automatically on these dates whether you send in your passbook or not. Gold Bond stamps are given as a bonus to passbook savers, as outlined on the enclosed card.

The current rate of dividend on passbook savings is 5 1/2% per year, compounded daily.

In addition to our savings passbooks, we also issue insured 6-month savings certificates. Designed to offer larger, longer-term investors the maximum rate for insured savings, these certificates are issued for a minimum of \$1,000, with larger amounts in multiples of \$100. They differ from passbook accounts in several respects. Earnings on certificates begin on the day of purchase and are paid at the end of each 6 months on maturity dates. The certificates are in certificate form, and checks are mailed to the certificate holders every 6 months from the date of issue, instead of being automatically credited to the account as is done on passbook accounts. Of course, if you have a passbook savings account with State Federal, the dividends on your savings certificate may be automatically credited to your passbook account upon your request. For your convenience, savings certificates are automatically renewed on the maturity dates for an additional 6 months unless you are notified at least 30 days prior to a maturity date. The current interest rate on 6-month savings certificates is 8 1/4% per year.

Savings in this association are INSURED up to \$100,000 by the Federal Savings and Loan Insurance Corporation, Washington, D.C. We are also members of the Federal Home Loan Bank System, a reserve credit system for associations. We lend our funds upon the security of selected monthly reducing first mortgages on homes. So, you will see, there is really exceptional security for savings placed with us.

You will probably wish some information concerning withdrawal of your funds. It has always been the policy of this association to pay withdrawals IN PART OR IN FULL without notice. We have followed this policy ever since organization in 1926. However, a savings and loan association may require notice of withdrawal if necessary. If the country should again experience an economic emergency such as prevailed in 1932-1933, it is possible that we would require notice. Under such circumstances it is quite likely that every financial institution would necessarily restrict withdrawals. This provision in the savings and loan laws is a wise one for the protection of the customers.

For your convenience I am enclosing a signature card that may be used for either an individual or a joint account. If you desire to open an

account in your own name alone, you should use Form 100. If, however, you wish to open an account in your name jointly with some other person, probably another member of your family, you should use Form 200, on the reverse side of the card. If you desire a 6-month savings certificate, the same signature card may be used.

We also have trust accounts, frequently used by parents in carrying savings accounts for children, or by persons who desire to hold funds in trusts for another. Signature card forms for this type of account will be mailed to you upon request.

I thank you kindly for your inquiry and extend to you a cordial invitation to use the facilities of this association

6. ***Rewrite of Annual Letter Report, with Tables and Other Improvements.*** Following is a report to shareholders. Assume this message appears on one side of an 8½ by 11 inch sheet and the annual statement of condition appears on the opposite side. Rewrite it so that the information is easier to read. For example, can you put in table form some or all the figures given in the first three paragraphs? And can you list the names and titles in the last two paragraphs? Also, add an appropriate rounding-out last paragraph.

Report to the Shareholders

We ended our 61st year May 3, 199-, which proved to be a very good year. Our assets totaled almost \$12,000,000 being \$11,997,728.90, representing an increase of \$430,315.75, which was due principally to the increase in home loans of \$538,622.30.

Savings accounts reflected a total of \$11,013,974.26, representing a gain for the year of \$385,321.70, which was substantially greater than the gain in the previous year. During the year the association repaid \$265,000 to the Federal Home Loan Bank and had no notes payable May 3, 199-. Net operating income, after expenses, amounted to \$558,293.40, reflecting an increase of \$32,423.01 over the previous year. The operating ratio of the association for the fiscal year was 17.87% of gross operating income, which was substantially lower than the national average, which is in excess of 27%.

During the year, \$42,000 was added to reserves, \$495,810.52 was distributed as earning on savings accounts, and \$20,482.88 was added to undivided profit. Total reserves were \$514,000 and undivided profit \$87,505.03, making a total of \$601,505.03, representing over 5% of total liabilities. Our reserves and undivided profit place us in a rather

enviable position and leave no question, in my opinion, of our ability to continue at our present rate of return to our savings accounts.

At our shareholders' meeting held Monday, April 5, the following were elected to serve as directors for the ensuing year: William E. Brady, Robert E. Becker, Stephen G. Mills, Mary A. Aitken, Daniel A. Roberts, Lisa L. Gifford, and Louise G. Bulett.

At the directors' reorganization meeting, immediately following the shareholders' meeting, the following officers were elected: Chairperson of the Board of Directors and President, William E. Brady; Vice Chairperson, Robert E. Becker; Executive Vice President, Secretary and Treasurer, Stephen G. Mills; Vice President and Assistant Secretary and Treasurer, Louise G. Hulett, and Assistant Secretary, William A. Dugger. Sylvia Reddie was reappointed Savings Officer, and Bonnie Whittemore was appointed Head Bookkeeper. Fred L. Sharp was reappointed attorney.

- 7. Collection of Sample Periodic Reports.** Although this chapter noted the presence of periodic reports in businesses, there is little consistency as to the kinds of periodic reports required within organizations. Our focus is on business. Yet, many other organizations—not directly business-related—also produce periodic reports, some of which may be similar to business organizations. Go to the offices of one or two of the following organizations and ask for copies of what they consider to be periodic reports. If they will not release the complete report, you could simply list the headings used within those reports. Locate similarities, determine whether some of the contents and headings might be of use to businesses.

Local church or synagogue	YMCA or YWCA
United Fund	Admissions office within your school
City Council	Local thrift shop
Clothing store	Post office
Local newspaper	Head office of your school

- 8. Short Report on a Business Book.** Locate a book review of a business book. Such a review can be found in a publication such as the *New York Times* or in a periodical that briefly discusses new books. Your task is to write a one-page report on a business book of your choice. What you choose for headings in that report is your decision. Your review, for example, might include topics such as these:

- Author's qualifications
- Theme or purpose of the book
- Implications for students entering business
- Major idea gained from the book
- Areas where the book could be improved
- Other topics of your choice

Long (Formal) Reports

I. Prefatory Sections

- A. Cover and External Title
- B. Title Fly and Internal Title
- C. Letter or Memorandum of Transmittal
- D. Table of Contents
- E. Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis

II. Supplemental Sections

- A. Bibliography
- B. Footnotes and Endnotes (Citations)
- C. Appendix
- D. Glossary
- E. Index

III. Presentation of the Long Report

- A. Writing the First Draft
- B. Editing and Revising the Rough Drafts
- C. Typing the Final Document

IV. Examples of Pages from a Long Analytical Report

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

A long report is simply an expansion of a shorter report. Major differences in the long report involve greater length and depth of discussion of more complex problems. Some long reports extend from a few pages to several hundred—even into several volumes of information.

- A report to a U.S. nuclear regulatory commission was 180 pages long.
- A report to a utility company on building a new power generating system included eight volumes.
- A report to the home-country manager of an Asian oil company recommending expansion into India was in excess of 200 pages.
- A report to a U.S. motor company recommending automobiles be built in Mexico was in excess of 300 pages.

A formal report does not mean more formal language; it means the report is more detailed, more complex in structure.

Consequently, long reports demand more preliminary collecting, sorting, interpreting, writing, and editing and creation of visuals (see Appendix A) than short reports. Long reports are a mix of informative and persuasive information.

A long report may also be called “formal,” but not formal in the sense of language usage. In fact, the principles of the seven C’s in Chapter 2 may also be applied here. We label a report *formal* when it includes more detail, more prefatory information, more visuals, and more supplementary forms of support. Topics are often involved and complex.

This chapter presents additional information you need to know regarding writing long reports: prefatory sections, supplementary sections, presentation of the long report, and a shortened example of a long report.

PREFATORY SECTIONS

Assume that someone within your organization requests that you investigate a problem. Thus you receive a charge—someone requests information. The request may be simple, often oral:

“Look into the issue of salary levels among our personnel in Europe.”

“Give me a report on changes in retirement benefits.”

“Submit to the Board some options on computer hardware.”

Or, you may receive a detailed statement that precisely spells out the issues to investigate. This letter or *memorandum of request* (some companies call it an *MOR*) may run several pages, even including a budget for completing the report.

In any event, you will have to do preliminary work, perhaps even meet with the individual or committee requesting a report from you. Checklist 12.1 summarizes what you need to know and do first.

As companies globalize and subsidiaries are located worldwide, the need to work in two languages adds to the complexity of completing a report. Often the required report is first written in the native language of the foreign subsidiary and then translated into English. Thus, you must request—if that fact is not already established—that the final document be in English. (On occasion a foreign subsidiary will submit two reports: one in the native language—for example,

Writing in one’s second language is considerably more difficult than writing in one’s native language.

■ Checklist 12.1 What to Do First When Asked to Complete a Report

1. Recognize clearly what is expected of you: issues, problems, purpose, scope.
2. Realize who your audience of readers will be.
3. Get an idea of sources to which you may turn.
4. Understand when the report is to be completed.
5. Be sure of financial and time constraints: costs, travel, release from work.
6. Ask if the authorizer wants progress reports.

Spanish—and one in English. That way—the Spanish-speaking manager would argue—managers in the subsidiary's home office can have their own translators review the Spanish-to-English version or read the report in Spanish.)

After you understand your specific charge and complete your preliminary investigation, it is time to consider the distinguishing features of the long report: cover and external title, title fly and internal title, letter or memo of transmittal, table of contents, and executive summary.

Cover and External Title

Even large companies have reports printed with special, visually appealing covers.

Many reports combine the cover page and title page as the first page. You can even purchase professionally produced covers that have space for a title. Or—as are some reports submitted to the President of the United States—the cover may be leather with the title embossed directly on the cover. However, most reports have a simple hard cover, with the title typed on a gummed label. (On occasion, a foreign subsidiary will submit two cover pages: one in the native language and one in English.)

A report title should indicate briefly and clearly what the report covers. Here are five suggestions.

1. Remember the five W's: *who*, *what*, *when*, *where*, *why*. As an example, suppose your report discusses a strategy for a company called LifePlus that markets exercise bicycles in Canada. You could use this analysis:

<i>Who:</i>	LifePlus	<i>Where:</i>	Canada
<i>What:</i>	Marketing strategy	<i>Why:</i>	To increase sales
<i>When:</i>	1999-		

Possible titles could be:

Recommendations for Increasing LifePlus' Sales
in Canada
A New Marketing Emphasis for 1999- Canadian Sales
Canadian Sales: Ways to Improve our Market

■ Communication Probe

Writing a report in one's own language is considerably easier than writing in a second language. Yet, foreign subsidiary report writers often must write in their second language. And too often the typical U.S. manager's reaction to that report is "that report just doesn't read right,"—or worse! A real scenario is the following pattern as traced by one of your authors some time ago:

Request for a proposal arrives at foreign country regional office. (*English*)
 Request sent to German subsidiary. German country manager has request translated into German for distribution to his staff. (*English-German*)
 Staff discusses request. (*German*)
 Initial report written in German. (*German*)
 Staff discusses report and finally approves. (*German*)
 Report translated into English. (*German-English*)
 Report sent to German country manager. (*German-English*)
 Report sent on to regional office and on to parent company in the United States. (*English*)

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1974). Technical written reports from Germany. *The Journal of Technical Writing and Communication*, 4(4), 291–303.

2. Keep title short. Eight to ten words is desirable. Try to omit articles—the, a, and an—whenever possible.

3. Consider a subtitle, often indicated with a colon. For instance:

Argentina: Recommendations for
 Establishing a Joint Venture
 Industrial Water Pollution: What Strategy
 Should Our Company Follow?
 Drug Use in the Workplace: Options for
 Decreasing the Problem

4. Avoid titles that are vague, extremely short:

Unclear

Root Causes
 Drugs
 Company Plans

Better

Core Issues Affecting Decline in Profits
 Marijuana and Its Abuse in the Workplace
 A Strategic Financial Plan: 1998–2000

5. Eliminate judgment terms:

Errors in Accounting Procedures in the Past Two
 Years
 Why Overseas Personnel Do Badly
 Issues That Hinder Our Acceptance in Jakarta

Your readers get an initial impression in the title: Give careful thought to being concise and clear.

Title Fly and Internal Title

By definition the title fly is simply the sheet of paper between the cover and the internal title page. Immediately following that page is the internal title page, which has four parts: the title as stated on the exterior cover, the recipient of the report, the preparer, and the date.

EXAMPLE 1

[title]	Peru: Recommendations for Establishing a Joint Venture
[for whom]	Prepared for [company] Board of Directors
[by whom]	Prepared by the International Strategic Review Committee
[date]	January 25, 199-

EXAMPLE 2

[title]	INDUSTRIAL WATER POLLUTION: WHAT STRATEGY SHOULD OUR COMPANY FOLLOW?
[for whom]	For the Environmental Committee
[by whom]	Prepared by Olga Lotz Russ Winoski Elaine Zimmer, Chairperson
[date]	September 5, 199-

**Title, for whom, by whom,
and date are the four parts
of a title page.**

Note that each example illustrates the four parts of the title page. Position each part symmetrically on the page for an initial positive impression.

Letter or Memorandum of Transmittal

A cover letter or cover memorandum are names for the first prose document of a report. Regardless of the formality of the report, it is conventional to address the receiver of the report—as if you're writing a letter—as “Dear.” Before looking at the five parts of a transmittal message, review the probe on the next page; it is an enlightening review of how a Middle East country handles a salutation in a cover letter.

Most transmittal messages have five parts.

1. Authorization

**Include the name of the
group or individual who re-
quested the report.**

Unless your report is self-initiated, someone has asked you to produce a report. Hence, your opening words in the transmittal document refer to that request. Include the date. Remember that much time may have passed (some reports

■ Communication Probe

Turkish letters and cover letters begin with a salutation. Two different “Dears” exist: *Sevgili* is used in informal contexts while *Sayin* is more formal, used when writing to an older person or a superior. Salutations in either kind of context end with a comma, not a colon. When submitting a report to a government official in Turkey, you begin with a specific salutation such as “To the Attorney General, Istanbul.” Salutations also include the name of the city where the office is located. Additionally, there are expressions relevant to the positions of the writer and reader. If the person to whom the letter or cover letter is sent is a subordinate, you request; if the person is a superior, you present. Western readers of foreign letters need to be aware of differences in letter formats, beginning with the salutation.

Kaleli, O. (1993). Writing in Turkish and English compared. Unpublished manuscript.

take several months to complete) since the initial request and that even the requester may have forgotten the details. Some report writers include in the appendix the actual report request as supplementary information.

2. Transmittal Details

Simply put, your transmittal message says, “Here’s the report you requested.” But politeness demands more. Use conversational language (with first- and second-person pronouns as “I,” “you,” “me”) as you would if you were handing the report to the recipient in person. A formal, distinguished group—such as a top government official or department—might use more formal language. Also, you may combine both the authorization and the transmittal details within the same paragraph.

3. Background, Methodology

One could call this information “throat clearing.” You briefly suggest the research methods you employed, giving the reader some feel for the breadth (also known as the scope or limits of the report) of your investigation. This also gives you the opportunity to build your credibility as senior author of the report: who you are and what your qualifications are as well as those of your committee members. In short, you forestall the inevitable questions of how conscientious you and your associates were in gathering information.

4. Highlights

You should include information that briefly mentions your conclusions. Here you must make a judgment: If your reader is friendly, potentially inclined to accept your conclusions, you could be precise as to the recommendations; if your reader is less inclined, consider being a bit more general.

As in short reports, here too consider whether your reader is favorably disposed to your recommendation. If yes, put the recommendation up front.

5. Courteous Ending

Think about doing any of the following in your ending statement:

- Acknowledging those who assisted
- Indicating, if necessary, that later reports will be forthcoming
- Verifying that the effort in completing the report was worthwhile
- Suggesting a personal willingness to respond to further questions or complete further research if that is necessary
- Including—if you are distant from the report readers—where you can be reached personally or via electronic means

Precision as to your electronic address is often included in the final line.

EXAMPLE 3

Dear Ms. Hammel:

Authorization and transmittal

Attached is the report you requested on April 10, 1997 on the issue of Drugs in the Workplace. We have tried to meet your requests as stated in your letter of that date and hope the report is useful to you and your office.

Methodology

Our approach to the issue involved work in three areas: meetings with local health and medical personnel; interviews with persons who have publicly indicated a problem with drugs; and meetings with other companies in the area. Three months of effort were devoted to the above investigations. After that initial data collection we also met with each of our vice presidents to get their reaction to our preliminary data.

Highlights

Three recommended solutions are supported by the committee; those recommendations are detailed in the executive summary. Consensus also appeared for the three criteria we used for evaluation: fairness, workability, and cost effectiveness.

Courteous ending

We hope the report is acceptable to the committee. As a group we found the investigation interesting, challenging, and most of all, hopefully rewarding in decreasing and eventually solving the problem of drugs in the workplace.

Cordially,

[Signature]

[Typed name and title]

A foreign language title page—with translation—is not unusual.

As with the title page, some foreign subsidiaries include the cover letter or memorandum both in the native language and in English. Such actions are a mark of respect and not an attempt to demean the English readers of the letter.

Table of Contents

Contents of the Report

Suggestion: Prepare the table of contents last—after you have assigned the headings and final page numbers. Place the table of contents just before the report body, being sure that all headings parallel those in the text. You need not include all headings in the body of the report. Usually you show no more than two degrees (first, second, and only occasionally the third). Going beyond that level results in micro, unnecessary detail.

Table of Tables

A long report will include illustrations, statistical data, clarifying end notes, visuals, even bibliographic citations, as we have in this textbook. What you choose to include depends on the kind of formal visuals shown throughout the body of the report. Your visual layout may be similar to the following:

Table of Tables		
Table		Page
1	(Title).....	7
2	(Title).....	24
3	(Title).....	34

Visuals may be included in the body of the report or included as a section in the appendix.

Visuals or Figures

Detailed figures or drawings, especially in highly technical reports, are frequently placed in the appendix. Such visuals are there for the reader's use: to see more micro and detailed graphics, as supplements to the prose discussion. Likewise, explicit visual aids may also be given their own section of a report, particularly when those visuals supplemented the oral presentation as support for the report. (See Appendix A.)

Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis

Executive summaries are often the most read page in a report.

Companies differ where the “executive summary,” “abstract,” “synopsis,” “précis,” “digest” should be placed. Some boards and chairpersons desire it right after the transmittal letter or memorandum. Regardless of its position within a report, it is often the most read piece—occasionally torn out—of a report. Busy managers, and even those tangentially interested, can determine whether they wish to read the entire report simply by reading the executive summary.

This prefatory part may be organized deductively (recommendation or conclusions section up front, then introduction and body) or inductively (introduction, body, and recommendation near the end). Either way, there is little agree-

■ Checklist 12.2 Prefatory Sections of a Long Report

1. Title of Report—Use the five W's:
 - *Who* wishes the report?
 - *What* is to be investigated?
 - *When* should the report be finished?
 - *Where* is the central issue of the report?
 - *Why* is the report requested?
2. Letter or Memorandum of Transmittal—Include the following information:
 - State who authorized the report.
 - Be informal in submitting the report.
 - Make some effort to explain the procedure in completing the report.
 - Include some highlights.
 - End with courtesy.
3. Table of Contents
 - Let your headings for major sections parallel those used in the body of the report.
 - Include a supplementary table or list of visuals if you use many statistics and figures.

ment as to which headings should be used in an executive summary. Dominant headings include

purpose	problem analysis
scope	results
background	solution criteria
data analysis	conclusions
methods of research	possible solutions/recommendations
current issues	recommendations
causes	benefits
effects	time-frame analysis

Checklist 12.3 gives guidelines for an effective executive summary.

Besides being a useful prefatory part of a long, formal report, informative executive summaries also serve other important functions. Some firms circulate to all their management personnel only executive summaries of reports. Then it is up to the managers to decide whether they need to see the complete document.

A well-written executive summary, or abstract, communicates essential information to many people. Some of the best examples of abstracted articles, for

■ Checklist 12.3 An Executive Summary

Try to make this short, one-page document as clear as possible; persons often unconnected with the report may read the summary purely for information. One proposition should be controlling: The executive summary should be able to stand alone.

1. Check that you have given a brief background statement.
2. Ask yourself: Have I analyzed the data carefully?
3. Be sure that the causes you attribute to the issue are established.
4. Give thought to including criteria that solutions should meet.
5. Know if your reader desires recommendations up-front or in the terminal section.
6. Include, if desirable, budget and time-frame implications.

instance, occur in the various electronic databases. Note in the following example the specific information for the common ABI/INFORM on-line system:

Copyright © 1993 by University Microfilms, Inc.
All rights reserved.

<i>Access No.</i>	00934500 ProQuest ABI/INFORM ® Global
<i>Title</i>	Multimedia: An emerging communications technique
<i>Authors</i>	Held, Gilbert
<i>Journal</i>	Information Strategy: The Executive's Journal [IFS]
	ISSN: 0743-8613
	Vol: 11 Iss: 2 Date: Winter 1995 p: 41-46
	Illus: Charts
<i>Reprint</i>	Contact UMI for article reprint (order no. 14374.00). Restrictions may apply.
<i>Subjects</i>	Multimedia computer applications; Trends; Communications; Customer services; Training
<i>Geo Places</i>	US
<i>Codes</i>	5240 (Software & systems); 9190 (United States)
<i>Abstract</i>	An emerging method of increasing the efficiency and effectiveness of communication in organizations is the use of multimedia. The term multimedia represents the merging of voice, data, and video into a computer-based application. To enhance customer service, multimedia kiosks can be placed in stores to display items that are not normally carried by a branch store and that many customers may have previously ordered based on limited information. . .

Although the abstract length varies somewhat in proportion to the report length, it should be confined to fewer than 500 words (preferably on one page). To show you how abstracts vary, here are two additional examples:

EXAMPLE 1 *A short abstract on a 75-page published report.*

Purpose, scope, method, sources, major facts and figures

To determine the basic vocabulary of written business communications, a computer count was made of 2,504 letters, memorandums, and business reports, submitted by 1,411 companies representative of the population of industries nationwide. A total of 606,496 running words and 15,522 different words were identified, with the 100 most frequently occurring words accounting for half of all word occurrences. Major differences between this list and previous lists were noted. A separate analysis of 500 letters, 300 memorandums, and 200 reports was made to identify the physical format, sentence structure, and readability levels of the documents.

EXAMPLE 2 *Executive summary of international consultant recommendation.*

Background

You requested advice on the possibilities of increasing the consumption of cold cereals in Japan. The specific question was this: What must be done to increase the consumption of cold cereals in Japan from the current 0.150 kilograms to 1.5 kilograms?

Data analysis

We collected data from the Japanese Institute for Social and Economic Affairs as well as other Japanese and US organizations. Data analysis showed that Japanese consumers spend 180 yen per serving to make their traditional breakfast of fish, rice, vegetables, and green tea. Cold cereal costs 240 yen per serving, or an increase of 25%. . .

Causes

The higher cost for the cold cereal breakfast is due to research and development costs, advertising efforts, and sales promotion efforts. Additionally, Americans drink more milk, often on their cereal. Finally, the aging population of Japan also mitigates against cold cereal: older persons resist changing from their traditional breakfast . . .

Possible options

1. Conduct an education program targeting the younger Japanese consumer, those less than age 25. Emphasis could be placed on cereal's nutritional benefits. . . .
2. Increase media advertising, emphasizing the nutritional elements of cold cereal. . . .
3. Develop more cereals made from rice. . . .

Conclusions

We conclude that any of the above three options would help increase the consumption of cold cereals in Japan. Particularly important is the concept that our marketing efforts should be directed toward those age 25 and younger.

SUPPLEMENTAL SECTIONS

Long reports have numerous headings and sections; they are more detailed; they include more visuals, more evidence, and involve more collaboration than a short report.

Furthermore, a long report may also include various kinds of supplementary information. That material is for readers who desire additional details related to, but not required within, the report itself. Such supplementary material may include a bibliography, a collection of endnotes (or footnotes), appendixes, a glossary, an index, and even visual aids.

■ Communication Probe

It is clear that when ending (inductive) or beginning (deductive) a report with a precise recommendation, persuasion is involved. Analytical reports often involve a discussion of a problem, a review of options—or alternatives—and a recommendation. Alternatives can be used persuasively. For instance, writers intending to persuade—in a report or other persuasive documents—can pose two alternatives, either of which are acceptable to the writer. The receiver, says one study, is likely to choose one of those two alternatives. Clearly, the receiver may also choose the unwritten option; that is, he or she may not like either alternative. Likewise, when laying out alternatives, it is useful to consider one highly positive alternative and several nonpositive, the writer giving more positive effort to his or her desired recommendation or alternative.

Gilsdorf, J. W. (1991, March). Write me your best case for . . . *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 53(1), 7–12.

Bibliography

Bibliographies are often not a part of business reports. Know whether your company desires them.

From basic writing courses you learned that a bibliography is a list of sources you cited as documentation for relevant content in your report. These sources range from articles to electronic databases. Such precision is more characteristic of scholarly writing but may on occasion be included in a formal business report. Business reports use citations (endnotes or footnotes) sparingly. In fact, many business reports omit both full-citation footnotes and bibliography. On the other hand, some do include a general bibliography but without any footnote source citations. Here we summarize appropriate ways to insert bibliographic information. Checklist 12.4 on p. 332 is an overview of bibliographic citation.

Placement

Bibliographic information is usually included at the end of the document. It is for additional reading, additional sources to which the reader may wish to turn. Some reports include bibliographic information at the end of each section or chapter. The choice is yours. In this book, for example, bibliographic information is combined with reference notes and placed at the end of each chapter.

Bibliographic Format

Modern Language Association formats are often used in qualitative statements.

You have two main choices for bibliographic form: the Modern Language Association (MLA) format (*MLA Handbook for Writers of Research Papers*) or the American Psychological Association (APA) *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association*. (Another format is Kate Turabian's *A Manual for Writers of Term Papers, Theses and Dissertations*, but this style is used more often for the purposes noted in the title.) Your choice may depend on which form your company prefers. Or lacking any guidance, choose one with which you feel most comfortable. Regardless, be consistent throughout your report. For instance, this book uses a modified APA format, combining brevity and clarity.

The American Psychological Association is also frequently used in numerous publications.

Once you decide on your format, you can present bibliographic entries in a single alphabetic list or under various headings. One could, for instance, arrange sources within broad groups such as books, periodicals, newspapers, government reports, or any other major categories of your choosing. A sample bibliography (also variously called *sources*, *references*, *works cited*, *selected bibliography*, *works consulted*) follows, using the format of the widely accepted American Psychological Association. Full details for the many, many variations of bibliographic citations are noted in the complete book of the APA, third edition.

Books

Baldwin, C. W. (1959). Medieval rhetoric and poetic. Gloucester MA: Peter Smith. (Original work published 1928).

[citation for a republished text]

Kristeller, P. O. (1979). Renaissance thought and its sources. (M. Mooney, ed.). New York: Columbia University Press. (Original works published 1944-1975).

[citation for edited book, and republished book]

Murphy, H. A., & Hildebrandt, H. W. (1991). Effective business communications (6th ed.). New York: McGraw-Hill.

[simple two-author text]

Quintilian. (1943). Institutio oratoria. (H. E. Butler, Trans.). Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press.

[citation for a translated text]

Periodicals and Newspaper

Chen, K. (1996, January 4). Chinese are going to town as growth of cities takes off. The Wall Street Journal, pp. A1, A12.

[citation for newspaper article with one author]

Hertling, J. (1966, January 5). China embraces the English language. The Chronicle of Higher Education, pp. A49, A51.

[citation for periodical with one author]

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1988). A Chinese managerial view of business communication, Management Communication Quarterly 2, (2), 217-234.

[citation for scholarly article with volume, issue number, and pages]

Government Publications, Reports

United States Environmental Protection Agency. (1995). Implementation for the clean air act amendments of 1990. Washington, D.C.: Office of Air and Radiation.

[citation from a government report]

Footnotes and Endnotes (Citations)

Kinds of Footnotes and Endnotes

Footnotes and endnotes are of two main types: those that explain *content* and those that *identify* sources of content, or citations.

1. Footnotes and Endnotes That Explain

An explanatory endnote or footnote¹ should provide additional information, discuss, or explain the content within the text. For example,

The term footnote is somewhat confusing. It can mean the inclusion of a superscript number in the text that refers the reader to an explanatory statement or a source citation. In this book we use superscript numbers for both purposes, including the explanation or source at the end of each chapter.

Many books position the above explanatory material at the bottom of the page, at the end of the chapter, or at the end of the book. Its position is up to you; however, it should relate to an idea in your report that is incidental, or that is too long, too complicated, or too technical to include in the text discussion, or that should not interrupt the flow of thought.

To refer your reader to explanatory footnotes or endnotes and to number them, you may use superscript numerals, easily inserted with today's word pro-

Footnotes may appear at the rear of a report or at the bottom of a page.

Unhesitatingly give credit to sources that supplied you with needed information.

A modified version of the APA format of identifying sources is used in this book.

cessing systems. Superscripts are small Arabic numbers placed slightly above the line. You can number these superscripts consecutively throughout a report or begin a new series with each chapter [*as we do in this book*].

2. Footnotes and Endnotes That Identify Source

Some footnotes or endnotes give credit to sources you used. Any quotations and important factual information that is not common knowledge or that is based on your experience must be supported by a reference to your sources. Citing sources does three things: It improves your own credibility as a writer, it helps convince your readers that your data are trustworthy, and it gives readers an opportunity to examine your sources.

Indicating to the reader that you have cited a source—to which he or she may wish to turn—can be done with a superscript numeral, similar to the explanatory footnote discussed above (as we have done in this book), or you may use the widely accepted APA format, in which a citation is placed in parentheses within the running text itself, including the author's surname and date of publication. Here we look at a few examples:

EXAMPLE 1 Two authors—cited within the text.

While traditional literature in strategy and organization theory suggests that organizational performance is a result of organizational adaptation to industry or market requirements (Hill, 1988; Porter, 1980, 1985), recent research highlights the importance of organizationally "distinctive competencies" . . .

Note that two sources are cited: We know the authors, we know the dates of all statements. Turning to the bibliography (or sources, references, works cited, selected bibliography, works consulted), you simply look in an alphabetical list for Hill, 1988, and Porter, 1980 and 1985, for a complete bibliographic citation:

Hill, C. (1988). Differentiation versus low cost or differentiation and low cost: Contingency framework. *Academy of Management Review*, 13(3), 401-421.
 Porter, M. (1980). *Competitive strategy*. New York: Free Press.
 Porter, M. (1985). *Competitive advantage*. New York: Free Press.

EXAMPLE 2 Multiple authors—cited within the text.

Compared to the United States, labour mobility between and within European countries is much lower (Bayoumi and Eichengreen, 1993; de Grauwe and Vanhaverbeke, 1993), wage flexibility is lower (Abraham, 1994; Blanchard and Katz, 1992; Decressin and Fatas, 1994) . . .

Again, we know the authors and the dates for their statements from reading the citations within the text. We do not know the source of their statements. That

■ Checklist 12.4 Bibliographic Citations

1. Determine which format is used within your company (you can choose from MLA (Modern Language Association), APA (American Psychological Association), and Turabian.
2. Know these facts about the book, periodical, or newspaper regardless of the format:
 - Author(s) names
 - Author capacity: editor, translator, compiler
 - Date of publication
 - Title of article or book
 - Edition
 - Page numbers
 - Volume number
 - Publisher

information can be found by referring to the bibliography. Just two citations are illustrated:

- Bayoumi, T., & Eichengreen, B. (1993). Shocking aspects of European monetary integration. In F. Torres and F. Giavazzi (Eds.). Adjustment and growth in the European monetary union (pp. 193-229). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Blanchard, O., & Katz, L. (1992). Regional evolutions. Brookings Papers on Economic Activity 1, (pp. 1-61). Washington D.C. Brookings.

EXAMPLE 3 *Government report—cited within the text.*

Most Chinese managers working in research and development (R&D) studied in areas as the following: engineering (45.4%); natural science (23.5%); medicine (20.3%); agricultural (7.7%); and other areas (2.9%) (China Stat, 1988: 814-832).

In the bibliography the citation to the *China Stat* document would appear as follows:

Statistical yearbook of China, 1987 (1988) (China Stat). Hong Kong: Economic Information and Agency.

Instead of providing a complete bibliography at the end of the book, this book uses a modified version of the APA bibliographic style, with superscripts to refer you to the Reference section at the end of the chapter rather than paren-

thetical in-text citations. We also included complete citations within the boxed Communication Probes. This system works well because it avoids footnotes at the bottom of the page, does not break up the text for a citation, and yet maintains the ease-of-reference style of inverted authors' names.

But it is your decision as to which citation format you wish to follow. The differences between the various forms are slight. We recommend you use the format accepted in your company. But keep in mind that many long company reports do not use any citations.

Appendix

You put materials into the appendix when you need to include them somewhere in the report but they are not essential in developing any part of the text. The appendix lets you avoid cluttering the body (discussion, text) with exhibits, copies of questionnaires, or pamphlets that are unnecessary for understanding the report but that may be useful for reference or as supporting information.

With short reports, you merely add the appendix sheets directly to the report. But for a formal report, you place a sheet of paper (the appendix title page) between the last page of the body and the first page of the appendix. If you have enough material in the appendix to justify a separate table of contents, show the contents below the title on the appendix dividing sheet.

Each separate entry (sample forms, detailed data for reference, tables, pictures, questionnaires, charts, maps, graphic representations, blueprints) in the appendix naturally requires an identifying title. As a rule, you should refer the reader to every entry in the appendix in the report body (within the discussion itself or in a footnote).

The last page of the appendix is the ideal place for any table or illustration the reader will need to refer to throughout the report. You can set up this table on a pull-out sheet and tell the reader about the sheet in the letter of transmittal or introduction.

Glossary

When your report includes any terms that have several possible interpretations, definitions should be inserted—in one of three places. If you have many definitions (for instance, in a technical report), a glossary at the end is preferable. Mention in your introduction that the report includes a glossary, which will be useful to readers who wish to check on some meanings even though the terms are not essential for understanding the report.

Index

The index lists topics alphabetically and guides the reader to various places that discuss certain subject matter in the report. Only in very long reports will you need an index.

PRESENTATION OF THE LONG REPORT

Presume for the moment that you have completed all your preliminary work: You have defined the problem, collected all needed material, sorted and inter-

puted data, organized the final outline, and prepared visual aids. Now your steps are writing, editing, revising, and typing the report.

Writing the First Draft

Accept no criticism for beginning to write with the easiest section; it helps you feel comfortable.

You may like to begin with a section you consider easiest. Nothing wrong with that. Feel comfortable with the job facing you. Use your outline and get your ideas into your word processor without stopping to correct every spelling, punctuation, or grammar error. Some people initially overwrite, later finding it easier to delete material than to locate additional and new information.

Introduction

You can begin with the introduction, or leave it until last. Either way is acceptable. Be sure to include opening statements that orient the reader to the rest of the report. For a 15- to 25-page, double-spaced, typewritten report, the introduction should be no more than 1½ or 2 pages.

Body or Text

Three or four main divisions are appropriate for a report that is 15 to 25 pages in length. If your report is longer than that, look critically at your outline to determine whether you can regroup sections or combine sections. Of course, a report consisting of one-hundred or several hundred pages will have proportionately more main divisions; in fact, the report may contain “chapters,” with each chapter having its own main divisions.

Conclusion, Summary (Terminal Section)

As we noted in the preceding chapter, you may label the terminal section “Summary,” “Conclusions,” or “Conclusions and Recommendations.”

Besides completing a first draft of the report body, you should also write a draft of the executive summary, letter or memo of transmittal, and bibliography or endnotes list, if you will have one. You can also set up the table of contents and the table of tables (if any) in rough draft, but only after the final typing is finished can you know correct page numbers for these tables.

Editing and rewriting can be exhilarating; they force you to review your prose for added clarity.

Editing and Revising the Rough Drafts

After you have finished the first draft, lay it aside for at least 1 day. Doing so will help you look objectively at the material and see more clearly the weaknesses in the draft. Editing requires objective self-criticism. What seemed right in the first writing may seem seriously out of place upon second reading. Remember too that the best writers revise and rewrite several times.

Text editing and revising functions are easily accomplished on a word processor. As you know, a few keystrokes permit condensing, changing or adding words, rearranging paragraphs, adjusting margins, detecting spelling errors, and a host of other functions unimaginable several years ago.

Typing the Final Document

Be consistent. This statement suggests that when selecting one of the many ways of physically putting together a report, you should be in harmony with the style others have used to prepare reports for your company. Several items should be considered.

Overall Appearance

Laser printers, various type fonts, and different sizes of type allow reports to be highly attractive. Spacing, margins, and pagination all contribute to a favorable impression of a report.

Spacing

Reports may be typewritten with double or single spacing. Those who prefer double spacing feel it is easy to read. Single-spaced reports have become popular in recent years not only because they save paper but also—with fewer pages for the same amount of report data—because they save (1) typing time, (2) filing space, (3) expense of both duplicating time and materials when multiple copies of a report are needed, and (4) reading time when turning fewer pages.

If you double-space the report, the first word of each paragraph should be indented (usually five spaces). In a single-spaced report, paragraphs may be indented or begin at the left margin. However, always double-space between paragraphs and both before and after long quotations, visual aids, and footnotes.

Regardless of whether the report is typed in double or single spacing, the following parts should be single-spaced:

1. Transmittal document—typed on company letterhead if you are writing it as an employee of the firm. And, of course, the letter should be centered attractively on the page.
2. Quotations and examples—of three or more typewritten lines. If this material consists of two or more paragraphs, double-space (leave a blank line) between them. Also, indent margins of the quote five spaces to the right and left of the double- or single-spaced text material. Use ellipses (. . .) to indicate omissions if you are quoting only parts of an author's paragraph. In long quotations you can show lengthy omissions by either a full line of periods or by four periods at the end of the paragraph.
3. A list of items you want to set off or emphasize.
4. Footnotes (but double-space between them).
5. Some tables and other visuals aids.

Margins

In addition to the following suggested margins, you need to add $\frac{1}{2}$ inch for binding on each page. The report is usually bound on the left-hand side. Acceptable margins are as follows:

■ Communication Probe

Consistently your authors have moved on this principle: Computers or PCs or word processors are central to report writing or for that matter to any business writing. Although some people may still wish to use an upright typewriter, computers for composing in English are core to Western business communication. Indeed, in writing a report or an analysis, it is easy to connect with persons throughout the world, to download information as precise as a bibliography on your topic, to get on line persons whose voice on the topic was only at the margins. If your report is done collaboratively, it is easy to E-mail your colleagues and get their input into that report. As computer technology moves ahead relentlessly, construction of information becomes more of a collaborative process, a social construction of knowledge.

Moran, C. (1992, February). Computers and English: What do we make of each other? *College English*, 54(2), 193–198. See also Handa, C. (ed.). (1990). *Computers and community*. Portsmouth NH: Heinemann; Holdstein, D. H., & Selfe, C. L. (eds.). (1990). *Computers and writing: Theory, research, practice*. New York: Modern Language Association; Masdon, R., & Kaye, A. (eds.). (1989). *Mindweaver*. New York: Pergamon.

First page of each prefatory part (preface or letter of transmittal, table of contents, table of tables, abstract), *body*, and *supplemental parts* (appendix, bibliography or endnotes, index): top margin of 1½ or 2 inches.

All other pages: Top, bottom, and side margins are 1 or 1½ inches (plus the ½-inch allowance for binding at either left side or top).

Pagination

Every page in the report—except the cover and title fly—should have a number, but not all numbers are actually typed on each page. For the prefatory sheets use small Roman numerals; for the body and supplemental sheets use Arabic numbers, according to these guidelines:

1. *Prefatory parts page numbers* are centered and placed ½ inch below the imaginary line that frames the bottom of the typewritten material. Count and number the prefatory pages as shown below:

Cover and title fly	Do not count or number.
Title page	Count (i) but do not insert number.
Transmittal document	Count, but usually do not insert number. A one-page letter is page ii at the bottom; a second page of the transmittal is page iii.
Table of contents	Count and number each page.
Table of tables	Count and number.
Executive summary	Count and number.

2. *Body and supplemental parts page numbers.*

- a. If your report is bound at the left, page numbers are usually placed near the upper-right corner of the page, aligned with the right margin and $\frac{1}{2}$ inch (or a double space) above the top imaginary line that frames the typewritten material. The exception is that the numbers for first pages of parts are either omitted (though counted) or placed $\frac{1}{2}$ inch (or a double space) below the imaginary line that frames the bottom of the typed material. They are centered with the typing on the page (as for prefatory parts pages).
- b. If your report is bound at the top, page numbers are usually placed in the center at the bottom of the page, $\frac{1}{2}$ inch, or a double space, below the imaginary line that frames the bottom of the typewritten text.

EXAMPLES OF PAGES FROM A LONG ANALYTICAL REPORT

What follows on pp. 338 to 346 is a shortened version of a long report submitted to a company that had no employee suggestion program. One of the board members recommended to the president that he consider such a program and requested that a report with recommendations come before the board of directors. The president of Central Company (not the real name) then requested, in writing, that such a report be completed by the vice president of Strategic Planning. Included from that report are these sections:

- Title page
- Transmittal memorandum
- Table of contents
- Executive summary
- Selected pages from the report
- Sample attachment—appendix

Title Page

EMPLOYEE SUGGESTION PROGRAMS:
A NEEDED ADDITION AT CENTRAL COMPANY

Prepared for
Mr. Todd Ritchie
President
Central Company

←1/2"→

Prepared by
Mr. Fred Cooley
Vice President, Strategic Planning

September 18, 199-

Transmittal Memorandum

2" Letterhead

September 18, 199-

TO: Mr. Todd Ritchie, President
Central Company

FROM: Fred Cooley, Vice President Strategic
Planning, Chairperson
Debra Hibbs, Personnel
Mark Henderson, Personnel
Donna Hollowell, Staff Assistant

SUBJECT: Recommendation for establishing an Employee
Suggestion Program at Central Business

On July 15, 199-, Mr. Todd Ritchie asked that we submit our recommendations concerning an employee suggestion program for Central Company. That report is now finished, and it is attached to this cover memorandum.

Our major recommendation is this: Central Company should institute an employee suggestion program.

That conclusion was arrived at after extensive investigation over the past two months. We conducted employee surveys, surveyed the competition, and invited an outside consultant to offer her suggestions.

As a result of our research, we have come to appreciate the superior work now being done by members of our company. Each person asked to sit in on a Quality Circle did so without question; each person benefited in two ways: they gained more information about the company, and they learned more about other persons in the company. The committee is grateful to them and others who assisted in the report.

If you or members of the Board have any additional questions, I or any other member of the committee would be pleased to meet with you.

Thank you for the opportunity for letting us contribute to the progress of the company.

Authorization

←1/2"→

Recommendation

Process

Process

Courtesy,
close

Table of Contents

2"	
CONTENTS	
	Page
Letter of Transmittal.....	
Executive Summary.....	
I. Introduction.....	
A. Authorization and Purpose.....	
B. The Problem at Central Company..	
C. Methods of Investigation.....	
D. Plan of Presentation.....	
II. Conclusions and Recommendations....	
III. Description of Implementing the Program.....	
A. Description of the Program.....	
B. Costs of the Program.....	
C. Administration of the Program...	
IV. Benefits of Adopting the Program.....	
Appendix B. Quality Circle Recommendations.....	
1 1/2"	

Executive Summary

Title	Employee Suggestion Programs: A Needed Addition at Central Company
Authorization recommendation	This report responds to the request of the president, Mr. Todd Ritchie, that a committee look into the issue of whether Central Business should adopt an employee suggestion program. The committee unanimously recommends that such a program be implemented.
Process of review, methodology	Data for that recommendation comes from the committee as based on our investigations over the past two months. We worked with employees of the company in Quality Circles, hired an outside consultant for a period of time, and had contact with our competitors. All eagerly gave their advice.
Problems	A central concern of the employees was their unwillingness to submit suggestions without receiving some kind of financial reward. They felt if they took the time to search out suggestions for improvements, they alone should receive a financial benefit. Such an approach would definitely impact the finances of the company. The committee weighed those consequences and still feel the positive benefits to the company outweigh the negative consequences.
Time frame	Finally, if the recommendation is accepted, the program could be put into effect within three months.

Sample Prose from Body of Report

Employee Suggestion Programs: A Needed Addition at Central Company

I. INTRODUCTION

Central company, for many years, has been a major community leader. We mean that our firm continues to employ workers from the area and, in turn, contributes to the community as a whole. We have consistently been good citizens. With such a perspective of looking outward, it seemed only logical that we look inward. That mission, we are told, was behind the charge that a committee look into the possibility of establishing an employee suggestion program at Central Company.

Authorization and Purpose

This report, authorized on July 15, 199-, by Mr. Todd Ritchie, is intended to review whether Central Company should establish an employee suggestion program. We realize the need for such a program and have given every effort to find an acceptable set of procedures to put such a program in place
. . .

The Problem at Central Company

Central Company must approach the current situation from two points of view: Would establishing an employee suggestion program be beneficial to the company, and would such a program be beneficial to the employees? . . .

Methods of Investigation

Our committee followed a three-step review process:

- Held six Quality Circle sessions with employees wherein we sought answers to this general question: What could the company do to make them feel more a part of the company?
- Visited with the personnel directors of seven competitors and related industries to get their assessments on employee suggestion programs.
- Hired an outside consultant in human resource management to get her feedback on company policies throughout the United States . . .

Employee Suggestion Programs:
A Needed Addition at Central Company

Plan of Presentation

With the above as background, our report will proceed on laying out the specific recommendations, describe how we will implement the program, and conclude with benefits of adopting the program . . .

II. CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. That Central Company offer cash awards to employees for their accepted suggestions under the Employee Suggestion Program (ESP)
- B. That an ongoing committee be formed to review ESP suggestions
- C. That an employee form for ESP suggestions be created and made available to all employees
- D. That the final decision of a financial award, and the amount, be reviewed by the chief financial officer

III. DESCRIPTION OF IMPLEMENTING THE PROGRAM

Before describing the program, we wish to comment on the results obtained through the investigations noted earlier in this report. Appendix B shows the statistical results of the Quality Circle group meetings. A look at that visual suggests that the highest percentage of employees (45%) feel there should be a formal method of presenting ideas to management. Such a formal procedure, they feel, could well be an employee suggestion program . . .

Finally, as additional sources of data, we then took the six areas as determined by the Quality Circles and had 200 of our 300 employees rank the areas as to their desired involvement. Their percentage of support for the ESP program was supported at 48% . . .

Description of the Program

The program will offer a cash award to the employee whose suggestion is accepted. Final computation of the award amount will vary, based on whether the suggestion results in a positive financial impact for the company. Awards will be based on the percentage of savings to the company over a 12-month period. Such awards will be limited to a

maximum of \$10,000. Awards for suggestions that do not have a financial impact, if accepted, will be \$100 . . .

All employees, both full- and part-time, will be eligible to participate . . .

Employee Suggestion Programs:
A Needed Addition at Central Company

Any suggestions that would benefit the company may be submitted into the following areas: operations, new product, product improvement, quality, training, community relations, employee morale, and other.

Costs of the Program

Awards for suggestions with a financial impact will be computed as a percentage of the savings to the company. We recommended that such awards be 5% of the savings realized during the first 12 months after implementation of the suggestion. We also recommend that the maximum award be \$10,000 . . .

Costs necessary for implementation may be approximately \$2,500. Implementation costs will include training and publicity. Administration costs for a year would be approximately \$2,500 and would include labor, training, printing, and supplies.

If no awards are granted, the most the company will lose will be the \$2,500 implementation costs and annual costs of \$2,500 for administration. The total amount at risk for a one-year period would be \$5,000 . . .

Administration of the Program

We have developed a four-part form that employees can use to submit suggestions. As we indicated earlier, these suggestions would fall into one of eight categories (see Appendix A). Such a form allows employees to record the current method within Central Company, the proposed new method, and the advantages expected.

Personnel coordinators in each of the 12 major departments will be assigned the duties of coordinating ESP in their areas. They will attend some of the one-hour training sessions other employees attend. Coordinators also will attend three-hour sessions addressing these issues: logistics, including tracking and processing; reviewer selection; and employee awareness campaigns.

Our main goal is to ensure that employees receive credit for their suggestions, following a pattern of review as the following:

- Employee completes form, attaches separate breakdown on savings expected, and submits material to supervisor.
- Supervisor signs, acknowledges awareness of the idea, and returns signed form to employee.
- Employee signs, tears off pink copy, and forwards form to ESP coordinator.
- Coordinator signs, tears off pink copy, and forwards to chairperson of the ESP review committee.
- Chairperson of ESP committee meets with review committee: They accept or reject suggestion, and return decision to ESP coordinator, who gives decision to employee's department head.
- ESP coordinates or determines whether suggestion has financial impact.

IV. BENEFITS OF ADOPTING THE PROGRAM

1. Central Company will increase revenues

Suggestions for new products and improvements to existing products have the potential for increasing marketing share and sales. Last year Far East Company increased revenues by \$1.2 million. Of that total 20% can be attributed to its employee suggestion program . . .

2. Central Company will decrease costs

Research conducted by Management Associations and by our outside consultant reports that no one knows how to streamline operations and increase efficiency better than employees. Surveys (on file in the chairperson's office) conducted in 199- show that costs were reduced by 1.2% through employee suggestions. . . .

3. Central Company will enhance its product line

In the training sessions, suggestions for improvements to current products and development of new products will be encouraged. Central employees, as consumers, have ideas for new products that could widen our product lines . . .

4. Central Company's morale will be enhanced

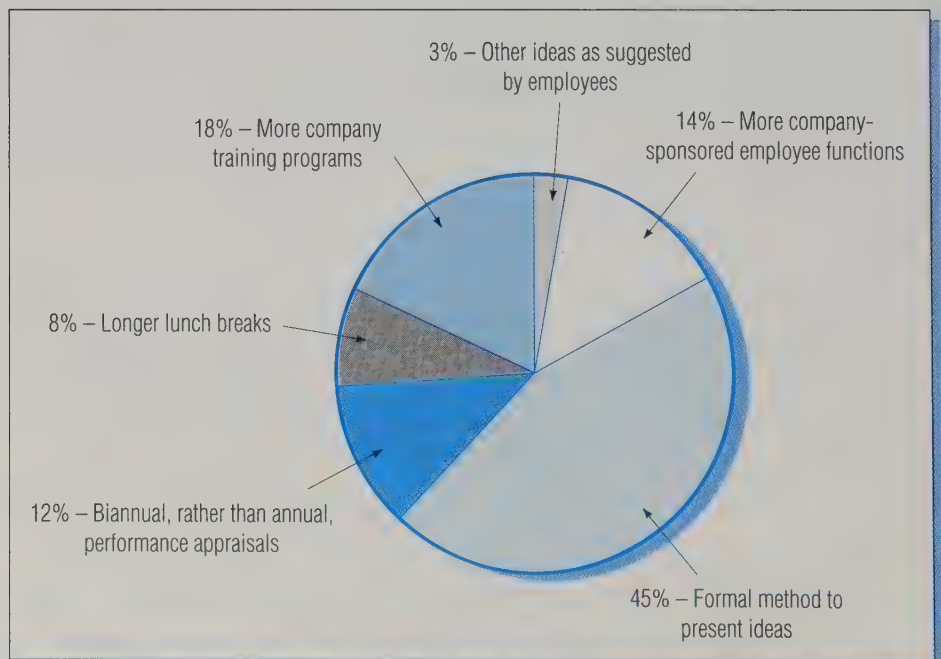
Results from a survey conducted by the American Institute of Human Resources listed "employee inclusions in the decision-making process" as a major factor in improving employee morale. As a corollary to an improved morale, we expect employee turnover to decrease. One former employee who left our employ for a competitor, for example, contributed an idea within his first six months of service that resulted in a new product. Had he remained with us, we would have benefited from that suggestion . . .

5. Central Company will improve its community relations

Appendix B Quality Circle Recommendations

We conducted seven Quality Circle meetings wherein this question was asked: What could the company do to make you feel more a part of the company? As a result of these meetings—led by our outside consultant—six areas of concern were discovered.

Results of this second investigation produced the following results:



■ Communication Probe

A significant portion of any report is its recommendation. There may be one; there may be several. Many of these recommendations demand a process or procedure for implementing the recommendations. Actions desired or instructions to implement must be clear to the reader. High-impact writing, say two researchers (clear purpose, layout of direction, short paragraphs, simple sentences, subject and verb close together, active verbs, and others), as applied to compliance instructions, made instructions clearer. Additionally, high-impact style may also elicit more timely responses than other styles of writing. Finally, using the deductive structure of organization (recommendation, conclusion first) is also effective in bringing about a higher rate of compliance and understanding.

Rogers, H. G., & Brown, F. W. (1993). The impact of writing style on compliance instructions. *The Journal of Technical Writing and Communication*, 23(1), 53–71.

In sections of the report just illustrated, the writers decided not to include outside sources or a bibliography. Most of their work was done internally; most data came from internal personnel and outside competitors and related groups. To include the names of competitors—as part of the outside groups consulted—is not appropriate in a report of this type.

SUMMARY

Throughout this chapter we connected the term *formal* with the term *long* report. The formal business report is formal because of its many parts, not because it uses formal language. A long report generally covers more complex issues and is considerably longer than the short reports discussed in Chapter 11. In addition to the body (text, discussion) of the report—where details are fleshed out—prefatory parts include the cover and external title, title fly and internal title, letter or memorandum of transmittal, table of contents, and an executive summary.

Supplementary parts of a long report include (if needed) a bibliography, footnotes or endnotes (citations), if they are necessary; appendixes; a glossary, if needed; and an index, if the report is especially long.

Documentation within the report is of two types: explaining (referring to content) or citing the sources of your information. Important here is your decision as to the format of your citations. Make a decision early to establish a consistent style, perhaps following the format of the Modern Language Association (MLA) or that of the American Psychological Association (APA). Be aware, however, that many business reports have few or no citations.

Finally, effective presentation of your long report is easier today with word processors. When using a word processor, writing, editing, revising, and typing the report is your final task. Also, be sure to apply the seven C's (Chapter 2) to your writing.

■ Communication Probe

Some companies make an inordinate effort to put together a detailed document that summarizes its corporate and mission statement: to guide behavior, to express an organizational culture, and to inspire commitment. Such reports may be short or long. Regardless of length, determining the company philosophy from the written document demands several things: a compelling philosophical statement, an effective communication and implementation process, and a process for ongoing affirmation and renewal. One company, Eaton, involves employees in an annual affirmation program, giving life to words earlier incorporated into a written statement.

Ledford, G., Wendenhof, J., & Strahley, J. (1995, Winter). Realizing a corporate philosophy. *Organizational Dynamics*, 23, 4–19.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Creating an External and Internal Title to a Foreign Company Report.*** Internal titles to your report should mirror exactly the title on the outside cover of the report. However, committees or report writers often consider several options before arriving at the final title. To achieve such a list of options, complete the following assignment: (1) read the chairperson's letter in an annual report to stockholders of a foreign company or (2) select any statement that an investment house has made about a foreign company. Then write out three different versions of a possible title page for that report. Let the class determine which of the three options comes closest to the content of the original report.
2. ***Outline of Report for Training Programs in an Aircraft Company Expanding into China.*** Read the following case and then offer an outline (down to two levels) on topics you would include in preparing a report on a training program for U.S. Flight Company.

U.S. Flight Company is to add three new support offices in China: in Sichuan province, Hunan province, and in the autonomous region of Xinjiang Uygur. These additional offices will support the expanding service commitments in China.

Those offices will be staffed by special field-service representatives of U.S. Flight who will assist the 12 airlines in China using U.S. Flight equipment. Currently, more than 200 U.S. Flight aircraft are in service, and they expect to add 150 aircraft in 1997.

Some joint venture training programs are already in place. It is the goal of the expanded training centers to train more than 1,500 personnel each year.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Topic Outline.** If you need practice in organizing topics under meaningful headings, try this assignment. Assume the sales manager of ABC New Car Agency in your city has asked you, a management consultant, to review and evaluate the agency's sales system. The internal control seems to be weak, and something is causing problems.

The main purpose of your study is to determine the strength of the internal control and its effect on the financial papers for new-car sales.

You have just finished both secondary and primary research. Two new accounting books (make up names) substantiate your concept for internal control. In your primary research you interviewed 4 middle managers and 15 or 20 employees. You studied the personality of the sales staff and the viewpoints of other personnel. You observed the personnel performing their duties and their interactions. Up to now you have information under the following topics, jumbled and in no useful order:

File clerk's job
 Key punch operator's responsibility
 Dealership's environment
 Title clerk's functions
 Salesperson's personality
 Internal control by buyers' orders
 Personnel system's internal control
 Dealership's history
 Sequence of signatures in sale of a car
 Accounting clerks' duties
 Control system's procedure
 Title clerk's work
 Sales staff's functions
 Flowchart of new-vehicle sales system [*you have drawn this on seven pages*]
 Dealership's new-vehicle sales system
 Introduction
 Conclusions
 Sales manager's part
 Bibliography

Choose main headings for the text of this report (3 or 4 should be sufficient). Then organize; place these 19 topics under the headings wherever they belong, in a complete outline of the well-planned formal report.

4. **Long Formal Report.** Your assignment is to write a formal informational or analytical report whose body is approximately 15 to 25 double-spaced pages. Choose a topic that is broad enough to justify the length. Yet beware of a topic so broad that it would require volumes. If possible, consider a subject that you know something about or one that especially interests you.

Try to find a topic that involves a business problem. (For example, you

might know there is too great a turnover of employees in a certain department.) From the problem, and with some thought on your part, you can determine the purpose of your report. Other ideas that you can use as a springboard for a topic are listed below, pertaining to problems involved in:

Accounting, credits, collections

The accountant's role in cost reduction and analysis
Computer programming and errors in monthly statements
Problems and progress of accounting in X Company
Accounting contributions to the effective management of X Company
Problems involved in a bank's converting to a computerized operation
Policy or procedure and degree of communications used by X Company in collecting retail accounts

General management and/or labor

The functioning and problems of your campus student-body governing organization; accomplishments and recommendations for greater effectiveness
A profit-sharing plan for X Company
Hiring handicapped workers: whether it would be charity or good business for X Company
A program for achieving optimum discipline in X Company
Business outlook for Y industry or X Company
Proposed plan for hiring and training minority groups in X Company
Development of a profitable ski area on a certain mountain
Suggestions for X Company's response to Z Union's attempt to organize workers
Recommendations for a formal salary scale for X Company

Personnel administration

Development of a personnel testing program for X Company
Analysis of the merit rating system of X Company
A safety program for X Company
The performance of women in top executive positions
Survey, interpretation, and recommendation—after a study on attitudes toward certain recent troublesome problems:
 Opinion of X Company's employees regarding wages, working hours, parking, food services, promotion plan
 Opinion of students in your school regarding grading, credit hours for certain courses, student parking, housing

Marketing

A promotional program for introduction of X product

A new plan for X Company to offer incentives to sales personnel
Where X Company should locate its next supermarket
How X company can measure effectiveness in its advertising
How downtown merchants can cope with suburban shopping centers

After you have clearly determined the purpose of your report, state it in one sentence. Continue your preliminary preparation. Then submit to your professor (or anyone he or she suggests) a memo report of your working plan. Be sure to include in this memo at least the following: problem, purpose, methodology, readers (both primary and secondary), and suggested outline. In this outline show the order for the introduction, major divisions of the text, subheadings for each major division, and the type of terminal section.

After you have approval of your working plan, you can begin to collect your data; then organize this material and interpret it. With the completion of this last stage—interpretation—you can draw conclusions and make recommendations. Naturally, if you're writing an informational report, you will skip interpretation of material and merely summarize. Also at this time you should prepare (at least in rough-draft form) your tables and any other necessary visual aids. If your professor requests it, submit the final outline that you will follow in writing your report—the one that will become your table of contents.

Now you should be ready to write. Choose the right time and place and follow the rules outlined in the chapter—for both the first draft and the revisions. After your final revision, you can type (or have typed) the body of the report in final draft, or you can first write the necessary prefatory and supplemental parts. In this report assignment include at least the following: cover, title page, letter of transmittal (or preface), and table of contents. Also, you will need to include other parts—especially appendix and bibliography—if your report requires them. If the transmittal may affect part of what is included in the body, you should at least plan the transmittal before the final typing of the body.

Although the content and presentation of the material are most important, also remember the role that mechanics play. Be sure you have nothing that distracts your reader from concentrating on what you want to tell. Thus, be sure the spelling, grammar, punctuation, and appearance are acceptable.

- 5. *Information Available or On-Line or Optical Disks.*** Go to either your library or your computer center where on-line databases or disks are located. Report to the class—with actual printouts—the various kinds of data available under common headings such as the following:

- General business information
- Company financial information
- Statistical data
- Industry-specific information

Your goal is to offer information as to the many kinds of electronic business data that are available. Sample printouts will permit your classmates to examine your collected information.

6. **Bibliography Styles of MLA and APA.** Obtain from your library or local bookstore the *MLA Handbook for Writers of Research Papers* or *Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association* and give the class examples of the citation style in a bibliography from either of the two works for each of the following references:

A one-author source; a two-author source
 A computer software source
 A doctoral dissertation
 Two books by the same person in a bibliography

7. **Report on Software Packages for Visual Aids.** As companies become more electronically versatile, some boards of directors insist on consistency in the use of visual aids: within reports and as overheads or slides to accompany an oral presentation. Complete a report to a board of directors that responds to the following charge:

The Board requests that you act as chairperson, along with a committee of Todd Jones, Roberta Stein, and Alanzo Pina, to complete a report on which software package our company should use within reports. We wish you to review some of the popular programs available, such as Harvard Graphics, Chart, Powerpoint, and MacPaint. There may be others you may wish to investigate. We are interested in knowing what our suppliers are using, a review of the complete costs for instituting a consistent program across the company, and a time frame for implementation. We would like your report, along with recommendation, within two months. The Secretary of the Board, Ms. Joetta Shriver, will respond to questions and review expenses in connection with your investigation.

8. **Comparative Interview of Two Writers.** Interview (1) a writer at a local newspaper or school paper and (2) a manager or administrator in your school. Determine the steps the newspaper writer goes through in preparing a report for his or her organization. Questions you may wish to ask both persons could include the following:

- In what form (oral or written) is the charge given you for your writing assignment?
- Do you do your initial outline of the topic alone, or do you depend on the help of others?
- What differences do you see between preparing your work and that of a company manager and a newspaper writer? And vice versa.
- Do you give your first draft to another person for review?
- Which guidelines do you feel are the most important when preparing your final draft?
- Are there suggestions you would give to potential writers?

Proposals

I. Purposes of Proposals

II. Kinds of Proposals

- A. Research Proposals
- B. Business Proposals

III. Parts of Proposals

- A. Title Page
- B. Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis
- C. Draft Contract
- D. Table of Contents
- E. Introduction
- F. Background
- G. Procedures
- H. Equipment and Facilities
 - I. Personnel
 - J. Budget
 - K. Appendixes

IV. Short Proposals

V. Long Formal Proposals

- A. Request for Proposal (RFP)
- B. Chronology of Procedures for Solicited Major Proposals
- C. U.S. Government Proposals
- D. Sample Sections of Long Proposals

VI. Writing Style and Appearance

VII. Summary

VIII. Exercises and Problems

Proposals may be written to departments within your own company or to outside requesters.

Persuasion lies at the heart of proposal writing. You seek to get your reader to do something, to accept your written plan for completing a task. It matters little whether your proposal is a memo or a full document. What does matter is the structure you apply to writing good proposals. You may write internal proposals, suggesting that your department can do a good job of completing a project or accomplishing a task for another department. You and your company may also go outside, submitting a “bid” that you are qualified to do something for someone else—for a fee.

Thus professors submit proposals to companies stating that they can help solve problems within a company; defense contractors submit proposals to the federal government that they can build something for the Department of Defense; advertising agencies bid on being the “agency of record” in publicizing a product or an idea for a client; companies submit proposals to foreign governments that they can build everything from bridges to skyscrapers—the list is endless.

This chapter discusses purposes, kinds, and parts of proposals; short and long proposals; and writing style and appearance of proposals.

PURPOSES OF PROPOSALS

The federal government is one of the largest requesters for proposals.

Numerous groups solicit proposals; the U.S. government is one of the foremost requesters. These requests may appear in trade publications or newspapers, or on occasion a Request for Proposal (RFP) is directed toward a company with specific expertise. Proposal topics are varied, as the following examples illustrate:

■ Communication Probe

Many universities in the United States have offices devoted solely to keeping track of proposal requests offered to the public and assisting others in writing responses to those proposals. Personnel and various booklets in those offices often tell why proposals writers fail—what gets in the way of being successful. Likewise, the federal government—and often chiefs of staff of members of Congress—make a sincere effort to help contractors obtain grants and success when approaching federal or state government offices. The Chief of Staff for Senator Dodd of Connecticut once pinpointed the central problems that block effective proposal writing: unclear purpose, inability to be concise, failure to follow the formalities as stated in the request for bid, unqualified individual or company, and lack of supporting data. Interestingly, only one of these drawbacks does not relate to writing.

Powell, M. C. (1996, February). [Interview with Michael C. Powell, Chief of Staff to Senator Christopher Dodd, Connecticut]. Washington, D.C.

- To sell property, such as airplanes, machines, buildings
- To construct parking structures, buildings, bridges, water systems, complete power plants, highways
- To survey water areas for possible oil fields
- To plan and construct airport baggage conveyor systems
- To clean up the ground soil at military airports

Although the above topics are large in scope, smaller projects are also made known to individuals and corporations:

- Improving engineering and just-in-time (JIT) performance within a company
- Communicating strategic issues throughout the company
- Preparing international managers for work in Asia
- Planning and basic research before developing an automobile factory in Mexico
- Constructing—as a subcontractor—buildings as part of a large project

Thus the purpose of a proposal is similar to that of a recommendation-justification report, discussed in Chapter 11. Both aim to solve a problem, alter a procedure, find answers to questions, offer advice and training, or conduct research on a topic of interest to both parties.

In some instances proposals submitted to a requesting agency or a company are also sent to outside readers or a review committee. These experts evaluate and can make recommendations concerning the credibility of the proposer, the legitimacy of the proposed benefits of the proposed services, the worthiness of previously produced products, and other relevant topics. Basically a requester is concerned with one question: Will the proposal as stated meet our needs? Money is the main medium of exchange, but some firms also barter (offer their services or product for another's services or product).

Outside reviewers may also read your proposal submitted to a requester.

KINDS OF PROPOSALS

Research Proposals

Proposals are sales presentations, easily classified into research proposals and business proposals. Simply put, a research proposal is usually academic in nature. Professors, or the school for which they work, desire to obtain a grant in response to a request or an announcement from the government or other agency. A proposal may even appear in a foreign language.

EXAMPLE 1 [*From government's Commerce Business Daily.*]

[[In Japanese]] Hiroyuld Ito, Director-General, Administration Bureau, Nagoya University, Furo-Cho, Chikusa-Ku, Nagoya 464-01, Japan. . . . Agency's Public notice for this tender no 510. Opening date 15:00, Oct. 31, 1996. Open tender no: product:

multidisplay information system for campus communication . . .

[Then follows the details needed and further information and office to contact.]

EXAMPLE 2 [From U.S. Information Agency (USIA).]

Professors and school or university departments often submit requests for research proposals.

USIA's Office of Academic Programs seeks proposals to the College and University Development Program in Business Management for Croatia and Macedonia. . . . The purpose of the exchange program is to develop curricula and teaching methodologies for foreign faculties in the field of business management. . . . Courses developed may include, but are not limited to, marketing, production management, economics, industrial relations, finance, accounting, international business, and business communications.

[Then follows information on contacts for submitting the proposal.]

Academic institutions submit most research proposals. Companies also want to become involved. That way they make contact with and become involved in the agency requesting the proposal. But most business employees will submit business proposals, our focus in the following discussion.

Business Proposals

In length, proposals may be similar to other reports—short or long and formal. Also, like reports, proposals may be *solicited* or *unsolicited*. An organization often knows in advance those individuals and corporations that are qualified to bid on a job or help solve a problem. So requests may come via the mails (as illustrated later in this chapter), or in the case of the government via the daily published *Commerce Business Daily*, in which between 500 and 1,000 notices are announced.

When you write a solicited business proposal, remember that you most likely will have many competitors also bidding for that contract (and the remuneration). Follow meticulously the proposal requirements of the solicitor, regarding problem, needed solution, specific work to be done or equipment to be installed, even the format of the proposal, number of copies desired, deadlines, and so forth. Whenever possible, use the outline and same words the agency has in its literature or guidelines. Do not use jargon that only you and your assistants can understand.

Likewise, when you write an *unsolicited* proposal, you need to convince the reader or review committee that you understand the organization's problem and that your firm or you are qualified to solve it successfully.

PARTS OF PROPOSALS

The parts of a proposal, listed below, may be used in major business proposals on sales of your company's services, expertise, equipment, or extensive installation

facilities. Or they may be adapted for a research study within your own firm or for another company outside your firm. Of course, only long, comprehensive proposals require most of or all these parts. Smaller projects may use only a few. Information required for a \$100 million grant or sales contract will surely be longer and more profound than for a \$500 research allowance. Therefore, *consider carefully which parts are desirable for your specific proposal outline.*

Title Page

Title pages of proposals are similar to either short or long reports.

Most organizations specify the information to be included in the title page, some even providing special forms that summarize basic administrative and fiscal data. As a minimum, the title page should include the title, the name of the person or company to whom the proposal is submitted, the person submitting the proposal, and the date. When in doubt, follow the suggestions in Chapter 12 concerning the title page for a report.

Executive Summary, Abstract, Synopsis

Even brief proposals should have an executive summary. Because you will be competing with others for the same opportunity, some evaluators will initially read only the executive summary, seeking to gain a quick overview. In fact, the executive summary should speak for the complete proposal, it should be able to stand alone, and it should summarize how objectives will be met and what procedures will be followed. Budget figures are frequently omitted because proposal abstracts may receive wide distribution.

Some proposal readers feel that the executive summary is one of the most important parts of a proposal; give it careful time and effort.

Draft Contract

A draft contract allows the receiver to offer a counteroffer.

In long proposals—and if the reader is nonhostile—a draft contract may be inserted after an executive summary. Such an early presentation (deductive) gives an immediate overview, including financial information.

Table of Contents

Brief proposals usually do not require a table of contents. Long proposals do require one, as well as a list of tables, figures, and illustrations.

Introduction

Purpose

Do not take for granted that the reader of your proposal will be the same person who sent you a request for a proposal. Staff members often give the proposal an initial reading, actually doing some screening before sending the proposal along, which is why you should write the introduction as if you were approaching a nonspecialist. Your purpose is often stated in infinitive form, as for example:

- To recommend a format for Board of Director Reports
- To bid on supplying 40 aircraft engines to Aviation Supplies Corporation
- To be the printer for the biannual Defense Contract Audit Manuals
- To supply the engineering data needed to retrofit Company Y's nuclear generating plant

Problem

In a business proposal, show clearly that you understand the problem or problems. Does your reader need a complex remodeling and construction job or extensive equipment replacement? If pertinent, mention difficulties that may be encountered and consider how you propose to overcome them. If your proposal concerns a research study, is it a community problem, for the local area or a general area?

Scope

Be precise about the scope of a project when dealing with a foreign country or company.

If your proposal is for service or equipment you are selling, in what areas will it serve the prospective buyer? Define the boundaries of your project. If you are proposing a research study, will you study one area of a community, company, department, or severe problem? What boundaries are you setting to accomplish your objectives?

Project Team

Even in short reports some proposals include a listing of the individuals who will work on the project, including the project director. In long proposals such information is a must, including a brief vita on each individual.

■ Communication Probe

Clarity in Stating the Problem and Purpose Statement

We are tempted to say “that it goes without saying” that a good report, a good proposal includes basic information. Thus most requests for proposals (RFPs) are a public cry for help: to solve a problem, to find an answer, to complete a project. We recommend that when writing a proposal, the problem be stated clearly: It is the core issue, the main theme, the heart of what your proposal will address. Without a clear understanding of the problem, your recommendation is meaningless. The problem statement is distinctly different from the *purpose statement*, a term referring to the precise end (stated preferably in an infinitive form) of the entire report.

Wayne, F. S., & Scriven, J. D. (1991, March). Problems and purpose statements: Are they synonymous terms in writing reports for business? *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communication*, 54(1), 30–37.

Background

If your proposal is short, the background may be omitted; in a longer proposal, information such as the following is usually included:

- Previous work completed on identical or related projects
- Possibly, literature reviews on the subject, particularly your evaluation of them
- Statements showing how your proposal will build on the already completed projects and research

Procedures

Here you briefly state, without exaggeration, how you will meet the requirements of your reader. A good way to review your proposals—they will be different in each situation—is to follow the suggestions in Checklist 13.1.

Equipment and Facilities

Show that you have thought deeply enough to realize what facilities will be needed. If your proposal is for your company's bid on an enormous construction job, probably several departments will cooperate with you in presenting needed facts and figures.

For a research project, state what equipment and facilities you already have for use, and assure that you can get the rest. Depending on the type of project, you might, for example, need everything from an electronic blackboard to a small airplane.

Personnel

If you did not include brief information on the individuals involved in the project in the introduction, a longer section is appropriate here. Two topics should be addressed: the personnel arrangements and the company areas involved, and their individual qualifications, expressed in complete biographic form. Include also the percentages of time that personnel will devote to the project.

■ Checklist 13.1 Basic Preparation for Writing a Proposal

1. Be realistic as to what you can accomplish. Avoid overextending your capabilities and those of your company.
2. Be specific as to method of meeting all goals.
3. Be precise with the time schedule.
4. Be clear as to how you will evaluate your work, production, or product.
5. Be exact as to the scope: What you will do and what you will not do.

Budget

Sponsors or organizations requesting proposals frequently specify how the budget should be presented. Read such specifications carefully. Not all groups allow the same costs.

While some budget sections may be in tabular or even a form of visual aid, it is customary to include a "budget justification" section, stating in paragraph form a further rationale for your financial figures.

Figure 13.1 is a sample tabular 12-month budget. "Sponsor" is the government office or organization for which the work will be done; "Company" is the firm that requests the funding.

TWELVE-MONTH BUDGET			
	Sponsor	Company	Total
PERSONNEL			
Project director, quarter-time	\$...	\$...	\$...
Project associate, 10%	...	...	...
Research assistant, half-time	...	...	...
Clerk-typist, half-time	...	...	...
Subtotal	\$...	\$...	\$...
Staff benefits (21% of salaries and wages)	\$...	\$...	\$...
Subtotal	\$...	\$...	\$...
CONSULTANTS	\$...	\$...	\$...
MATERIALS AND SUPPLIES			
Miscellaneous office supplies	\$...	\$...	\$...
Glassware	...	...	...
Chemicals	...	...	...
Subtotal	\$...	\$...	\$...
TRAVEL			
Project director consultation with sponsor, Washington, D.C., and return. 1 person, 2 days:	\$...	\$...	\$...
Air fare	...	...	...
Per diem @ \$100/day	...	...	...
Local transportation	\$...	\$...	\$...
Subtotal			
TOTAL DIRECT COSTS	\$...	\$...	\$...
INDIRECT COSTS (60% of modified total direct costs)	\$...	\$...	\$...
GRAND TOTAL	<u>\$45,064</u>	<u>\$7,909</u>	<u>\$52,973</u>

Figure 13.1 Sample budget.

Appendixes

Some reviewers of proposals leave reading of appendixes to the last, if they read them at all. Additional bulk may to the reader represent additional padding, and could produce a negative reaction. Certainly, visuals (maps or graphs) and some pertinent letters of support and endorsement can be added. But when in doubt, leave out.

SHORT PROPOSALS

Following are sections of a proposal submitted to a utility company to complete two units of their power substation, part of a much larger project:

- Letter of transmittal
- Executive summary
- Body of proposal with information on: project team, scope of services, construction contract packages, computerized engineering system

Letter of Transmittal

Engineering Company
[address]
[City, State, Zip]

September 22, 199-

Mr. Thurston Blair
[usual internal address]

Dear Mr. Blair:

With pleasure we respond to your Request for Proposal sent to us on August 20, 199-. We at Engineering Company are happy to be included in your list of companies qualified to construct two units

■ Communication Probe

The term *fact book* accompanies some proposals: various collections of evidence to accompany the prose discussion. Additionally, proposals to either the federal government or to outside agencies now include computer graphics technology. Thus, it is now possible, with the ever-increasing numbers of software packages, to use color graphics and photographs in the proposals. Good prose, plus high-technology graphics, can lead to successful proposal presentation.

Barr, S. (1995, Winter). Proposal production: Full color and fast! *Economic Development Review*, 13, 37–40; Weddle, R. (1995, winter). Preparing tailored fact books and prospect proposals. *Economic Development Review*, 13, 32–36.

of your power plant, completely with all internal controls.

Since receiving your letter we have appointed a special internal committee to respond to the questions and procedures outlined in your earlier note. The attached report is structured to correspond to the numbered sections of your letter.

You will note that your requirements are highlighted in italics with our responses following in normal-type style. On occasion we have also included some editorial comments where we feel we are especially strong in meeting your requirements.

Throughout, we have quoted figures that we feel respond favorably to your request that we keep our budget figures at a minimum. Indeed, we feel our figures will be highly competitive inasmuch as we completed a similar project for another utility in Australia. References from that company and many others with whom we have worked in the past are available for your inspection and review.

If after reading the enclosed proposal you have questions or desire additional information, please give me a call at (313) 555-4567. If I do not hear from you, the committee and I look forward to meeting you and your review committee on October 9, 1991, at 9:00 A.M. in our offices.

JR<sub>9:hhh

Sincerely,

Henry Holt
Vice President, General Manager

Executive Summary

Engineering Company is capable of constructing Units 1 and 2 of Utility Company power plant project, with a common control room between the two units, for a total cost of \$6 million.

To meet the above responsibilities we have moved forward on the following assumptions:

- No provisions have been made for additional units on the site.
- The project will be completed within one year after signing of the final contract.
- Optional labor-hours beyond the contract will be billed at the rate of \$25 plus 15%.
- The control units will be air-insulated.
- The soil conditions presume that foundations can be supported on undisturbed earth.

- The water source will be the Fox River.
- No auxiliary boilers will be required.

All pretesting of the site confirms that we can complete the project within one year, as stated in your Request for Proposal letter of September 22, 199-.

Seven individuals will be assigned to completing the project: an executive representative, a project manager, two project engineers, a project construction manager, a lead construction manager, and a lead procurement representative. The lead construction manager will be on site through the completion of the project.

Body of Proposal

[The proposal follows the main sections of your Request for Proposal: The Project Team; Scope of Services; Draft Contracts; Financial Details; and Similar Project Labor-Hour Comparisons.]

Project Team

Henry Holt, P.E.
Executive Representative-Responsible executive in overall charge of the operation
Vice President and General Manager
Publications information
Vita information

John McCabe, P.E.
Proposed project manager
Publication information
Vita information

W. Theofile Cooley
Proposed project engineer
Publication information
Vita information (and a list of five other names)

Scope of Services

I. Scope of Services

The services are delineated below (subject to addition or deletion as the Owner may determine). *[Sections have been omitted.]*

- A. A Project Design Manual will be prepared within 180 days of the contract award outlining all project parameters for the re-

view and approval of the Owner. Included in the manual will be eight areas:

- General description of the units
- Organizational charts of the Owner and Engineering Company
- Administrative procedures
- Engineering criteria
- Description of contract packages (both equipment and construction)
- List of studies to be performed
- Project economic criteria
- Testing and start-up procedures

. . .

- H. Provide a scale model program coordinated with various equipment suppliers. That model will yield sufficient detailed information to be used as a design verification and training tool.

We will prepare a 3/8-inch scale model of the units. Structural members, equipment, ducts, and control panels will be included. The model will be shipped to the site to be used during construction. Two hundred hours will be required to complete the model.

. . .

- L. Procurement and related services

1. Will recommend a list of qualified bidders for both equipment and supplies. Visit the bidder facilities and prequalify bidders or to verify qualifications.
2. Assist the Owner in procedures for purchasing and procurement recommendations on equipment and materials with long lead times.
3. Contract specifications will be prepared in accordance with all government regulations.

II. Proposal Construction Contract Packages

<u>Title</u>	<u>Explanation of Scope</u>
General Services	Site mobilization, security services, maintenance, fur-

	nish and install temporary construction power.
Site Preparation	Site clearing, rough grading, excavation and fill; furnish and install storm drainage, erosion control systems and site fencing. Construction sedimentation control ponds, roads, and parking facility subgrades. Furnish and install all temporary buildings for engineering work.
Material Testing	Perform all site material testing.
Main Foundations	Construct base slab for the two units. Place concrete. Furnish and install underslab and embedded piping, grounding, and conduit for electrical units.
Unit Enclosures	Furnish and install main building enclosures for the two requested units complete with elevated concrete floors and floor metal deck, siding, roof deck, doors, sash, louvers and masonry. Furnish and install complete interior partitions and architectural work for main units including plumbing and plumbing fixtures.

[Thereafter follow several pages of additional detail.]

III. Computerized Engineering System

For years Engineering Company has been in the foreground of using computer-assisted engineering techniques. Our 15,000-square-foot planning and design building houses all the conceivable forms of computing hardware and software. Additionally, we have on staff three computer programmers, two technical experts, and an office dedicated to working with individuals directly involved in the project.

A software package developed in-house will be used throughout the project. That software currently contains over 100 standard report formats. And with the Report Writer insert in our program, our reports can readily be modified to meet the Owner's needs and ours.

Copies of several of our report forms are included in the appendix to this report.

Foremost, our system will be set up following authorization with the overall architect for your project. Initially, the installation will be in our [city] office with a CRT and plotter in our on-site office. Before construction begins, a minicomputer will be moved to the job site.

As a summary of our capabilities, the following software subsystems will be used throughout the project:

- Command processing
- Planning and scheduling
- Estimating
- Cost and performance measurement
- Property records
- Data management
- Report writer capable of handling reports as the following:
 - ⇒ Time Scheduling
 - ⇒ Target Scheduling
 - ⇒ Estimating
 - ⇒ Accounting
 - ⇒ Cost Controls
 - ⇒ Graphics

Realize that in working with some foreign governments, a contract as a result of an accepted proposal means bargaining will still occur.

It has been your authors' experience that over the years more detail, more precision is being included in proposals. You will note in the above example that much detailed information is included. Such detail avoids misunderstandings,

■ Communication Probe

Visual displays are often a part of each proposal. Even are used in completing a project. In our opinion one of the best books on the subject is Tufte's *The Visual Display of Quantitative Information*, a true masterpiece of prose and visual examples. Therein Tufte notes five principles for graphic excellence that can be used in proposals and other kinds of business writing:

1. Interesting data is a mixture of substance, statistics, and design.
2. Clarify, precision, and efficiency are needed to communicate complex ideas.
3. Giving the greatest number of ideas in the shortest time is a mark of visual excellence.
4. Multivariate visuals distinguishes it from average visuals.
5. Truth, as an ethical precept, is core to good graphic design.

Tufte, E. (1983). *The visual display of quantitative information*. Cheshire, CT: Graphics Press.

avoids lawsuits, and hastens completion of a project. On the international level such proposal detail is even more necessary. Add the additional impediment of several languages, and the problems of interpretation can multiply. Too often it is said of foreign companies and governments, "once the proposal is signed, the real bargaining begins." If you agree on the details early, you avoid the miscalculations that can slow or even stop a project until the clarification is complete.

LONG FORMAL PROPOSALS

Large projects require proposals with elaborate detail; some may be bound into several volumes when the dollar figure is in millions or even billions of dollars. Excerpts relating to information connected to long formal proposals follow:

Interest groups from throughout the United States have offices in Washington, D.C., to keep tabs on current and upcoming requests for proposals.

- Request for Proposal (RFP)
- Chronology of procedures for solicited major proposals
- Submitting proposals to the federal government
- Samples of sections from long proposals

Request for Proposal (RFP)

A government, a company, an agency, an individual may send an RFP to outside vendors who they feel are qualified to complete a given project.

Requester

Department of Defense
(airplanes, ships)

Electric utility (plant
modification)

Auto company (foreign
auto plant expansion)

Foreign government
(Singapore airport
expansion)

Foreign government
(high-speed train service
from Beijing to Shanghai)

Survey of consumer
attitudes (social research)

Possible Vendors

Vendors have to possess basic qualifications or on occasion have produced products for the government; thus qualified, large vendors receive requests to submit bids for specific airplanes, submarines, warships, and numerous other items used by the federal government

Design and construction companies: to either modify, for instance, present nuclear facilities to coal-fired facilities

Professors at major universities with expertise in the country in which the auto company desires to expand

Construction companies in Japan, Indonesia, and the United States

Foreign governments and railroad engineering firms in Germany, Japan, and France

Schools of business that have expertise in assessing consumer attitudes throughout the country

"Short lists" consists of persons or groups who are the final candidates for winning the proposal.

Thus, for any of these projects the agency could submit an RFP to an outside vendor who they feel qualifies to bid on the request. Each vendor—and there may be several—receives the identical preliminary information.

Such a common approach helps the soliciting group. It can now compare data, determine who will be asked to submit a more detailed proposal. (Being asked to submit a second proposal is called making the "short list.") In brief, the soliciting group for large contracts, for instance in excess of \$100 million, (1) sends a preliminary request to possible interested parties and (2) eliminates through this initial screening some companies. It is the "short list" of vendors who are asked for more detailed information, again in competition with others on that "short list."

Excerpt from Request for Proposal (RFP) Letter

The following letter is from a large automotive company in the United States interested in building a completely new facility to produce automobiles. This preliminary letter sought to determine which construction companies had some interest in the project before requesting more detailed information.

Letterhead of Requester

Gentlemen:

Our company as you know has for over 80 years been involved in the designing, engineering, and assembling of automobiles throughout the United States. We would like to discuss your firm's capabilities, resources, experience, philosophy, and innovative approaches to assist our internal team in the design and construction of an entirely new auto assembly facility.

If your response is favorable, we will provide a complete conceptual package containing master specifications, building sections and elevations, a construction budget, scope of services, etc. Your organization, if ultimately selected, will perform complete engineering services to general construction bid documents. These services will be rendered on a lump-sum basis.

If your firm is interested in being a partner in this endeavor, we would like to hear from you and arrange for a discussion in your facilities within the next month. In line with our company's approach, we have attached certain preliminary information and will present further details related to the project upon our visit. To make arrangements, please call . . .

Sincerely,

[Name]

■ Checklist 13.2 Request for Proposal (RFP) Communication

1. Leave no doubt as to the product or service for which you desire bids.
2. Give the precise name of the person and address—even the phone number—to whom your proposal should be sent.
3. Be precise as to what bidders must include: This makes initial screening easier in locating qualified candidates.
4. Indicate the time by which the proposal should arrive.

Attached to this cover letter were four pages requesting preliminary information, divided into four major categories and subpoints. Note the detail; note the importance given to company philosophy in addition to construction data.

Company's philosophy and mission

Corporate philosophy

People philosophy

Mission

General description of possible facilities

Administration and support facilities

Ancillary facilities

General assembly facility

Body shop facility

Manufacturing facility

Paint shop facility

Powerhouse-cogeneration facility

Powertrain facility

Site work

Stamping facility

Water-wastewater facility

Tentative Company engineering schedule

General Company technical requirements

Chronology of Procedures for Solicited Major Proposals

A complete chronology of the entire process for a major proposal could go through eight steps:

The oral statement offered in defense of the proposal—often when making the short list—must be well-prepared, well-rehearsed.

1. The soliciting company publicly announces a project in professional publications, newspapers, and newsletters or writes to certain companies asking if they are interested in bidding on the project. (See the cover letter on p. 368 as an example of such an initial request.)
2. Contacted companies, and others reacting to the public announcement, submit preliminary proposals based on initial request information.
3. The soliciting company reviews all submitted documents, eliminates some companies on the basis of this preliminary review, and establishes a “short list” of finalists.
4. The soliciting company (a) asks each of the finalists bidding for the contract to submit a highly detailed proposal and (b) sets deadlines for receiving the proposal.
5. Finalist (the “short list” candidates) companies select their written and oral presentation teams; writing of their proposal proceeds through several editions; oral rehearsals of statements based on the proposal occur.
6. Finalist companies submit proposals to the soliciting group; dates are established for the oral presentation to the soliciting group.
7. Finalist companies make their presentations.
8. Finalist companies wait for response—from one month to as long as half a year, or longer.

U.S. Government Proposals

The preceding eight-step process is common in business proposals, and the federal government—one of the largest receivers of proposals—has a similar review process. There, however, the soliciting agency will hold its own internal review, but may also involve outside experts, frequently including representatives, for instance, from the Defense Contract Audit Agency.

When one is writing a proposal for the government, it is necessary to meet strictly each agency’s proposal requirements, learned through contacting a contracting officer or requesting proposal specifications as announced in the *Commerce Business Daily*. Such a request for a proposal follows:

U.S. Department of Labor, Office of Procurement
Services Room S-5220, 200 Constitution Ave., N.W.
Washington, D.C. 20210

Government proposals save space and time by extensive use of abbreviations; a key for those abbreviations often precedes the request.

70-PERSONAL LIBRARY SOFTWARE & CENTRAL SITE
MAINTENANCE SOL RFP L/A 94-38 DUE 091694 POC Raymond J. Vanzego, Contract Negotiator (202) 555-6445. The Department of Labor intends to enter into sole source negotiations with Personal Librarian Software, of 2400 Research Boulevard, Suite 350, Rockville, Maryland 20850, for Personal Librarian Software. 25 current users on 300 enterprise network and add-on software including "P/L Batch"

and "Replica" as needed. Also, Central Site Maintenance Plan that will include future upgrades as released. This notice is for information purposes only. No solicitation document is available. Interested persons may identify their interest and capability to respond to the requirement or submit proposals. All responses to this notice must be received within fifteen (15) days of the date of publication of this notice, and must cite RFP L/A 94-38. (0244)

After reading the above solicitation, you could contact the person named first in the proposal. He would give you additional information and send appropriate forms.

The Washington, D.C., area and its environs are crowded with offices of special-interest groups seeking to obtain contracts from the government. Many of those offices maintain personal contacts with many government offices and know of impending RFPs. Additionally, these offices include samples of successful proposals they have used in the past. Fair warning: The competition is keen; proposals must be well-written and -researched.

Sample Sections of Long Proposals

So important are proposals for some firms that they have spent thousands of dollars to equip their own company libraries with individual study rooms and up-to-date research facilities plus a staff of typists, designers, photographers, editors, and computer experts. Their main purpose is to help their marketing representatives turn out top-quality, winning proposals—solicited and unsolicited.

■ Checklist 13.3 Submitting Proposals to the Government

Most government Requests for Proposals are sufficiently detailed. Thus in your reading of the *Commerce Business Daily* you will receive sufficient precise information. Nevertheless, we recommend that you speak with the person or office listed in the announcement, for two reasons: Doing so will answer your questions and will indicate your deep interest in the proposal. In that phone call:

1. Ask if they are willing to send you sample successful proposals from the past.
2. Ask if the proposal is a new one.
3. Ask if there is in place a contractor whose contract has expired (*by law the government must request open bids on the expiration of certain contracts*).
4. Ask if there is anything not listed in the request that you should be concerned with in writing the proposal.

Often thousands of dollars are spent on preparing the visual appearance of a proposal.

Nor is visual persuasion on the written proposal neglected. Company logos are often on each page and name card. Color is used extensively. All visual aids may be bound in a separate booklet or be on various pages of the proposal. For example, one marketing executive's successful unsolicited major proposal has on its colorful cover an accurate sketch of the prospective customer's buildings. The proposal—32 pages, single-spaced—is attractively bound and protected by a plastic cover. Inside are also five appropriate full-page pictures. Here is that proposal's considerate transmittal letter (with changed names); it was typed on the company's letterhead and bound in the proposal:

Dear Mr. Johnson:

**Purpose: review
of RASC needs**

Thank you for the opportunity to review the communication needs of the Region Administrative Services Center.

**Problem areas
and solutions to
be discussed**

In the past few years this administrative center has grown rapidly in both staff and services to the community. Because your communications system has not kept pace with your growth, a number of communication-related problems have developed.

Your department heads, receptionists, and employees have been most cooperative during our discussions to determine major communication problem areas. The problems uncovered and the solutions to them are discussed in the following pages.

**RASC benefits
from two pro-
posed systems**

Metrodynamic Communications looks forward to providing a telecommunications system that will grow and expand as your Center expands. To meet that goal, we recommend a Direction PBX. The Direction PBX features stored program control combined with time division switching, which provides exceptional versatility for today's needs and is easily adaptable to future requirements.

As an alternative, Centrex II will also respond to your needs, with capabilities somewhat different from the Direction system.

**Benefits now
and in future**

Either system will provide the Regional Administrative Services Center with an efficient, flexible, versatile system for today and tomorrow. I am looking forward to working with you on a continuing basis.

Sincerely,

■ Communication Probe

Fifteen academic researchers were interviewed to probe some of the complex relationships between them and outside funding agencies. It was found that some of the problems of academics also pertain to other proposal writers. A major conclusion was this: Proposal writing and the funding process is a highly political, multi-institutional enterprise. Those two situational factors, and others, mitigated against successful funding of proposals. As with interpersonal communication, all felt the need for more communication between researchers and potential funding agencies.

Mehlenbacher, B. (1994, September). The rhetorical nature of academic research funding, *IEEE Transactions on Professional Communication*, 37, 157–162.

This proposal's table of contents includes six major parts. Each part is preceded by a title listing its topics, some with subheads and pertinent pictures. The body of the proposal is neatly typed with helpful headings (second-, third-, and fourth-degree). Colorful illustrations and pictures help emphasize that the proposed system is "efficient, economical, flexible." Important figures, rates, charges, and other details are shown in tables both within the text and in the appendix.

The following are sample headings found in longer formal proposals for (1) a general proposal, (2) a construction management proposal for several million dollars, and (3) a research proposal.

PROPOSAL 1 *A general formal proposal.*

1. *Prefatory parts*

- Title page
- Letter of transmittal
- Table of contents
- List of tables and/or figures (if any)
- Executive summary or abstract

2. *Body of proposal*

- Introduction
 - Problem
 - Need
 - Background
 - Objectives or purpose
- Procedures (discussion section)
 - Methods and sources
 - Plan of attack
 - Sequence of activities
 - Equipment, facilities, products
 - Personnel qualifications

Evaluation and benefits of project
Budget of costs, prices, total bid

3. *Supplementary parts*

Agency forms
Budget justification
References
Tables, maps, or graphs (if any)

PROPOSAL 2 *A construction management proposal.*

1. *Prefatory parts*

Cover, with title
Inside title page
Table of contents
Request for proposal letter (owner's solicitation letter)
Response to proposal letter (company's cover letter)
Description of owner's requirements
Scope of services
Description of facilities
Working relationship
Contracts
Schedule for selecting architect or engineer
Phase 1, qualifying firms
Phase 2, interviews
Phase 3, negotiations of fees and notice to proceed

2. *Body of proposal*

General format
Approach to delivery of services
Capabilities of firm
Demonstration of management system
Personnel in delivery of services
Contract terms and conditions
Firm information
Fee

3. *Supplementary parts*

Master project schedule
Vendor surveillance
Projected fuel analysis
Table defining direct costs, overhead fees

PROPOSAL 3 *A research proposal.*

1. *Prefatory parts*

Title
Abstract
Table of contents
Introduction (including statement of problem, purpose of research, and significance of research)

2. *Body of proposal*

Background (including literature survey)

Description of proposed research (including method or approach)

Description of relevant institutional resources

List of references

Personnel

Budget

WRITING STYLE AND APPEARANCE

All the rules of writing, including the seven C's, pertain to proposal writing.

You will be wise to apply all business communication principles and report-writing techniques when writing the proposal—whether it is for a research grant or for a million-dollar sales contract by your company. Remember also that appearance throughout your proposal makes important nonverbal impressions.

In its digest on proposal writing, the Washington State Office of Economic Opportunity includes the following excellent advice:

First impressions are very critical. None is more so than that first impression your proposal gives to the reader when submitted to an agency or foundation for consideration. Many proposals are lost at the first look by the reader. He [or she] appraises the proposal immediately in terms of:

- | | |
|----------------------------|--|
| 1. General appearance | 4. Consistency of style |
| 2. Neatness | 5. Title—is it grandiose or does it properly describe the project? |
| 3. Specific appearance of: | 6. Completeness |
| a. Table of contents | 7. Professionalism |
| b. List of figures | |
| c. Title page | |
| d. Maps | |
| e. Graphs | |
| f. Charts | |

Therefore, you cannot afford to skim on the time you spend in “polishing” your proposal. Each item must be checked and rechecked. Since you have spent many hours developing the proposal idea, and further hours researching and writing before your first draft, why risk your investment over poor typing, proofing, graphics, etc.? Some of the most important time spent working on the proposal will be that spent on the final draft.

If you are not an artist, it might be advisable to employ one to prepare the cover, charts, graphs, etc. The cost is minimal when you consider the potential return.

Be sure you and your typist are familiar with an appropriate typing style. Learn it well and be sure to follow it consistently. . . . Select one which best fits your needs and adopt it for all your proposals.

Don't accept or be satisfied with sloppy typing or artwork. Make sure it is reworked until satisfactory. You want all the final copy to be neat and clean prior to submission.

The preceding suggestions on proposal outline, format, writing style and appearance can be adapted to all kinds of proposals. If, instead of seeking funds for a comprehensive research study, you are writing a proposal that is your company's bid on a \$5 million sales or construction contract, the basic characteristics of the formal proposal are similar.

SUMMARY

Proposal writing is primarily persuasive writing.

Writing proposals is persuasive writing: You seek a response, wanting the reader to accept your recommendation—you wish acceptance. That is true whether writing a research proposal (more often written by professors individually or on behalf of schools or universities) or a business proposal where you hope to receive a financial return.

Requesters of proposals govern the majority of the content. The soliciting group or individual often lays out the requirements of what must be included, similar to the following 11 sections: title page, executive summary, draft contract, table of contents, introduction, background, procedures, equipment and facilities, personnel, budget, and appendixes. Most of these are similar to the inclusions in a long report.

Short proposals do not have as much detail, and are often for smaller sums of money. Here the emphasis is heavily on the qualifications of the vendor.

Long formal proposals—which often include sections similar to the above 11 parts of a proposal—are detailed and complex; they bid for huge sums of money. At this level, it is not unusual for the soliciting group to write a Request for Proposal (RFP) to already identified candidates. A “short list” of qualified vendors is formed with later requests to that small group to submit detailed proposals. Our U.S. government often operates in this manner.

Finally, writing style is no different from other short or long reports. Clarity, above all—especially in the executive summary—is needed for instant and clear communication.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. ***Preparing a Proposal for an Announced Request for Bid.*** Read the following invitation to bid (a request for proposal) that appeared in a foreign newspaper. Then do two things: (1) write a letter to the company requesting further information, and (2) assume you have received that information and write your response along lines suggested in this chapter:

INVITATION TO BID-FOREIGN COUNTRY AIRLINE

Interested buyers are invited to a sealed bidding for the sale of the following:

- a. Ten BAC aircraft in 109 seat configuration with two engines each
- b. One rediffusion flight simulator
- c. Eleven spare Rolls Royce Spey 512-14DW engines
- d. Large inventory of rotator spares, expendables

Interested parties should please contact G.L. Hong at Foreign Country Airline, Raffles Place, Singapore.

2. **Writing an RFP (Request for Proposal) Letter.** It is well known that one of the main entrances to doing business in China is via Hong Kong. There, many worldwide accounting firms have offices for working with international companies. Write an RFP letter to a U.S. company indicating that you have services to help a company establish contacts with mainland China. In writing such a proposal letter do these things:
 - a. Try to use an area of business that is your specialty, e.g., accounting, finance, marketing, human resources
 - b. Select a company in the United States that you know something about.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Proposal to Development Foundation Regarding Research Project.** Your instructor may on occasion submit a proposal either to begin or to finish a research project. Assume that he or she has asked you to join in applying to a foundation to begin a research project on the general topic of the formal preparation needed for today's executives.

Assume further that you have investigated the various private foundations in the United States and located one which has in the past funded educational research. In writing to the Development Foundation, you discover that it has specific requirements.

- a. An initial summary page should be limited to the following information:
 - Institution
 - Principal investigators
 - Brief title
 - Descriptive title
 - Time period for the investigation
 - Budget
- b. The contents of the proposal should use the following headings:
 - Request
 - Purpose of research
 - Procedure
 - Intended results
 - Time schedule
 - Budget (first, second year)
 - Investigators

Your responsibility is to (1) create a title page for the proposal and (2) develop an outline of the ideas to be included under the Development Foundation's major headings.

4. **Proposal to Another Firm to Distribute Your Firm's Products.** Assume you are marketing manager in a manufacturing firm whose products are now successfully marketed by distributors in 15 states. Assume products with which you are somewhat familiar or on which you can get specific information. They may be furniture items, building construction materials,

electronic office equipment, or others. After careful research by your staff members, you have found that a certain five-state region in the United States is expanding rapidly for various reasons (make up the reasons).

You have never before marketed your products in that region, and in the past 2 months you—with your assistant manager—have visited the area in person. Also, you have conversed with the vice president and purchasing manager of a large firm that distributes other products related in general to those your firm manufactures. However, neither that distributor nor any dealer in the area has products similar to yours. You feel sure that dealers, business firms, builders, and individual customers need and should have your products. Being without them could cause problems.

In this assignment you are to write a convincing proposal to the distributing firm's purchasing manager. Your purpose is to persuade him that the area needs the products you are selling. State the problem, purpose and benefits, scope (area in which your products will help the distributor's business), your marketing procedure, quality and prices of your products, and any other pertinent information.

5. *Report on a Proposal's Process from Initial Request to Winning Bid.*

Some local companies (engineering firms, ad agencies, and others) attempt to win contracts through submitting proposals. Your task in this exercise is to interview someone who is or was involved in preparing a proposal in one of those firms. Your goal is to trace the proposal's process: from initial request for a proposal to final selection of the winning bidder. Not all firms use identical procedures or formats; thus, you and your classmates will each learn different formats for the respective firms in your area. (1) Present a brief written report on the results of your investigation, and (2) on the option of your instructor offer a brief oral report based on the written statement.

Some interview questions helpful for your report might include the following:

- a. How were you or your firm contacted? How did you find out about the opportunity for submitting a proposal?
- b. Who determined the team to work on the proposal? What were the central goals of the proposal?
- c. Was a project leader or chairperson of the project appointed? What were his or her responsibilities?
- d. What were the major headings or parts of the proposal?
- e. Which modern technological approaches were used to supplement the oral presentation?
- f. If the company was denied the proposal, were any reasons given for denial?

6. *Proposal to a Chosen Organization or Agency.* Choose a problem that you can solve by experimentation, survey, observation, or any combination of these, and write your proposal to the organization that is concerned with the problem. Or (if more appropriate) assume your proposal goes to a fund-

ing agency whose philosophy is in keeping with the problem you propose to research. Here are suggestions for topics—but feel free to choose your own.

- a. Try to solve a problem related to a firm's product development; plant expansion; improvement of a sales, accounting, or purchasing system; or curtailment of shoplifting.
- b. Analyze a problem in your community—crime in a certain area, a traffic snarl situation, poor citizen involvement in local issues, need for attracting new industry or keeping young, educated persons in the community.
- c. Undertake a project in one of your college classes—or survey a sample of the student body regarding an important campus problem.

Follow thoughtfully the suggestion in this chapter regarding proposal writing. Organize your topics under appropriate headings, and write a proposal that meets all requirements as to content, format, and writing style. Then submit your complete proposal to (a) your instructor and/or (b) your class in an oral presentation. Be prepared to defend your proposal and to have the class critique it.

7. ***Proposals for Sponsored Research to the Government, Foundations, or Inside School Groups.*** Some schools and universities follow a basic format when submitting proposals for sponsored research, either to the government, to private foundations, or even to inside school groups. If your school has an office that helps with preparing such proposals, speak with a member of that office and determine (1) the recommended inclusions in an academic research proposal and (2) some reasons for acceptance or rejection of a proposal. Present to the class, in an oral report complete with some visual aids, the results of your findings.
8. ***Report on a Sample Instructor Proposal.*** If your school does not have an office assisting in developing proposals for either internal or external sponsored research, speak with a professor or teacher who has submitted a proposal. Determine (1) what the purpose of the proposal was, (2) what major points were covered in the proposal, and (3) what he or she felt helped the proposal to be accepted or rejected. Here too you could orally present to the class the results of your investigation, along with a visual aid that summarizes your main points.
9. ***Noting Problems in Proposal Writing.*** Most schools have certain people or even entire offices that assist instructors—even students—in writing and submitting proposals. Interview an administrator in such an office, or if there is no office, perhaps an instructor who has submitted a proposal. He or she will have some ideas as to what should or should not be done in writing a proposal. In parallel form summarize the positive and negative elements they personally feel should be avoided or included in a proposal. This report could be in the form of an executive summary or in a short report format.

Strategies for Oral Communication

Chapter 14 Strategies for Successful Speaking and Successful Listening

Chapter 15 Strategies for Successful Informative and Persuasive Speaking

Chapter 16 Strategies for Successful Interpersonal Communication

Chapter 17 Strategies for Successful Business and Group Meetings

Strategies for Successful Speaking and Successful Listening

I. Strategies for Improving Oral Presentations

- A. Steps for Preparing Effective Oral Presentations
- B. Kinds of Oral Presentations
- C. Ways of Delivering the Oral Message
- D. Strategies for an Effective Oral Delivery
- E. Strategies for an Effective Nonverbal Delivery

II. Strategies for Reducing Stage Fright

- A. Signs of Discomfort
- B. Strategies for Decreasing Speaking Fears

III. Strategies for Improving Listening Skills

- A. Faults in Listening
- B. Purposes for Listening
- C. Results of Good Listening

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

Oral communication has an ancient foundation; its roots go back to the time of the Greeks and Romans—and earlier.

In the ancient world, writers such as Aristotle, Cicero, and Quintilian—names unfamiliar to many people—were some of the Greek and Roman practitioners of the art of rhetoric or persuasion. Its roots are deep. Its heritage is oral.

Our statement suggests that orally moving a message from sender to receiver is not new. Throughout each day, in your personal life and in the world of business, you orally communicate with customers, colleagues, associates, supervisors, employees, employers, and others.

This chapter introduces you to successful strategies needed to be effective in oral communication:

- Strategies for improving oral presentations
- Strategies for reducing stagefright
- Strategies for improving listening

In a sense this chapter is macro, providing an overview of oral communication, rather than micro. Later chapters are more specific: informative and persuasive speaking, interpersonal communication, and business and group meetings. We begin with viewing basic strategies.

STRATEGIES FOR IMPROVING ORAL PRESENTATIONS

During your career in the business world, you will give various kinds of oral presentations. Indeed, how your capabilities are measured will initially occur based on your oral words. You need a strategy.

Oral presentations need a strategy: To reflect favorably upon you.

This section takes you through the steps needed to be effective in oral communication:

- Steps for preparing effective oral presentations
- Kinds of oral presentations
- Ways of delivering the oral message
- Strategies for using an effective oral delivery
- Strategies for effective nonverbal delivery

Steps for Preparing Effective Oral Presentations

Seven steps are essential for successful oral statements, short or long. The more up-front preparation you do, the more confidence you will have before a group.

1. Determine the purpose.
2. Analyze the audience and occasion.
3. Select the main ideas for the message.
4. Research the topic.
5. Organize the data and write the draft.
6. Create visual aids.
7. Rehearse the talk.

■ Communication Probe

A recent study sought to determine which modes of communication were used during a business day. Out of the eight modes frequently cited, oral communication dominated, with face-to-face communication the most common (81.4% U.S.; 77.5% Asian; and 94.4% Chinese) and use of the telephone next (81.4% U.S.; 90% Asian; and 87.6% Chinese). The following table suggests that within three cultures—even where written communication is extensively used—businesspersons still prefer to interact on the personal, oral level. It will be interesting to see what occurs over the years if more intensive use of electronic communication decreases the need for interpersonal contact.

Modes of communication used by selected U.S. executives and Asian and Chinese managers

Modes	U.S. Executives*	Asian Managers†	Chinese Managers
Face to face	81.4%	77.5%	94.4%
Telephone	81.4	90.0	87.6
Written	69.9	55.0	87.1
Mail	NA‡	NA	69.0
Teleconference	12.9	5.0	11.5
Telex	NA‡	NA	15.6
Fax	NA‡	NA	9.5
Computers	10.7	30.0	20.5

*Executives are defined as chief executive officers, presidents, and vice presidents.

†Not available in the U.S. Executive and Asian Manager database.

‡Includes Singapore, Malaysia, and Hong Kong managers.

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Liu, J. (1991). Communication through foreign languages: An economic force in Chinese enterprises. *Journal of Asian Pacific Communication*, 2(1) 45–67.

Determine the Purpose

We communicate to produce a result. We wish something to occur as a result of our words. On the macro level these overall goals are: to inform, to persuade, to entertain.

Three basic types of oral communication are found in business speaking: Informing, persuading, and entertaining.

1. To Inform or Instruct. Here your core goal is to clarify, secure understanding, explain a process. Your teacher, most often, is making a speech *to inform*. So are your authors as we write about the process of oral communication. In brief, at the conclusion of your message you hope listeners have a better comprehension of an issue, an idea, a process, a procedure.

2. To Persuade. Gaining willing acceptance of an idea is core to persuasion. Note that the key word here is *willing*. Your goal is that after you have finished your presentation, listeners will accept your proposal, your claim, your thesis;

you hope they will do as you ask them to do. Advertisements also desire a positive result. But their tools of persuasion may include the oral plus many other kinds of persuasive devices.

3. To Entertain. This speaking genre may include not only humorous statements you will make—of which there will probably be few—but also the numerous ceremonial, introductory, or stimulating statements. Social occasions such as promotion parties, retirement, or anniversaries are characteristic of this kind of speaking.

Analyze the Audience and Occasion

Whether one writes or speaks, the message must be adapted to the audience. If your talk is within your organization, you will have some idea about who and how many people will be in the audience.

As in writing, a knowledge of the audience is significant for communicating effectively.

Less information is available when speaking to outside groups. Then, seek out information such as the size of the group, age range, interests, goals, occupations, and other tidbits which could be incorporated into your remarks. Some of that information may be obtained from the person who asked you to speak and from other members of the group. If all audience members have the same occupation, such as purchasing agents or computer salespersons, you can use more technical expressions and illustrations.

Select the Main Ideas for the Message

Selecting your main theme or your core ideas should be done first. Then gathering additional information will be in support of those core ideas. Your first list of core ideas may be disorganized, haphazard, which is fine. Later you can select those ideas that are workable and offer a unified theme. Some speakers begin with filling a complete page with single words or incomplete sentences. And onto this list they impose a form of organization. Do not rush this stage of preparation; do not presume this initial structure will be your final version.

Research the Topic

It is obvious that you will not possess all information relating to your central theme. Thus, as in writing, you need to collect facts, data, information. Your research may cause you to drop some of your initial ideas and add new ones. One has only to read newspaper accounts of the President's speech to realize it was still under revision until the last moment. New facts, new views are constantly appearing.

Organize the Data and Write the Draft

Assume that you have completed gathering your information. Then it is time to force some order on your information, usually in the form of an initial outline. As

■ Communication Probe

Research on communication issues was fervent during the 1970s. Two such studies during that period suggest that the credibility of the speaker is a major predictor of success in persuasion. On the other hand if a speaker feels he or she is lacking in credibility as perceived by an audience, he or she can refer to experiences with the topic. Or, the speaker can connect him or herself with others who are competent on the topic. Therefore, one conclusion is to search out evidence that supports your message in a credible, hopefully uncontestable manner.

Lashbrook, V. (1971). Source credibility: A summary of experimental research. Paper presented at the Speech Communication Association convention, San Francisco; McCroskey, J. C. (1969). A summary of experimental research on the effects of evidence in persuasive communication. *Quarterly Journal of Speech*, 55, 169–176.

you do this, remember that a good speech has three parts: an introduction, a body (or text, discussion), and a conclusion or summary.

Remembering the PAL is an easy way to recall the major three parts of an introduction: Porch, aim, layout.

1. Introduction. Traditionally an introduction seeks to do several things: Get attention, include an aim or purpose, and lay out the direction of the speech. Think of these three elements as a *PAL*:

Porch	Your opening remarks. It is your throat-clearing statement, your preamble, your preface, your greeting. Additionally you may begin with a quotation, a question, a startling statement, a reference to the occasion, a reference to the past, a humorous story. Use these choices to get started.
Aim	Your purpose. Why you are giving the talk. Here you clearly state the aim for your remarks; you make clear your intent.
Layout	Your agenda. Cicero long ago suggested such a “layout” was the <i>divisio</i> of one’s remarks. Telling the audience your main parts, often by number, gives them a precise understanding of the major points you will cover; it’s the roadmap for what follows.

The body is the heart of your talk; here you explain and support the main purpose of your presentation.

2. Body (Text, Discussion). Some people refer to the heart of the message as the text or discussion. Here you include evidence, data for your central theme; here you organize the supports for your central purpose. Organizing the body of the talk is similar to developing the text or discussion of a major paper. However, in speaking there is often a time constraint; such a constraint demands that most talks be limited to two or three main points.

Summaries review what has been said; conclusions draw inferences from data.

3. Summary or Conclusion. A summary reminds the audience of the main ideas covered in the body of the talk, whereas a conclusion draws inferences

from the data. Regardless of your intent, there must be an ending or a “closing” to your remarks.

Create Visual Aids

Some presentations do not require visuals. It would be odd to include an overhead of the major dates in the career of a retiree. On the other hand, it would be odd not to include a visual when speaking about the structure of an organization. But most important is answering this question: Would a visual add to understanding and support of your message? A discussion of different kinds of visuals is included in Appendix A.

Rehearse the Talk

Two purposes underlie rehearsals: You will become more comfortable with your material and you can still revise where necessary. When rehearsing, stand and deliver your talk out loud.

Three rehearsals are recommended. If you rehearse too much, the statement sounds memorized.

How many times should you rehearse? Three times is about the right number. Nevertheless, a company president presenting a holiday greeting rehearsed four times; a vice president before a congressional committee went through his talk three times; a President of the United States rehearsed once. The final decision is up to you.

Keep in mind the following issues:

- Always imagine the audience in front of you.
- Use transitional phrases and sentences to show your listeners the relationships between sections of your report. Avoid long sentences and unusual words.
- Take each of the main points one at a time and learn to present each with its supporting material as a unit.
- Include the visual aids you’ll use—and in the margin, note where each aid should be used.
- Anticipate questions from the audience. Jot them on paper and consider thoughtful answers.
- Stop at the allotted time. Then cut and revise the speech accordingly until you can deliver it within the time limit, allowing also for a question-and-answer period.

Kinds of Oral Presentations

Basically, all oral communication lies between informative speaking on one end of a continuum and persuasion at the other end. For most purposes the statements are therefore some variation of inform, persuade, or entertain. Additionally, one could add such variations as motivate, inspire, and eulogize. But these are simply relatives of the three basic forms, discussed earlier in this chapter.

Short talks may range from 1 to 10 minutes in length. You may simply introduce someone, present an award to a retiree, give a briefing to visitors to your company, or offer an opening statement in a group meeting. You could also represent the company outside your office: accepting an award, showing your sup-

■ Checklist 14.1 Preparing Effective Oral Messages

1. Know the precise purpose of your presentation: Will you inform, persuade, or entertain?
2. Identify your audience and the situation. What are their approximate ages, their occupations, their interests, their biases, their reasons for being present?
3. Select the main ideas, the core concepts you wish to discuss.
4. Research your topic thoroughly.
5. Organize your information and prepare a first draft.
6. Create some visual aids, if necessary (Appendix A).
7. Rehearse your talk at least three times.

The longer the presentation, the higher the risk of losing an audience's attention.

port for a local cause, offering greetings at a community banquet. And so on and on.

Longer statements may vary from 10 minutes to 1 hour. It is not unusual in Asia, for instance, to have speeches 2 hours long. But with the increasing emphasis on brevity, some corporations limit statements to 20 or 30 minutes, knowing that attention spans decrease the longer the statement.

Ways of Delivering the Oral Message

You have four options for speaking: extemporaneous, reading, memorization, and impromptu delivery.

Extemporaneous delivery is preferred by both audiences and speakers; it allows more eye contact and more verbal and nonverbal involvement with the audience.

1. Extemporaneous

This method—most preferred by audiences and speakers—allows a speaker to use notes or an outline. He or she usually may use 3 by 5-inch cards or a full sheet of paper as notes for the remarks.

Use this method whenever possible: It allows more eye contact with an audience, permits you to establish rapport, and enables you to move with ease.

2. Reading

Major political figures and others who do not want to make a mistake read a manuscript. If they will be filmed or have their statement appear on the evening news, ad-libbing could lead to problems. A familiar story runs like this. A speaker once read his remarks and got this reaction from a listener: “I didn’t like your reading your speech; I didn’t think you read it well; and I didn’t think what you read was worth reading!”

Today speakers on television often “read” from a teleprompter, a device allowing them to read their words directly from a script passing in front of the camera lens. Recent presidents of the United States have favored this method.

When constructing a manuscript for reading, some speakers use a page style similar to a TV script, leaving a left margin of about one-third of the page. In that wide margin are pronunciation aids or suggestions as to where to look in an audience.

3. Memorization

A risk of memorization is forgetting your precise words; groping for words in front of an audience decreases your credibility.

Few speakers today memorize complete speeches. Nor should they. Often the first few words of a statement can be memorized, but the time needed to recall a long speech is prohibitive.

4. Impromptu

Many of us are called upon at the last moment to offer comments. When you speak “off the cuff,” without preparation, without a forewarning that you will speak, you are speaking impromptu.

How can you prepare? Winston Churchill, the energetic British prime minister during the Second World War, “rehearsed” his impromptu remarks at home; later, in the House of Commons, he gave the impression that his remarks were spur of the moment. A vice president doodled through a discussion: In reality he was also jotting down notes for later use in his “impromptu” remarks.

Strategies for an Effective Oral Delivery

One of your personal signatures is your voice; varying pitch, rate, and volume gives it more interest and appeal.

As writing has its criteria to move ideas clearly across a page, so too does the speaker in an oral situation. In addition to completing the seven steps for preparing an oral message and choosing the methods of delivering it, you need to focus on decreasing stage fright and the desirable elements of oral and nonverbal delivery.

Your voice is your trademark; it is that part of yourself that adds the human element to your words. Writing does not have that immediacy because the words are static on a page. You can give extra life to your delivery in five traditional ways.

■ Communication Probe

One of your authors, early on, investigated this hypothesis: Does the mode of presentation—that is, extemporaneous or manuscript delivery—affect an audience’s recall of information? Results suggest that the mode of communication employed makes no difference: Audiences recall information about equally well when speakers use either method. However, audiences—beyond question—desired the extemporaneous mode of delivery. They simply liked it more. Fortunately, in the business world most presentations are of the extemporaneous type.

Hildebrandt H. W., & Stevens, W. (1963). Manuscript and extemporaneous delivery in communicating information. *Speech Monographs*, 30, 369–382.

1. Pitch

At its simplest level *pitch* is the highness or lowness of your voice. In speaking, this pitch should be varied. Traditional problems in using pitch are monotone, high or low voice, and same word value.

Monotone. “He’s a monotone” is no compliment. This critical statement implies that the speaker has little or no variation in pitch. An oscilloscope would show a rather flat line.

Lack of pitch variation may result in being called a monotone.

High or Low Voice. Often monotones are voices that rarely rise out of a lower register. On the other hand, excited people frequent the upper ranges.

Same Word Value. In writing we emphasize a word visually by underlining it, marking it boldface, or using italics. When each word in speaking, regardless of its importance in a thought group, is the same, the speaker does not distinguish with vocal stress between important and unimportant words. Cantonese, for instance, is an accented language. Much pitch variation occurs.

The above problems are decreased through pitch changes, through glides—from a higher to a lower level, abruptly. Say this sentence: “Mary, don’t do that!”

On which word did you raise your voice? Here are the possibilities:

Mary, don’t do that!

Mary, don’t *do* that!

Mary, *don’t* do that!

Mary, don’t do *that*!

When emphasizing an entire sentence, usually the strong declarative thoughts end with a downward pitch change, giving the feeling of finality, of determination. A rising inflection is more appropriate to asking questions or suggesting indecision.

2. Rate

Take a guess: How many words do you use per minute as you speak? Most communication experts suggest the range for public speakers lies between 80 to 160 words per minute. In more casual conversation some people may range from 80 to 250 words per minute.

What the above statement suggests is that the rate of speech varies from individual to individual. A speaker may be considered dull if he or she is slow or unvarying, even though the speaker’s content may be superior. Conversely, the fast speaker also causes discomfort: We hope the rapid-fire speaker will slow down in order for us to digest the thoughts.

A key word related to rate is *pause*. We call pauses between major thought groups “oral white space,” similar to the white space between paragraphs in a written document. As in writing, a pause in speaking lets your receiver reflect on the message and helps break the flow of thought. A pause lets you, the speaker, collect your thoughts, take time to move to a visual, or rest your voice.

Variation in rate is better than speaking at the same speed.

3. Volume

Unless you as a speaker are heard, many of your words will be lost. It takes real courage for a listener to stand at the rear of a room and shout “Speak up, please!” Volume is the loudness or softness of your voice. How do you improve it?

Contrast in Emphasis. Contrast in emphasis involves using a louder or softer volume on certain words, certain ideas, certain parts of your talk, even certain syllables. For instance, how would you orally deliver the following statement?

And with that we conclude our remarks. Personally, I look forward to working with you and the other members of your project team. I can't forget that at one time I was asked to join your firm. Now I'm on the other side, offering a proposal that I hope you'll accept. Regardless of your final decision, we wish you to know that we enjoyed this morning with you.

When in doubt as to your volume level, ask a colleague about her or his impressions from the back or side of a room.

In the above instance—heard by one of the authors—the speaker lowered his voice and made the statement a moving personal appeal at the conclusion of a rigorous 3-hour team presentation.

Controlled Breathing. Too frequently speakers breathe in shallow gasps. You must—as does a singer—have lungs filled with air in order to produce a higher pressure level to propel the air forcefully past your vocal folds. Breathe deeply. In fact, slow, deep breathing prior to speaking helps to decrease stage fright symptoms.

Certainly you must adapt your volume level to the size of the audience and room. Speaking to 100 people in a room without an amplification aid would surely demand more volume than in a small room of 5 people.

One's voice is hard to describe; we often turn to metaphors to describe voice quality.

4. Vocal Quality

Before reading the next several lines, pause and see how many words you can think of that describe the human voice. Did you choose any of the following: *husky, throaty, deep, loud, vibrant, dynamic, mellow, moving, weak, strong, harsh, shrill, effeminate, masculine, gentle, squeaky, muffled, falsetto, silvery, ravishing, clear, ringing, effortless, secure, flexible, serene, pliable, vibrant, colorful, furry rug*? Many of the preceding are metaphors, implying a comparison of the voice with another known quantity. Regardless of your voice's quality, it is the indefinable something that distinguishes your voice from others.

There is some debate about whether anything can be done about changing voice quality. Your mouth, tongue, lips, teeth, vocal folds, sinuses, hard and soft palate, and nose all affect that quality. If you are unhappy with your voice, see a competent speech therapist for professional help. Some experts also suggest relaxing the throat, thereby allowing an unrestricted sound to enter the resonating chambers of the mouth, throat, and nasal cavities.

5. Pronunciation

We more easily forgive pronunciation errors in foreign speakers than in native speakers. You are expected to be correct in the business world. In fact, we sub-

■ Communication Probe

A lighthearted spoof—quite serious, really—of jargon and its consequences in the business world recently appeared. The author’s observation is that consultants entering a company to improve communication come loaded with their own vocabularies, their own font of words. Thus with some difficulty the company must learn about *empowerment*, *paradigms*, *vision congruencies*, *short-term disabilities*, *cultural interventions*, and a host of others. Soon, however, the company is mouthing these same terms, or in the author’s terms “psychobabble.” Underneath the satire the message is clear: Do not neglect the simplicity of the English language; do not give up clarity for jargon.

Theibert, T. (1994, August 1). Eschew that paradigm! Drop the jargon. *Wall Street Journal*, 18A.

Speech therapists can help with pronunciation concerns, particularly with non-native speakers.

consciously react negatively when any word is mispronounced—relative to our concept of how it should be pronounced. (*Danger*: we may be wrong, the speaker right.)

Additional pronunciation problems need to be mentioned.

Jargon. Within your organization you will learn jargon pronunciations, often for abbreviations. Thus *can* used within one group will mean “contract audit manual,” but to outsiders could mean a part that forces a roller to move. A danger clearly lies in using these in-group pronunciations outside your group, with inevitable quizzical nonverbal reactions from your listeners.

Varied Regional Accents. For many words, southern pronunciation and accents, for example, differ from those in Chicago or Boston. For most of these words, however, there is a common standard throughout the states, as there must be for us to understand quickly.

Added or Omitted Sounds. Speakers should, of course, be careful not to add such sounds as *uh*, *hm*, *y’know*, *er*, *OK* between words or sentences. If one has many of these interjections (one speaker had 24, another 42, another 147), they break up the flow or words for the listener. The result is similar to the negative impression that writing errors leave with a reader. Some speakers literally don’t hear their interjections until they hear them played back on a videotape.

Other bad habits of adding and omitting may also affect pronunciation. In the following examples, the preferred pronunciation is second:

A videotape recording is superior in reflecting your pronunciation. It captures you as others hear you.

Adding		Omitting	
idear	idea	gonna	going to
athalete	athlete	watcha say	what did you say
arthuritis	arthritis	meetn	meeting
hunerd	hundred	dija	did you

■ Checklist 14.2 Striving for Oral Vocal Variety

All the following suggestions move on one main assumption: You must have variety and enthusiasm in each of the vocal characteristics.

1. Try repeating thought groups in your speech in different ways. Ask yourself: Which way sounds more effective through varying pitch (highness/lowness of the voice); rate (fastness/slowness of speech); volume (loudness/softness).
2. Think of adding oral white space: Insert silence (pauses) between major points of your talk.
3. Be sure you have the correct pronunciation of words. This suggestion is most appropriate for persons using English as a second language. When in doubt, ask a native speaker or check the dictionary for the preferred pronunciation.

Suggestions for improving pronunciation are:

Listen to the Educated and Cultured People of Your Community. You can usually assume that their standard is correct and acceptable for their region of the country. A respected businessperson's speech is also a good guide.

Consult a Recent Dictionary. More options on pronunciations of words are included in recent editions. When in doubt, get a consensus from your class members or your instructors.

Strategies for an Effective Nonverbal Delivery

How much do you nonverbally communicate about yourself when speaking? How close do you stand to someone in polite conversation? How important is your attire when speaking? These are questions often raised when thinking of nonverbal communication. Your posture, movement, gesture, facial expression, and attire all convey external nonverbal cues. Many nonverbal cultural habits are discussed in Chapter 3.

1. Posture

Many of you have seen the film *Patton*, in which the actor George C. Scott plays the role of General Patton. In one scene Scott delivers a ringing motivational statement: He delivers it erect, straight, and unbending. The entire scene suggests confidence, rapport with his audience of soliders. One senses the poise and confidence of the speaker.

Thus, when you stand straight and balance your weight on both feet, you give the impression of complete control, of poise. Your outward appearance mirrors your inner mood.

Posture, how you stand, even sit, communicates something about you as a communicator.

■ Communication Probe

Although extensive communication research was conducted in the sixties and seventies, Professor Roger D. Masters has continued that investigation specifically as it applies to political leaders. But some of his conclusions have applicability beyond the political arena. In fact, all audiences dislike speakers who exhibit fear: looking down, hesitating, jerky in movement, or seeming to freeze. People react positively when candidates smile warmly, tilt their head, and establish eye contact with their audience. “If you think about it,” he says, “politics is about getting people to look at you. Our studies show that effective leaders are attention-binding.”

McDonald, K. (1996, January 5). The body language of leadership. *The Chronicle of Higher Education*, A6–A9; Masters, R. (1993). *Beyond relativism: Science and human values*. Hanover, NH: University Press of New England; Masters, R. (1989). *The nature of politics*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.

Conversely, when draped over a podium with your shoulders sagging, you give the feeling of depression, of lack of control. However, a casual posture may also be adapted to the audience. When speaking to a business conference of, say, 10 people, you might sit on the edge of a table or even address them from a chair. Certainly a formal talk to 200 people would demand more formality in posture.

Women should be especially concerned about posture, sometimes choosing shorter-heeled shoes when speaking. Too high a heel causes some female speakers to rock from side to side. Choose a comfortable set of shoes to avoid conveying a negative, ill-at-ease impression.

2. Movement

Lecterns are movement-inhibiting. If you must use a lectern, try moving slightly from one edge to the other.

Taking a few steps during a presentation helps hold attention, as does any moving object. There are times, however, when a lectern precludes extensive movement other than short steps to its side. Yet, move if possible, for the following reasons:

Move to Hold Attention. At large sessions, lecterns restrict your movement. In business meetings the audience may be smaller, thus permitting you to stand behind a desk or table. Move more often from side to side rather than back and forth. But do not move continuously, like a caged lion!

Move to Get Rid of Nervousness. A way of decreasing stage fright is to move about, especially in the beginning of your talk. Even the manner in which you approach the lectern tells something about you nonverbally. Are you slow and plodding, or do you move with assurance, determination, enthusiasm? The latter approach gives a confident feeling while decreasing some of your initial nervousness.

Move to Suggest Transitions. Cues for transitions in writing include headings, words, and numerical hints such as (1), (2), (3) or (a), (b), (c). In your talk, you

■ Communication Probe

One of the earliest researchers into nonverbal communication (Birdwhistle) suggested that words alone do not carry meaning in communication. He argued that no more than 30 to 35 percent of meaning is carried entirely by words. Nonverbal communication adds, subtracts, and amends the messages we send. Nonverbal symbols, in conjunction with oral symbols, say much about who we are, how we feel, and even how we feel about others. Hence, the oral communication context involves both verbal and nonverbal symbols, each hopefully getting listeners to understand us and do what we wish them to do. Sending the right symbols demands knowing the audience's receptivity to those symbols.

Birdwhistle, R. (1970). *Kinesics and context*. Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press; Knapp, M. L. (1990). Nonverbal communication. In G. L. Dahnke & G. W. Clatterbuck (Eds.), *Human communication: Theory and Research* (pp. 50–69). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

visually supplement the oral words of transition by physically moving when making a direction shift. The audience follows you more easily.

Move to Increase Emphasis. In writing we use exclamation points following emphatic statements. In speaking, a movement toward the audience, accompanied by a gesture, can imply you are stressing a point. Emphasis through movement suggests idea importance and holds group attention.

3. Gestures

At a simplistic level any movement of the hands, arms, head, shoulders are termed *gestures*. At a more micro level there is an entire science of body movements called *kinesics*, of which gestures are a part:

Emblems. Behavior that has a direct verbal counterpart such as the thumb upward for hitchhiking; the arm wave for hello or goodbye.

Illustrators. Here belong the gestures, usually the arm used to describe a circle, or the finger pointing to emphasize a point. As emblems had direct verbal counterpart, illustrators do not.

Affect Displays. Speakers may use any of the primary emotional states usually via facial expression: happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise, disgust, contempt, and interest.

Regulators. Speakers use body movements of their audience to search out responses to their message. Thus listeners may nod their heads, maintain eye contact, shift their postures, incline their heads to hear better.

Adapters. These are often the unintentional movements to a physical or psychological state: scratching a nose, twisting a pencil, smoothing one's hair.

Be aware—as noted in Chapter 3—that acceptable gestures in your native country might prove unacceptable in other countries.

Hand and arm gestures are used for several reasons:

To Emphasize. For example, the clenched fist emphasizes a point by either hitting the palm of the hand or shaking it upright before an audience.

To Point. The index finger calls attention, indicating either locations or directions.

To Reject. A sample phrase accompanying this gesture would be “I can’t believe the actions of our competitors.” Here the hand may go to the side in an act of rejection.

To Describe. Clearly, though your hands cannot give the precise picture of the idea or thing you are speaking about, even an approximation of size is worthwhile.

As with the voice, varying gestures also help to hold the attention of an audience.

Finally, some suggestions regarding gestures are in order:

Vary Gestures. Using the same action repetitiously is boring to the audience and suggests lack of creativity on your part.

Avoid Continuous Gestures. Visually the audience needs a rest from the speaker’s frequent gestures. Overuse can weaken the emphasis.

Watch Timing. The gesture should accompany the oral thought, not precede or follow it.

Adapt Gestures. Seated at a table is not the time for broad, all-inclusive gestures. On the other hand, a large audience would not see a small gesture. Adapt to the size of the group.

4. Facial Expressions

Earlier we suggested that one’s facial expressions could convey primary gestures. Thus a smile or a laugh suggests that your topic interests you. A frown or

■ Communication Probe

Two tests over the years (Rosenthal, 1979, and Buck, 1984) have attempted to answer this question: Which gender is most perceptive in sending and receiving nonverbal messages? Rosenthal’s Profile of Nonverbal Sensitivity (PONS) test and Buck’s Communication of Affect-Receiving Ability Test (CARAT) lead to some interesting conclusions. Through viewing slides and film, with emphasis on the face, the body, and the voice, women seem to do better in sending and receiving nonverbal messages.

Rosenthal, R. (ed.). (1979). *Skill in nonverbal communication: Individual differences*. Cambridge, MA: Oelgeschlager, Gunn, & Hain; Hall, J. A. (1984). *Nonverbal sex differences: Communication accuracy and expressive style*. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press.

■ Checklist 14.3 Enhancing Your Non-verbal Communication

1. Stand erect. It is better to err on the side of more formality than casualness in speaking.
2. Move! To hold attention, to get rid of nervousness, to suggest transitions, to increase emphasis.
3. Gestures add emphasis to your oral words. Use them to emphasize a point, to suggest rejection of an idea, to describe size. Using your arms helps hold attention.
4. Facial expressions suggest enthusiasm for your topic. A mobile face is an interesting face. Look at the audience: Give them the feeling of high interest in them and your topic.
5. Your attire is determined by the culture of your group. When in doubt, be more formal than informal.

glare may convey nonverbal impressions that you are worried, angry, or perhaps ill at ease. You must not only feel but show interest in your ideas. Sincerity is important.

Facial expression includes eye contact. Speakers who bury their head in their notes or who speak to the screen behind them lose a sense of directness with the audience. Eye contact with your listeners suggests respect and goodwill, adding to a favorable impression of you as a speaker.

5. Appearance

Western attire is accepted throughout the world. Conversely, western businesspersons must recognize that other nations may have different dress codes.

Local newspapers often include questions about and answers to what to wear to interviews, sales meetings, social gatherings. How you look and what you wear affect listeners. Thus some companies are more casual in dress, others less so. Learning the company culture includes learning its dress code.

Most western companies encourage males to wear the traditional shirt, tie, and suit and females to wear a white blouse with a dark skirt and jacket. But those “rules” are consistently changing. Terms as *smart casual* or *business casual* are symbols for appearance; it is important that you know what they mean in your particular environment.

STRATEGIES FOR REDUCING STAGE FRIGHT

Being at ease, or simply giving the *impression* of being at ease, is difficult for most people. Few people can approach an audience without some feeling of discomfort. In traditional rankings, speaking before an audience is rated the most fearful thing some people do.

Pick up any newspaper, read what persons have to say about situations demanding a performance in front of people: Many resist and fear the idea. Barbara Streisand avoided public performances for years out of stage fright; Van

■ Communication Probe

Because speech anxiety is so widespread, numerous studies and approaches to meeting that anxiety have appeared over the years. Without getting into extensive detail, those anxiety-reducing techniques involved skills based on cognitive and affective approaches. A study that combined all three methods resulted in some interesting conclusions. Performance visualization is effective in reducing communication anxiety. Relaxation techniques were encouraged and imagining ability (reading a script of a successful speech and viewing a speech) was the type of performance visualization employed. “People who have the ability to imagine situations vividly receive more benefit from performance visualization than do others.”

Ayers, J., Hopf, T., & Ayers, D. M. (1984). An examination of whether imagining ability enhances the effectiveness of an intervention designed to reduce speech anxiety. *Communication Education*, 43, 252–258.

Cliburn said, “Those who know me best know that when I walk out on a stage, I’m nervous, always nervous”; Luciano Pavarotti, the superb tenor, said, “I would not want even an enemy to suffer those terrible moments”; Steve Carlton, a recent inductee into the Baseball Hall of Fame, put it this way: “This is a wonderful thing . . . once the speech is over.” And the list of similar comments is endless.

Signs of Discomfort

Signs of discomfort are universally experienced: The heart rate increases, blood pressure and body temperature rise, and some say their mouths feel dry. Look carefully at each of the preceding: All are internal, none are visible to the audience. What you feel internally is not obvious to listeners. Surely you will also feel as if your voice is trembling and your palms are sweaty. Again, you may be aware of these things, but they are not obvious to the audience.

Strategies for Decreasing Speaking Fears

Regardless of culture, stage fright is universal. Following our eight suggestions helps decrease the intensity of that fear.

In a true sense it is mind over matter, confidence above all, feeling that you know the subject better than anyone else, the feeling that you are in charge. If it makes you feel any better, musicians, football players, and singers have similar feelings before a performance or contest. Checklist 14.4 offers eight helpful ways to decrease your discomfort.

STRATEGIES FOR IMPROVING LISTENING SKILLS

Listening is a neglected study in school and colleges even though managers from around the world consider it a significant part of one’s communication skills. Our review here concerns common faults of listening, purposes for listening, and results of good listening.

■ Checklist 14.4 Decreasing Stage Fright

1. Know your subject well. Prepare with the attitude that you want to know the subject, on that day, better than anyone else.
2. Rehearse your talk several times. If possible, rehearse in the same room where you'll speak. This can easily be done within your company. But if your speech will be outside your company, try to arrive at the place early and take a look around.
3. Request—in advance—a lectern. It helps to hold not only your notes but also, occasionally, a trembling hand.
4. Precheck any equipment you'll need—projector, screen, extension cord—and know which electric outlet is nearest the podium or lectern.
5. Take an object with you—a pen, your notes, a marking pencil. Of course one should not play with the object, but using it as a pointer and as something to touch has helped calm some speakers.
6. Breathe deeply and slowly before speaking. Try moving a little in your chair: cross and uncross your legs.
7. Move during the speech. Some movement holds audience attention and releases nervous energy. Even behind a lectern one can move slightly or use a lavalier mike and, thereby, increase the possible range of movement. If you're seated, shift positions in your chair or gesture a bit more with your arms.
8. Approach the lectern with assurance and enthusiasm.

■ Communication Probe

An interesting study in Finland viewed these hypotheses: In front of the same audience, an individual's heart rate is significantly higher in a public speaking context than in a small group context. Further, an individual heart rate level is significantly higher in a small group context in front of an audience than in a dyadic context without any audience. Public speaking was the most stressful as measured via increases in heart rate, rising to 144 beats above the baseline rate of 83. Speaking in small groups caused the heart rate to reach 117 beats per minute. The authors conclude that the heart does reflect the nature and demands of the communicative situation.

Porhola, M., & Isotalus, P. (1993, June). Communication-elicited arousal in public speaking, small group and dyadic contexts: Comparisons of change in heart rate. *Communication Research Reports*, 10(1), 29–37.

Faults in Listening

Listening is as important as the other three components of communication, namely, speaking, reading, and writing.

Much information that you send orally is lost because of listeners' poor listening habits. In fact, studies agree that listening efficiency is no better than 25 to 30 percent. Why? Some causes follow.

Prejudice Against the Speaker. Perhaps you have heard this quotation. "Who is saying it shouts so loudly that what is said is easily forgotten." We are distracted because who the speaker is conflicts with our attitudes. For example, can you maintain attention when the speaker's position, attitude, or belief is entirely contrary to your own?

External Distractions. The preceding fault was more of an internal distraction. Some nonverbal cues are strong external distractions. Does the speaker stammer? Wear loud clothing? Dress sloppily? Walk or gesture excessively? Reek of perfume or cologne? All these and more cause persons to tune out on speakers.

Actually, the entire physical environment affects listening. Among the negative factors are noisy fans, poor or glaring lights, distracting background music, overheated or cold or oddly shaped or gaudily decorated rooms, excessive draft from a window or register, and so on. Also, sitting near disturbing individuals in the audience might distract a listener's attention from the speaker's message.

Thinking Speed. Most of us speak between 80 and 160 words per minute. Yet people have the capacity to think at the phenomenal rate of up to 800 words per minute. That leaves time on the listener's hands (or in his or her head). What do you do during all the time when you are not actually processing the speaker's words? Do you go off on tangents, focus your attention elsewhere, begin to daydream, shift your attention? Soon you can be off, far away from the words of the speaker—missing some important points.

We have time on our hands while listening to a speech. Our thinking speed outpaces the speaker's rate of speech.

Premature Evaluation. How many times have you interrupted persons before they completed their thought? Finished their sentence? Stated *their* conclusions? Directly as a result of our rapid thinking speed, we race ahead to what we feel is the conclusion. We anticipate. We arrive at the concluding thought quickly—although often one that is quite different from that the speaker intended.

Semantic Stereotypes. As certain kinds of people bother us, so too do their words. An interesting class interchange occurs when discussing this question: What is your favorite word, and why? Opposite that question is, What words bother you, and why?

Internal reaction words vary from person to person, each list influenced by feelings, attitudes, prejudices, and biases we carry inside ourselves. (See the communication model in Chapter 1.) Hence, some words cause negative reactions. We tune out the speaker because the word annoys us; it shouts so loudly in our brain that effective listening is impaired.

Delivery. A monotone can readily put listeners to sleep—or cause them to lose interest. Sadly, some teachers speak in monotones. So do significant people in government or business. How a speaker delivers his or her message does annoy

■ Communication Probe

Listening research had its heyday during the sixties and seventies. Little has been added to change the conclusions of some classical studies on the topic. It is estimated that we spend nearly 45 percent of our verbal communication day in listening. That is not surprising in a world given increasingly to the visual medium. Additional support is given the thesis that more business communication should be devoted to improving listening. Data, for example, from a sample of Hong Kong utility managers suggest that communication courses should include emphasis upon the following forms of communication:

Writing	32.7%
Speaking	31.4
Listening	19.3
Reading	17.0

In other words, the traditional forms of business communication in one Asian country—similarly mirrored in the United States and elsewhere—still focus on the two main media. Yet, listening as part of the “big four” ranks third as a desirable addition to communication improvement.

Hildebrandt, H. W. (1996). Chinese utility executives. Unpublished raw data; See also studies reviewed by Wolvin, A., & Coakley, C. (1982). *Listening*. Dubuque, IA: Brown.

some people—and they become bored, uninterested, and critical of the message. “He’s a bore” is more a critique of delivery than an assessment of a speaker’s mental abilities.

Purposes for Listening

It should be no surprise that poor listening is not entirely the fault of the speaker.

A speaker alone gets an audience to listen. Wrong. All of us have had the experience of reading to the end of a page and not knowing what we have read. Similarly, it is possible to hear someone without being able to summarize what the person has said. The fault is not entirely that of the sender. Why listen? There are four good reasons:

1. To Gain New Information and Ideas

Throughout our lifetimes there are kernels of information that become a part of us through the spoken word. Lectures in class, for example, can supplement and clarify a textbook; informative indoctrinations give new employees background to a company; persuasive statements to clients give both information and reasons for buying. New ideas are received daily, via the oral medium, if one listens. In

other words, speakers must select reliable evidence. A goal is to arrive at a conclusion that is true, workable, and acceptable to many people.

2. To Question and Test Evidence and Assumptions

When a speaker presents a message, much of what is said consists of facts (verifiable data) or opinions (inferences). Good listeners test those facts and opinions against assumptions and then question the speaker. Additional information and the selection of acceptable evidence and data are discussed in the following three chapters.

3. To Be Inspired

Martin Luther King's "I Have a Dream" speech inspired, as did Patton in the film of the same name. Keynoters are selected to set the tone, the mood, the outline of where a group should go. Sales meetings are known for their rousing kickoffs, their enthusiastic openings—occasionally with bands, vocalists, even stage shows, all seeking to motivate, to inspire the audience favorably.

4. To Improve Your Own Communication

Role models and mentors are valuable to young people entering the business world. If your role model is also an effective communicator, you are lucky. However, if your mentor lacks some communication skills, and thus cannot serve as a resource, other excellent ways exist to study communicators: attending meetings, hearing speeches, or even observing famous officials speaking on television. Choose the best techniques; listen for and adopt those that are done well. Add them to your list of desirable speaking attributes. Omit undesirable habits that you see and hear.

Results of Good Listening

In summary, the following six benefits will occur if you listen purposefully and positively because such attentive listening

1. Leads to helpful, positive attitudes—by understanding the hindrances that lie in the way of good listening.
2. Permits the speaker and listeners to improve communication because each side is more aware of and receptive to the other's viewpoint.
3. Indicates by feedback to the speaker that listeners are interested; in turn, the speaker tries harder to give his or her best presentation.
4. Helps listeners obtain useful information on which they can make accurate decisions.
5. Creates better understanding of others and thus helps listeners work with others.

■ Checklist 14.5 How to Improve Your Listening Skills

1. *Be prepared.* For a class, this means completing your reading and assignment responsibilities. For an outside speaker, you can learn something about the speaker, the topic, the audience, the situation even before attending.
2. *Accent the positive.* “If you have to do it, do it with a positive attitude” is a centerpiece of life.
3. *Listen to understand, not refute.* Respect the viewpoint of those with whom you disagree. Try to understand the points they emphasize and why they have such feelings (training, background, etc.). Don’t allow your personal biases and attitudes regarding the speakers or their views to influence your listening to their message.
4. *Focus your attention.* Construct a mental outline of where the speaker is going. Listen for transitions and the progression of ideas.
5. *Concentrate on context.* Construct a mental outline of where the speaker is going. Listen for transitions and the progression of ideas.
6. *Take notes.* Jot down ideas. Even incomplete sentences or single words will later be a memory jogger of what was said.
7. *Curb the impulse to interrupt.* This suggestion applies to interviews, conferences, job instructions, and meetings. Listen attentively until the speaker invites questions.
8. *Summarize and evaluate.* Restate—in your own words—just what you think was said. You should also question evidence used and mentally test the validity of evidence in support of a proposition.

6. Helps the speaker (especially in an interview) in talking out a problem; a person needs to receive, as well as give, help

SUMMARY

One strategy for improving oral communication is to follow seven steps: (1) determine your purpose; (2) know the audience and occasion; (3) select your main ideas; (4) collect data; (5) organize your material; (6) plan visuals, if needed; and (7) rehearse about three times.

Then determine whether your talk is to inform (make something clear), persuade (get willing acceptance), or entertain (some form of celebratory statement). Once that is determined, most likely you will present the talk extemporaneously, from notes in an outline form.

Enthusiasm is a key word in giving variety to the two main parts of delivery. *Oral communication* involves variety in pitch, rate, volume, and pause. *Nonverbal communication* pertains to posture, movement, gesture, and eye contact.

■ Communication Probe

Current pragmatic articles still lament the poor listening abilities of businesspersons. No profession is immune from that indictment: Internal auditors are concerned, pharmaceutical companies, and innumerable other areas of business. Recognizing the fact that people listen at an efficient rate of about 25 percent or less, suggestions for improving that listening efficiency are similar to suggestions made in this chapter: Listen for key concepts and ideas, anticipate what the speaker is going to say, review key points occasionally, look for unspoken messages, and provide feedback.

Flagg, J., Kerr, D., & Smith, L. (1995, Winter). Conducting effective interviews. *Internal Auditing*, 10, 41–45; Lamons, B. (1995, September 11). Good listeners are good communicators. *Marketing News*, 29, 13; (1995, September). Home-grown training at Fannie Mae. *Management Review*, 84, SS3.

Strategic listening means being positive, purposeful when listening to someone. Eight actions should be taken: Be prepared; accept the positive; listen to understand, not refute; focus attention; concentrate on context; take notes; curb impulse to interrupt; and summarize and evaluate.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Nonverbal Characteristics of Other Cultures.** Books, journals, and periodicals frequently have articles relevant to nonverbal communication habits of different countries. Search out an article or a chapter in a book (ABI Inform is a good source under the term *intercultural*), and then do two things after reading your material: (1) summarize some of the nonverbal habits of the country under discussion and (2) suggest how some of those same nonverbal habits are used or not used in the United States.
2. **Oral Characteristics of Other Cultures.** Interview an international student either in class or in your school. Ask him or her to summarize some of the difficulties experienced in using English. What oral habits of U.S. students are found to be different? Are there specific sounds in the English language that are especially difficult to master? It is interesting to collect a series of statements from different foreign students in order for you—as future businesspersons—to better understand the difficulties faced by others speaking in their second language.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Analysis of Public Presentation.** Attend a public presentation offered by a business person. Using the following format, write brief statements on some of the principles learned in this chapter:

CRITIQUE OF ORAL AND NONVERBAL SECTIONS OF A PRESENTATION

To what extent did the speaker have variety in the following characteristics of voice?

Pitch:
Rate:
Volume:
Pause:

To what extent did the speaker use nonverbal communication in his or her presentation?

Posture:
Movement:
Gesture:
Pause:

4. **Oral Presentation Based on Resume.** The way of decreasing your nervousness in speaking is to talk about a well known topic—yourself. Prepare an assignment that (1) presents a brief oral statement in support of a specific job, backed up by (2) your resume prepared as a transparency. *Suggestions:* Be organized, think of the main sections of your resume (e.g., goals, education, work experience) that you will use as the basis for your support for a specific job.
5. **Nonverbal Communication Log.** Test the assertion that people consciously or unconsciously communicate nonverbally during oral communication. Note any situations you wish, but you should have at least three examples per day for a week.
 - a. Divide your log into two parts: On the left side of a page put the heading “Situation;” on the right side, “Example” or “Conclusions.”
 - b. Defend in class the conclusions you drew from the nonverbal cues noted in your left-hand column.
6. **Short Informative Talk to Introduce Speaker or Award Winner.** For this assignment each student will give a short (3- to 5-minute) talk to introduce a member of the class as either a speaker or an award winner. First, choose a classmate (by any method your instructor suggests). Then exchange resumes with that person. Confer with each other to get acquainted. (Your classmate needs information to introduce you, too.)

You may each assume that your classmate is a speaker about a certain topic at a meeting of a business, professional, campus, or other club of which you are both members. You have been chosen to introduce him or her. If you prefer, instead of introducing your classmate as a speaker, you may assume you were asked to present him or her with an award.

Whichever specific purpose you choose for your talk, select from your classmate’s resume at least four pertinent facts—with his or her approval.

All statements in your talk should be true—except of course the assumption that this classmate is a speaker or an award winner. To support either of these assumptions you may need to add a few made-up incidents. For instance, if you will present an award, be sure to mention clearly a (made-up) noteworthy achievement—on the job or in scholarship or in community activities, sports, music, or whatever. Organize your talk well, and present it enthusiastically to your audience.

7. *Listening to Newscasts for Repetitions.* Even though TV newscasts are not a pure form of public speaking, newscasters use some of the same features you will use in more formal presentations. Listen to several things in newscaster statements: their introduction to the newscast, transitions between stories, and their concluding remarks at the end of the newscast. Questions you may ask as you watch may include the following:

- Is there consistency in the way the newscaster opens the newscast over a period of several days?
- Are the same words used to move from one point to another in the newscast?
- Are signoffs the same after each newscast?
- Is there a time connection between the kinds of news report? For instance, are serious and tragic stories given less or more time than humorous incidents?
- And other questions of your choice.

Then, write a brief report on your findings, including specific examples of the kinds of repetitions (or varied) beginnings, transitions, and endings used.

8. *Listening for Evolving Slang in Speaking.* Slang (specialized vocabulary and idioms used by an “in” group) is always with us. No organization, no college class, no group of students, no classroom can avoid terms that are added and omitted over one’s lifetime. Three people are needed for this assignment: a student who has worked for several years prior to returning to school, a student who has never had a permanent job prior to coming to school, and a minority student. Each should prepare a list of slang terms they have heard in their daily contacts with friends, in the classroom, or in their work environment.

After the class members have their own list, they should form a group and combine their slang terms into one list. Bring that list to class and let the members of the class guess the meaning of the slang terms, affirm whether they use the terms, and decide whether the terms are now out of date.

Strategies for Successful Informative and Persuasive Speaking

I. Purposes of Informative and Persuasive Speaking

- A. Informative Specific Purposes
- B. Persuasive Specific Purposes

II. Kinds of Informative and Persuasive Speaking

- A. Informative Speaking
- B. Persuasive Speaking

III. Audience Analysis for Informative and Persuasive Speaking

- A. Degrees of Interest and Attitudes
- B. Occasion
- C. Location

IV. Organization for Informative and Persuasive Speaking

- A. The Introduction
- B. The Body (Text, Discussion)
- C. The Summary or Conclusion

V. Supports for Informative and Persuasive Speaking

- A. Six Forms of Support (Evidence, Data)
- B. Questions on Forms of Support

VI. Summary

VII. Exercises and Problems

VIII. Reference

Oral communication is our most used mode of communication. It may involve only one other person. It means speaking within a meeting, conversing in the hall, announcing over a PA system, using the telephone, speaking to 100 people, or whispering words of love.

But here, as in the preceding chapter, we mean speaking to a group of people. We mean giving a speech: to a small group or a large audience. And to be effective in the business world requires knowing something about informative and persuasive speaking. The former focuses on making an idea clear, the latter on gaining willing acceptance for your proposal.

For both types of speaking we review the following:

- Purposes of informative and persuasive speaking
- Kinds of informative and persuasive speaking
- Audience analysis for informative and persuasive speaking
- Organization for informative and persuasive speaking
- Support (evidence, data) for informative and persuasive speaking

PURPOSES OF INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Making an idea clear is central to the purpose of informative speaking.

Oral communication consistently has two purposes: a general, or macro, purpose (to inform or persuade), and a specific, or micro, purpose (precise objective to be communicated). When thinking of the specific purpose, we suggest phrasing that purpose as an infinitive.

Informative Specific Purposes

Vague Specific Purpose

Olympic games

Health care

Better Specific Purpose

To compare information, using the criterion of modern technology, as to which country should host the year 2000 Olympic games.

To review the various funding options for a national health care program.

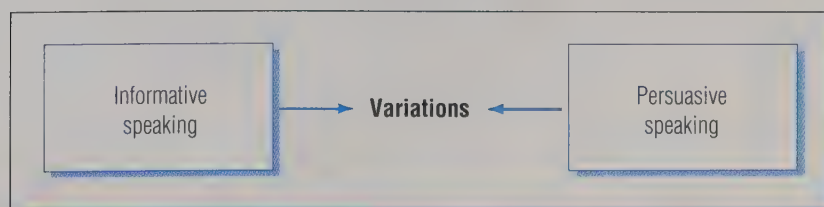


Figure 15.1 Informative-persuasive continuum.

Exchange rates

To trace the exchange rates over 15 years of the Thai baht and the U.S. dollar.

After having drafted your specific purpose, you can link three things: the title of the talk, the general purpose, and the specific purpose.

Search for unity between the title and the specific purpose of your talk.

Title:	An International Barrier: Language
General purpose:	To inform
Specific purpose:	To note three barriers of speaking in a second language: Definite articles, tenses, and prepositions

Process as Purpose

How does something work? What are the steps we follow to complete an act? These and similar questions suggest that you will explain the steps involved in a process. A study of *process* is knowing the systematic steps needed to bring about a desired result. Thus you might speak about how a machine works, how to construct a good audit report, how to enroll in the company's health program, or how to use a word processing program. Two organizational formats are frequently used: chronological and topical.

Chronological Organization. Many oral statements relating to a process move chronologically, that is, from a beginning to an ending. The following example is organized chronologically.

Title:	Our Employees Overseas
General purpose:	To inform
Specific purpose:	To suggest the procedures in preparing for overseas work
Main points:	I. Contact with personnel office II. Visit to overseas location III. Debriefing with previous personnel in overseas location

Topical organization lets you determine the major headings for your speech.

Topical Organization. If a process is complex and does not readily fit into a chronological pattern, you may wish to select headings that give only the main points of that process. It is your judgment as to what those headings might be. A good example of a topical approach to explaining a topic are the self-learning exercises for software programs. Often the process discussion begins with general headings and then along come the smaller segments. Microsoft *Word* has such an approach.

Title:	Learning Microsoft <u>Word</u>
General purpose:	To inform
Specific purpose:	To introduce users to the basic process of learning Microsoft <u>Word</u>

- Main points:
- I. Word disks
 - II. Microsoft Word manual
 - III. Word Pocket Guide
 - IV. Fast Results: A Sampler
 - V. Quick Help

You should think of the kinds of visuals you will use to supplement your process presentation. These may be self-created or taken—with proper citation, of course—from materials already available on your topic.

For instance, a human resources manager might wish to use his or her “Main Points” headings on the visual aids, as taken from the following example:

- | | |
|-------------------|---|
| Title: | How to Develop an Employee Attitude Survey |
| General purpose: | To inform |
| Specific purpose: | To discuss phases of an employee survey |
| Main points: | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> I. Decisions on survey and questions II. Distribution and collection of questionnaires III. Tabulation and analysis of data IV. Implementation and follow-up |

A detailed outline for development of an employee attitude survey might be similar to that in Figure 15.2, adapted from suggested plans by Léland G. Verheyen.¹

Policy as Purpose

New employees often have a series of get-acquainted sessions wherein company policies are clarified. The topics can describe a process but can also clarify company policies or concepts. You therefore may inform groups on a new policy, a current policy, or changes to existing company policy.

In some ways policy speeches are more difficult to give than those explaining the steps in a process or the functioning of a machine. With policies or directives you deal with ideas more than with things that you can touch and feel or see. Visual aids, then, become valuable additions to your speeches on policy matters.

- | | |
|-------------------|--|
| Title: | Drugs in the Workplace |
| General purpose: | To inform |
| Specific purpose: | To clarify company policy on use of drugs in the workplace |
| Main points: | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> I. Company definitions of what drugs are II. Company policy on administered drug tests III. Company evaluation of results and employee rights IV. Company rehabilitation policy |

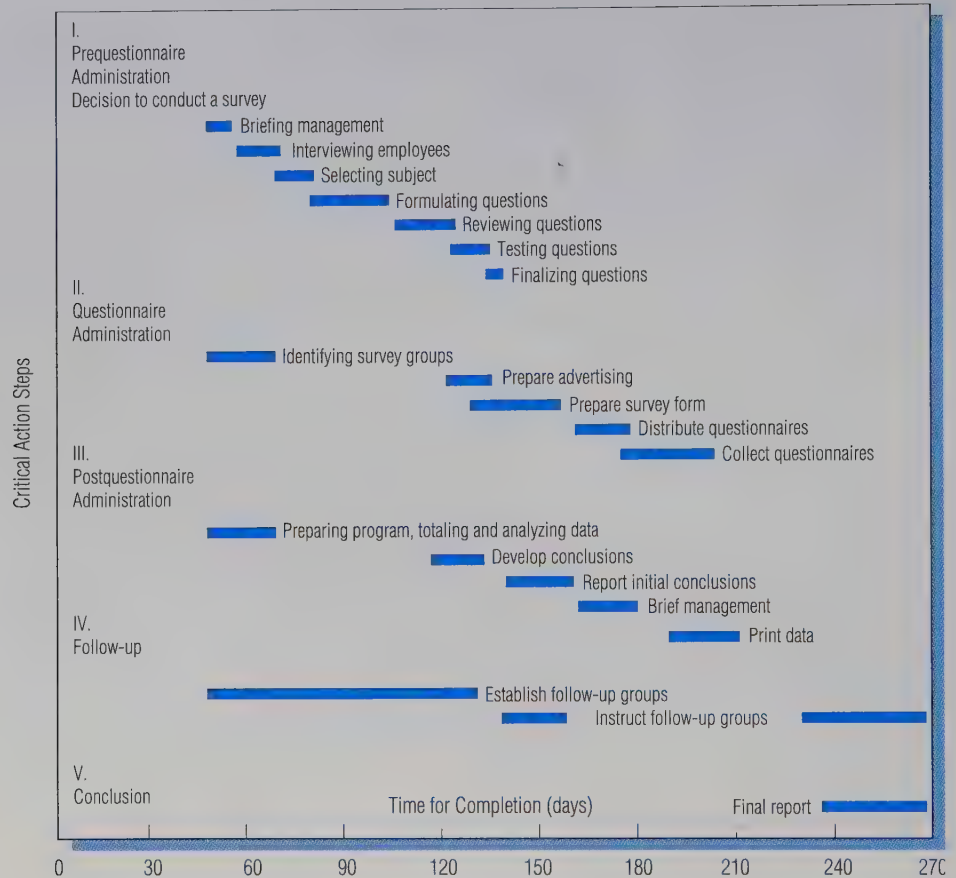


Figure 15.2 Development of employee attitude survey.

Title:	Creation of Trust Fund for Republic of Peru
General purpose:	To inform
Specific purpose:	To inform the Peruvian Government on additional options to consider in preserving its natural resources
Main points:	I. History of the "Fondo Nacional para Areas Protegidas por el Estado" (FONANPE) II. Management of the Peruvian Trust Fund III. Options for further preservation of Peru's natural resources

Persuasive Specific Purposes

Witness the advertisements that daily bombard us with appeals: Buy this object, try this product, take this trip, fly this airline. We are inundated with persuasion.

Gaining willing acceptance of your central thesis is a core purpose of persuasive speaking.

As informative speaking focuses on the information end of the communication continuum, persuasion represents the other end.

Using the same format as for informative speaking, persuasive statements also have a general and a specific purpose. Phrasing your specific purpose in infinitive form channels your thinking into a precise goal statement.

Phrasing your specific purpose in an infinitive phrase makes your goal clearer both to yourself and your audience.

Vague Specific Purpose

Health care

M.B.A.s

Language problems

Taiwan investments

Better Specific Purpose

To recommend that the American Academy of Family Physicians consistently be asked for input.

To suggest that at the M.B.A. level there be mandatory requirements for a second language.

To suggest that acronyms used by the federal government lead to unnecessary misunderstandings.

To argue that Taiwan's capital investments in China were greater than in other sections of the world.

When you have determined your general purpose (to persuade) and selected an interesting title that gets attention, you then state the precise response you wish to get from your audience.

Persuasion is difficult. The more thoughtful you are and the more time you take in preparing carefully—as in the informative speeches—the better chance for later success. It is a good idea to write out the specific purpose. The purpose becomes the central theme around which you build your speech to achieve the desired response. Note in the following three examples how the titles get attention. The general purpose reminds you of the overall goal; and the specific purpose, in an infinitive phrase, is exact.

Title:	Seven Days of Reporting
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To convince listeners that four changes have to be made in the weekly sales reports
Title:	Decreasing Telephone Expenses
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To recommend three options for company consideration and select "Call Lock" as the preferred method

Title:	Promoting Public Acceptance of Japan's Nuclear Policy
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To recommend four actions to be taken in implementing a public awareness program

KINDS OF INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Informative Speaking

Commonly, there are four types of informative situations in business communication: reports, goodwill, briefings, and instruction.

Reports

High on the list of dislikes about a job is the weekly or monthly meeting. Frequently the response to that ritual is "I don't like the reports"; "they're too long"; "meetings drag on endlessly"; and so forth. Sadly, many report sessions do fall into those categories. Why? Because some speakers do little to make their statements interesting or work on clarity of organization.

The following list summarizes the most common forms of oral informative business reports:

Oral informative statements often build on written material.

- Periodic department reports
- Progress reports on sales or ongoing committee activities
- Statements on area or division responsibilities
- Reports on manufacturing problems in the plant
- Reports on competitive operations
- Reports on problems with vendors
- Monthly personnel reports
- Abstract of contact reports for month

■ Checklist 15.1 Deciding Whether to Inform or Persuade

1. To inform:
 - a. Are you seeking to clarify an idea, a process, a procedure?
 - b. Do you wish to explain how something works?
 - c. Will the audience leave knowing both sides of an issue?
2. To persuade:
 - a. Are you going to support a point of view?
 - b. Do you wish action as a result of your speech?
 - c. Will you be clear as to which side of an issue you will support?

A weekly staff meeting, a monthly board of directors' meeting, a yearly stockholders' meeting, or even a yearly visit overseas to hear reports from functional units of a large multinational corporation can be the setting for making something clear to listeners.

Goodwill

Utility companies particularly—and early on—recognized the value of remaining in contact with the community. Their goal, and that of similar organizations today, is to leave a positive company image in the community. Although written flyers often dominate in releasing information to the public, oral speech is often used.

Thus many companies have speakers' bureaus. Company employees—top-level executives—speak in a variety of public settings, often on topics about which the speakers have considerable knowledge. Announcements in local papers occasionally name topics on which employees will speak to local civic, church, or other community groups. Even agencies of the federal or state government present informative statements to the public. A phone call to a company's speaker's bureau or to a government public relations office or consumer affairs office could bring a speaker on topics as varied as the following:

- A History of Solar Energy. Its Prospects for the Future
- Nuclear Power: Safe for the Country of France
- Plans for the New Substation
- Proposed DNR Changes for Refuse Disposal

In the above real instances the speakers brought along a company-produced film to supplement their oral remarks. Clearly, only the better speakers are selected to represent the company to the public.

Less frequent, but also important, are the various other short goodwill statements. Long before you are a top-level executive, you may be asked to welcome visitors, offer a tour and explanation of the company, introduce speakers, confer awards, speak at dedication ceremonies, or host a retirement party. All seek to bring about goodwill for your company.

Briefings

Short, problem-solving sessions in the military are called *briefings*. The term has a similar meaning in the business world. Usually, speakers offer background information, current situation, options to meet the situation, pro and con sides of an argument—all presented to management that they can make an informed decision. You, as a staff person, will make concise presentations on the above or similar topics. After that, management will review your comments and make a decision.

For instance, a utility preparing for an increase in utility rates (a rate case) had numerous brief staff meetings to decide on which strategies to follow. A chronology of topics in preparation for its rate case followed this pattern:

Briefings often lay out information on both sides of an issue.

1. Selection of rate case manager.
2. Selection of potential witnesses.
3. Meeting of all team members to select initial strategy.
4. Writing and redrafting of case.
5. Assembly of final case of direct testimony.
6. Rehearsal of witnesses: Work with manager.
7. Filing of case.
8. Rehearsal in preparation for cross-examination before public service commissioners.

Hence, there are many meetings, occasionally several a week, to hear oral informative statements and to make decisions. Much informative speaking precedes any final decision in the world of business.

Instruction

A common belief is that the longer you are with a firm, the more instruction you will give to younger employees, to others who can benefit from your experience. Your responsibility may be to instruct either several people or on some occasions an entire class of recruits new to the firm. The central goal, again, is to make clear a process, policy, or even the philosophy of the company.

Your goal as an instructor is to have listeners follow your explanations, learn from your instruction, and then apply this knowledge within the organization. Examples of topics offered in an organization are:

- Using our word processor—an introduction
- Completing the sickness and accident forms
- Setting up a retirement plan
- Using recent tax law changes in auditing
- Conserving energy

When informing, you are often acting as a teacher.

■ Communication Probe

Informative communication may be part of a process, making informative material the initial step toward problem solving. Informing may be a form of inquiry, providing background data, background content that contributes to an eventual solution. Thus out of inquiry, out of informative communication may arise a position or thesis or claim. Persuasion, then, depends heavily upon background material, or on what the authors of your text refer to as informative communication.

Batteiger, R. P. (1994). Taking positions and marking choices—An overview of argument. In R. P. Batteiger, *Writing and reading arguments* (pp. 1–13). Boston: Allyn and Bacon.

Speaking in such situations as reporting, community goodwill, and briefings gives you less freedom than when instructing. Here you have more room for individual creativity: choice of subtopics, arrangement of material, structure of the classroom.

That there is a need to teach employees to instruct more effectively has not gone unnoticed. Some universities offer in their management or education programs, for example, seminars on training the trainer, training in the organization, and instructional development workshops. All these seminars focus on one core idea: preparing employees to do a better job of managing, and then preparing them to instruct others.

Persuasive Speaking

Opportunities to persuade are endless; however, persuasion as a whole may be classified into four major categories: policy, procedure, value, or fact.

Policy

Policy refers to a course of action to be taken or not to be taken. A policy, a method of proceeding would occur in response to questions as the following:

- What policy should we follow regarding investment in South Africa?
- Should we establish a statement about adding Martin Luther King's birthday to the list of elective vacation days?
- Which changes in policy does the board recommend in health care?
- Which guidelines should we remain firm on in dealing with the former Soviet Union?
- What is the University's policy regarding electronic linkage from the school to the home of instructors?

Try answering the above questions. Some of you will immediately seize upon a single solution, while others will let several choices or answers run through your mind. Your goal in answering a policy question is to arrive at a decision and then recommend that decision to another person or group. To do that requires persuasion, supplying reasons for accepting your recommendation.

A sample outline for the last topic might look like this:

Advocating a change from the status quo involves asking for a change in policy.

Title:	Electronic Linkage: Desirable or Undesirable
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To recommend the University allow electronic linkages with instructors' homes
Main points:	I. Policies at peer schools
	II. Concerns with linkage
	III. Benefits from establishing linkage

Procedure

Questions such as the following suggest a procedure is requested: How will the policy be policed? What steps should be followed in implementing the policy?

What steps should be carried out? What is the scenario of how we will prepare for the court case? Questions and statements of procedure parallel those seen in the discussion of process relating to informative speeches. There the intent was to make a process clear; in persuasive speaking the speaker persuades that one procedure or process is more desirable than another.

- What is the quickest way to install a floppy?
- In formulating a PR strategy for the next year, which steps should we follow with our ad agency?
- In rewriting the company bylaws, where should items on the foreign subsidiaries be placed?
- Crises may hit our company. Which persons and offices should handle crisis communication?
- The agenda for the directors' meeting should have six major categories.
- Let's add the electrical harness for the automobile at step 12.

Not all persons agree on procedures; persuasion is required to support your personal position on how to proceed.

One has only to speak to employees in a manufacturing facility to learn that there are other ways of doing things. Company manuals, standard operating procedures (SOPs), and traditions play forceful roles in how things are carried out. When you propose changes to established procedures, you really have two tasks: You must first show why the previous system is inadequate and you must persuade that your new proposal is better, more cost-efficient, and more effective. An initial outline for a speech about a change in procedure may look like the following (taken from an actual study by a review committee):

Title:		Proposals: A Needed Change
General purpose:		To persuade
Specific purpose:		To recommend a change in proposal preparation for contracts over \$1 million
Main points:	I.	Current preparation procedure
	II.	Problems with current method
		A. To us as the proposers
		B. To proposal requesters
	III.	Recommend changes to procedure
	IV.	Anticipated positive results of accepting proposed changes

Visual aids often accompany requests for change from the current position. (See Appendix A.) The proposal review committee in the above example used visual supports such as (1) cost figures, based on hours worked, for the several departments compiling the internal data; (2) memorandums which showed that several departments were working on the identical background information; (3) pages from the proposal, showing errors of fact and costing, poor grammar and spelling.

Value

The following questions and statements imply a value judgment. Select the value words that suggest how the statement differs from questions and statements of policy and procedure.

- What benefits did we derive from supporting the Olympics?
- Give me three reasons why our bottom line will improve if we invest in Poland.
- Give me a list of the better speakers in the organization.
- It's unwise to compete with the cottage industries of Asia.
- That's the poorest memorandum I've seen in a long time.

Value terms demand clarification; value speeches require using definitions.

A value judgment is needed to answer the questions above and react to the assertions. While you can still turn to facts to support your view, it is quite difficult, for instance, to find many facts in support of the term *better*. All of us carry around in our heads a concept of “better”; and therein lies the problem: We must persuade others that our interpretation of the term *better* is the one to accept. Words and their opposites, as in the following list, imply some kind of value judgment:

Fair/unfair	Honest/dishonest
Good/bad	Valuable/valueless
Interesting/uninteresting	Brave/cowardly
Beautiful/ugly	Advantageous/disadvantageous
Sincere/insincere	Modern/outdated
Leader/follower	Progressive/nonprogressive
Creative/noncreative	Traditional/modern

You may ask “How does one handle value terms?” Try a definition—later discussed as a means to clarity in informative and persuasive speaking. That way you put all receivers on the same level of meaning you attach to the value term. For instance, the following is an adaptation of a statement made in an actual persuasive speech:

I know that we will consider the matter closely, for that's the policy of this company. But I have one favor to ask. Keep in mind what I mean by “acceptable.” For me it means that no worker will be displaced because of the changes; no parachute will be opened for employees here less than 15 years; no retirement benefits will be impacted in any way.

What the speaker did was laudatory: She defined and made public her criteria for her use of the term *acceptable*. This definition, in part, clarified her judgment term and permitted at least a crude form of measurement. It would be ludicrous to try to define each evaluative term we use. To define the statement “It's a nice day” or “That's a good memo” each time it's used goes beyond common sense, a quality needed in handling value situations. A value speech outline could look like this:

Title:	Benefits of Investing in New Zealand
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To recommend to the board that advantages outweigh the disadvantages of investing in New Zealand

- Main points:
- I. Background information on the country
 - A. Geography
 - B. Government
 - C. Economic climate
 - II. Opportunities for growth in New Zealand
 - III. Favorable government policies on foreign investment
 - IV. Ease of doing business
 - A. Language is English
 - B. Politics appear stable
 - C. Tourism on the upswing

Fact (Present or Past)

One would think that matters of fact should raise few questions as to what is true. But not surprising, there are questions as to what happened, when something occurred, or who did what? You are seeking answers to what is true and verifiable. You may be alone as to what you believe is true. In turn, you may have to persuade or inform others.

Business questions and statements requiring a factual answer are represented in the following:

- What is the expenditure of Macau in U.S. dollars for their new airport?
- What did our letter of August 3, 199-, promise those who responded within two weeks?
- Travel costs are way out of line; I want a report on last month's expenditures.
- Our 10-K report was misquoted by the financial services.
- Your department has the highest absenteeism in 199-.

Not everyone agrees as to what is a fact. Extensive research may be required to prove the validity of your facts.

■ Communication Probe

Using statistics or numbers as forms of persuasive support is old hat. Numbers are both praised and condemned. Regardless of your position, numerical support is used to buttress persuasive statements with audiences, either written or oral. One researcher suggests that "[statistics] and other numerical data are simply one of several ways of viewing a situation." Her research suggests that newsy magazines such as *Business Week* use numbers as a kind of shorthand. On the other hand, writers depending on more sophisticated idea development use minimal statistics and other forms of support. Conclusion: Use statistics, but be sure of their credibility and conclusions drawn from them.

Butler, M. S. (1991, March). The persuasive use of numerical data in influential business periodicals. *The Bulletin of the Association for Business Communications*, 54(1), 13-16.

On the surface, answers to questions of fact may appear clear—perhaps to only one person. Under close examination, some supposed facts may be totally in error, owing to a misreading of data, a misunderstanding of data entered into the computer, or a host of other reasons. Witness a court of law where 12 jurors try to decide the “facts” of a case; there is rarely 100 percent agreement, and in some cases so divergent are interpretations of facts that no decision is reached.

Fact (Future)

An area for business management is called *strategic planning*, laying out long-term goals for an entire company or for departments within that company. In stating goals, many internal and external impediments must be considered. Since future planning is based on projections from the past, there is much guesswork involved. The speaker recommending future company directions will therefore face inaccuracies in data; he or she will have to predict future facts.

This book makes no attempt to analyze the various statistical methods and probabilities regarding future data. Predicting the future, inevitably, is risky. Yet, few people can avoid offering interpretations of data, of facts that may impact a company's future. Some companies lay out their sales projections for an entire year and adjust them every several months in view of changes affecting the original projections. All you can do is try to be as correct as possible, building on past facts as the foundation for future projections.

Title:	Environmental Pollution in Country X
General purpose:	To persuade
Specific purpose:	To offer facts that Country X continues to have a high level of pollution
Main points:	I. Background to the problem II. Survey of country's inhabitants concerning pollution A. Drinking water B. Soil C. Air III. Impact of farming on country pollution IV. Proposed governmental action as a result of gathered information

AUDIENCE ANALYSIS FOR INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Knowing as much about your audience as you can decreases your chances of making either content or attitudinal errors.

Surely a group to whom you consistently speak needs less analysis than a new audience. It is this latter group that demands more of your time. Learn something of your audience's up-front interests and attitudes, the occasion, and the location where the speech will be given.

Degrees of Interest and Attitudes

Informative Speaking

Look at Figure 15.3; its structure is similar to a forced-choice questionnaire. That is, questions are worded so that audience responses range from “very interested” to “very uninterested.” You should be able to answer the following three questions:

1. How much do my listeners know about the topic?
2. What is their level of comprehension?
3. What percentage of the group is well informed? What percentage of the group is uninformed?

If your assessment shows an audience is “very familiar” with the topic, you would omit the obvious, the simple, the elementary. You would go on to a more advanced explanation. Such an approach is more characteristic of the informative presentation.

Persuasive Speaking

Using a similar five-point scale allows you to know where your audience falls on the agree-disagree continuum (Figure 15.4). Certainly you will not know precisely where an audience lies on the continuum, but early soundings can give you a general sense of an audience’s position on your topic. Yet one factor even more relevant for persuasion is the attitude of being for (pro) or against (con) your position.

Your assessment focuses on what you think the attitude of your audience is toward accepting your proposal. If they strongly agree with you, your task is easier; if they strongly disagree, your task is more difficult.

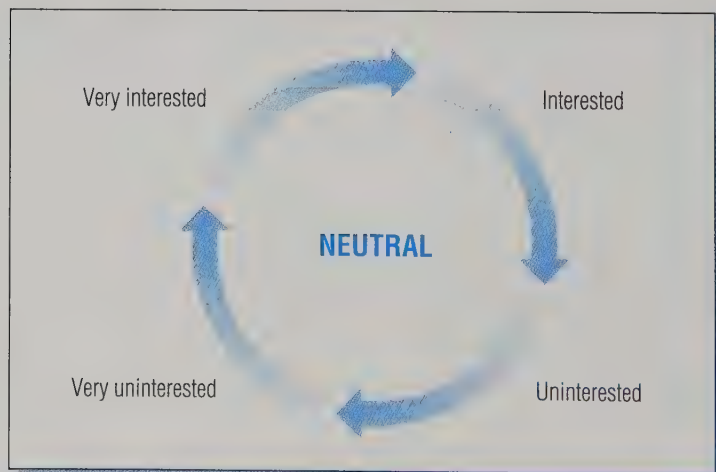


Figure 15.3 Degrees of interest.

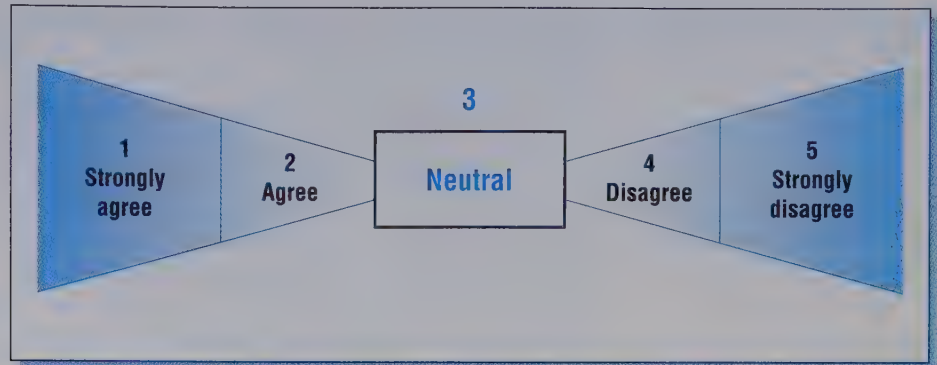


Figure 15.4 Degrees of agreement.

How can you face the hostile, prejudiced audience? Among various ways you may possibly choose these two: search for commonality, and compare agreements with disagreements.

Begin with areas of agreement when speaking before hostile groups.

Search for Common Ground. Speakers facing a hostile audience usually begin with familiar, commonly accepted topics before moving to areas of disagreement. You can begin inductively, using examples, illustrations, and goodwill comments that produce little disagreement. You can use four approaches in your opening remarks:

1. Insert praise for the organization and its members.
2. Mention names of colleagues or friends within the organization with whom you have worked in the past.
3. Make use of patriotism, loyalty, cooperation.
4. Be polite—even poke fun at yourself.

Not all the above commonalities will work all the time in the United States, and in foreign countries perhaps less so. Abroad, you must be aware of differing cultural standards, as discussed in Chapter 3.

Compare Agreements and Disagreements. A second method to consider in breaking down attitudinal hindrances to your position is to review areas of agreement and disagreement—for yourself—prior to giving the speech. Depend heavily upon facts here, use value judgments sparingly. Your goal is to force yourself to see the areas of difference before offering your main position. Labor negotiators and lobbyists often use the parallel-column, agree-disagree approach as an initial review of positions. In some companies the day care issue, for example, may have two points of view:

■ Communication Probe

Ask yourself these questions: How alike are you to your friends—in their beliefs, their attitudes? Do the similarities outweigh the dissimilarities? Are you a likable person? Communicators who give the feeling of being likable to their audiences are in turn liked by their audience. In fact, we spend more time communicating with persons with likable characteristics. Cheerful speakers, for instance, are more likely to hold attention. A speaker who shows little concern for or interest in an audience finds it more difficult to hold the interest of an audience.

Burgoon, J. K., & Miller, M. D. (1990). In G. L. Dahnke & G. W. Clatterbuck (eds.), *Human communication: Theory and research* (pp. 227–258). Belmont, CA: Wadsworth.

Point of View I— Agreement with Your Position

On-site day care permits a single mother to work.

Six percent of industry today offers day care for younger children.

Children in workplace day care are close to one of the parents.

Women with children desire to work for a company with day care.

Point of View II— Disagreement with Your Position

Mothers, regardless of their situation, belong in the home.

Day care costs incurred by the company decrease earnings for everyone.

Single persons feel slighted; they support day care even though they have no children.

Day care is an unacceptable criterion for choosing a place of work.

Although the above two methods—the search for common ground and the comparison of viewpoints—cannot solve all problems with a potentially hostile group, they do force you to review possible audience attitudes toward your topic. Clearly, a group strongly opposed to your idea will force a change in your approach; a more neutral group offers fewer problems.

Occasion

Most of your speaking will occur inside your company, either to members of your own group or to other functional areas. At daily, weekly, or monthly staff meetings you will most likely review the progress of the company; you will inform—extensively, and often.

You will also persuade within your own company. “Good luck on entering the lion’s den” carries a meaning quite clear to business speakers: You are giving a speech on your home ground, perhaps in front of colleagues who are opposed

■ Checklist 15.2 Suggestions for Approaching a Hostile Group

1. Offer a greeting to gain goodwill.
 - “We have differences in philosophy, yet I bring you greetings from many friends of yours whom I have met during this past year.”
 - “I’ve spoken to many groups over the years; each has given me a hearing. I bring you greetings from your colleagues in . . .”
2. Make use of the fairness concept.
 - “All of us in this room have a degree of freedom not experienced anywhere else in the world; I’m using that freedom to bring a different point of view.”
 - “This group is known for its many representatives of fairness; I trust you’ll consider my remarks fair.”
3. Appeal to a sense of human weakness.
 - “Well, I’ve made mistakes in my days; may I tell you about one I made in my first appearance before this group.”
4. Quote from a supporter of the audience’s views.
 - “One of the directors of your association strongly supported the concept of brotherhood. I’ll begin with a quotation he uttered last year.”
 - “Your newsletter has this heading: ‘Unity as based on truth.’ I like that, and believe I can pass that test.”

to your position. Thus your analysis is not as difficult as when speaking to persons outside the organization. Your own work group is relatively constant, many of the same people—with their prejudices and attitudes already in place—being present from session to session. Thus, when either informing or persuading, it is easier to speak when the audience is known and familiar.

When speaking to outside groups, you must devote more thought to the occasion. Are you the main speaker? Are you first or last on the program? How much time will be given to you? These questions apply either to informing or persuading.

Additional concerns arise when persuading an outside audience. There it is more difficult to summarize group attitudes, know their point of view, determine their precise position. Indeed, there may not be a group attitude unless you are, for example, a supporter of nuclear power speaking to an antinuclear group. You may be asked to participate in a public debate, supporting your company’s position in contrast to an outside opposing group; there you would know the format in advance and could bring in material strongly founded on logical supports. Here too you must know—particularly when addressing government groups on behalf of the company—whether your proposal is being given a first reading or whether a decision will be made later. Knowledge of political parties and their position to our company’s proposal is a must before attending a city government meeting.

Location

This obvious characteristic needs minimal discussion. It is sufficient to say that each location for your presentation has its own peculiar physical environment. Members of company speakers' bureaus have spoken in church basements, large auditoriums, oppressively small conference rooms, and even in lounges of local bars. Know the physical arrangements, find out whether you will have a podium or a table. Will you have a public address system? Surely the physical size of the room is important, but underlying all these factors is the attitudinal influence of the room on you, the speaker. Checklist 15.3 gives suggestions for analyzing your audience and the locales of your speech.

ORGANIZATION FOR INFORMATION AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Your basic preparation is over. You have determined whether you will inform or persuade; you have stated your specific purpose and analyzed your audience. You also have begun collecting data. Now it's time to organize the data into a logical pattern. To give you suggestions, we employ the structure suggested since ancient times: introduction, body or discussion, summary or conclusion.

The Introduction

Give effort to the introduction; here you set the tone and pattern for the rest of your talk.

In the preceding chapter we suggested that introductions are composed of three parts: (1) the porch, (2) the aim, or purpose, and (3) the layout. This system we call the PAL approach to public speaking. Let's view those sections with reference to either the speech to inform or persuade.

The Porch (P)

This is the opening statement, the beginning, through using five different approaches.

1. *Tell an anecdote, appropriate joke, or good-natured story relating to your subject.*

"Funny things happen to people between 40 and 60; here's one incident that's common to that group."

■ Checklist 15.3 Analysis of Audience and Locale

1. Know their interests, likes, and dislikes.
2. Determine their degree of knowledge of the topic.
3. Know whether there is hostility toward the topic or toward you.
4. Be aware of the gender of the group and approximate ages.
5. Find out about the physical setting for the speech.

■ Communication Probe

Patterns of arrangement are as diverse as the writers who expose them. While forms of organization are oftentimes appropriate for given topics, writers—and speakers—must also focus on the content. A series of questions is suggested: Can one group similar matters together? Do some ideas appear to be subordinate? Can one move from the general to the specific or the specific to the general? Does the content presuppose certain approaches to arrangement? Are there logical reasons for the specific arrangement? Once these questions have been answered, there is the continuing issue of the audience in arrangement strategies.

Selzer, J. (1989). Arranging business prose. In Myra Kogen (ed.), *Writing in the business professions* (pp. 37–54). Urbana, IL: National Council of Teachers of English, Association for Business Communication.

“An interesting communication story is of a speaker mistaking a restroom in a London airport. I’ll begin there.”

“Merit pay increase may have two definitions: the company’s and mine. You’ll like mine better.”

2. *Use a quotation that gives some background or inspiration to your speech.*

“As Oliver Wendell Holmes wrote, ‘A great thing in this world is not so much where we stand as in what direction we are moving.’ That’s my theme: In which direction are we headed?”

“‘No man is an island,’ John Donne said. That’s the basic idea we promote in this company.”

“‘The shadows are lengthening for me. The twilight is here.’ The words of General MacArthur in 1962 are not a drumroll for ending: They were the beginning of a new resolve for the rest of us.”

3. *Greet your audience sincerely.*

“Two places I especially enjoy coming to are home and your community. It’s good to be with you.”

“The sound of your applause is indeed a warm greeting; I thank you. It’s good to be here.”

4. *Make a startling statement.*

“By the end of my talk, over 2,000 new babies will have been born: Over 1,800 people will have died.”

“Last year we had the lowest turnover rate in the industry: 6 percent.”

“One of you has just won dinner for two. A look on page 27 of the workbook, with my signature, indicates the lucky winner.”

5. Ask questions that make audiences start to think.

“Let me begin by asking some general questions: What’s the average age of a company president? Which area of study do managers say is the most important in reaching the top?”

“Three questions are foremost: What are the architectural plans for the company condominiums?—Who gets first claim on applying for entrance?—How much will they cost?”

The Aim (A)

Briefly, the *aim* is simply stating—clearly and precisely—the *purpose* of your presentation. Examples such as the following have been used:

“One reason brings me here today: to chat with you about the changes in our retirement policy.” (*We know the central purpose immediately.*)

“Let me state up front that our monthly meeting has one purpose: to summarize our positive operating results for the last period.” (*There is little question as to the core idea for the speech.*)

“I’m here to ask for your support as a candidate for the office of state senator.” (*Either pro or con, the audience knows the speaker’s main thrust.*)

“My point is this: We must change our policy regarding the promotion of persons from within the company.” (*Using the word policy immediately sets the purpose of the talk.*)

Therefore, be precise, be exact, be concise regarding the reason you are before an audience. That way you avoid the embarrassing statement one occasionally hears from an audience member at the end of a confusing talk, “I haven’t the slightest idea what that was all about.”

The Layout (L)

By layout we mean giving an *overview*, setting the *agenda*, laying out the *roadmap* of where your speech will proceed. According to an old quotation, “It’s tellin’ ’em what yur gonna cover.” It’s giving a foretaste of the major points to be covered in the body of the talk. Some examples follow.

“I’m here to discuss three major costs connected with product liability.” (*The audience immediately knows you’ll cover three points.*)

“Today I’ll concentrate on the cultural problems abroad regarding different concepts of keeping time.” (*The audience knows there will be several—precise number unknown—issues to be discussed.*)

“One of the reasons I’m here is to support the idea of establishing a subsidiary in the Philippines, for the following four reasons.” (*The audience know four reasons will be presented.*)

Occasionally speakers also state what the three, or four points will be, thus making the layout even clearer, as in the following examples:

“To help you understand why we believe Venezuela provides Wright Oil with attractive investment opportunities, I will discuss Venezuela’s economic, financial, investment, and political situation.” (*Listeners know the four areas to be discussed later in the body of the talk.*)

“Based on my analysis, the marketing research department recommends [*aim*] that Happy Inn expand into the Danish market with several moderately priced 300-room hotels. My criteria for this recommendation are the following: favorable business and investment trends in Denmark, increases in the Danish tourist market, and Happy Inn’s strength in northern Europe.” (*Three criteria serve as the core arguments to be supported in the body of the presentation.*)

Regardless of which approach you use in the layout—simply giving the number of points to be covered or precisely listing the points—audiences tend to remember your major points when the layout is clearly done. Sample introductions using the complete PAL technique are illustrated below.

EXAMPLE 1 *Informative.*

Porch (P)	"Here's a game I'd like to play; it's a variation of Trivial Pursuit.
Aim (A)	What I'd like to do is use this approach to describe some of the characteristics of top-level executives in the United States.
Layout (L)	Our categories for analysis will include career patterns, education, and personal background."

EXAMPLE 2 *Persuasive.*

Porch (P)	"How many of you know the word <u>Macau</u> ? Do any of you even know it's a country? Have any idea where it is?
Aim (A)	I'll tell you. But I'll also make clear that on behalf of the research committee we recommend establishing a pharmaceutical joint venture with a company in that region of the world.
Layout (L)	Our committee reviewed four criteria; these will serve as the basis for our recommendation and reasons for requesting your acceptance: positive government attitude, improved infrastructure, positive investment climate, and a positive market for our products.

The Body (Text, Discussion)

The body or discussion of your topic is where your ideas are developed in detail.

Informative Speaking

Known variously as the *body*, the *discussion*, the *text*, or the *main section*, this part of your speech supports your aim, or specific purpose. Here also appear the

major sections you announced in your layout. In informative speaking you can choose from several ways to make your ideas clear.

1. By Topical Organization. This means you organize topics into natural divisions or into some kind of general classification. No two people organize a topic in an identical matter; each would be correct according to his or her own purpose. A speech on “The Automobile as a People Mover” could be variously organized:

- | | |
|----------------------------|---|
| I. The electrical system | I. Rubber and its use in an automobile |
| II. The lubrication system | II. Plastics as a major portion of the automobile |
| III. The cooling system | III. Steel's contribution to an automobile |

You decide on the major sections in the body of your speech. Then, to make those sections clear, determine the supports (as discussed later in this chapter).

2. By Chronological Organization. Listeners like to follow material according to the order in which events or happenings take place: past, present, and future. That's chronological. If a sequence is obvious, has a beginning and an ending, has a definite sequential motion, has a prescribed order of events, use the chronological order.

An informational speech on “Rights of Students in the Business School Concerning Grade Issues” could have the following major headings:

- I. Individual meetings with the instructor [*earliest*]
- II. Consultation with the department chairperson [*later*]
- III. Consultation with the dean of the school [*later*]
- IV. Final review by academic committee [*latest*]

Instructing a group of middle managers on “Preparing for Meetings” could include:

- I. Decisions before the meeting
- II. Notification of members
- III. Arrangements for the meeting
- IV. The leader's role
- V. The participants' role
- VI. Evaluating the meeting

Even though the headings in the above example are chronological—from before the meeting to after the meeting—you may use your own subheadings within the chronological pattern.

3. By Cause to Effect. We know that certain pressures and stimuli cause other things to happen: Pressing down on the accelerator makes a car go faster;

opening a refrigerator door lets cool air escape; investing money in a bond results in dividend payments; advertising a sale should bring in more customers.

In the preceding examples there is a high chance that the causes produced the stated effects. If the causes were not there, no effect would have occurred. But three caveats are noteworthy in considering causal reasoning.

- a. Avoid assuming that a single cause produces a precise result.

Effect

Low earnings per share

Spelling errors

Takeovers and mergers

Your low raise

A low grade on an assignment

Questionable Cause

are not solely the result of decreased sales.

may or may not be due to a faulty spell-checker.

are not entirely due to the actions of greedy people.

is not wholly due to your boss's not liking you.

does not necessarily mean the instructor dislikes you.

- b. Avoid assuming a false connection, that is, presuming that because one event occurred after another, the two are linked. In the following examples, ask yourself if there is a precise, infallible connection between the cause and the effect.

Effect

Sales were up in 199-

The consulting area of the Big

Eight has grown

She's been a problem

Unemployment is up,

I got an A;

False Linking Causes

after new management took over.

since deregulation.

since she's been here.

and stocks are down.

I changed instructors.

- c. Realize there may be multiple causes, some major, some minor. Not all causes are of equal value. A speaker who states that a minor cause is major is open to challenge. Such is often the basis of argument—discussed in the next chapter—as two different teams or individuals try to determine causes for a problem and try to correct it.

Persuasive Speaking

Synonyms are numerous for the term *thesis*; each, however, carries the idea of a specific declaration followed by credible supporting material.

As the informative speech has options for organizing the body of the speech, so does the persuasive statement. In place of informing, you now use the body to persuade, to get the audience to accept your position, to believe your evidence. What you are doing is gaining acceptance of your aim, often expressed as a claim, assertion, thesis, generalization, proposition, resolution, or even a formal legal statement.

Position:	That one month of foreign travel be required of all students studying for a business degree.
Claim:	I maintain that the <i>Economist</i> is one of the most widely read business journals.
Assertion:	One often hears this assertion, which I happen to accept: There is a high correlation between a favorable home life and one's job satisfaction.
Resolution:	Whereas, lack of exercise among utility executives is a concern of health officials, and Whereas, high correlations exist between exercise and decreases in stress, now therefore Be it resolved: That our corporation support the construction of a physical fitness and wellness center, and that it be available to all employees.
Legal proposition:	Article XII, Section IC, of the code suggests that four members of the financial staff be endorsed by the chief financial officer. Therefore, an amendment through addition should be inserted into Article XII, Section IC, as follows, "That all . . ."

All the terms in the left-hand column assert that something should be done, accepted, or believed. Each demands proof before listeners will willingly go along with you.

Remember this: Persuasive speaking may use the same kinds of organization discussed earlier (topical, chronological, and cause-to-effect). But most persuasive business speaking uses the problem-solution format, proposing a change from the status quo or recommending that things remain as they are.

Problem-Solution—For Change

Frequently your intent will be to argue that something is wrong and that a change is in order; you are unhappy with the status quo. For this reason you must convince listeners that a problem exists and that you have a solution to remedy the problem. You begin with proving the existence of a problem.

The Problem. Central to your thinking is the idea that something is wrong; there is dissatisfaction; flaws exist in the way things are going; failures far outnumber successes; costs are outrunning profits; negatives exceed the positives; the situation is so bad that something must be done; difficulties are many; there is a need for change; things are a mess. Remember, not all your listeners may feel there is a problem, so your first step is proving that one exists. Two brief examples of the problem section in the body follow:

- Problem:**
- Our preparation for a rate case hearing before the Indiana Utility Regulatory Commission can be improved.
 - 1. Neglecting contacts with advocacy groups
 - 2. Preparing case with insufficient evidence

Often used in the business world is the problem-solution-benefit organizational structure for persuasive speaking.

- Problem:** There is need for improving communication between upper and lower management.
1. Lower management feels they are being talked down to
 2. Downward communication is often without explanation
 3. Personal interaction is minimal between the two levels

By presenting your problem analysis you have met half your responsibilities. You now must present the solution for solving the problem.

The Solution, or Recommendation. Politely state your solution and then give your reasons. Several questions may run through your listeners' minds:

- Do we really need to change from what we're now doing?
- Will the proposal really solve the problem?
- Can one be sure that the solution will work? Be practical? Be effective? Be cost-effective?
- Will the benefits of the solution outweigh the negatives?
- Will the proposal create a host of entirely new problems?

Having answered what debaters call these "stock issues," you are ready to amplify your solution. Two examples of organizing solutions or recommendations follow:

Recommend we improve our preparation for rate hearings through the following steps.

1. Inform the Indiana Utility Regulatory Commission as to the motivation behind the proposed rate increase.
2. Focus on local consumer organizations.
3. Inform company employees.
4. Write numerous news releases for the public media.

Recommendations for opening lines of communication between upper and lower management.

1. Publish monthly newsletters; inform all levels of the organization.
2. Institute a "Good Idea Program" to encourage employee involvement at all levels.
3. Promote visits between levels of management.

Overview of forms of cooperation.

1. Restricted investment.
2. Technology licenses.
3. Customer and supplier.
4. Joint venture.

Your solution is a mixture of laying out your recommendation and showing how it will remove the problems you cited earlier. One more step needs to be

taken in the body of the speech advocating change: Show the benefits of adopting your solution and the disadvantages of not accepting the solution.

The Benefits from the Solution Briefly, you can insert in your talk positive results if your solution is adopted. You're trying to heighten desire for acceptance, summarizing future desirable effects. Your answers would be "yes" to the questions raised on page 433. Yes, we really do need to change; yes, my proposal would solve the problems, along with producing the following benefits; yes, my proposal would work, would be practical, would be effective, would be cost-effective; yes, by accepting my proposal the benefits would outweigh the negatives; yes, my solution implies that a change is needed and would not create a series of new problems.

Do not hesitate to show the negative consequences if your proposal will not be accepted.

The Disadvantages of Not Accepting the Solution. Conversely, you may also use a negative approach. A typical method is to suggest that if your recommendation or solution is not accepted, undesirable consequences will occur. You project into the future, suggesting that the current situation will continue (the status quo will be maintained); current problems, as you have defined them, will continue; undesirable consequences, such as costs, work force issues, or examples relevant to your topic, will not be removed. An example of two negatives is seen in the following:

Negative: Neglecting to improve our preparatory steps for a rate case hearing will result in continued poor preparation.

1. The Commission will sense we are unprepared to defend our requested rate increase.
2. The public will be up in arms unless we get publicity out into the community.
3. The leading consumer groups of the city will feel neglected if they are not kept informed, resulting in less support of our position.

Negative: Not adopting an open-line communication system will permit the current problem to continue.

1. Team spirit will not increase.
2. Vested interests will continue in strength.

Thus the problem-solution-benefit form of organizing the body of the persuasive speech first proves the existence of a problem, supplies a remedy to that problem, and then projects positive benefits if the solution is adopted or negative consequences if the recommendation is not accepted.

Problem-Solution—For No Change

Arguing that no problem exists is as common as arguing that a problem does exist.

Any hint at changing a procedure or accepting a different idea within an organization is to some people a red flag. Indeed, most people like things to remain as they are. We all have heard statements such as "What's wrong with the way we're

■ Communication Probe

Immunity. That term is usually associated with the medical world. Yet, used metaphorically, it has applicability to the world of business as well. There “immunity” can be a shield, a hindrance, an impediment, an obstacle to individuals receiving a message. In brief, some persons consciously edit out unwanted information, screening out much information formed by public relations people. One answer is to select a strategy that is in tune with the audiences selected to hear the message, with the intent of influencing their behavior. How to achieve this, one expert suggests, is via communication strategy, creativity, message building, delivery, and evaluation.

Obrien, T. (1995, May). Business must overcome “message immunity.” *Communication World*, 12, 32.

now doing it?” “Why should we tamper with success?” “There’s no problem; why can’t we leave things alone?” “That recommendation is worse than what we’ve got now.” “Over my dead body will that solution be adopted,” and so forth through a series of statements reflecting resistance to change.

The Problem. If you feel the current situation is acceptable as is, you are in favor of the status quo. Such an attitude may be as legitimate as that of those who wish a change, except that you must prove that no problem or need to change exists. All your subheads in support of the proposition must leave one impression: There is no problem; things are fine.

If you are in favor, for example, of keeping your training program in your company as now structured, you might formulate the following generic main headings, which may be adapted to other topics as well:

- Problem:** Current situation for training managers
1. In-house programs
 2. Use of outside consultants and trainers
 3. Release time for on-site programs

The Solution. Debaters on the negative side of an issue—those opposed to change and in favor of the status quo—would argue that no new solution is needed, things are currently acceptable. By analogy, a political party out of power contends that so many problems exist that a change in the administration should be made; the group in power argues that to continue success, the current party must remain.

- Recommendation that we remain with the current system
1. Continue in-house programs along with release time
 2. Continue use of outside expert consultants and trainers

The Summary or Conclusion

Earlier we stated that a summary pulls together the main points of your talk. Now you tell an audience what you have told them—similar to the summaries at the end of each chapter in this book. If your talk has symmetry, the summary will closely mirror the purpose and layout as expressed in your introduction, as for example:

Introduction

In January 1997, MCA announced that it had agreed with Nippon Steel Corporation of Japan to explore various types of joint opportunities in the entertainment and leisure field. You asked that I investigate some of those possibilities and provide both positive and negative views on various options and then come in with a recommendation.

Summary

In summary, current successes of theme parks in Japan offer great opportunities for our company. My review of several options, both pluses and minuses, leads to one recommendation: MCA and Nippon Steel should establish a joint venture tour and entertainment facility in Tokyo.

Although the summary may closely follow the introduction, using a visual aid—perhaps the same one used in the beginning of the speech—is a good way to add visual emphasis and provide a frame for the entire speech (see Appendix A).

Conclusions draw inferences, conclusions, judgments—as based on your material. Here you make one last call to action, one final appeal that your proposal be accepted. You imply that your evidence was sufficient to support your position and now request audience acceptance.

“And so our conclusion is inescapable: We must approve the four steps recommended for improving our preparation for rate case hearings.”

“To review, I sincerely ask for your support in trying different methods of opening lines of communication between upper and lower management: through newsletters, through a ‘Good Idea Program,’ and through personal visits between management levels.”

Summaries reiterate what was covered; conclusions are inferences from data.

SUPPORTS FOR INFORMATIVE AND PERSUASIVE SPEAKING

Since the time of Aristotle, Cicero, and Quintilian—writers on oral communication in the ancient world—speakers have been told that good oral communication rests upon three bases: *ethos*, *pathos*, and *logos*. These Greek terms are perhaps not part of your vocabulary, yet you have used what they mean in your writing and will do so in your speaking.

Consistently, personal credibility is rated highly if you are to persuade successfully.

Ethos concerns your credibility as a speaker, what you do that suggests good sense or a high moral character. You give your listeners the impression that you are a believable person. You do that by knowing your subject, giving the feeling that you are fairly presenting your information via a delivery that is enthusiastic and believable. In other words, both you as a person and the contents of your speech must give an image of high credibility and believability.

Pathos is using emotion to support your ideas. Few of us would admit—especially in the business world—that we are moved to action on the basis of our emotions. Our advertising and marketing friends have been capitalizing on emotions for years. But few speeches in staff meetings or before company groups depend on the emotional impact left on listeners. Surely, we are influenced by appeals to fear, to self-preservation, to physical well-being, to self-esteem, and to a host of other needs, but they do not often find a prominent place in internal business communication.

It is *logos*, the third part of ancient rhetorical principles, that receives major emphasis in both written and oral persuasion. *Logos* involves using evidence and reasoning, organizing supports into logical patterns of argument. All of us hope that rational thinking governs our actions. And to a great extent speaking to your peers within a company is based on rational thinking.

Now we focus on facts and opinions and then on the seven kinds of evidence that are used to support persuasive positions.

Six Forms of Support (Evidence, Data)

Regardless of what you consider a valid number of forms of support—and there is disagreement on this subject—we suggest that the raw material for supporting your speaking aim be found through using six different supports. Clearly, the core of your supports has to be founded on facts, verifiable data. Opinions are also used, but using opinions demands selecting a credible source. After we have looked at how facts and opinions are used in six different kinds of support, we will suggest ways of testing their reliability.

■ Communication Probe

Most of us accept the norm that rational arguments help us accept ideas, support propositions, believe others. Surely data, evidence, and supports assist us in making a decision, but humans are inconsistent in accepting changes in belief. Using evidence is helpful, but not a 100% guarantee of success in changing others' views. However, some early studies suggest that careful use of evidence is effective; it does have some influence on the receivers of a message, particularly if it is new and relevant to the assertion or claim.

Reynolds, R. A., & Burgoon, M. (1983). Belief processing, reasoning, and evidence. In R. Bostrom (ed.). *Communication yearbook* 7 (pp. 49–82). Beverly Hills: Sage. McCroskey, J. C. (1972). In T. D. Beisecker & D. W. Parson (eds.), *The process of social influence* (pp. 318–324). Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall.

Examples

You will use this form of evidence more than any other. It is a short, pithy item, representative of a group. An example also helps clarify in addition to acting as a form of support.

“For example, some companies in foreign countries turn off their fax machines at night in order to conserve energy. What that means is that senders in distant time zones cannot make contact.”

“Here’s an example: It took K-mart three news releases to clarify the situation concerning the possible sale of certain subsidiaries.”

Then you can draw conclusions from the example, offer judgments based on the presented information.

Illustrations

Illustrations are elongated examples; they lay out in detail a specific situation, suggesting, for example, that your proposed solution has worked successfully elsewhere.

“TV teaching was used in this manner by X company in successfully preparing employees for overseas work. They began with a film on intercultural problems, followed that with a written analysis of what participants felt was the problem, and ended with a discussion with people who had spent time in that country. The whole process took place over three weeks.”

Statistics

Many of the statistics (numbers) you use in persuasion in the business world are self-generated. They are therefore dependent on your method of collection and the inferences you draw from them. You should know what statistical measures to use to prove the validity of your data.

You will also use statistics from sources other than yourself. If statistics come from members of your own staff, you are in a good position to gauge the reliability of the data. On the other hand, turning to secondary sources outside your immediate area demands knowing the credibility of that source and the secondary source in which the information may have been reported.

“According to the World Tourism Organization, more international tourists are arriving in Vietnam. It is estimated that Vietnam’s share of tourists (including businesspersons) from Southeast Asia, Japan, Europe, North America, and Australia should increase from 2.7% in 1989 (187,573) to 8.4% (1,596,264) in 2005.”

Quotations, Testimony

Using credible sources beyond yourself adds to your credibility. That linkage adds to improved acceptance of your ideas. A *literal* quotation is using the words

Quoting credible sources also improves the speaker’s credibility.

of a well-established, accepted expert, an individual, or a book genuinely informed on the topic. You will use this kind of citation often in your business presentations.

“A recent story in the *Bangkok Post* stated that ‘Thailand launched a campaign to retain the 1998 Asian games.’ ”

“Samart chairman Mr. Peter Sutch said that profits for the next fiscal year should equal or even surpass the 5.4% increase over last year.”

When speakers use a *literary* quotation, they are evoking the words of a source primarily for its emotional or philosophical support. You would probably not use this kind of quotation in the business world, but rather in nonbusiness affiliations. Thus a quotation from Shakespeare, Browning, Abraham Lincoln, Confucius, or the Bible could be used for its possible emotion-getting reaction from the audience.

“Even the Bible (Matthew 25:20) suggests we use what has been given us: ‘And so he that had received five talents came and brought other five talents, saying, Lord, thou deliveredst unto me five talents: behold I have gained beside them five talents more.’ ”

“One of the great business stories involving accounting principles, mistrust, and usury is in Shakespeare’s *Merchant of Venice*; let me offer a few quotations from Portia’s speech. . . .”

Comparisons demand similarities between two subjects; those similarities should outweigh the dissimilarities.

Comparisons (Analogies)

Comparisons estimate similarities and differences between at least two different items. Thus investors wish to know the earnings per share from quarter to quarter, rates of exchange between nations, comparisons that help clarify complex procedures, differences in salaries from company to company, or recommendations as to which business communication book is best on the market. Again, once the comparison is stated, you can draw conclusions from that information. Be careful. Not all persons will draw the same conclusions as you!

“Note the differences in earnings per share in 1996 with 199-; there is a 2% increase. That success should continue.”

“Think of the human heart as a pump. As the water pump in an automobile moves water through the system, so the human heart pumps blood through our human system.”

Definitions

Keep in mind that definitions are not exactly supports. Yet, using them helps both speaker and audience to be at the same level of understanding. In either informative or persuasive speeches, words have denotative (dictionary) meanings

or meanings that you personally link to your ideas. Use either form to clarify your thought.

“Asian Dragons? Let me clarify. It means the four countries of Korea, Hong Kong, Thailand, and Singapore, each offering the rest of the world increased competition.”

“*Engineer* refers to our authorized representative for purchasing; he or she will be the final authority in administering the contract.”

Questions on Forms of Support

Recall what was said earlier: All listeners and readers come with their own biases and prejudices on topics. So do we as speakers; we too select—edit out—opinions, even facts that do not conform to our way of thinking. In collecting evidence we must be careful about the accuracy and neutrality of our sources. One way an audience counters your arguments is to raise questions such as those offered in Checklist 15.4—all of which you should consider in selecting your evidence.

Do the facts agree with other facts? If there is conflict between two sets of facts, both may be wrong. If the facts you use are supported by others, the data are more valid.

Are the opinions you use or depend on reliable? Just because a person is a respected member of the community does not make him or her an expert on every subject. Search for expert, rather than lay, opinions.

Answering these and other questions better prepares you for responding to

■ Checklist 15.4 Selecting Evidence for Your Speech

1. Is the source reliable? Is the material taken from data considered valid by common standards of honesty and integrity?
2. Does the person whom you are quoting have a reputation for credibility? For fairness? For careful research?
3. Is your information true? Valid? Is it accurate or taken out of context?
4. What is the recency of your data? How old is the information? Is it out of date? Are more recent statements available on the same topic?
5. Are your statistics valid? Have you used commonly accepted means of determining reliability?
6. Have you indicated how you obtained your evidence? Do you make it clear when you are moving from your opinion to what is considered fact?
7. How wide is your scope? How many others agree with your evidence?
8. Is your evidence ambiguous? Do you go through it with generalities, rather than specifics?

■ Communication Probe

Self-esteem does play a role in persuasion. Possessing this trait cuts two ways: When you're exposed to appeals from others and in turn expressing your own opinions and arguments. Persons with high self-esteem have confidence in themselves, are comfortable with their own opinions when persuading others. Moreover, these same high self-esteem persons are also more confident in challenging the opinions of others. An inevitable conclusion is that when addressing an audience possessing high self-esteem, there is need for careful selection of and credible supports for evidence selected.

Cox, D. F., & Bauer, R. A. (1964). Self confidence and persuasability in women. *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 28, 453–466; Gelfand, D. M. (1962). The influence of self-esteem on the rate of verbal conditioning and social matching behavior. *Journal of Abnormal and Social Psychology*, 65, 259–265; Gollow, J. G., & Dittes, J. E. (1965). Different effects of manipulated self-esteem on persuasability depending on the threat and complexity of the communication. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 2, 195–201.

possible objections and at the same time gives you confidence that your choice of evidence is acceptable and valid.

SUMMARY

In our view, the general purposes of oral communication lie on a continuum: On one end is the process of informing (through reports, goodwill statements, briefings, and instruction), and on the other is the process of persuasion (on issues of policy, procedure, value, and fact). Blending does occur between the two, informative communication frequently providing the background for persuasion. In the former you seek to clarify, make an idea or process clear; in the latter you seek willing acceptance of your ideas.

Central to either informing or persuading is knowing your audience, which means tuning in to their degrees of interest in your topic and their attitudes toward you or the subject. Both the occasion for your talk and the location details should also be known.

Your ideas may be organized in the traditional introduction, body, and conclusion format. In the introduction consider using the PAL (porch, aim, layout); in the body or discussion you have many choices: from topical, chronological, or cause to effect in informative speaking, and the more traditional problem-solution outline in persuasive speaking. A summary to your remarks reviews your major points, whereas a conclusion draws inferences from data presented.

Supports—also known as evidence or data—include using examples, statistics, quotations, comparisons, and definitions. All these need validity in order to establish your credibility with the audience.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Presentation of a Talk in a Foreign Language.** This assignment requires that one or two persons competent in a foreign language present a 2- or 3-minute speech in a foreign language. Class members listening to this foreign speech then seek answers to the following questions:
 - Was the presentation to inform or persuade?
 - Could you determine whether the tone was serious or lighthearted?
 - Were there any words recognizable to you?
 - Was there a sense of sincerity in his or her remarks?
2. **Determining the Clarity of a Foreign Visual Aid.** Again this assignment works better if the student completing the assignment knows a foreign language. Have that student go to the library or some other resource and locate a visual aid in a foreign language. Clearly that visual is being used as a form of support or as evidence to accompany the written statement. Make a transparency of that foreign visual. Then do the following:
 - Project the foreign visual—as a transparency—on a screen.
 - Have members of the class draw *inferences* as to what the visual is trying to communicate or trying to support.
 - Let the student who understands the visual then interpret it.
 - Assess whether the visual meets the requirements of clarity and a form of support.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Informative Speech to Peers.** Prepare an informative speech on any topic of your choice. Your goal is to make clear an idea to an audience of peers. As you prepare the talk, be sure to do the following: Use clear organization, support your specific purpose with a variety of support forms, and deliver with desirable pitch, rate, and volume. For a 3- to 5-minute talk, use the following format:

Title: _____
 General purpose: to inform _____

Introduction

I. Specific purpose _____
 II. _____

Body

III.
 IV.
 V.

Summary

VI.
 VII.

4. **Persuasive Speech on a Controversial Topic.** Prepare a 5-minute oral statement on a controversial topic that you wish to defend before the class. You will make but one main point. Clearly, you will have to present evidence so the group will accept your proposition. Your support (evidence) should come from reliable outside sources and individual investigation. Prepare an outline similar to the following:

Title of one-point proposition: _____
General purpose: To persuade
Specific purpose: _____
Specific main point: _____
First support: _____
Second support: _____
Third support: _____

The following are sample one-point assertions:

- Reprimands to employees should begin with an oral statement followed with a written summary.
- Concepts of time are different in Asia than in the United States.
- Recommendation: English should be the universal language of business throughout the world.
- Nonverbal communication is as effective as oral communication.
- There should be mandatory retirement at age 62.

5. **Revision of General Purposes into Specific Phrases.** Rewrite the following vague phrases into an infinitive phrase for a speech to persuade.

Health care in the United States
Term limits for members of Congress
Government bonds
E-mail
Nonverbal communication
Asian communication
European right of free speech
Dress and the listener

6. **Informative Speech to Clarify an Idea or Explain a Purpose.** Prepare an informative presentation that makes an idea clear or explains a process. This speech should be about 4 to 6 minutes in length. Criteria are organizational clarity, a good delivery, and content that supports your ideas. Try also to use visual aids. You may choose from these topics or others:

The steps involved in buying stock
What is meant by the “invisible hand” in business
Characteristics of rejection letters
How a word processor works
What is meant by “first-in, last-out” in the accounting field

7. **Assessing Periodicals for Credibility.** After reading this chapter, you should be more attuned to the credibility of sources used for your facts and opinions. Daily you are bombarded with visual and auditory stimuli. And it

is from some of these stimuli that you collect forms of support for your speeches, or papers.

Divide a paper into two parts, as follows:

NAME OF PERIODICAL	ASSESSMENT
1.	1.
2.	2.

On the left side name a periodical (daily paper, magazine), on the right side assess the credibility of that publication as a source for financial news. Number one could be your selection as the most credible source; your last number in that column—at least five—could be your lowest-ranking source. Give reasons—support why one periodical has higher credibility than another.

8. **Oral Presentation of Long Formal Report.** Assume you have been asked to present your long, formal report orally at an informal conference attended by 10 managers in your company. Their work is closely concerned with the subject matter of your report. Prepare your report presentation thoughtfully. Usually a mere “summary” of the report is not the best method because it may be too general to be meaningful to your listeners. In addition, if appropriate, select specific highlights about the problem and its solution. Choose the ideas that are most likely to be of interest and importance to your audience. For example, you might introduce to them the three or four most important factors you considered in the report. Be well informed about the overall highlights of your report, and be prepared to defend your findings in a question-and-answer session (with your class members) immediately after you have presented your report. (In your presentation, you will of course *not* read many parts of the report to the audience.) Make your talk businesslike, with the right tone; it may be 20 or more minutes in length.
9. **Persuasive Speech to Support Keeping Things As They Are.** Occasionally you may make a speech opposing change; you like things the way they are. Prepare a 5-minute statement wherein you are opposed to change. Some possible topics include the following:
 - Insider trading rules are adequate.
 - Keep the present political party in power.
 - There is no need for a foreign language requirement for business students.
 - Keep our present requirements for receiving a degree.
 - The current tax laws are adequate.
10. **Noting Comparison Between an Informative Talk and a Stockholder Letter.** Go to your library and locate three different annual reports. These could be in similar product categories (all chemical or all automotive or all fast-food, for example). Read only the letter to the stockholders, usually

signed by the president or CEO (chief executive officer). Your task will be to determine answers to the following questions:

- a. Is the structure similar to that of an informative speech? Does it have an introduction, body, and conclusion?
- b. What is the specific purpose of the letter?
- c. Is the letter informative or persuasive? Why?
- d. What forms of evidence are used in the letter?
- e. Was the letter effective?

11. **Critical Analysis of a Paragraph.** The statement that follows is attributed to no particular speaker. However, it does illustrate some flaws in critical thinking. It could have been spoken at a sales meeting or in another persuasive situation.

Analyze the statement at each of the numbered points in the statement. Each one is a location for potential critical thinking errors. You might think of content, reasoning, language, and sources for the information.

“There is no doubt [1] that every [2] home in the United States needs [3] a microwave oven. Most [4] homes have it [5] already. In fact, statistics suggest [6] that microwave ovens are the fastest growing item added to every [7] new home. Years ago [8] the outdated [9] woodstove, the bane [10] of every farm woman [11], was the center of the family. While the microwave oven cannot match that emotional and desirable bond, it can add the same speed and efficiency enjoyed by others.” [12]

REFERENCE

1. L. G. Verheyen. (1988, August). *Training and Development Journal*, 72–76.

Strategies for Successful Interpersonal Communication

I. Dyadic Communication

- A. Self-Perceptions
- B. Dyadic Communication Relationships

II. Interviewing

- A. Interview Purposes
- B. Interviewee's Responsibilities
- C. Interviewer's Responsibilities

III. Telephoning

IV. Dictating

- A. Suggestions for Dictating
- B. Example of Dictation

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

VII. Reference

Face-to-face communication is the most common form of communication within organizations.

Thus far this book has focused on the more formal aspects of business communication: writing and speaking in formal business settings. But there is another side: more informal, more casual, more given to informal interactions between people. Such interaction may be called *interpersonal*; it is primarily face-to-face communication between two or more people with the opportunity for immediate feedback. Hence both sender and receiver affect one another; the feedback loop involves oral and nonverbal responses and is immediate rather than delayed, as in written communication.

Many of your communications will be with one other person. Such interaction is called *dyadic*. And this 1:1 relationship is the foundation for group and committee work, discussed in the next chapter. Here, however, we focus on some principles relating to dyadic communication and then offer suggestions on handling three common forms of interpersonal communication: interviewing, telephoning, and dictating.

DYADIC COMMUNICATION

Your self-perceptions can be tested through honest feedback from an intimate friend.

We define a *dyad* as two persons seeking to exchange information. Of course that may occur within a meeting, but here we focus on personal 1:1 interactions. And because two persons interact, we begin with a look at self-perceptions: how each of us sees the self.

■ Communication Probe

Four types of communication pervade the business world. Sometimes called the Big Four, their percentage of use has not varied much over the years—speaking, writing, listening, and reading are cornerstones of business communication. Note that two of the four relate to oral communication, some of that being interpersonal in nature. Thus writing and reading pertain to the written word. Without detailing the many studies that have investigated their percentage of usage, look at the following percentages of use by some recent Asian and Egyptian managers:

PERCENTAGE OF DAY DEVOTED TO THE FOLLOWING TYPES OF COMMUNICATION

	Egyptian	Asian
Speaking	27.3	28.7
Listening	21.8	25.3
Writing	28.6	24.4
Reading	25.1	21.4

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Edington, D. (1987). *A managerial profile: The Asian manager*. Ann Arbor: Division of Research, University of Michigan Business School, University of Michigan; Hildebrandt, W. W. (1996). [Questionnaire data from Egypt. Unpublished raw data.]

Self-Perceptions

Setting us apart from animals is our ability to look at ourselves. We can, objectively or subjectively, consider who we are. Surely most of those perceptions will be private, but on occasion we do make them public. Others' perceptions of us may be different. Take a look at the following characteristics of one man:

Tall	Married
Has a beard	Drives a four-wheel drive truck
Wears jeans to class	Smokes
Has holes in the jeans	Wears horn-rimmed glasses
Wears cap on backward	Wears no socks
Friendly	Consistently late

Although the above is an incomplete picture of the person, he nevertheless exists. What inferences do you draw from the above cues? What is your perception of this person? Would you invite him to your home? When asked to write a description of this man, one person wrote:

He is someone from a broken home who rarely had guidance in preparing for the outside world. His home was probably disorganized. His habits were influenced by members of his family, one of whom smoked. Clearly, he likes the out-of-doors.

Would you agree? It is virtually impossible to arrive at conclusions based solely on visible, nonverbal characteristics. Actually, the description of the person is that of a college professor; he has written over 40 articles, has appeared on national forums, and currently is a leading university lecturer. His self-perception is positive; he gets along well with his peers, and he is a diabetic type I. His teaching awards have been numerous.

In short, over time we accept some personal verbal and nonverbal habits of others that are out of sync with our own. We often are inaccurate in our perception of others, and we may have a distorted view of even ourselves. A cyclical action may occur, as seen in Figure 16.1.

Thus, misjudging a person because of idiosyncratic behavior can lead to serious misunderstandings. Your personal biases may shout so loudly that you do not even hear what the other person says. You may have thought a lot, but not very correctly; you may have spoken a lot, but not very precisely. In short, both your self-perception and the perceptions of others can influence transactions in communication.

Jumping to conclusions about an individual can be done too quickly: Be cautious in drawing conclusions about others.

Dyadic Communication Relationships

It is virtually impossible *not* to communicate in reaction to another person.

Earlier we said that dyadic communication involves two people seeking to exchange information. Consequently, communication that is unidirectional lacks feedback.

Look at Figure 16.2. Speaker A sends a message to receiver B and receives little feedback from Receiver B. Receiver B, in turn, sends that same message to listener C, again with little feedback. The cycle continues. That is not good inter-

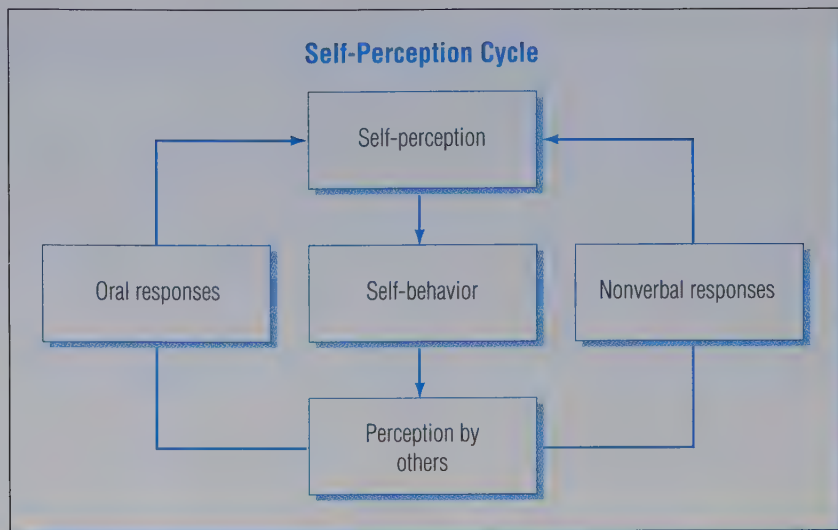


Figure 16.1 The cyclical nature of self-perception.

personal communication. Some argue that it is impossible *not* to communicate. Even averting one's eyes or turning away from a speaker is a form of response. Figure 16.3 is a more purposeful dyadic exchange.

Answer this question: What are the most frequent two-person communication interactions occurring during a business day? If you guessed face-to-face communication, you are correct. We can classify two-person conversations two ways—by function and type.

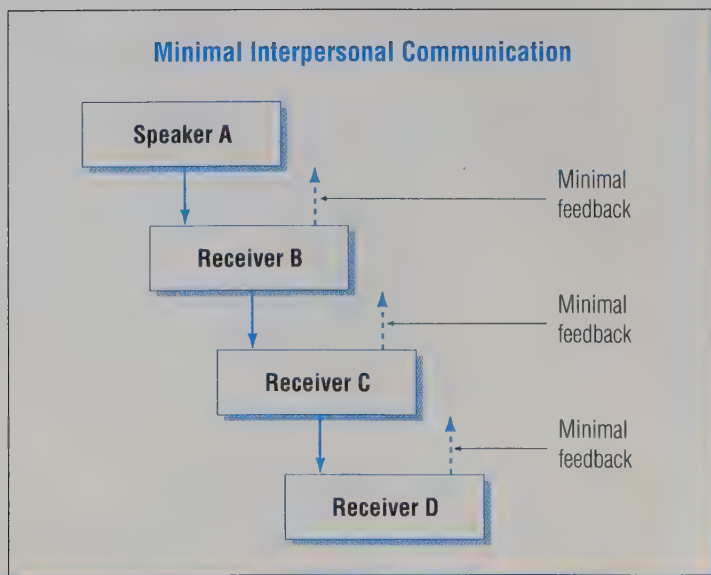


Figure 16.2 Minimal interpersonal communication.

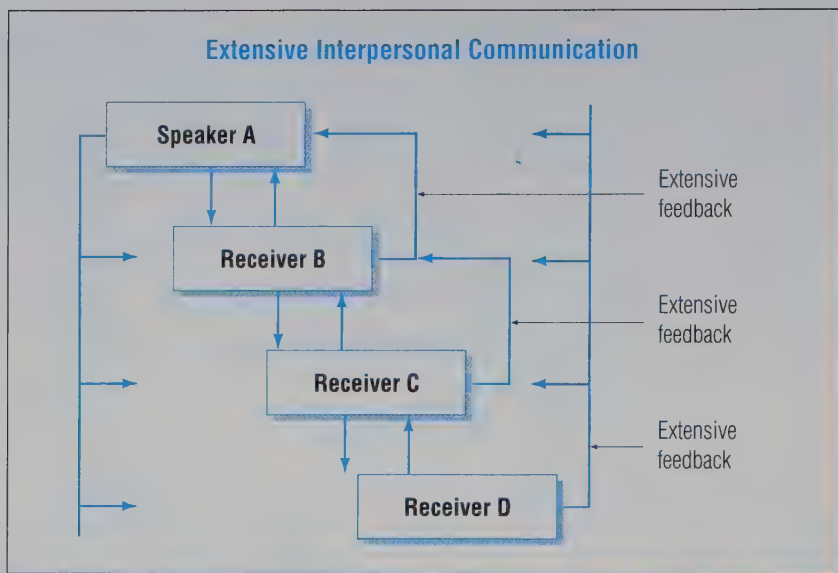


Figure 16.3 Extensive interpersonal communication.

Both informal (unplanned meetings) and formal (planned) interactions between two people are part of a communication day.

Functional Relationships

A purposeful meeting may involve two people meeting for a common purpose. Here the glue holding them together is tighter than the hall conversation or the quick hello on the street. The following are functionally related interactions:

- Interviewing for a position (*qualifications of a candidate are evaluated*).
- Instructional interview (*new employee finds out about the specific duties for a new position*).
- Telephone exchange (*clarification of issues, informing on topics, hopes for closing a deal*).
- Grade review (*session to clarify grades on a recent examination, between student and instructor*).
- Job termination (*exit interview seeking to get departing employee's reasons for leaving a position*).

And there are many others. Note that all the above examples have one common aim: to achieve something, to assist, to guide, to explain, to review. The meeting is not haphazard, but in most instances planned by one of the parties in the exchange.

Types of Relationships

A second way of viewing dyadic communication is to think about the levels at which you relate to people. On a continuum of intimate to nonintimate, where do the following persons lie?

■ Communication Probe

It does not take much insight to guess which form of communication is most often used in business settings: face-to-face communication. That informal mode of speaking with others is characteristic everywhere—among U.S. managers and Asian managers. In fact, with Asian managers the telephone is the most preferred means for interaction with another person. Tie that statement in with face-to-face communication, and you realize the importance given to the value of interpersonal communication. Asian statistics follow:

Modes of Communication	Percentage of Respondents Listing Modes of Communication as 1 of 4 Modes of Communication
Telephone	90
Face-to-face	77.5
Memorandum	55
Computer mail	30
Letter	29
Electronic blackboard	5
Teleconferencing	5
Videoconferencing	5

Hildebrandt, H. W., & Edington, D. (1987). *A managerial profile: The Asian manager*. Ann Arbor: Division of Research, University of Michigan Business School.

Your family	Your secretary
Your boss	Your teacher
Your coworkers	Your president
Your fellow students	Your roommate
Your spouse	Your significant other

Clearly, we desire to communicate more often, and intimately, with those with whom we feel comfortable and trust.

Each of the above categories falls somewhere on the continuum, as seen in Figure 16.4. A follow-up question to the above is what will cause your relationship to end with any of the above persons? It is safe to say that most of our relationships with others are more nonintimate: quick to flourish, quick to die.

The words exchanged between persons in an intimate relationship (spouses, significant others, dates, partners) are clearly at a different level of exposure and intimacy than the other relationship categories. Although some intimate relationships do exist in a work setting, your communication will more likely avoid the kinds of topics and intimacy reserved for your family and those close to you.

Most of your interpersonal communication at work will be at the “friend” and “acquaintances” levels. It will be more formal, with the topics heavily business-related. At meetings you may see people you do not know; they are strangers and completely nonintimate.

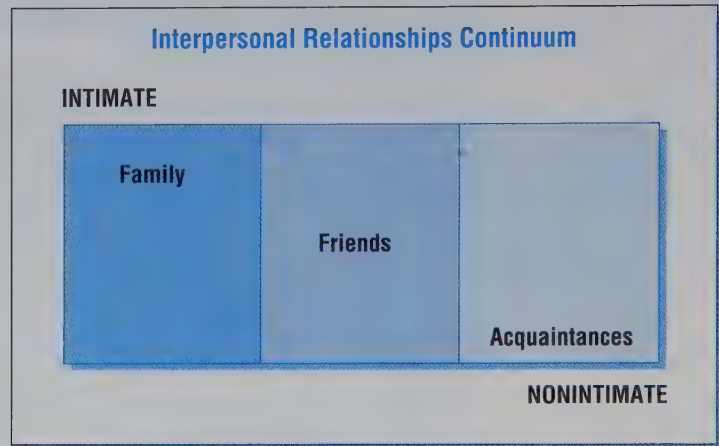


Figure 16.4 Interpersonal relationships continuum.

Reflect for a moment. What sort of oral or nonverbal greeting did you receive from complete strangers today? Were you greeted orally or given some form of recognition as a stranger passed you? Was eye contact avoided?

As your intimacy with another person increases, the kinds of communication you exchange and kinds of things you talk about also change. Thus, speaking about the weather is a safe, nonthreatening oral greeting; or a slight nod, or a hesitant wave to a stranger is usually acceptable. Rare is the person who launches into controversy immediately on meeting a stranger. Only after some sharing of pleasantries do both persons begin to open up and make public their

■ Communication Probe

No test is exact enough to determine whether your perceptions about another person are correct. Yet, you must interact, you must communicate with other people. You, to a large extent, may prefer certain of those people. How? Our degrees of positive feelings for another are as varied as the research on the topic. Propinquity (proximity of physical closeness) is a cause; so are similarities in attitudes. Demographic characteristics such as age, gender, education, cultural or ethnic identity, and socioeconomic status also play a role, as do similarity in beliefs, opinions, and values. When two people believe, and sense, the presence of these characteristics, they are on the way to becoming close interpersonal communicators.

Byrne, D. (1969). Attitudes and attraction. In L. Berkowitz (ed.), *Advances in experimental social psychology*, Vol. 4. New York: Academic Press; Byrne, D. (1971). *The attraction paradigm*. New York: Academic Press; McCroskey, J. C., Richmond, V. P., & Daly, J. A. (1975). The development of a measure of perceived homophily in interpersonal communication. *Human Communication Research*, 1, 323–332.

Communication Probe

A recent theory on determining linkages between one's self-perception of his or her communication abilities and that of others is the Competing Values Communication Model. Here you first self-assess your oral or written skills. Then other people (peers, subordinates, or superiors) are asked to do the same about you. Through statistical calculations applied to 12 criteria, it is possible to create a visual picture of where you feel you are *now* and where you would *like to be*. Similar calculations are done for others' evaluations. A sample of a completed visual of one person's self-assessment is depicted in Figure 16.5.

Rogers, P. S. & Hildebrandt, H. W. (1993). Competing values instruments for analyzing written and spoken management messages. *Human Resource Management*, 32(1), 121–142; Quinn, R. E., Hildebrandt, H. W., Rogers, P. S., & Thompson, M. (1991). A competing values framework for analyzing presentational communication in management contexts. *The Journal of Business Communication*, 28(3), 213–232.

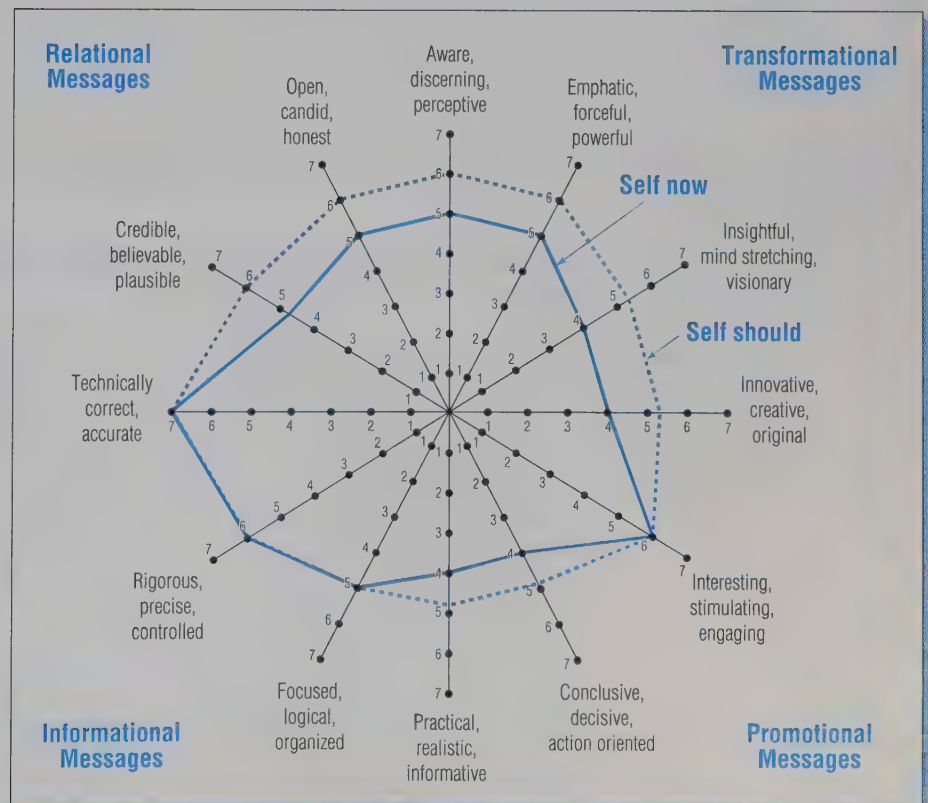


Figure 16.5 One person's self-assessment.

■ Checklist 16.1 Interpersonal Disclosures in Interpersonal Communication

1. Recognize that interpersonal relationships take time. Ask: Am I comfortable with certain people? What can I do to improve my relationship with them?
2. Recognize that some persons do not offer self-disclosure statements. Ask: If you want a closer relationship with others, have you—over time—attempted to make public more of your personal thoughts?
3. Recognize that relationships end; this is not unusual. Ask: Have you personally made an effort to continue or discontinue that relationship? Can you assess why the relationship ended?

views on issues. Time generally raises the level of intimacy. Some forms of address may become more familiar; first names replace last names. Checklist 16.1 describes interpersonal relationships more fully.

INTERVIEWING

A job interview may be the most intense dyadic communication you will ever encounter.

Some colleges and universities have an Office of Career Development. Among its purposes is to prepare you to do a better job when interviewing for a position.

■ Communication Probe

Dyad research suggests that when there is agreement on the process when working through an issue, there is an increased degree of success for that project. Likewise, business organizations are realizing the importance of “gatekeepers,” or persons who control access to another person or office. Thus, establishing a rapport with a gatekeeper increases the success of a company in improving its informal external communication. Although the research is preliminary among information technology professionals, it is a start at determining that self-reporting information dissemination behavior can be used to identify gatekeepers among individuals with diverse information-gathering behaviors.

Watson, W., Ponthieu, L., & Critelli, J. (1995, September). Team interpersonal process effectiveness in venture partnerships and its connection to perceived success. *Journal of Business Venturing*, 10, 393–411; Kolobas, J., & McGill, T. (1995, September). Identification of technological gatekeepers in the information technology profession. *Journal of the American Society for Information Science*, 46, 581–589.

In fact, an interview—there are many types—may be one of your most important dyadic communications. Here the dyadic interaction may place you in a session with a complete stranger or with someone known in your work environment. Regardless, you need preparation.

This section reviews seven common interview objectives, presents three checklists that you as interviewee can use as a guide for successful interviews, and discusses the responsibilities of the interviewer.

Interview Purposes

We stated above that interpersonal communication is purposeful. Such is the case in the following interview situations:

Use	Procedure	Example
Seeking position	Candidates speak with company representative.	Recruiter meets with graduating students or job seekers.
Informing on job	Job requirements are stated as based on job description or job experience.	Senior member or boss meets with new employee early in job experience.
Solving problem	Facts are collected, options reviewed, decision is made.	Employer talks with successful employee who is abrasive.
Supporting solution	Information is collected and arguments are planned to persuade.	Manager persuades employee who is opposed to recommendation.
Counseling employee	Facts are used to support contention that employee needs help.	Employee, accused of drug abuse on the job, is presented with treatment options.
Evaluating employee	Job performance review form is discussed.	Supervisor makes yearly review of employee.
Gathering information	Data are gathered on why employees leave; emphasis is on events and not personalities.	Manager conducts exit interview.

Interviewee's Responsibilities

Considerable literature—articles, books, videotapes—is readily available for a detailed discussion of the role you play in the process of seeking a job. Our suggestions are in the form of three checklists, each of which acts as a summary of a stage of the interview process (see Checklists 16.2, 16.3, and 16.4). Most job interviews in the past have been those in which the candidate appears in person

■ Checklist 16.2 Preparation Before the Job Interview

Thorough preparation is essential. Go through the following five steps to ensure success at the interview:

1. Understand yourself (*a rational self-assessment of your strengths and weaknesses is a must*).
2. Know details about available position (*review how your skills relate to the open position*).
3. Do homework on company (*analyze the firm; read the Wall Street Journal on the day of the interview for possible firm references*).
4. Rehearse possible questions (*brainstorm issues, questions*).
5. Speak with insiders (*learn from alumni, from others familiar with the company*).

for evaluation. However, a growing format for interviewing candidates for positions is the interview via your personal computer.

Computer Interviews

The personal, on-campus interview still dominates. Yet, as costs increase to meet candidates face to face or in videoconferencing techniques, some initial effort is being given to computer conferencing. Basic technological aids needed include a high-speed telephone line and on each end a computer, a small camera, a micro-

■ Checklist 16.3 Procedures During the Job Interview

1. Give positive first impression; offer a warm handshake; show a pleasant smile.
2. State your understanding of the interview (usually the interviewer gives this statement).
3. Organize your answers; think of stating a thesis or claim and then supporting that position with data or evidence, as you do in writing or formal speaking.
4. Listen. That task is difficult because you may desire to do most of the talking. Avoid confrontation.
5. Ask thoughtful questions: about the company, about the position.
6. Offer a conclusion at the end of the session: who, what, when, where, and possibly why. Obtain agreement on those conclusions.

■ Checklist 16.4 Follow-Up After the Job Interview

1. If there were specific actions to be accomplished, do so promptly.
2. If you are to provide additional information, gather than information and offer it to the interviewer.
3. If a thank-you note is required, send it within a day or so.

phone, and some software. Both the candidate and the interviewer sit at their computers and via a split screen can speak to each other and even pinpoint sections of the resume. Your school, and even some companies, may be in the process of signing up for this interactive system.

Suggestions for the Computer Interview

Stephen Miller¹ offers seven suggestions for a computer interview:

- Try out the equipment beforehand.
- Avoid excessive movement.
- Use an audio and visual check before beginning.
- Dress as if the interview were live: person to person.
- Operate on the assumption that everything you say will be heard.
- Avoid high-contrast clothing; small cameras have difficulty with contrast.
- Try to relax.

Interviewer's Responsibilities

Recruiters to schools are often recent graduates of those schools. They know the school; they know the caliber of the students. You too may be in that position—someday. For your preparation, and knowing how the interviewer prepares, we look at objectives of the patterned interview, a checklist of an interviewer's preparation, the procedures during the interview, and an evaluation of the conclusion.

Objectives of the Patterned Interview

In a patterned interview, the interviewer controls the direction of the conversation. He or she may actually follow an agreed-upon evaluation form used by all company recruiters. Remember, they have read your resume, and they will know more about you than you will know about them. In fact, some schools publish complete resumes of all their graduates—with standardized resume forms. All resumes may also be included on a CD-ROM disk and available to companies for a fee.

Recruiters often have four goals:

- Evaluate job qualifications that resumes cannot provide.
- Determine the oral communication ability of the interviewee; can the interviewee think off the cuff in a cogent and logical manner?

Sophisticated measures are being used for initial screening of job applicants. The job interview thus becomes highly important.

- Give the applicant essential facts about the job and company.
- Establish goodwill on behalf of the company.

Interviewer's Preparation Before Interview

Warm-Up Period of the Interview. Earlier we considered how we communicate with strangers, trying to avoid controversial topics as both persons search for a common ground. Nonverbally, greet the candidate with a firm handshake and a warm smile. Orally, suggest a degree of enthusiasm in your greeting; be sincere and friendly. It is up to the interviewer to set the interviewee at ease, perhaps building on some current topic as suggested in the resume. A candidate's hobbies are a nice, noncontroversial beginning to an interview.

Main Content of the Interview. After the brief warm-up, you make clear the purpose of the interview and the topics you plan to cover. You encourage the applicant to do most of the talking, but you control the interview and see that it does not wander aimlessly. You ask appropriate planned questions, use desirable methods throughout the interview, and avoid pitfalls.

Asking appropriate questions. You might begin by letting the applicant describe his or her education, and then move to the work history and off-the-job activities. Focus on relevant information that cannot be obtained as well from other sources.

Open-ended questions and statements are usually preferred because the applicant can give you more information—both verbal and nonverbal. Among useful open-ended questions you might ask are those that begin with “what,” “which,” “why,” “how,” or “tell me.”

Which courses were the most useful in your degree program? Why?

Which courses did you like best? Least? Why?

Please describe yourself in comparison with other members of your class.

■ Checklist 16.5 Interviewer Preparation Before Interview

1. Read each applicant's resume prior to the meeting.
2. Focus on core information desired: for instance, character, personality, work experience, training, motivation, interests.
3. Be aware of national and state regulations regarding fair employment practices.
4. Plan your questions. Know if your questions are within the laws concerning marital status, age, race, sex, religion, and other matters. (*Some schools have oversight committees to be sure all questions and the behavior of the interviewers are appropriate.*)
5. Omit personal bias from your prepared questions.

Outside of school what are your interests?

What experiences in your previous jobs have helped you prepare for the job you are now seeking?

Describe the kind of manager for whom you would like to work.

Why are you leaving your present job? [*If the applicant mentions “problems with my supervisor” or other vague reasons, you may tactfully probe for clarification.*]

Dead-end questions (also called *closed questions*) usually ask for only “yes” or “no” or other one-word answers.

How many people graduated in your class?

Can you give me the percentage of foreign graduates who majored in Accounting? Marketing? Finance?

How many accounting courses did you have in college? Did you enjoy college? Which course was most difficult?

Questions similar to these elicit quick responses that are easy to tabulate. But the information is often less helpful than that from open-ended questions—unless you probe for an explanation or reasons for the answers.

Using effective methods. Tense applicants do not give positive impressions. In part, that may be due to unfair, leading, negative questions. Avoid such self-betraying questions, value-judgment questions, and any questions that the respondent may be reluctant to answer.

One of the things that I’ve supported for years is . . . ; what’s your opinion on that?

[*School*] is known for its lousy school attitude; would you agree with me?

What’s your reaction to the favorable (unfavorable) ruling of the Supreme Court on the issue of . . . ?

Tell me, why are so many of you so tense in this school?

Questions should be neutral. Embarrassing the interviewee—even in a planned confrontational interview—adds few benefits.

Evaluation After the Interview

Your authors follow one basic rule after an interview: They immediately write notes on all interviewed candidates. Memories are variable; written notes help keep a paper trail of important recollections. In your evaluation of the interview, the cues in the following Communication Probe should prove useful in determining a macro impression of the candidate.

It is your choice as to the form of your notes following the interview. Some persons simply write a paragraph on each interviewee; others complete a check-list evaluation form. The form is unimportant. More important are your topic inclusions such as education and training, work experience, current off-the-the-job life, personal characteristics, and an overall summary. Such a form might look

Know the interview “rules” of the school and which questions can be asked in an interview.

Interview formats are as diverse as the companies doing the interviewing.

■ Communication Probe

POSITIVE AND NEGATIVE IMPRESSIONS FOLLOWING AN INTERVIEW

Positive Cues

Early arrival
Alert, responsive attitude
Emphatic attitude
Relaxed manner
Smiling
Clear voice

Negative Cues

Behavioral and Psychological Cues

Late arrival
Inattentive
Condescending or withdrawn
Tense, fidgety
Frowning
Mumbling, timid

Verbal Cues

Sticking to main point
Incisiveness
Relevant responses
Organized presentation
Appropriate use of humor
Spontaneous replies
Speaks well of people
Candor

Changes the subject
Generalizes, excessive detail
Irrelevant responses
Disorganized
Uncalled-for levity
Long pauses
Criticizes others
Rationalizes, evasive

like the following interview assessment guide, which is taken from the University of Michigan's Office of Career Development; it is one example of an actual form used in campus interviews.

Campus Interview Appraisal Guide

Name of Student

Name of Recruiter

INSTRUCTIONS: 1. Rate the candidate on each dimension using the following scale (circle your rating).

4 = outstanding

2 = good

0 = did not observe

3 = superior

1 = unacceptable

2. List what you see as the candidate's primary strengths and weaknesses.

3. Make your final recommendation.

LEADERSHIP STYLE AND INFLUENCE. Asserting ideas and opinions effectively and gaining impact without relying on authority or position.

- | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|--|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> + Consistently in a leadership role among group of friends or classmates. + Takes charge of ambiguous situations, establishing structure and direction toward objectives. + Controls conflict directly. | | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> – No school-related leadership experience. – Past experience demonstrates authoritarian or extreme task orientation when leading. | |

TECHNICAL/PROFESSIONAL KNOWLEDGE. Possessing technical knowledge and understanding of discipline fundamentals through past training and experience.

- | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|--|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> + Special awards, recognition for academic excellence + Closely related job experience. + Able to apply knowledge in practical business settings. | | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> – Limited previous experience in required area. – Difficulty communicating concepts and theories. – Little reading of industry publications to keep skills up to date. | |

COMMUNICATION. Presenting material orally and in writing in an interesting, persuasive, organized, articulate, and concise manner.

- | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> + Speaks clearly and articulately. + Extensive vocabulary-used descriptively and precisely. + Makes points concisely. | | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> – Mumbles, rambles, digresses, interrupts. – Flat, monotonic. – Mechanical gestures, nervous mannerisms | |

INTERPERSONAL RELATIONS. Developing and maintaining smooth, cooperative working relations with others.

- | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> + Socially active in school, participator, committed member. + Demonstrates an understanding of other's needs and concerns. + Interpersonally poised, gains impact in business and social situations. | | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> – Prefers to interact only with persons like themselves. – Blunt, insensitive, critical. – Makes poor initial impression on others. | |

INITIATIVE AND DRIVE. Actively attempting to influence events and to originate actions to achieve goals.

- | 4 | 3 | 2 | 1 |
|---|---|---|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> + Successfully juggles range of academic, social and part/fulltime work demands. + Surpasses established performance standards by effort. + Overcomes significant obstacles to get results. | | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> – Works only toward goals others have set. – Uncomfortable on own, quickly looks for aid of others. – Fast to start and slow to finish—has trouble sustaining energy. | |

TELEPHONING

All of us have grown up using the telephone. It is basic to business communication and is used extensively even in international communication. Rather than give a detailed discussion of its usage or the types of telephone capabilities, we offer Checklists 16.6, 16.7, and 16.8 for you to review.

DICTATING

Most international hotels and their business centers have dictation facilities for immediate transcriptions to one's central office.

Dyadic communication is direct communication between two persons. Dictation is oral communication between two people but with a twist. You speak to someone either directly or via some electronic device. Your goal, often, is to have someone else type a communication that will be sent to an addressee. Shorthand is falling by the wayside; in its place is the spoken word recorded on the many kinds of electronic devices for transcription later.

Suggestions for Dictating

Your approach will vary little from preparing for a telephone call. Here too you collect information, plan for your specific purpose, organize ideas clearly, and speak in a firm, clear voice. What you do additionally is give more instructions to the stenographer transcribing your words unto paper. We offer seven suggestions.

1. Give the precise name, address of the individual(s) to whom the message is to be sent.
2. Speak clearly. Be careful with plurals. It's also better to repeat when using numbers. Sounds such as "p" and "b," "f" and "v," and "t" and "d" can be misunderstood.
3. Spell unusual words or names when using them for the first time, as in the following list:

■ Checklist 16.6 Points to Consider in International Telephoning

1. Be aware of time zones. Western Europe is between 6 and 7 hours ahead of the eastern United States. Asia is 13 or 14 hours ahead. Few businesspersons want to get phone calls in the middle of the night.
2. Speak more clearly. Often your message receiver is foreign and is using English as a second language. Overarticulate in place of mumbling.
3. Restate and summarize more often. Memories are prone to error.
4. Follow up the conversation with a letter or fax. That way you and the message receiver have a statement that summarizes the major points covered.

■ Checklist 16.7 Sender's Preparation Prior to a Phone Call

1. Know your specific purpose; have some questions in mind. It is better to have one central purpose than many rambling thoughts. Introduce yourself if much time has elapsed between calls.
2. Know the precise person you are calling, and the best time to call.
3. Give thought to your opening statement. As noted earlier in this text, even a PAL (porch, aim, layout) introduction can focus direction for the conversation.
4. Take notes. Have before you pertinent papers of previous correspondence or summaries of previous discussions.

accept, except
 addition, edition
 affect, effect
 assistance, assistants
 brake, break
 cease, seize
 coarse, course
 compliment, complement
 council, consul, counsel
 formally, formerly
 its, it's
 latter, ladder

ordinance, ordnance
 practical, practicable
 principal, principle
 residence, residents
 right, rite, write
 sight, site, cite
 stationary, stationery
 straight, strait
 their, there, they're
 to, too, two
 waive, wave
 weather, whether
 who's, whose

4. Suggest punctuation. Clearly, this suggestion depends on the amount of time you have spent with a secretary. But in many instances a secretar-

■ Checklist 16.8 Message Receiver's Guidelines

1. Be patient. Giving the feeling that the phone call is an intrusion gets the conversation off to a negative start.
2. Listen. Interruptions break up both your and your partner's train of thought.
3. Restate. Be sure you understand and that your partner agrees.
4. End politely. Suggest, if your partner does not, that you would be happy to supply a summary of the conversation.

Of all dictation suggestions, this one is foremost: Speak more slowly and distinctly than usual.

ial pool transcribes your words. When in doubt, insert your suggestions as to paragraphs and specific punctuation, if you feel it is needed.

5. Avoid side comments. These “off the cuff” comments (intended merely as your personal opinions) confuse more than clarify.
6. Dictate at a slower rate of speech. Too rapid a rate may slur some words; too slow—with too many interruptions caused by holding the pause button on the recording machine—will confuse the stenographer.
7. End with a suggestion regarding the time you will need the recorded information and state where you can be reached.

Example of Dictation

The following opening and closing sections from a good-news reply to a phoned request for product information simulate how an orally dictated letter might “sound” to the transcriber. If you dictate to the secretary face to face, most of the words below in italics will be omitted. If, however, you use a voice-recording instrument, your instructions to the transcriber may be similar to those in italics below. Of course, voice inflection conveys additional (unspoken) instructions—for instance at the end of each sentence.

“Good morning, operator. This is Robert Bridges in the consumer service department. Extension 507. Please transcribe this letter addressed to Mr. Phillip P-h-i-double l-i-p Jones, Department four two, Harrington H-a-double r-i-n-g-t-o-n Corporation, one six zero zero Avenue of the Americas plural. New York, New York, one zero zero three eight. Dear Mr. Jones.

“Thank you for your inquiry about our, *operator, next two words all caps ELECTRO hyphen SPEED, operator, cap M as in Mary Model 28, operator, cap T Typewriter.* Yes, *comma* indeed *comma* this model has proved very popular in such applications as yours in which, *operator, one word* downtime must be minimized. *Paragraph.*”

[*Middle paragraphs dictated in similar fashion.*]

“Our sales representative in the *cap E Eastern cap T Territory comma Tanya T-a-n-y-a* Brickler *B-r-i-c-k-l-e-r comma* will call you next week to set up a meeting to discuss your needs more specifically *semicolon* she will then be able to inventory your needs and give you a price quotation. To help you investigate our product line more thoroughly *comma* I have enclosed six colorful brochures *period, parenthesis.* Note the blue leaflet that describes the automatic *quote, initial cap N Never hyphen, initial cap F Forget end quote* one zero zero *hyphen* character memory system *period, close parenthesis, paragraph.*

Please call me at five five five *hyphen* double nine eight seven if we can answer additional inquiries about our typewriters. Cordially yours, Robert Bridges, Customer Service Representative. Enclosures, six.

A shortened version of the same material—providing your secretary knows your style—might proceed in this manner.

“Joanne, I’ll give you the business cards for all the next couple of letters when I return. Just omit the inside address. This is letter one.

“Dear Mr. Jones. Thanks for your inquiry about our ELECTRO-SPEED Model 28 Typewriter. Yes, this model has proved very popular in such applications as yours in which downtime must be minimized. Next Paragraph . . .”

Joanne would know, from previous letters dictated by her boss, which words to capitalize, where the dictator wishes abbreviations, and even when the preferred ending should be.

SUMMARY

A dyad is defined as two persons seeking to exchange information. Communication in that situation is two-way. Feedback is immediate. In that interchange both persons have a perception of themselves, either accurate or erroneous. Regardless of those perceptions, we are most open with those closest to us, and less so with our partners in a business environment.

An interview is one of the more common forms of dyadic communication, which is often 1:1. You and your partner seek to solve a problem, inform, and even persuade. These general purposes are found in situations such as seeking a position, informing about job requirements, solving a company problem, counseling an employee, and evaluating an employee.

Face-to-face communication and the telephone are the most used modes of communication. At the international level additional problems arise, primarily language issues and problems of time. One should prepare as carefully for a phone conversation as for a longer oral statement.

Dictation is oral communication to an intermediary who transcribes the spoken words into a written message. Desirable dictation practices include clear pronunciation, spelling of unusual words (where appropriate), and adequate instructions to the transcriber. With today’s word processing systems, several drafts can easily be prepared before a final one is approved.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Hindrances to Interpersonal Communication in an International Setting.** It does not take much effort to recognize that communication problems occur when speaking with someone who is highly conversant in your own language. Problems are compounded when you add another variable: someone who uses English as a second language. Even though you may not have visited a foreign country (or if you have, so much the better), simply make a list of hindrances that you think might occur when holding a 1:1 conversation with a person using English as a second language. Chapter 3 should give you a start on compiling your own list.
2. **Mock Interview of International Student or Nonnative Speaker.** This assignment requires one nonnative member of the class to provide two

things: A resume as prepared in that international student's own country (it will be different from those prepared in the United States) and his or her willingness to be interviewed by members of the class. Specific goals: (a) Have the international student explain some differences between her or his resume and those in the United States; (b) have the international student suggest which questions in an interview would be acceptable; and (c) have the international student describe the differences between interviews conducted in her or his own country and those in the United States.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Oral Report After an Interview.** This project involves an interview (for information-gathering purposes) and an oral presentation (for information-dissemination purposes). Your first task is to identify and interview a person who has a type of job or career that you hope to enter upon graduation. The purpose of the interview is to determine what kinds of communication activities that person must engage in during a typical week. You should not only cover the types of written messages sent and received but also determine the volume or frequency, the job title for the originator of the incoming messages, and the disposition of the messages (what your interviewee does upon receiving each type of message). Do not forget to cover oral communication messages (verbal orders or directives, telephone requests, etc.). For outgoing written or oral messages, find out to whom (title of person) the messages are directed. Unless the interviewee keeps a log of such activities, you will have to depend on the interviewee's estimates for some of the information.

The second part of this assignment requires you to make a formal oral report of your findings in class. A 3- to 5-minute time limit should be sufficient; however, your instructor may wish to establish other limits.

4. **Exit Interview Planned to Gather Useful Information.** For efficiently handling a situation in which your oral communication skills are important to a company, you must do some preliminary planning and practice.

Assume that you work for a firm with high employee turnover. Your responsibility is to gather information that will be useful to management in determining why so many employees leave. This information will be gathered in an exit interview procedure used by your company and conducted with every employee who leaves. You are to establish specific objectives to be followed during the interview, set up strategies that can be followed, and develop a specific list of questions that you will ask during the interview.

Try these questions out in an interview setting in class, using another member of the class as the employee who is leaving the company. In your interview, you should first express appreciation to the employee for his or her service. (This should be done in order to set the tone for a positive and relaxed interview.) You should then emphasize to the employee that in no way will the information gathered be used against the employee when seeking employment elsewhere. Stress the fact that the information will be used to help management improve working conditions in the company and per-

haps help cut down on employee turnover. Use any technique that you believe will ensure a nonthreatening situation.

Your primary functions during the interview are to solicit the information your company needs and to provide information that will be helpful to the employee.

5. **Oral Instructive Explanation About a Particular Job.** Present to the class a 5-minute instructive explanation on how to perform the duties of a particular job you are familiar with. After you finish, call on a class member to tell as well as possible what she or he learned. (This procedure tests not only your instructional clarity but also the listener's attentiveness.)
6. **Oral Improvements on Three Telephone Responses to Customers.** The following replies are similar to some that employees have given to customers when answering telephone calls. What impressions do you think they make? Write your suggestions for improving each. Then be prepared to share your ideas orally in class.
 - a. "Hello. Yeah, it's Jake. Huh? What kinda TV do ya have? I dunno if we have a part to fit it. I can't tell ya; I have ta know the model number of your TV. Wait a sec. I'll look. Woops. Got a customer here just now. Call again. Bye." [*Click*]
 - b. "Hi, nope. This is not Mr. Brown. Wow! I'm not sure if he's out or just not taking calls. Maybe he's still out to lunch. What was your name? Hang on."
 - c. "Hello. XY repair service. Gosh, we're so far behind today. Have a stack of cars here. No way we could getcha in today. Well, maybe. Don't call until after tomorrow."
7. **A Difficult Job Interview Question for Class Discussion.** As a class exercise you are asked to bring in one question that you consider difficult to answer in an interview. The question may be one actually asked in a job interview or a potential question about which you feel uncomfortable in answering. Because each of your classmates will also bring a question to read in class, you will all hear a variety of questions. Some class members may then try responding to them—tactfully, truthfully, and as specifically as possible.
8. **Oral Report on Interviews Via Computers.** Electronic innovations are occurring daily. It would be useful to contact three groups now working on or using the computer as an interview tool. ViewNet, of Madison, Wisconsin, has been in the market for 8 years, marketing a PC-based program. Schools trying the program include Brown, the Georgia Institute of Technology, Vanderbilt, the University of Michigan, and others. Companies participating include Boeing, Chase Bank, Procter and Gamble, and others. Choose topical headings for an oral report to the class, after contacting some

of the above participants. Describe in some detail the emerging process and evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of the system as you see it.

REFERENCE

1. Miller, S. (1996, January 7). Lights! Camera! Telephone? It's the long-distance interview. *The New York Times* (Education Life Suppl.), p. 13.

Strategies for Successful Business and Group Meetings

I. Background Information on Groups

- A. Definition of a Group Meeting
- B. Formation of Groups

II. Purposes and Kinds of Meetings

- A. Informational Meetings
- B. Suggested Solution Meetings
- C. Problem-Solving Meetings

III. Solving Problems in Meetings or Groups

- A. Authorization for a Committee
- B. Methods of Solving Problems in Meetings

IV. Leadership Responsibilities in Meetings

- A. Kinds of Leadership
- B. Planning Steps Before the Meeting
- C. Procedures During the Meeting
- D. Follow-Up After the Meeting

V. Participant Responsibilities in Meetings

- A. Preparation for Meetings
- B. Effective Participant Roles in Meetings

IV. Summary

VII. Exercises and Problems

VIII. References

You know the familiar definition of a meeting: a group of people wasting time on topics of unimportance. Perhaps true. But it need not be that way. Each day—no matter the country or the company—meetings are held to conduct business more efficiently and for more profit. Sadly, if there is one activity in the business world that disturbs people, it is the meeting—for any number of negative reasons.

Poorly run meetings need not occur. Thus, this chapter offers some background information on groups, reviews the purposes and kinds of meetings occurring in business, lays out the various ways to solve problems in meetings, and summarizes the responsibilities of both the group leader and participants.

BACKGROUND INFORMATION ON GROUPS

Definition of a Group Meeting

Purposive discourse between two or more people is a common definition of a group meeting.

Definitions for meetings are legendary: “They keep minutes and spend hours”; “they sow but do not reap”; “a camel is a horse designed by a committee”; and so on. But let’s be positive: A meeting is a gathering of two or more people where purposive discourse occurs. Of course these purposes will vary.

In the preceding chapter we suggested that dyadic communication is primarily an interchange between two people. A group is larger: at least 3 people and perhaps as many as 15 or more. Additionally, a group often meets face to face with a common purpose in mind. Such a group may also be informal (unplanned, free-flowing discourse) or formal (clear, planned purpose).

Informal or casual meetings also make up groups. Such meetings build rapport between people and can be the basis for later formal meetings.

Informal Group

Casual or informal group meetings are common. Here you casually chat over coffee, meet after work, or get together for purely social occasions. You and your friends meet to socialize, to interact—often spontaneously, without plan. Your business day is filled with such informal group meetings. Ironically, out of the need for frequent casual meetings may develop the need for more formal and directed meetings.

Formal Group

Often called task-oriented groups, *formal groups* often search for answers to problems, look for a course of action, make recommendations to a higher authority. This means that you and others may meet to change a policy, make decisions on how a specific problem should be solved, and decide on the beginning steps to implement a solution.

Our focus in this chapter is more on this formal group: a gathering where the participants and leader know the specific reason for getting together. Would you call the following meeting announcement specific?

TO: The Staff
FROM: Personnel
SUBJECT: Vacations

Hope you can make the meeting on November 10.
We’ve got to talk about vacations for everyone.

■ Communication Probe

There are many reasons why people join a group, foremost of which is interpersonal attraction. Additionally, there are such factors as proximity, even physical attributes, similar and perceived abilities in others. Others suggest that similarity in attitudes strengthen interpersonal attraction, as well as similarity in personalities. From the above it is easy to add other shared characteristics one searches for in working within groups: similarity in economic status, gender, and race. In brief, interpersonal attraction is a major cause for joining, for working and meeting with others interested in a common purpose.

Festinger, L., Schachter, S., & Black, K. W. (1950). *Social pressure in informal groups*. New York: Harper; Maissonneuve, J., Palmade, G., & Fourment, C. (1952). Selective choices and propinquity. *Sociometry*, 15, 135–140; Byrne, D., & Nelson, D. (1964). Attraction as a function of attitude similarity-dissimilarity: The effect of topic importance. *Psychonomic Science*, 1, 93–94; and many others.

Hopefully you said “no,” for the purpose of the above meeting announcement is vague, incomplete, imprecise. We make suggestions for clarifying meeting announcements later.

Formation of Groups

As with other encounters, people go through an interpersonal ritual before beginning movement toward solving a problem.

How are groups formed? Surely informal or casual group meetings arise out of a common liking for the other persons. You just enjoy being with them. In fact, strong interpersonal attraction, as discussed in Chapter 16, is the glue holding persons together for a common, even casual, purpose. One researcher¹ suggests that most groups go through four formative stages in becoming a group.

Forming	Here the group tries to get started. It is the orientation phase for group members.
Storming	Members begin to stake out their positions; they begin to have conflicts and arguments.
Norming	Progress begins here. Members work to solve conflicts and recognize acceptable kinds of conduct.
Performing	Here the group begins to achieve its goals.

Most likely when joining an organization, you will join the group at step four, *performing*; it would be rare for you as a company newcomer to try to get a group started. More likely you would join a mature group, one under way for some time.

Once you are part of a group seeking to solve a problem, one other thing occurs: The group begins to follow certain phases in solving the problem.

■ Checklist 17.1 Guidelines for Starting a Group

1. Ask: Do the other members of your proposed group agree on what the purpose of the group should be?
2. Ask: Do the initial members of the group get along well; is there personal compatibility?
3. Ask: Do the similarities—in such areas as abilities, personalities, economic status, physical attributes—outweigh the dissimilarities?
4. Ask: Do you wish to proceed in an informal or a formal manner, or are meetings to be spontaneous?

It's normal to have conflict as divergent views begin to appear in a discussion.

Orientation	Here discussion is free-flowing, people orally wander about, each trying to focus on asking questions. Here too, questions are numerous: Members try to inform, ask further questions. Here members' convictions are tentative and somewhat ambiguous.
Conflict	After the preliminary sparring is over, members begin to offer opinions, evidence in support of their position. At this phase initial conflicts occur. There may even be resistance to the agreed-upon task.
Emergence	Open exchanges continue; members begin to search for ways of truly solving the problem. Compromises occur, and there is a decrease in conflict and sincere movement toward decreasing differences in opinion.
Solutions	A positive attitude exists at this phase. Options have been discussed, and criteria for measuring those options have been viewed. Now is the time to complete the task and agree upon a solution. ²

PURPOSES AND KINDS OF MEETINGS

We noted that meetings have two core purposes: to present information and to help solve problems. Obviously both purposes occur in all meetings. Three kinds of meetings help achieve these objectives.

Informational Meetings

Informational meetings seek only to clarify, to make something clear, to give information.

Review the following list: all were actual meeting topics in various companies.

- Changes in reporting procedures in the purchasing department
- Report on the company's strategic plans for the next fiscal year
- Announcement of the new mission statement

■ Communication Probe

Group satisfaction with meetings has been researched extensively. A major finding is that the quality of group decisions increases as members exchange facts and reasons, and it decreases as members stick to their positions. A recent study applied the Myers-Briggs Personality Type Indicator to the group process, making use of an electronically supported meeting. The result: All participants contributed more original solutions in the group decision support system than in a face-to-face environment, and made more comments than in the traditional environment. As can be expected, extroverts participated extensively in any environment.

Innami, I. (1994, December). The quality of group decisions group verbal behavior, and intervention. *Organizational Behavior & Human Decision Processes*, 60, 409–430; Yellen, R., Winniford, M. A., & Sanford, C. (1995, January). Extraversion and introversion in electronically supported meetings. *Information and Management*, 28, 63–74.

- Retirement planning for those over age 50
- Cultural differences between British and Finnish organizations
- Documents needed for working relationships with Thailand's National Energy Policy Committee

At each of these meetings the members learned, asked questions, sought to understand. No problems were solved; no recommendations for change occurred. In each case there was an opening statement by the caller of the meeting and then a discussion. Participants came to the meeting with one pivotal purpose: to be informed, to understand the information.

Suggested Solution Meetings

Visualize this situation. A manager desires to receive input from her staff on an issue; she desires to review preliminary recommendations before solving the issue. The complete scenario may run something like this:

1. A supervisor senses a problem and desires a meeting to review options on addressing the problem. The goal: purely exploratory.
2. A memo or E-mail message is sent to all staffers asking for possible options on removing the problem.
3. Suggestions are tabulated and distributed to all respondents.
4. A meeting is called to discuss all possible options.

The manager and the review committee review all recommendations. Comments on the options occur at the meeting. Often no decision is made. The

meeting is exploratory and informational. Then a final recommendation is prepared either for higher approval or group consensus.

Problem-Solving Meetings

No group proceeds identically in trying to solve a problem; most often variations of problem, solution, benefit, action steps occur.

Problem, solution, benefit, action. These four steps trace the most common process in solving problems typical of the business world. Often (1) the major problem is presented early in the meeting, (2) participants suggest solutions, discussing and evaluating them, and (3) participants arrive at a decision for further action. All the steps involved in this process are discussed in the following section.

SOLVING PROBLEMS IN MEETINGS OR GROUPS

Because the problem-solving meeting requires the most careful planning and supervision by the leader and rational discussion by the participants, the remainder of this chapter focuses on the problem-solution meeting. You can, of course, use most of the suggestions for all types of meetings.

Authorization for a Committee

You may be asked to form a committee to solve a specific problem. That letter or memorandum of authorization—similar to the letter of authorization or charge noted in Chapter 11—may come from your superior, or even at the level of the secretary of the board. Regardless of the source, that note should include who, what, when, where, and why as good cornerstone questions to answer. Two examples of memos for authorizing a committee follow:

EXAMPLE 1: *Committee authorization.*

Charges to committees must be vividly clear; the precise problem to be solved must be unambiguous.

TO: ER Nursing staff of [name of hospital]
 FROM: Nancy Glover, Chairperson
 Economic and General Welfare
 SUBJECT: Establishing a committee to investigate continuing education requirements for re-licensure

Our Chief of Staff requested that I convene a committee of staff nurses to review what steps the hospital should take to ensure nurse re-licensure in our various specialties. May I set the first meeting of this ad hoc group for Monday, November 14, 1997, in the ER Conference Room at 4:00 p.m.? Our task is to consider the following issues.

1. How to encourage individual nurses to achieve certification.
2. What is the possibility of on-site programs?

3. What is the approximate off-from-work time needed to meet continuing education requirements?
4. Who will collaborate with the Board of Nursing to ensure that all requirements for re-licensure have been met?

I look forward to working with you on these important issues.

EXAMPLE 2: *Committee authorization.*

TO: International Review Committee
FROM: Judy Ho, Manager, Marketing Development
Chairperson, International Review Committee
SUBJECT: Need for recommendations concerning expansion into Eastern Europe

As you know, our International Review Committee has been in place for the past two years. During that time we have made recommendations as to whether we should or should not establish advertising branches in Eastern Europe.

Last year, as you know, we had success in penetrating the markets of Bulgaria, Poland, and Austria. Profits from those countries increased by 10%. As a result of this favorable increase, our CEO has asked that we identify new market opportunities in other parts of Europe. I have been asked to convene all members of the International Review Committee to get their views on establishing a branch advertising office in Eastern Europe.

Would you therefore please meet in Room 3255B on March 9, 1997, at 11:00 a.m. through lunch. At that initial meeting I'd like to establish some criteria for possible expansion and assign responsibilities for gathering additional information.

Please E-mail me if you cannot be present on March 9.

Illustrated above is *who* requested the meeting, the specific *purpose* of the meeting, who is to be *present*, and the *time* and *location* for the meeting. A detailed analysis on how to work on problem-solving issues in a meeting will now be discussed.

Methods of Solving Problems in Meetings

Just how do you solve a problem in a group? Some of you may use intuition (rapid insight into a problem), rationalization (justification of solution over time), or scientific, reflective thinking (logical progression) to arrive at an answer. We

■ Communication Probe

The usual structure for a problem-solution meeting moves from initial awareness of an issue to its eventual resolution. But the process to follow in getting there varies from study to study, from person to person. In a major statement relating to what CEOs desire from problem-solving meetings, a researcher discovered that they desire answers to four questions.

- What is the plan?
- Why is the plan recommended?
- What are the goals?
- How much will it cost to implement the plan?

Answer these questions, says the author, and meeting participants will get a decision from the superior.

Lovett, Paul D. (1988, November–December). Meetings that work: Plans bosses can approve. *Harvard Business Review*, 38–44.

favor this last approach, the one used most often in business. Four steps are involved in problem-solving meetings: background analysis, solution discovery, solution evaluation, and choice of action.

Background Analysis

You sense a problem; you feel something is wrong; you hear contradictory stories; you know something is not going well. Welcome to frustration. You now can solve the problem alone, or you can assemble a group. We recommend three steps.

State problems in the affirmative. Negative wordings create apprehensions and could imply a preliminary judgment.

1. State the Problem or Question in an Affirmative Tone. Affirmatively stating the central issue is more effective than stating the issue in the negative.

Negative Wording

How not to handle personnel dismissal?

Which kinds of related businesses should we avoid?

How can the negative consequences of foreign maids be decreased in Asia?

Preferred Affirmative Wording

What should be our procedure in dismissing personnel from their positions?

In which related businesses should we consider expansion?

Which steps should be taken to improve treatment of foreign maids in Asia?

2. Define and Limit the Problem. Each of the above affirmative questions require some definitions. This information is usually included in the authorization memorandum or in the initial stages of a group meeting.

By personnel we mean only those employees in job classifications 12-17. By related businesses we mean only core competencies, i.e., those that have at least a 50% relationship to our manufacturing process. By foreign maids we mean only those women from the Philippines who have been in Asia since 1990.

3. Collect Facts on the History of the Problem. Several questions, and others, relate to gathering initial data.

- How long has the problem existed?
- Describe the symptoms of the problem.
- What is the extent of the problem?
- Can we tentatively guess at the possible causes and effects of the problem?
- How do other companies handle the problem?

Your thoughtful examination of background material will have helped to prepare you for the role of discussant or leader of the meeting. And, if you have prepared written background material for the group, it will serve as backup information to prepare for the next stage: solution discovery.

Solution Discovery

Stating definite criteria for a solution places everyone on the same page.

1. Establish Criteria. Ask yourself: What are some of the frequently used criteria applied in problem-solution meetings? If you answered *fairness, workability, acceptability, positive consequences, favorable costs, number of people impacted, and return on investment*, you would be among the majority.

Apply some of the above criteria to the following issue: “In view of our high energy costs, what should be the policy of our company regarding alternative sources of energy?” Your group might set up criteria for assessing solutions to the issue as follows:

- The solution must be *acceptable* to the Environmental Protection Agency and the company.
- The solution should have little *impact* on the earnings per share.
- The supply of energy must be *adequate* (favorable) to cover energy needs into the next century.

Unless there is consistency in applying criteria, each participant will assess solutions using their own criteria. But note: Some criteria may change during a meeting and attach different weights to those criteria.

Brainstorming is a positive way of getting all solution variations on the table.

2. List Possible Solutions

During a meeting you as a new graduate may offer a solution that you feel has been logically thought out, based on time and research, and then firmly insist that the problem can be solved only in this way. It is a rude introduction to the business world when others suggest that your solution has little merit. Hence, the thoughtful chairperson and participants should consider several alternative solutions, perhaps ranging from the practical to the highly innovative.

A good technique at this point in the problem-solving process is simply to list alternatives. *Brainstorming*—the process of listing as many ideas as possible without judgment from any group member—is a favored method. Here persons, interested in solving a problem, offer ideas in a freewheeling atmosphere. No criticisms are allowed, even for off-the-wall solutions.

After everyone has had a chance to voice suggestions, the list is shortened, usually in light of stated criteria. Several good ideas may thus arise, and later serve as a list from which may come the final solution.

What list of solutions, for example, would you propose to the question “What should be the company policy on drugs in the workplace?” A shortened list of possible solutions from one company looked like this:

- During recruitment let candidates sign release forms for drug testing.
- Managers should orally and in writing communicate this message: Employees will be fired if caught using drugs on the job.
- External drug rehabilitation programs will be used for those using drugs.
- "No Drugs in the Workplace" should be posted throughout the company.
- An employee assistance program (EAP) is the central goal in the war against drugs.
- Drug testing must be used in conjunction with other means of employee assistance.

Solution Evaluation

The preceding step was simply formulating a list of *tentative* suggestions on solving a problem. Now you must evaluate all suggestions in light of your stated criteria. In other words, you begin testing, locating pro and con reasons about a solution, answering whether a preferred solution truly will solve a problem or create new ones. As you work through the process in a discussion, you may end with selecting one of your tentative proposals, create an entirely new solution, or combine parts of several solutions. Your responsibility is this: You should arrive at a solution during this evaluation phase.

A series of questions can serve as hints to what you could be asking, for example, on this problem: “What health programs will best meet the needs of our workers?”

- What will be the consequences of adopting one of the tentative solutions?
- Will any of the solutions introduce new dangers or new problems?
- Will all the causes of the problem be removed?
- How does each of the solutions meet the criteria established for judgment of the solutions?
- What are the advantages and disadvantages of each solution?
- What effect will the solution have on the future?
- Has the solution proved workable at another company or in a similar situation?
- Is there a professional organization or a person held in high regard in support of one of the options?

In each of us are hidden reasons why we support or do not support a proposed solution. Rational persons try to apply a reasoned approach to problem-solving meetings. Consensus, or formal vote, then determines the solution to be accepted.

With the solution accepted, you still have one more thing to decide.

Choice of Action

A favorite question of senior management receiving a recommendation from a committee is this: What costs are involved? That question, along with a time schedule, is basic to any group recommendation.

The following example was part of an action marketing plan for placing ads into catalogs sent to consumers in their homes:

Marketing Budget for First Year

Our marketing recommendation for the new product Diet Lite has been prepared for introduction on September 1, 199-

<u>Annual marketing plan</u>	\$360,000.
Packaging	\$25,000
Revised product sheets	35,000
Advertisement design	35,000
Co-op advertising plan	60,000
Media planning and placement	205,000

Personnel involved

Media Director
Graphic Arts Department
Administration

The document was signed by the vice president for Media Relations.

Thus, problem solving will be the major reason for business group meetings. And while some meetings will not precisely follow the three main divisions noted above, all do begin with some kind of opening analysis, spend considerable time reviewing options, and end with a recommendation for action. Getting to the

Financial data is a needed part of a final action plan.

final stage is sometimes messy, but it is better to live in a democracy where we listen to the view of others than in a totalitarian society where decisions are often made with little input. How to be a good leader and a good participant using the above problem-solving structure is the topic to which we now turn.

LEADERSHIP RESPONSIBILITIES IN MEETINGS

“She’s a bore”; “He only needs our committee to help him in delaying a decision”; “He leads a committee that should have been buried long ago.” These are negative evaluations of chairpersons; many are worse. In brief, when you are appointed chairperson, you have major responsibilities; it is up to you to lead a group through the intricate process of resolving an issue. You should know about the three different kinds of leadership and its functions—before, during, and after the meeting—to be effective.

Kinds of Leadership

Look at Figure 17.1. We suggest that styles of leadership are on a continuum from authoritarian through democratic to leaderless; here we elaborate on this premise.

Authoritarian

Avoid the following characteristics typical of an authoritarian leader: shows contempt for some members, dominates the discussion, praises those who agree

■ Communication Probe

Research on leadership is worldwide. Indeed, throughout business history people have been interested in what makes an effective leader. Numerous comparative studies sought to determine the differences in leadership styles across cultures, with similarities in style dominant. Although some of this leadership research is somewhat macro, some of the ingredients for leadership have a carryover to leadership of smaller groups. Regardless of culture, differences in leadership style may result from beliefs, values, needs, risk taking, cognitive styles, and personal factors. Indeed, one’s personal value style may influence managerial leadership—how one

- Perceives and defines a situation
- Defines and tackles problems and decisions
- Approaches interpersonal relations
- Interprets ethical behavior
- Responds to organizational pressures

Ronen, S. (1986). *Comparative and multinational management* (pp. 197–220). New York: Wiley. England, G. W., & Lee, R. The relationship between managerial values and managerial success in the United States, Japan, India, and Australia. *The Journal of Applied Psychology*, 59(4), 411–419; Westwood, R. I., & Chan, A. (1992). Headship and leadership. In R. I. Westwood (ed.), *Organizational behavior* (pp. 118–143). Hong Kong: Longmans.

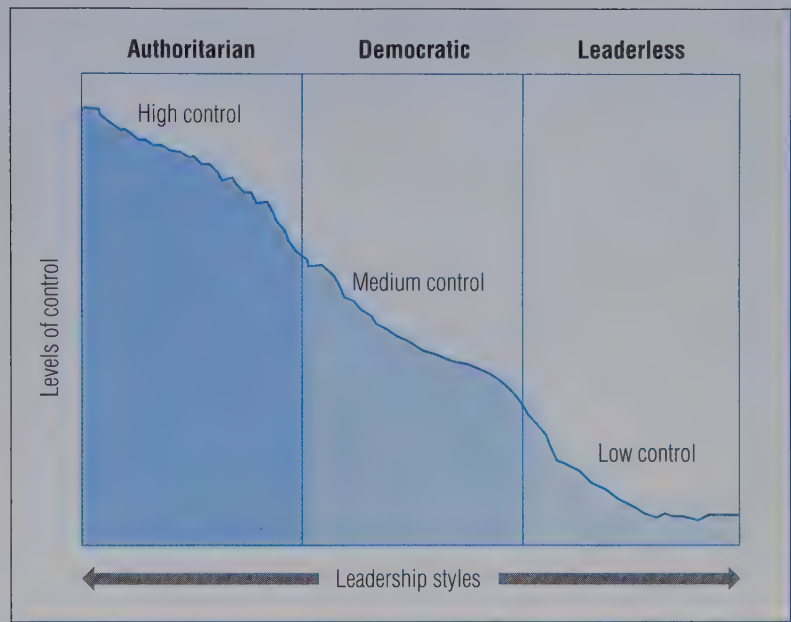


Figure 17.1 Styles of leadership.

with his or her position, speaks often and loudly, issues orders and commands, suggests that higher authority supports his or her position. Such leadership characteristics do not belong in our current system of group meetings.

Leaderless

This is almost as bad as the authoritarian style, but here the leader delegates all direction and decision-making steps to others. This person believes in shared leadership, allowing high-ability people to run the meeting. While sometimes successful, there is need for someone to offer some guidance, some positive feedback to the group that something has been achieved.

Democratic, Participative

You live in a democracy; you know that all points of view have the right to be heard. You also know that in such an environment the group has the final authority, that groups will vary in their ability to make decisions. Your major goal is to help the group make the best decision possible rather than force them into it; you facilitate productive group discussion, invite minority opinions, evaluate unsupported generalizations, and clarify vague statements. To achieve such a lofty profile is possible—with work.

Realize that business discussions take time, are frequently disorganized, are in need of good guidance before, during, and after a meeting.

Planning Steps Before the Meeting

It seems obvious that you as a group leader should know the precise purpose of your upcoming meeting. In your preparation, take the following steps:

■ Communication Probe

Leadership is difficult to define. One way of defining it is to say that a leader is a person who is capable, through communication, of assisting a group in achieving specific goals. How? A series of studies suggests that some persons desire to be leaders: They seek that position. Likewise, a person who actively uses communication skills, oral and nonverbal, in a meeting is likely to emerge as a leader. Why? Others have the opportunity of hearing and viewing this person's views on issues and can make judgments about them. Although quantity of contributions is important, so is the quality of those contributions as measured by their relevancy, helpfulness, and reinforcement to group members. Communication, early and of high quality, contributes to desirable leadership.

Shaw, M. E., & Gourd, D. S. (1990). Group dynamics and communication. In G. L. Dahnke & G. W. Clatterbuck (eds.), *Human Communication: Theory and research* (pp. 123–155). Belmont CA: Wadsworth; Stogdill, R. M. *Handbook of leadership*. New York: Free Press; and many others.

1. Review the Problem and Determine the Precise Purpose

As with formulating an informative or persuasive speech, take some time to write out what you think is the central purpose of the meeting. Such a statement works well if put in infinitive form.

Of all people, the chairperson must know precisely the purpose of a meeting.

- To determine what percentage of our profits should be contributed to charities during the year.
- To decide whether the regional office—now located in London—should be returned to Detroit.
- To ask: What steps should we take in reprimanding the employee who falsified accounting records over the past year?

In brief, by phrasing the question in infinitive form, you already are answering this question: Do we really need a meeting or can a decision be made via telephone, memos, letters, video- or teleconferencing, or E-mail? It is the chairperson's call as to the medium selected.

2. Decide Who Should Participate

In regularly scheduled meetings the cast will be similar; who will be there is predetermined. Specialists might also be called in for their expertise or a facilitator to assist in the deliberations. But when a special ad hoc (temporary committee), is formed, it is desirable to have persons representative of the group as a whole. Usual criteria include gender, age, diversity of view, ethnic groups, and others.

Ideally, a smaller group (3 to 5 members) is more harmonious than a larger group. Often a small group may draft some preliminary information and lay out some options before going to a larger group. In the following Communication Probe some further research observations were observed.

■ Communication Probe

It appears quite obvious that in smaller groups more speaking occurs because of the diversity of talents, interest in the issue, and ease of interrelationships. Additionally, as the group increases in size, coordination difficulties increase, irrelevant inputs occur, and individuals are inhibited to speak. Some other negatives occur as group size increases: Some members may dominate the discussion, responsibilities are shifted to key members, and greater stress is placed on the leader. Conversely, in smaller groups research suggests that its members are better satisfied and record more positive evaluations of their group. Finally, it is clear that consensus is far more difficult to achieve in larger groups.

Bales, R. F., Strodtbeck, F. L., Mills, T. M., & Rosenborough, M. E. (1951). Channels of communication in small groups. *American Sociological Review*, 16, 461–468; Poole, M. S., McPhee, R. D., & Seibold, D. R. (1982). A comparison of normative and interactional explanations of group decision-making: Social decision schemas versus valence distributions. *Speech Monographs*, 49, 1–19; Hemphill, J. K. (1950). Relations between the size of the group and the behavior of “superior” leaders. *Journal of Social Psychology*, 32, 11–22; and many others.

3. Arrange for Meeting Date, Time, Place

- Be exact as to time and date. E-mailing a reminder to participants works well.
- Avoid Friday afternoon. Generally Tuesday through Thursday are desirable.
- Be precise as to location. A room change from a consistent location demands both oral and E-mail follow-up.

4. Create an Agenda

It is desirable for the chairperson to send out the agenda in advance of a meeting.

Three core questions are the basis for meetings: Fact (is something true or not); value (whether something is desirable or undesirable); and policy (should something be done or not be done).

You, as chair, have the responsibility to set the agenda. An agenda is the roadmap of what will be covered in the meeting. That information can be sent in advance (desirable) or distributed at the meeting. Busy managers and executives tend to follow the latter.

We have repeatedly emphasized the importance of the *wording* of the problem question. Be clear when putting that information in the agenda; know that your agenda can word that problem as a question of fact, value, and policy.³

Fact questions are concerned with what is true. You try to answer the question, what are the facts of the matter? For example,

- Who is the leading builder of luxury boats in the world? Is that company a competitor with our size boats?
- What are the constraints on TV advertising in Germany?
- China is developing rules for joint ventures in their country; which Hong Kong legal firm has the largest client list on international joint ventures?

Value questions depend on words implying appraisal and judgment of the goodness or badness, rightness or wrongness, acceptability or unacceptability, and merits or demerits of a person, place, or thing.

- What assurance do you have that the government will be *fair* to minority firms from the West?
- Is there a *value* to our sending three people to the executive program on human resource development?
- Is *it worthwhile* for our company to continue its program of sales awards to persons whose gross sales are above \$75,000 a month?

Policy or procedure questions will occupy most of your meetings: What should be done? What action should we take? Who should carry out the decision?

- Which actions should we take to cover future maintenance of our physical plant?
- We build numerous products for medical care; to what extent should we ourselves make the component parts or have them built by others?
- To what extent should we do three things: Invest time and money in creating new markets in Asia or Europe; align ourselves with a firm already in place in those parts of the world; or piggyback with another firm interested in our overall objectives?

It makes little difference which of the three question formats you choose. What does make a difference is clarity in wording. The wording should be short, clear, unbiased, as in the following sample agenda and later announcements for the meeting.

Agenda for Marketing Staff Meeting
November 15, 199-

1. Review of progress on actions approved at meeting of October 6, 199-. [*Informative*]
2. Problems with our ad clients since last meeting. [*Informative*]
3. Action item: What theme should we pursue in our new TV ad campaign for Client X? [*Policy question*]
4. Action item: Who should be asked to coordinate the written and oral proposal in response to the request that we bid for the agency of record for potential Client Y? [*Policy question*]
5. Other issues to come before the group.

5. Distribute the Announcement for the Meeting

If you have decided on the main questions for discussion, laid out the agenda for the meeting, and decided on who, what, when, and where, you're ready to send out the announcement for the meeting. Some announcements are simple and brief; others may be detailed. In fact, most of the items in the agenda can serve as a major portion of the call to the meeting.

October 7, 199-

Title of topic	TO: Warehouse salespeople FROM: Chris SUBJECT: Potential computer market for home use
Importance	<u>Electronic Topics</u> suggests in its October issue that a potential market exists for increased sales of computers in the home.
Topic question	Will each of you please give thought to this question: How can we increase sales of our personal computer hardware and software in our immediate area? This will be the first meeting on the issue; we'll assign more responsibilities at the meeting.
Responsibilities	
Date, time, place	We'll meet two weeks from now, Tuesday, October 21, 199-, in my office, at 9:00 a.m.

In addition to the five ingredients listed above and "importance" of the topic, you may also—when desirable—include suggested reference materials, as sent with this announcement:

May 22, 199-

Date, time, place	TO: Product Planning Committee FROM: RNS, President SUBJECT: Monthly meeting, Wednesday, June 6, 10:00 a.m., Rm. 816
Responsibility	Two questions are to be discussed in our monthly meeting:
Specific topic questions	1. What other uses can you suggest for our disposable tubing? 2. What policy should we follow about producing intravenous suckers that use internal wiring for support?
Individual responsibilities	Beyond these two questions we will have a review of progress on our redesigned mod-

ules-by Mike S. and Tom G.-and the usual monthly review of our ongoing new-product items, by all of you.

Responsibilities of group

My staff has prepared the background and history of the two questions above. I ask you to come prepared to recommend options. Suggested reference material is enclosed with this announcement for the meeting.

6. Check on Physical Arrangements

- Select the seating pattern.
- Determine what kind of materials are needed in the room.
- Have available the usual electronic visual aids.

Leadership procedures before the meeting are summarized in Checklist 17.2.

Procedures During the Meeting

Here's a hint. Learn from other group leaders; note those actions and procedures that you feel make them effective group leaders. On the other hand, avoid those leadership characteristics that you feel produce a negative effect.

1. Begin with an Opening Statement

Be sure to prepare your introductory remarks before the meetings. Checklist 17.3 has guidelines for beginning the problem-solving meeting effectively.

2. Stimulate Discussion

Remember, you as the leader primarily encourage all to participate, which means getting all views on the table. For instance, to assist discussion of a topic, you might write on a board or chart the criteria the solution should meet. List on

A neutral, free-from-bias, opening statement from the chairperson can get the sessions off on a positive note.

Involving all members in a discussion is central to a leader's responsibilities.

■ Checklist 17.2 Leadership Procedures Before the Meeting

1. Understand the central problem for discussion; know your precise purpose in calling the meeting.
2. Decide who should participate.
3. Be precise as to date, time, and place for the meeting.
4. Prepare an agenda in advance of the meeting.
5. Distribute an announcement for the meeting.
6. Check on physical arrangements.

■ Checklist 17.3 How to Begin a Problem-Solving Meeting

1. State the problem.

“We’re here today for an analysis of this question: ‘Which divisions are not meeting the financial goals set last January?’ ”

2. Indicate importance of problem.

“At no time in the history of this company have we faced more serious problems. Without exaggeration, I suggest that we must come up with a firm answer to the question I put on the agenda: ‘What should be our position on expanding our overseas data processing operations?’ ”

3. Suggest issues.

“It appears that three issues relate to our question of overseas expansion: (1) What is the political base of those countries in which we wish to expand, (2) what is the economic base, and (3) under what conditions should we consider moving more production to foreign countries?”

4. Use a quotation.

“*Jobber News*’s editorial has this comment: ‘Revising a ruling last year by an administrative judge, the Federal Trade Commission has ordered Tenselo, Inc., to sell off its Martoe Equipment Co. unit.’ That opening comment is a good springboard to our meeting today: Which units in our organization are possible targets for court action?”

5. State cause for discussion.

“The Citizens’ Lobby in the House is prepared to offer two bills on the issue of regulating content and sale of dread-disease insurance policies. They were kind to send us copies of those two possible options, and wish our suggestions for change. Before we begin our discussion, I suggest we examine both versions, then move into our discussion.”

another surface the possible solutions. Then discuss. Ask questions to keep the discussion moving, and keep participants on the main path. Get conferees to analyze their own thinking and that of others.

Above all keep an atmosphere of goodwill and cooperation. If the situation becomes tense or hostile, keep calm. Ask for restatements, request courtesy in place of acrimony. Even taking a recess diffuses tensions.

3. Understand the Roles of the Participants

There are many classifications, many names given to participants in meetings. Benne and Sheats’ classification⁴ of the National Training Laboratory in Group Development is our favorite:

■ Communication Probe

Your job within the business world often determines your group memberships. Such a philosophy weakens substantially in a volunteer group where you remain by choice. But in both kinds of groups there is need for cohesiveness; certain forces act upon you to keep you a member. It follows, therefore, that cohesive groups will be more successful, will possess similar attitudes, exhibit a willingness to work together, will actually influence others within a group. A danger, of course, is that such cohesiveness can lead to *groupthink* (too much thinking alike, loss of discrimination) and to intolerance of opinions different from the norm. Regardless, cohesiveness as a characteristic of groups is desirable.

Terborg, J. R., Castore, C., & DeNinno, J. A. (1976). A longitudinal field investigation of the impact of group composition on group performance and cohesion. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 34, 782-790; Blanchard, F. A., Weigel, R. H. & Cook, S. W. (1975). The effect of relative competence of group members upon interpersonal attraction in cooperating interracial groups. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 32, 519-530; Shaw, M. E., & Shaw, L. M. (1962). Some effects of sociometric grouping upon learning in a second grade classroom. *Journal of Social Psychology*, 57, 453-458.

Group Task Roles. Anyone may play these roles, even the chairperson.

Initiator-contributor	Coordinator
Information seeking	Orienter
Opinion seeker	Evaluator-critic
Information giver	Energizer
Opinion giver	Procedural technician
Elaborator	Recorder

Group Building and Maintenance Roles. Keeping the goals of the group in mind through group-centered attitudes characterizes these roles.

Encourager	Group observer
Harmonizer	Compromiser
Standard setter	Follower
Gatekeeper (opens channels of communication)	

“Individual” Roles. The emphasis here is self-oriented roles, often at odds with group building and maintenance roles.

Aggressor	Recognition seeker
Blocker	Self-confessor
Playboy	Dominator
Help seeker	Special interest pleader

Problem participants demand special attention. Consider our suggestions for five common problem participants.

The Reticent, Nonparticipating Member. First ask this person a question he can answer by a simple “yes” or “no.” Then whenever possible, ask this member to give the conferees some information that he is sure to know because of job, training, or experience. Thank and praise the person as much as you can; he may then be more likely to enter the discussion confidently.

The “Know-It-All.” This person may be asked to justify every statement she makes. Whenever possible, ask other conferees for their opinions of these statements. Sometimes, if necessary and you feel the majority are annoyed by this person’s arrogance, you may tactfully quiet the person by asking for a show of hands from the group, which strongly outvotes the know-it-all’s suggestions.

If the negative member still insists on knowing all the answers, a private, outside-the-meeting session can bring the group’s concern to the person. This one-on-one meeting in a nonthreatening atmosphere may produce more positive results.

The Long-Winded Speaker. Thank this excessive talker when he is at the end of a sentence, and then recognize someone else. Or you might move the discussion to another highly important point, perhaps with a statement like “Well, we have two more points to consider before we wind up this meeting, so let’s move along to the next topic.”

The Erroneous Member. If the other members—out of respect—are reluctant to correct this person, an especially tactful comment by you, the leader, may be required. As with any bad-news message, avoid direct criticism, sarcasm, or ridicule. Shield the person’s pride. “When praising people, single them out; when criticizing them, put them in a group.” Perhaps analyze a similar case, without referring to the speaker personally.

The Conferee Who Shows Personal Animosity. Although rare, sometimes an angry member shouts hateful, tactless comments toward another member or members. You can show an attitude of calm understanding and turn her off by directing a question to another conferee.

4. Interpret Data for Solution Evaluation

After all options are before the group, it’s time to evaluate. Encourage consideration of advantages and disadvantages. As a leader—at this stage—avoid imposing your opinions on the group. Or, if you wish to participate, ask another member to chair the meeting.

5. State the Major Conclusions and Plan of Action

In earlier chapters we suggested that written analytical reports, for example, end with a clear call to action, a clear indication of what you wish readers to accept. It is no less in concluding a meeting.

Chairpersons should summarize and ensure that all members know their responsibilities as a result of the meeting.

■ Checklist 17.4 How to Be a Good Leader During and After the Meeting

1. Prepare your opening statement in advance.
2. Involve all members in the discussion, if possible.
3. Encourage participant comments to be positive: from sincerely trying to solve a problem to encouraging others into more helpful roles.
4. Encourage members to evaluate all options before making a decision.
5. Be precise in stating the conclusions and final action plan.
6. Write out minutes of the meeting; send members that record along with individual responsibilities agreed to in the meeting.

- Summarize (list major conclusions of the discussion).
- State individuals responsible for specific actions.
- Indicate by which time a task is to be completed.
- Extend thanks to the members for attending and completing the task.

Follow-Up After the Meeting

Secretaries take minutes; chairpersons check for accuracy.

A leader has two final responsibilities: distributing the minutes of the meeting and seeing that responsible committees, departments, or individuals are appointed to complete decided upon actions. Good minutes will include who and when a task is to be completed. Briefly, minutes should include the following:

- Name of the organization, department, or group
- Date, time, place of meeting
- Names of members present, including who chaired the meeting
- Signature of the secretary who recorded the minutes

It is also the responsibility of the secretary (or chairperson) to keep a permanent file—a paper trail—of all material viewed or distributed at the meeting.

PARTICIPANT RESPONSIBILITIES IN MEETINGS

Not all of you can be leaders; the law of averages works against you. Accordingly, you most often will be a participant. You too have responsibilities.

Preparation for Meetings

Personal preparation adds to meeting effectiveness. Do your homework, collect information, check your data, confirm your conclusions. In other words, the phrase “I don’t know” in response to a manager’s question is harmful to your career—to put it mildly. Be overprepared.

Effective Participant Roles in Meetings

Professors William M. Sattler, now deceased, and N. Edd Miller⁵ wrote a classic text on discussion and meeting procedure; they recommend nine roles for you to play to succeed as a good participant during a meeting.

1. Organizer

Some persons do not like clutter—even in meetings. Some are natural organizers. They dislike disorganization. Meetings, as you know, often move without direction, from either the inability of the leader to give direction or because members wander off the path. When you are an organizer, you give procedural suggestions, you steer the group back to main, central issues.

“I feel we’re wandering from the topic. I suggest we return to the main subject, which in my estimation is, what criteria should we consider for any foreign expansion?”

“Let me pause a moment and reflect on what I think are our central concerns: What will be the reaction of our shareholders and what will be the potential reaction of the market?”

“Mr. Chairman, I suggest we consider moving to item two on our agenda; that issue requires a decision from us by next month.”

2. Clarifier

Chairpersons may misinterpret questions and issues; participants can act as clarifiers when issues become unclear.

A clarifier points out misunderstandings, attempts to make clear unclear expressions or foggy ideas.

“It’s useful that we begin with a consistent definition of the term *strategic*; let’s see if we can set a common understanding of the timeframe.”

Let me add this comment: Some of you are using exchange rate figures for the German Mark from two months ago, some from last week, others from today. As you know, even a decimal point shift will affect our budget. I suggest we use today’s figure for consistent analysis.”

3. Questioner

Many questions need clarification. You wish to fill in your knowledge gap for yourself and others. Be careful: Know the difference between a vital or an inconsequential question. But when in doubt ask your question; others may have had the same question but were afraid to voice their concern.

4. Factual Contributor

Valuable is the participant who brings valid, credible data to a meeting.

Any time you add substantive (factual, accepted opinions) information to a discussion, you are making a worthwhile contribution. Watch your tone. Presenting factual information in an arrogant or overbearing manner will create negative reactions. Be positive.

“You make an interesting point; I like it. May I add some data from a study appearing in the fall issue of the *Journal of Business Communication*?”

“If you read the *Wall Street Journal* this morning, their information is slightly different. Here’s what the article said . . .”

“We seem to be guessing on what our chairman wished us to do. Let me take a minute and read from his letter to this committee . . .”

5. Energizer

Groups can also feel “down”; Energizers pursue ways of keeping persons interested and motivated.

Football coaches often typify this role; so do group members desiring to keep the discussion moving, stimulating members to reach their goal. Gloom is a part of meetings; so is frustration. An energizer suggests there is light at the end of the tunnel.

“Hang in there, we’re almost there. If we can make it another half hour, I’m sure we’ll reach some kind of consensus.”

“Madam chairperson, perhaps a recess is in order. That would give us a little time to reflect and get a cup of coffee. Then let’s come back and finish this task before the end of the hour.”

6. Idea Creator

So needed is this kind of contributor. The creator risks ideas that may be new, different, even unusual. If you are an idea creator, you are willing to test an idea in the open forum of the meeting.

“Let me try this idea . . .”

“Wait a second, there may be third option . . .”

“Before coming here I made several phone calls for others’ ideas. They mentioned three possibilities; here they are . . .”

“*The Nation*, one of Thailand’s newspapers, recently had an in-depth analysis of hotel expansions in Bangkok. May I summarize three issues which could help us get started?”

And so on. Creativity in offering options, different points of view is needed in group meetings. If you play such a role, you will become one of the more valuable members of any group.

7. Critical Tester

Every meeting needs a person willing to challenge, tactfully, the validity and reasonableness of contributions. Note that the stress is on what is said rather than on who is saying it. Focus on the idea, the content, the evidence, the reasoning, leaving out all references to the person. All persons have the right to do so whenever a misleading or inaccurate statement is made. The following are questions to keep in mind:

Tact is required when testing opinions of others. Focus on the content rather than on who is making the statement.

- Were a sufficient number of facts given on which to build a conclusion?
- Is the information consistent, or do some contradictions get in the way of accepting the information?
- Are the facts—and the language—clear?
- Are the sources of information and the statistics reliable?
- Is the information recent; can one see the source and verify the evidence given?
- Was the cause sufficiently powerful to produce the alleged effect?
- Have some data been omitted in leading to the conclusion?

You should not hesitate to challenge an unsupported conclusion, an out-of-date source, a biased piece of information, an incomplete recital of facts, an unclear cause producing even more unclear effects, an unclear referent or source—and other illogical matters that potentially can negatively influence the discussion. Not to do so is to omit good participant responsibility when reading a report or participating in a discussion.

8. Conciliator

Deadlocks are not uncommon in meetings. Both sides refuse to budge; violent disagreements do occur. What often happens is that persons become so polarized that not losing face is as important as not losing the argument. You as a conciliator attempt to find a middle ground, seek to find a compromise.

“Let me try this suggestion: Instead of offering a two-year appointment, could we consider a one-year appointment with a review after the first six months? If our review is favorable, we could then move toward a three-year appointment.”

“Well, we’re at an impasse as to what the final recommendation should be. I suggest four people—two from both sides—hammer out a draft and then come to the whole body for our review.”

“O.K., we’re still far apart; it seems we’re not going to reach agreement this evening. We can either call in an outside facilitator, have an outsider chair the meeting, or we continue in deadlock. I recommend we get a neutral facilitator to help us to closure on the issue.”

9. Helper of Others

A final role you can play is to invite other participants to join in. You do not wish to embarrass others, but try to help those who may feel inadequate or who are simply hesitant to speak up in the forum. Tact, sensitivity, and cooperativeness with the chairperson characterize this role.

“Most of us have had a chance to participate. I’d like to hear what Jane has to say on the topic.” (*invitation to participate*)

“Mr. Chairman, there appears to be a slight misunderstanding. I think what Kellie was saying is this . . .” (*clarification and further support*)

“Superior thought, Donna. Let me make a comment and then invite others to make observations.” (*praise of member*)

A chairperson should invite full participation. If the chairperson ignores anyone, participants can invite the silent member to participate.

■ Checklist 17.5 How to Be a Good Participant During a Meeting

1. Bring the group back to the central topic if the group wanders away.
2. Clarify, ask a question, if the issue is unclear.
3. Give substantive—accepted facts and opinions—statements to add credible information to the discussion. Risk giving ideas that could transform (bring about a different perspective) the group.
4. Be a cheerleader, energize the group, if it seems to lapse into negativism.
5. Test ideas; tactfully suggest correct information.
6. Search for a middle ground; suggest possible compromises.
7. Help others; invite participation; ask for contributions from those more silent.

“We all were a little harsh on your first point. Could you take a little time and explain your second concern.” (*support of member*)

No one expects you to use all of the preceding nine roles. But be aware of them. Adopt an appropriate role whenever you feel it is necessary. Using one or two of them during a meeting will add to the quality of the meeting and let you make a significant contribution to the discussion.

SUMMARY

Of all the chapters in this book, this chapter brought together the many elements of good business writing and oral communication. Many meetings and discussions within those meetings depend heavily upon written documents, most often to arrive at a solution to a problem.

Thus, business groups are formed, or are already in place, primarily to resolve problems. These are formal groups, moving from an initial awareness of a problem to its eventual resolution. Some call these steps problem, solution, benefits, action. Regardless of titles of the steps, a problem-solving meeting should result in action.

Both the chairperson of a problem-solving meeting and its participants require skills. For the leader, this means primarily being a democratic leader, guiding, encouraging, compromising. The participant must focus on two things: contributing content of value via positive participant roles and suggesting procedural steps to improve both the harmony of the group and the flow of the discussion. In short, a good meeting requires cooperation between the leader and its participants.

Keep in mind the two other purposes for meetings: informational (giving of information to individuals) and suggested solution meetings. This latter form is in the form of a hearing, a bringing together of various preliminary views prior to the final recommendation.

■ Communication Probe

Electronic brainstorming is a term coming into vogue in connection with electronic discussions. One researcher argues that although groups meet to generate ideas, share information, and initiate action, in face-to-face meetings, members of the group may worry about the way others will perceive their ideas. Thus, some members hold back ideas; they can be apprehensive, literally uncomfortable with proposing an idea. In contrast, electronic brainstorming allows persons to anonymously type in their ideas, which, in turn, are passed on to other participants electronically and synchronously. Thus more ideas are displayed before the entire group, without the proposer being known.

Kay, G. (1994/1994, Winter). Effective meetings through electronic brainstorming. *Management Quarterly*, 35, 15–26.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Differences Between Western and Asian Leadership Styles.** Much has been written on the differences between western (primarily U.S.) leadership and Asian leadership styles. Knowing what some of those differences are will help us understand what occurs during meetings where westerners and Asians interact. Look up the following terms in some leadership texts; give a brief definition of each and their possible implications in group meetings:

- Headship
- Individualism
- Independence
- Paternalism
- Transformational

Suggested sources for some of the above terms include:

Westwood, R. I. and Chan, A. (1992). Headship and leadership. In R. I. Westwood (ed.), *Organizational behaviour* (pp. 118–143). Hong Kong: Longmans Group; Dahnke, G. L. and Clatterbuck, G. W. (eds.) (1990). *Human Communication: Theory and Research*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth; Hildebrandt, H. W. (1988). International/intercultural communication: A comparative study of Asian and U.S. managers. *World Communication*, 17, 49–68.

2. **Interview with Second-Language Student.** One of your classmates may be from a foreign country and speaks English as a second language. Presumably this student has participated in or is aware of meeting procedures in his or her native land. Differences do exist. Search out some of those differences in an interview with a foreign student or friend from a foreign country. Then prepare a written and oral report to the class on your find-

ings. You may wish to use some of the following questions to supplement your own:

- Describe how the leader begins the meeting.
- To what extent do the members participate in the discussion?
- Are the members critical of ideas presented? What is their approach to testing evidence?
- How does the meeting end: Does the leader announce the decision, or does it evolve naturally from the discussion?

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Report on a Meeting, Chairperson, and Participants.** Attend a meeting on your campus or in your community; report back on the following questions:
 - a. Was the purpose of the meeting clear?
 - b. What were some of the chairperson's actions?
 - How was the meeting begun?
 - Was the chairperson democratic, or were other kinds of leadership exhibited?
 - What was done to move the group along toward a decision?
 - How was the decision regarding a problem announced?
 - c. What roles did the participants play?
 - Did some members exhibit negative characteristics? If so, what were those characteristics?
 - What kinds of support did members bring to the discussion? How did they support their ideas?
 - Describe the most useful member in the group; what made that person effective?
4. **Evaluations of Questions for Problem-Solving Discussion.** The following questions were posed by other students as they considered topics for a discussion. Their goal was to have a problem-solving discussion before the class. Evaluate these questions: Which are satisfactory and which are not?
 - a. New products for next year?
 - b. What is the problem with our new administration and education building?
 - c. Is our economy getting better or worse?
 - d. What should the government's policy be on allowing banks to sell securities?
 - e. Oral communication in business—what makes it effective?
 - f. What steps can business take to improve business relations with Third World countries?
 - g. Should B.B.A. students go on in school and obtain their M.B.A. degree?
 - h. Which of the Big Eight accounting firms is the most respected in our state?

5. Evaluation of Participants' Contributions During a Public Meeting.

Attend a public meeting of a local school board, a city council, or a student organization. Use the following evaluation form to determine the number and kinds of contributions the participants made. Bring the form to class for a report on the roles participants played in the meeting.

PARTICIPATION FORM							
Discussion group: _____							
Date: _____							
Check in the appropriate category the type of contribution made by each of the participants. (See the discussion of participant roles in this chapter.)							
Type of contribution	Participant						
	#1	#2	#3	#4	#5	#6	#7
Organizer							
Clarifier							
Questioner							
Factual contributor							
Energizer							
Idea creator							
Critical tester							
Conciliator							
Helper of others							

Which type of contribution was made most often? Why? _____

6. Oral-Written Group Work Using Scientific, Reflective Method. The following information summarizes the basic requirements of this oral written assignment involving extensive group work on using the scientific, reflective method.

- a. Each member of the class will be assigned to a group.
- b. Each group will select its own chairperson, set its own meetings outside

of class, meet the deadlines imposed, select its own problem for the assignment.

- c. Each group will present to the class and instructor the following information:
- (1) On the day before the background-analysis presentation, distribute to the class—or announce—the topic to be discussed in the following class period.
 - (2) On the day of the informative, background-analysis presentation about the group problem:
 - (a) The group distributes the agenda for the meeting.
 - (b) The chairperson introduces group members, sets out the direction for the meeting.
 - (c) Each member in the group orally presents one part of the background, location, recognition, description of the problem chosen by the group.
 - Definitions needed to understand discussion
 - History of problem
 - Effects of problem
 - Causes of problem
 - Importance of problem
 - Evolution of problem (early period; late period)
 - Comparison of problem
 - (d) The chairperson concludes the presentation and allows questions and discussion with members of the class.
 - (e) A secretary can take minutes on the presentations of group members.
 - (f) The meeting is adjourned.
 - (3) On the day of the persuasive solution presentations about the group problem:
 - (a) The minutes of the preceding meeting may be presented to the class for approval.
 - (b) The chairperson of the group summarizes the preceding background presentation of the group.
 - (c) Each member in the group orally offers his or her own solution to the group problem.
 - Criteria for evaluating alternatives to solving the problem
 - Overview or range or listing of solutions available to solve the problem
 - Solution A
 - Solution B
 - Solution C
 - Solution A/B
 - Solution C/D
 - (d) The chairperson concludes the presentation by summarizing the alternative solutions presented and allows questions and discussion with group members.
 - (e) A secretary may record the presentations of the group members.

- (f) The class or group may or may not decide on a single solution.

7. Review the Decision Process on a Published Issue: Review in a local newspaper, a campus paper, or a national business journal an issue that ultimately was solved, by vote of a governing body. Such an issue may have consumed several months of deliberations and may be a business issue, a school issue, or a governmental issue. Your task is to review the process of arriving at the final decision, through doing the following:

- a. State the problem as you perceive it as a question of fact, value, or policy.
- b. List the various options that were considered.
- c. State whether criteria were announced before or during any discussion.
- d. Summarize, briefly, the final solution or recommendation voted on or approved by the approval body.

Having presented that outline, offer an analysis as to where you think the major problems lie in arriving at the final decision.

8. Review of Governmental Discussions. Newspaper and TV reporters are not participants in actual governmental discussions. Yet, the average reader or viewer must often depend on these sources for information about the results of an issue. Such an issue was the budget discussion at the end of 1995 and the beginning of 1996: Both the President and Congress held innumerable discussions.

Although we do not know what actually occurred during these budget discussions, there are adequate records of those protracted discussions. Bring in a written report that does the following:

- Gives examples of various newspaper headings that summarized the proceedings
- Summarizes some of the arguments issued on both sides of the budget issue
- Reviews several newspaper editorials, and the inferences those editorials drew from the budget battle

Then draw some inferences from your collected data, answering questions similar to the following: What outside influences (political) enter into decisions made by government officials? What suggestions do you have to speed up decision making within the government on strong contentious issues? Is the communication received from the various newspaper accounts unbiased? And other questions of your choice.

9. Assessing a Student Group Meeting. Inevitably you will be a participant in a student group assignment. Often those meetings are a disaster; at other times they are quite successful. Therefore, monitoring and evaluating those student meetings can lead to improvements in the future. At the end of a meeting, apply the following KSS evaluation method to a meeting. [Tripman, J. (1996). *Making Meetings Work*. Thousand Oaks: Sage Publications.]

On a sheet of paper write three questions and then report the results to the class:

- What during this meeting went well and should be KEPT?
- What during this meeting did not go well and should be STOPPED?
- What did not happen during this meeting and should be STARTED?

A variation on this assignment is to have several groups complete it and then have each group report their answers. The results can point up interesting similarities and differences.

REFERENCES

1. Tuckman, B. W. (1965). Development sequences in small groups. *Psychological Bulletin*, 63, 384–399.
2. Fisher, B. A. (1970). Decision emergence: Phases in group decision making. *Speech Monographs*, 37, 53–66; Tuckman, B.W. (1965). Development sequences in small groups. *Psychological Bulletin*, 63, 384–399.
3. Sattler, W. M., & Miller, N. E. (1966). *Discussion and conference*. Englewood Cliffs NJ: Prentice-Hall.
4. Benne, K. D., & Sheats, Paul. (1948, Spring). Functional roles of group members. *Journal of Social Issues*, 4, 41–49.
5. Sattler, W. M., & Miller, N. E. (1966). *Discussion and conference*. Englewood Cliffs NJ: Prentice-Hall.

The Job Application Process

Chapter 18 The Job Application Process—The Written Job Presentation

Chapter 19 The Job Application Process—Interviews and Follow-Up

The Job Application Process—The Written Job Presentation

I. Self-Assessment

- A. Know Your Skills
- B. Know Your Accomplishments
- C. Know Your Interests
- D. Know Your Personal Values

II. Market Assessment

- A. Written Sources of Career and Job Information
- B. Helpful Persons Regarding Employers and Jobs

III. Resume (Vita, Qualifications Brief)

- A. Opening Section
- B. Education
- C. Work Experience
- D. Achievements, Awards, Service Activities
- E. Personal Data (Optional)
- F. References
- G. Sample Resumes

IV. Cover Letter to Resume

- A. Opening—For Favorable Attention
- B. Middle Paragraphs—For Data, Details
- C. Last Paragraph—For Easy Action
- D. Sample Letters of Application

V. Summary

VI. Exercises and Problems

Throughout this brochure we've presented an overview of who we are, where we came from, how we approach our business, and most importantly, what we promise . . . to you!

This brochure introduces you to career opportunities available at [company]. We've organized the information into answers to big questions—the kind you probably have as you face critical decisions about your career and future.

Companies market themselves to potential employees via handsome brochures that summarize their missions, products, and services.

These representative statements from company recruiting brochures lead to several conclusions: Companies are widening their search for promising job applicants, companies are marketing themselves, companies are aware of the significant decisions you make when searching for a job.

The next task is yours: How should you decide whether you are interested and qualified to approach a particular company for a job? Times have changed. Japan, for instance, had lifelong job security; that is changing. So, too, certain positions in the United States seemed to be guaranteed for life; that is also changing. Reengineering of corporations, restructuring of entire companies, and takeovers all guarantee that few positions will be for life. You, as a new graduate or currently employed worker, can expect to hold several jobs over your lifetime.

This chapter—and the following—take you through the steps necessary to prepare you for doing a good self- and company assessment in landing a job. Here we focus on self- and market assessment and recommend vital inclusions in a well-formed resume and cover letter.

SELF-ASSESSMENT

Who are you? This is not a simple question. A cursory answer is that you already know who you are. But beyond your surface awareness lie deeper qualities, which when evaluated, prepare you for landing a job: your skills, achievements, interests, and even personal values. Being aware of these qualities allows you to better sell your product—yourself!

■ Communication Probe

Historically, three approaches to career assessment have been discussed in books and articles: individual career assessment, group session assessment, and books and tapes for self-assessment. Recently, an additional approach was suggested: a three-step long-distance support model. This approach involves the following steps: A professional counselor meets with client employees; several questionnaires are completed at home or during the workshop; the counselor scores and interprets the questionnaires; a personal report for each of the employees is prepared. The result was that employees felt better about themselves, felt they knew themselves better, and felt renewed.

Godkewitsch, M. (1989–1990). Exploring the long-distance career support model. *Optimum*, 20, 65–69.

Know Your Skills

Verbs suggest action; using them to describe your skills gives the impression that you are a dynamic person.

Verbs are core in relating to your reader what you have accomplished and where your skills lie. But before choosing these action verbs, you have to assess your interest in and support for ideas that follow those verbs. For example, you might write a list of skills under each of the following verbs:

- Enjoy *analyzing* financial data
- *Administered* a program of 10 students working with minority businesses
- Prepared *consulting* proposals in response to tender offers
- Involved in student *planning* for the admissions office
- Helped prepare the *evaluating* document for core courses in our school
- *Coordinated* off-campus internships
- Discovered that I like to *negotiate*, preparing the written document and the oral defense as based on that document
- Noted that I worked well in *mediating* differences between student group members
- *Created* three new products for our small company from initial idea to product manufacture and assembly
- Delighted to *speak* before groups—both in school and to outside groups

Of course, these 10 statements are illustrative. Yet they show that *beginning* with a verb—and including more later—forces you to focus on a specific skill following that verb. Take time in compiling such a personal list.

Know Your Accomplishments

Record accomplishments. What may be trivial to you may be important to someone else.

No matter how young—or old—you are, you have already accomplished something. Again, stating those accomplishments following a verb is a good way to profile your accomplishments; show the *result* of your specific achievement, as for instance in these categories:

■ Communication Probe

Knowing the skills sought in students was the focus of a recent Darden study. In short, what were some selection criteria when making decisions relevant to hiring people? To answer that question, close to 40 firms recruiting persons nationwide were interviewed. Seven top attributes sought in graduating M.B.A.s in their final round interviews were these: communication skills (verbal and nonverbal), 85%; interpersonal skills, 69%; self-motivation/initiative (self-monitoring and independence), 67%; professional presence/initial impact (ability to interact), 62%; leadership, 56%; analysis/problem solving, 54%; and academic achievement, 51%.

Dowd, K. O., & Liedtka, J. M. (1994). A study of management characteristics sought by recruiters today. *The Career Forum*, 14(1), 21–23.

- Winning the scholarship award allowed me to travel to Europe [*education*]
- Reducing the labor-hours required for product changeover resulted in a savings of 5% [*work-related projects*]
- Obtaining the Combat Infantry Badge resulted in a promotion to Master Sergeant [*success in military service*]
- Joining the church group ended with my being elected chairperson [*extracurricular activities*]
- Winning the outstanding student investor award allowed me to invest new capital into the market [*awards, honors*]
- Traveling resulted in a major paper and proposal for entering the east European market [*intercultural exposure*]
- Starting my own business taught me practical experience and introduced me to basic fundamentals of entrepreneurial business [*business ventures*]
- Speaking French and Spanish allowed me to head a student study group to Europe [*knowledge of foreign languages*]

Know Your Interests

Analyzing your interests, preferences, and attitudes can help you determine in what type of job you can use your skills.

Which jobs have I enjoyed the most? Why?
Do I prefer to work with figures, machines, people, or ideas?
What do I like to do with my free time?
Which things have brought me high satisfaction?
Which hobbies do I enjoy the most?
And many other self analysis questions . . .

Know Your Personal Values

Earlier, Chapter 4 discussed various situations involving ethical environments; often your decision is based on your own value judgments. Values can also be applied to jobs and what you seek to get from them. Look at the following descriptions; each has a value attached to them; check those statements that apply to you:

1. _____ A desire to help people, a desire to work with them in a personal manner. A concern to make the world a better place in which to live.
2. _____ A position of major responsibility. You would also receive a sizable salary and high recognition.

3. _____ A wish to face risk. You would have to be willing to travel and be concerned with exciting tasks.
4. _____ An ideal place in which to work; people would know one another. The atmosphere would be friendly and warm.
5. _____ A desire to accomplish much on your own. A keen interest in being your own boss.
6. _____ A wish to control events and people. While consensus would be desirable, you would make many decisions alone.
7. _____ A wanderlust. You tire easily of monotonous routines.
8. _____ A dislike for a desk; you would rather be involved in outdoor or physical activity.
9. _____ A dollar sign floats before your eyes. When asked to draw a picture of your interests, that same sign appears.

Values are difficult to measure. Each person carries in his or her own head those things considered of prime importance.

Respectively, the order of the values connected with the above descriptions are altruism, prestige, adventure, association, independence, power, variety, physical activity, and money. You can add to the above list for other values you feel are important.

These four self-assessment categories outlined are for your own use. You will not mail them to anyone. But such a start at self-analysis allows you to see patterns that can give you preliminary ideas as to the kind of work you would like to do.

■ Checklist 18.1 Self-Assessment

1. Skills

- My strongest skills are in this area: _____
- I must work further on this skill: _____

2. Accomplishments

Rank from 1 (high) to 9 (low) your accomplishments in the following areas: education, work-related projects, military service, extracurricular activities, awards, honors, travel, business ventures, international cultural awareness, or others.

3. Interests

- I most enjoy _____
- I least enjoy _____

4. Values

Rank from 1 (high) to 9 (low) your values in the following areas: altruism, adventure, association, independence, power, variety, physical activity, and money.

■ Communication Probe

Self-assessment is not limited only to obtaining a job. Self-assessment can occur while even holding a present position. Some companies have an on-going self-assessment program for the good of the individual and for the good of the company. Often such assessment involves the popular Myer-Briggs Type Indicator, but often companies create their own assessment programs, often called career enrichment programs. Chevron Corporation includes these components: complete self-assessment; joint planning between employee and employer; review of the plan by a group of supervisors; implementation of the plan; and an end-of-cycle review.

(1995, September). Chevron changes focus from career development to career enrichment. *Business Credit*, 97, 24.

MARKET ASSESSMENT

You now have to ask these questions. Which jobs and employers need what I have to offer? In which business market (company) would I like to work? This section includes suggestions to help you in your job-related research.

Written Sources of Career and Job Information

Trade publications, libraries, placement offices are principal places to locate information on possible functional job areas.

Innumerable sources exist. Your school library, local library, and even the career or placement center at your school have countless articles and books on careers and job information. We included here just a few classic, representative samples.

Self-Assessment and Career Planning

- Harr, G. (1995). *Career guide: Road maps to meaning in the world of work*. Pacific Grove, CA: Brooks/Cole Publishing.
- Herriot, P. (1992). *The career management challenge: Balancing individual and organizational needs*. Newbury Park CA: Sage Publications.
- Pollock, D. (1995). *Life beyond school: A career guide for college graduates*. Kaaawa HI: Jungle Press.

Resume and Cover Letter Preparation

- Kaplan, R. (1994). *Sure-hire cover letters*. New York: AMACOM.
- Karsen, A. (1991). *Ready, aim, hired: Developing your brand name resume*. Homewood IL: Business One Irwin.
- Wilson, R. (1994). *Conquer resume objections*. New York: Wiley.

Interviewing Strategies

- Curzon, S. (1995). *Managing the interview: A how-to-do-it manual for hiring*. New York: Neal-Schuman.

- Yate, M. J. (1993). *Knock 'em dead: With greater answers to tough interview questions*. Holbrook MA: Bob Adams.

Internships

- (1995) *Internships: A directory for career-finders*. New York: Macmillan. Smith, C. (Ed.).
- (1990). *Great careers: The Fourth of July resource guide for the promotion of careers, in public, community, and international service*. Garrett Park MD: Garrett Park Press.

International Careers

- Cantrell, W. (1992). *International internships and volunteer programs . . .* Oakton VA: Worldwide Books.
- *The student's guide to international internships*. (1993). Washington, DC: National Internships.

Additionally, many company directories and employment guides, industry directories, books relating to geographic job searches, cost-of-living directories, and search firms are available. CD-ROM and ABI-Inform databases, job fairs, and the College Placement Council are additional sources for career ideas. For the most up-to-date information concerning a company, consult its annual report, 10-K reports, and recruiting booklets.

Helpful Persons Regarding Employers and Jobs

Networking (remaining in contact with individuals or groups) allows you to make known your job wishes. Or, your network lets you know of potential job positions.

Networking is the current buzzword for linking your interests with a position or company through the help of another person or group. In all parts of the world, the family often nourishes those connections, from generation to generation. If you do not possess such familial network relationships, you must turn to other people, such as those listed below, to help you assess job opportunities.

- *Alumni*. Obtain a list of your university alumni from around the world.
- *Business friends*. Ask for an informational interview with local business persons for advice and even a reference.
- *Counselors*. Your school or placement office staff people who are tuned into the latest areas where jobs and opportunities are growing.
- *Employment Agencies*. Make an appointment with a search firm; get on their list; ask for a review of opportunities in your area of expertise.
- *Former employers and coworkers*.
- *Friends, relatives, acquaintances*.
- *Labor unions*.

RESUME (VITA, QUALIFICATIONS BRIEF)

Phrases or incomplete sentences are acceptable in a resume.

Having completed your self-analysis and market analysis, you must now focus on writing your resume. Briefly, a resume is a summary of your qualifications and intended career path. Some schools require all student resumes to be consistent

■ Communication Probe

Interesting but similar conclusions were gleaned from a cross-cultural study between job selection approaches in the United States and Japan. Both countries are industrialized and both have a formalized recruitment process, two factors considered in the study. Comparative data from over 600 U.S. male employees and over 500 Japanese male employees were examined. Major variables included country of the firm, size of the firm, educational level of the employees, and age. Dependent variables were direct contact in the employees' employment process; source of the job information; and influence of personal ties in the job selection. *In both countries, most employees heard of job openings from personal sources.* Not unexpectedly, the size of the firm influenced both availability of job information and final selection practices.

Marx, J. (1988, August). Organizational recruitment as a two-stage process: A comparative analysis of Detroit and Yokohama. *Work and Occupations*, 15, 276–293.

in form. Such consistency allows companies using a school resume book to quickly review many graduates and, on that basis, invite some to a personal interview.

Content and layout of resumes vary; there is no best type. Present your information under headings in phrases instead of full sentences. Focus on your job-related achievements. Push the positive—but be honest.

Here we discuss the possible contents of a resume. Choose those parts that best fit your background, and then arrange them in any desirable order. After the opening discussion, we will present examples of complete resumes.

Opening Section

Heading

Information in the heading tells the reader where you can be contacted.

John Sweetland
405 N. State St.
Waseca, MN 56093
Phone 507 555-3237

Although the above is customary, some students, and particularly persons currently in a job position, also include their E-mail-Internet and fax number:

Lyoun@mus.umich.edu and FAX 313 555-4567

Such an insertion quickly suggests you are in control of recent technological means of communication.

■ Communication Probe

Consistently, writers and researchers suggest similar inclusions in a resume. The information below is based on a recent survey of steps. Note the similarity in the following list with those suggested in this book:

- Preparation is essential.
- Identification of self- and company interests.
- Work experience.
- Professional objectives.
- Education qualifications.
- Achievements.
- Personal information.
- References.

Hornsby, J., & Smith, B. (1995, Winter). Resume content: What should be included and excluded. *SAM Advanced Management Journal*, 60, 4–9.

Job or Career Objective

Based on your self-assessment and an analysis of the job market, you should try for a single-sentence statement of your goal. Such a statement may be general or specific: General, if you know your functional area of interest; specific, if you desire more precision, combining the functional area with an industry.

General goal statement

1. An entry-level sales position
2. An assistant in a brand management area
3. An entry-level position in institutional lending

Specific goal statement

1. An entry-level sales position in automotive parts
2. An assistant in brand management in the food industry
3. An entry-level position in the lending section of the savings and loan industry

Some resumes at this point include a brief statement of your basic qualifications. Such a statement is a mini summary of what you can offer to the job. It is your decision; some persons opt to include such information in the cover letter accompanying the resume.

You now face another decision: Which area should be in second position in the resume? A general rule is put the most important qualification immediately after the heading. If you have superior job experience, put that next; if education—the category most often in the second position—is important, position it next.

People tend to remember “first” things; therefore, after the heading select your most important selling point.

Education

Here are some recommendations regarding what to include under the heading Education.

1. Include school names, locations, dates attended, and degrees of certificates earned. High schools are usually not included. But if you did something outstanding there, such information may be added.
2. Insert abbreviations for your degrees; most employers or their human resources department are familiar with major degree citations.
3. Decide whether to include your grade-point average. Certainly if it is high, it should be included. If your grade-point average is low, omit it. Later in your resume you may indicate, for example, that you worked full-time to finance your education and still managed to earn a degree.
4. Determine whether to include specific courses completed. In a detailed resume, such information may be unnecessary; companies today know the basic required courses for most degrees.
5. Note honors and scholarships.

Work Experience

The third section of a resume is usually devoted to work experience. Here you include information that helps employers evaluate whether you have the necessary background for a current position. Clearly, work experience similar to that for which you are applying indicates you like the type of work in question.

List your jobs in reverse chronological order; put the present or most recent one first. Keep in mind the following points:

1. Give the name, location, and dates of employment for each company.
2. Insert your position and title, if any, beside each company.
3. Use verbs that show your major accomplishments while working for each company; be precise as to the results of your work experiences. The list of action verbs on the facing page is helpful.

Arrange the facts for each job in the best “selling” order. Put the most important fact first following your opening verb.

Follow the rules of parallelism, making two or more elements in a series similar in grammatical word structure. *Manager, representative, salesperson, accountant* are all parallel because each is a job title and a noun. *Managing*, a kind of work, would not be parallel to the preceding titles. Duties, as *filing, word processing, planning* are parallel. Most often the verbs, as in the long list, are in the past tense when describing activities performed for a previous company.

Achievements, Awards, Service Activities

Try to limit your resume to one page. If you have received few noteworthy awards, this information may be omitted or included in sections on education and

accomplished	delegated	interpreted	published
achieved	demonstrated	interviewed	questioned
adapted	designed	introduced	realized
administered	developed	invented	recommended
adopted	devised	investigated	reduced
advanced	directed	judged	researched
advised	disposed	juried	restated
allocated	drafted	justified	reviewed
analyzed	edited	led	revised
appraised	employed	listened	saved
approved	enlisted	maintained	scheduled
assessed	established	managed	secured
assisted	executed	marketed	selected
audited	expanded	matched	sold
broadened	expedited	measured	sponsored
brought	explained	monitored	staffed
calculated	extrapolated	negotiated	suggested
clarified	facilitated	obtained	summarized
communicated	forecasted	offered	supervised
compiled	formed	operated	taught
completed	formulated	optimized	trained
conceived	furnished	organized	transferred
conciliated	generated	originated	transformed
conducted	guided	performed	undertook
constructed	handled	persuaded	used
consulted	headed	planned	validated
contacted	implemented	prepared	verified
contracted	improved	presented	weighed
controlled	increased	prioritized	widened
coordinated	influenced	produced	won
created	initiated	programmed	worked
decided	inspected	projected	wrote
decreased	instructed	promoted	
defined	integrated	proposed	

work experience. Regardless, this is not the time to be humble. Receiving any award deserves mention in a resume. Additional items often include offices held, athletic accomplishments, published materials, fluency in foreign languages, speaking awards (debate, extemporaneous contests), professional fraternities, student organizations, and community services that involve working with people.

Personal Data (Optional)

Including personal information is now entirely optional. Civil rights laws clearly prohibit discrimination in hiring on the basis of race, age, religion, sex, marital status, or national origin. Exceptions include occupational restrictions that are reasonably necessary to the normal operation of particular businesses, enterprises, or occupations. For example, some jobs, such as playing professional football, may reasonably require certain physical attributes.

Although no law forbids you from volunteering personal information, you must be careful about including information that could accuse you of being discriminatory. Bias and prejudice still exist; *omit any information that might be considered negatively!* Common inclusions under personal data include health, hobbies, physical skills, travel, and, if not included elsewhere, Peace Corps, Americorps, military service details, or other national service organizations.

References

Employers today often ask prior to or just after an interview for a list of references. Including a long list of individuals in a resume is becoming less usual. Potential employers know you will select persons who will evaluate you positively. Often the phrase “references available on request” is the last statement at the end of a resume. However, your school may suggest including references. If that is the case, consider the following:

■ Checklist 18.2 Review of Major Sections of a Resume

1. Opening Section
 - a. Your name, address (school and/or home), telephone numbers, fax number, or E-mail address
 - b. Your job or career objective
 - c. Your basic qualifications (optional)
2. Education
 - a. Schooling beyond high school: names and locations, dates attended, degrees and certificates
 - b. Major, significant pertinent courses; academic honors; grade-point average [if high]; special skills; significant achievements
 - c. Positions, such as assistant to an instructor, grader, or research assistant
3. Work Experience
 - a. Employer names, dates, location; titles and positions held; specific accomplishments preceded by a verb
 - b. Volunteer work
4. Achievements, Awards, Service Activities
 - a. School and community achievements, honors, offices, publications
 - b. Travel, languages, self-support, other facts
5. Personal Data (Optional)
 - a. Date of availability
 - b. Health, military service, hobbies
6. References (Optional)

- Limit your list to three individuals, complete with information about where they may be reached via phone, fax, letter, or E-mail.
- Avoid including relatives as references.
- Choose individuals such as former work supervisors, professors, teachers, colleagues, or business friends.
- Be sure you have the permission of the individual whose name you use as a reference.

Sample Resumes

In the preceding sections we discussed the six major parts of a resume: opening section, education, work experience, achievements, personal data, and references. Review the following four examples, which illustrate all the sections. A description of each resume is included at the bottom of the example.

All the above guides for completing a resume are just as applicable to creating your material for electronic resume transmission. There, however, your material can be read by many readers, particularly on line resume service organizations hired by human resource departments of corporations. Remember: Electronic screening is efficient for large corporations that may use sorting systems, scanners, or on-line data pools. Your resume, particularly your goal or objective statement, will be more general rather than directed at a specific company, for a specific position.

COVER LETTER TO RESUME

Also called the “cold contact” letter or the job application letter, the resume cover letter has one purpose: to attract the interest of your prospective employer to give you a job interview. A resume could be called the shotgun approach—it covers much material; a resume cover letter could be called the rifle approach—it focuses on precise points.

Try to write a one-page job application letter composed of the following points: opening, middle paragraphs, and last paragraph, as noted below. This tripartite approach should also continue to be reader-centered and should include evidence (data) to support your claims.

You have only about 30 seconds to capture the attention of your reader in the cover letter.

■ Communication Probe

Obviously, the nonverbal appearance of the resume must catch the eye of the prospective employer. Thus neatness, accurate spelling, and acceptable grammar are givens in a resume. And only after reading the resume—along with the cover letter—can an employer make a decision whether to interview the candidate. Four factors in the content of a resume, says one researcher, work against its success: candidate had too many lateral job moves; candidate did not include a cover letter; candidate held too many jobs in a short period of time; and the candidate lacked related experience.

Macdougall, N. (1990, September). An employer rates resumes. *CMA magazine*, 64, 35.

ELLEN RAAB	
Campus Address <i>[Street]</i> <i>[City, State, ZIP]</i> <i>[Telephone; Fax; E-mail]</i>	Permanent Address <i>[Street]</i> <i>[City, State, ZIP]</i> <i>[Telephone; Fax]</i>
Goal	A position in marketing or advertising.
Education	School of Business Administration College <i>[Name, City, State]</i> B.B.A. degree candidate. May 1997. Concentration in marketing with interest in advertising. Member of Marketing Club. Active on advertising and product management committees. GPA = 3.25. Community College <i>[Name, City, State]</i> A.A.—Associate in Arts degree, June 1995. Member of Phi Theta Kappa, honorary fraternity. Received <i>[Name]</i> Scholarship for Outstanding Community College Student. GPA = 3.6.
Experience	<i>[Company Name]</i> <i>[City, State]</i> Intern. Summer 1996. Worked directly with buyers, assistant buyers, store management, sales associate, and senior merchandise management. As assistant department manager, responsibilities included trend analysis, implementation of merchandise concepts, communication with buyers, promotion preparation, and motivation of sales force. Distributed information to sales managers. Trassel Advertising <i>[City, State]</i> Intern. Summer 1995. Gained experience in sales promotion, public relations, media placement, agency presentations, client relations, copy writing, and commercial production. Commerce Weekly <i>[City, State]</i> Advertising display staff. January-April 1994. Created layout, ads, and guided ads through the areas of artwork, typesetting, and billing. Lawn Maintenance <i>[City, State]</i> Owner and partner. Summers 1991-1993. Marketed services to new and already established areas of our working community. Increased customers yearly.
Activities	Research assistant for professor of marketing. Leader of "Sunbank Products" marketing term project; organized advertising agency presentation of new marketing strategy for Sunbank baby food. Member Zeta Beta Tau fraternity. Active on fundraising committees. Team member in intramural softball and football. Participant in Dean's Seminar Program.
Available	Sept. 1, 1997. References furnished upon request.

Figure 18.1 One-page resume with main headings in left margin; right-hand margin justified (vertically straight); "Activities" in place of terms "Achievements, Awards, Service, Activities."

Henry Zse
2030 Welch Ct.
[City, State, Zip]
[Telephone; Fax; E-mail]

OBJECTIVE: A management position in accounting

EDUCATION: **The University of [Name]** [City, State]
School of Business Administration
MBA candidate for May 1999.
– Active member, Accounting Club—Special Events Coordinator
– Active member, Black Business Students' Association

The University of [Name] [City, State]
BBS degree, December 1997
– Graduated magna cum laude (GPA 3.59/4.0)
– Honors: National Dean's list; Scholastic All-American
– Elected President, School of Business and Industry Forum

EXPERIENCE [Company Name] [City, State]
1994-1996 General Accountant
– Reviewed with re-engineering of the payment process and systems; ensured uniformity across the organization
– Assisted with re-engineering of the payment process for contract services; resulted in 3-5% rate reduction in services provided
– Coordinated two cross-functional teams to review contract services
– Promoted to Senior General Accountant in June, 1996
– Prepared month-end journal vouchers in accordance with corporate guidelines

College Graduate in Training
– Managed Dealer Incentive Programs for [Name] motor division
– Analyzed and recommended changes in indirect costs associated with specialty vehicles
– Resolved 100% of outstanding items on five supplier accounts

1993 [Company Name] [City, State]
Winter Intern
– Analyzed district performance for various products distributed to suppliers around the country
– Evaluated physician assistants' responsibilities to determine viability as a potential target market

ADDITIONAL – Volunteer tutor, Project STEP tutorial program
– 1994 campaign manager, local Friends of Scouting
– One and one-half years retail sales experience

Figure 18.2 One-page resume with traditional main headings and dates in left margin.

Opening—For Favorable Attention

In Chapters 14 and 15 we stressed the importance of the *aim*, making clear—up front—your central purpose. Be businesslike—indicate you're applying for a job. Four possible opening styles are recommended: summary, name, question, and news item openings.

RESUME OF WINNIE NG*[Address, City, State, Zip]**[Telephone; Fax; E-mail]***Professional Objective:** Business education teaching position in a *[State]* Class A secondary school.**EDUCATION FOR BUSINESS AND TEACHING***[Name] University, [City, State], September 1994 to June 1997***Major:** Business education, secondary school emphasis

Courses in accounting; business communication; business law; computer programming; data processing; graphic arts; marketing; office practice; secretarial procedures; teaching accounting, shorthand; machine operations

Minor: Economics Courses in European and American economic history, international economics, macroeconomics, microeconomics

Grade Point Average: 3.9 (out of possible 4.0)

Degree: M.B.A. (master of business administration)

University of *[Name, City, State], September 1990-1994*

Grade Point Average: 3.8 (out of possible 4.0)

Degree: B.A. (bachelor of arts), with emphasis on business courses.

EMPLOYMENT EXPERIENCE**Student Teacher:** Broadway High, *[City, State], September to December 1991*

Supervisor: Ms. Jayne Hamilton

Courses taught: Shorthand 2, Word Processor Typesetting, Secretarial Procedures, Computer Operations: MS DOS; Windows

Responsibilities: Planned and supervised three complete units for each class, ranging from 20-30 students, with approval of Ms. Hamilton and Mr. Thomas Jones.

Bookkeeper and Baron Ford Motor, 850 Fifth Avenue, *[City, State]***Secretary:** January 1986 to December 1990 (part time during school; full time, summer):

Mr. David Lowns, Office Manager

Responsibilities: Varied over the two years. Operated switchboard, recorded accounts payable ledger, prepared reports, typed letters, assisted office manager as secretary and file clerk.

Figure 18.3 Resume (on two pages), with centered and side headings.**Summary Opening**

An effective opening is a summary of your two or three outstanding qualifications related to the job you seek. For instance:

1. Orion Pictures, Slavic Pictures. Both these companies gave me the opportunity to apply the financial skills learned in school. For two years I also worked for Turner Broadcasting;

RESUME OF WINNIE NG

Page 2

EMPLOYMENT EXPERIENCE *(continued)*

Assistant Claims Adjuster: Central Administrator, 360 Main Street,
[City, State] summer 1985
Supervisor: Mr. Walter Arnold
Responsibilities: Processed claims for health insurance, maintained all billing files on customer accounts, and sent reminders for premium payments

Part-time jobs before 1985:

Waitress in Jolly Home Restaurant, grocery store sales clerk, library assistant

HONORARIES, CLUBS, ACTIVITIES**College**

Phi Beta Kappa, academic national scholarship honorary
 Beta Gamma Sigma, national scholastic honorary in business administration
 Recording secretary, Business Student's Association
 Vice president, Beta Beta sorority
 Recipient of two academic scholarships: from Lions Club and XYZ Business Association

High School

National Honor Society and Torch Club—three years; secretary one year
 President, Business Education Club
 Editor, Annual
 Outstanding Graduate 1986, chosen by Alumni Association

SKILLS AND HOBBIES

Write and speak the French language.

Office skills include operating computers (IBM, Apple, Zenith), copying machines, electronic calculators; writing shorthand 125 wpm, and typing 60 wpm.

Hobbies include hiking, working with people, swimming, professional enrichment.

REFERENCES

Available with credentials at Placement Center,
 [Name, Address] University

Figure 18.3 *(continued)*

there I headed an international marketing team searching for broadcast opportunities in southern Europe. *[extensive work experience]*

2. Classical music has for years been an interest of mine. Thus my CD collection, membership in the school symphony orchestra, and work as an usher at classical concerts suggest an awareness of the classical stage. Your published job description for a continuity writer for your station suggests that my background includes the qualifications you desire. *[no work experience]*

RESUME

PERSONAL PARTICULARS

NAME: Zhong Bei Baolin
 ADDRESS: 12f, Block 24
 Crossway Gardens
 Lam Tin, Kowloon
 TELEPHONE: 2431 0014 (home)
 2829 7470 (office)
 1228128 pager 5609
 SEX: Male
 DATE AND PLACE
 OF BIRTH: January 25, 1962, Hong Kong
 H.K.I.D. No: G259643(A)
 MARITAL STATUS: Married

EDUCATION

1994-1996 Master of Science in Mechanical Engineering
Hong Kong University of Science and Technology
 1990-1993 Professional Diploma in Informational Technology
Hong Kong Polytechnic University
 1985-1987 Bachelor of Science in Mechanical Engineering
University of Hong Kong
 1982-1985 High Diploma in Mechanical Engineering
Hong Kong Polytechnic University
 1975-1982 Lung Cheung Government Technical School

PC KNOWLEDGE

Lotus, Database, AutoCad, Multimate, MS Word, Word Star, Harvard Graphics, MS Windows, DOS

INTERESTS

Badminton, Squash, Reading

WORK EXPERIENCE

Feb.' 96-present Senior Engineer
[Company] Hong Kong Limited
 – Project management and design of E&M works in the construction and maintenance of Service Stations in Hong Kong and China
 – Provide preliminary design and estimates for potential projects
 – Handle regular maintenance work for service station facilities
 – Prepare tenders for E&M work for service stations

Foreign resumes include more personal information than do those of the United States; it is your option as to what personal information you include.

Figure 18.4 This two-page resume suggests that different cultures, different schools in foreign lands prepare resumes differently. Note especially the opening Personal Particulars section. Asian students have no distaste for or interest in hiding any of what western students would consider highly personal information. Then too, the United States has rules that prohibit that information from being made public, either on a resume or during a personal interview. Similar comments on "private" information can be made for European students, some of whom even include the names of their parents and the occupation of their father.

Interestingly, the above resume—names and details changed—omits mention of the fact that he knows English well: In Asia much of the information western students place in resumes is discussed orally during the interview. Also, note that the resume writer chooses to place his work experience last.

There is no objective or goal statement. We were told that when he received his current position, only those who felt they met the stipulated job requirements applied; hence, his goal statement is absent.

Sept.' 90-Jan.' 91 Engineer

[Company] Motor Bus (1993) Co. Ltd.

- Design of depot facilities, commissioning of equipment in bus depot
- Supervision of workforce and the repair and maintenance of bus and depot facilities
- Liaison with vehicle parts manufacturers
- Liaison with bus drivers to solve engineering and operational problems

Oct.' 88-Sept.' 90 Engineering Graduate

[Company] Motor Bus (1993) Co. Ltd.

- A two-year training program included workshop practice, supervision, management, and design works in bus-maintenance field.

3. Your international expansion plans have been cited in many major business publications. Your desire to expand into India caught my attention. I am of Indian descent. I have visited India with my parents extensively and have interned with an international oil exploration firm. My background suggests I can be a worthy candidate for your expansion plans. *[has cultural awareness knowledge]*

Name Opening

To use this kind of cover letter opening requires *networking*, learning about opportunities from another person or group. If a networking reference, or anyone

Name cards—kept on file—are constant reminders of persons on whom you might call for future references in cover letters.

well known to you, has suggested you apply for a position, you can use that person's name in the opening—unless he or she has asked you to keep it confidential. Many job opportunities with the federal government, if you are interested in that kind of work, are carried via the Washington “network.”

1. Professor Joseph Haan, my major professor in Operations Management at [university] told me of a possible opening in your area. Work with him over the past two years as a research assistant suggests I have some of the basic requirements for your open position.
2. Your ad in the employment section of the International Herald Tribune, on Friday, January 27, 199-, suggested the need for someone interested in working on investment opportunities in China. As a student who has visited China on several occasions, and one who owns some “B” shares of stock in that country, I would like to apply for the position of investment trainee in your company.
3. Your name comes to me via a mutual friend, Mr. Richard Sarns. He recommended that I send you my resume for your open position of assistant product manager.

Question Opening

A bit more difficult to write, but just as effective, is the question that shows understanding of a company problem or significant need. You as an applicant desire to help.

Geht es auf Deutsch? Are you in need of a German translator? Who answers the questions of your foreign guests at your Cape Cod guest house? German is one of my foreign languages, as is French and a little Italian. These language skills, and work in the Holiday Inn chain, lead me to approach you for the position of General Manager.

Read publications not only for content, but for future job opportunities.

News Item Opening

Any young person or seasoned businessperson should frequently read business publications. Not to do so may cost you a job opportunity. A planned expansion, a newly released product, a refinancing program, a new account—all are possible motivators for sending a job application letter. Often you send such a letter without a specific job in mind; you are interested in letting your readers know you have qualifications that tie in with their future plans.

1. Mexico, NAFTA were the headlines in the [name of journal, date]. And a significant portion of that article summarized your expansion plans into Mexico. My minor at [name of school] was Spanish,

with a second minor in Civil Engineering. Because of those two reasons, and others as noted in the accompanying resume, I'd like to apply for a job that makes use of my talents.

2. Congratulations on being voted in [*name of magazine, date*] as the most innovative Michigan company in creative information systems. For two years I have been linked with "open systems theory," applying that information to my current position of senior systems analyst. My academic concentration and my practical experience will enable me to perform well as a potential member of your staff.

Middle Paragraphs—For Data, Details

Support your claims; use truthful data, evidence, supports that both clarify and sustain your conclusions.

Two or at most three paragraphs is all the space you have to persuade your reader you have the necessary job qualifications.

- Avoid repetition of facts in the resume.
- Ask yourself: Which two points effectively show a potential employer that I have the necessary qualifications?
- Conclude each statement with this question: So what?
- Include brief, valid, startling data (evidence) in support of your job qualifications.
- Put your strongest argument first.

Education

Many of you will consider education your most important qualification, especially if you are applying for a first job. But avoid the impression that a college degree (entrepreneur and chairman of Microsoft Bill Gates does not have a college degree) overshadows all achievements.

- Emphasize how your *overall* education prepared you for the work or area you seek.
- Show that you have both a broad background in business (and arts and sciences) and depth in certain major courses.
- Explain how additional electives supplemented your major.

1. My training in production control at [*name*] enables me to analyze, study, and recommend methods of work simplification in your factory projects. Additionally, my seven-week internship-as part of our M.B.A. requirement-allowed me to work on the floor of [*name*] motor company where pragmatic experience added to my classroom work.
2. Many executives have made this assertion: "Seek multifunctional employees." My degree in music theory, with a minor in accounting principles, has given me understanding in two areas needed for your position as Assistant Business Manager.

Work Experience

Full- or part-time job responsibilities add valuable data to your resume cover letter. Suggest that in your responsibilities in previous jobs you

- Gained practical experience to accompany your education
- Adapted to different work environments
- Supervised other people with positive results
- Administered large expendable funds honestly and correctly
- Negotiated major tender offers with foreign suppliers

1. My internship with you during the past two summers made my decision easy: I'd like to be considered as a permanent employee of your product design area. As a result of that prior effort, I know CAD-CAM and all its derivatives, as well as detail work with the production people who manufacture the product.
2. Two summers at Raffles Place in Singapore-at the *[name of bank]*-honed my international financial skills. There we worked on bringing to market the Singapore Telecom stock and were in the process of planning a forthcoming sale of another major country utility. Such work experience is superb background for joining your international banking division.

Personal Attitudes, Interests, Activities, Qualities

Relating your personal attitudes, interests, activities, or personal qualities to the job requirements may also be included, as illustrated in the following examples.

Your Ability to Work with People

- Used good judgment in working with senior people.
- Known to be a conscientious listener to new members of the firm.
- Led student groups of various nationalities and cultural interests.
- Won applause for using good judgment with incomplete information.

Your Attitude Toward Employment

- Long have held an interest in *[functional area]*.
- Even in spare time I have devoted effort to furthering my interest in *[functional area]* as seen in the following examples.
- For a long time I have shown enthusiasm for this field; my intent is to make it my full-time occupation.

Simply listing your abilities is not enough; show how those abilities relate to the position for which you are applying.

■ Checklist 18.3 Cover Letter to Resume

1. Obtain favorable attention
 - a. Summary—Select two or three outstanding qualifications.
 - b. Name—Choose a known individual with whom the reader is familiar or the publication in which the reader's notice appeared.
 - c. Question—State one or two questions that suggest you are familiar with the company.
 - d. News item—Relate your opening comment to an item that appeared in the national press.
2. Give effort to data, details in the middle paragraphs
 - a. Education—Be truthful as to degrees, majors, and minors.
 - b. Work experience—Be precise about how previous experience trained you for the current position.
 - c. Personal attitudes, interests, activities, qualities: Relate, show how your qualities can improve your performance with the announced job.
3. Focus on easy action in the last paragraph
 - a. State when you are available on the phone or in person.
 - b. Ask if a local representative is in the area whom you could contact if the home office is extremely distant.

■ All my school teachers will quickly support my thesis that my readings, my papers, my outside interests have been devoted to *[functional area]*.

Your Personal Qualities

- My schooling was funded through scholarships and my own outside-of-school work *[determination]*.
- Each day was tightly planned in order to meet all commitments for the day *[organized, time control]*.
- Winning the undergraduate school investment award taught me the value of in-depth research before making a decision *[analytical mind]*.
- Two suggestions that led to completed projects were under my supervision *[initiative]*.

Last Paragraph—For Easy Action

In the final paragraph you ask for action; here, more than in other parts of your job application letter, use the first person singular "I." Some suggestions:

John Bitar

1247 Golden Rd., Apt. #3
Middleburg, VA 22117
May 15, 199-

Dr. John Hollowell, Superintendent
[City] High School Employment Services
[City, State, Zip]

Dear Dr. Hollowell:

In September, will one of your grade schools need a physical education instructor who can make learning realistic and interesting for students? If so, please consider me for the position. My qualifications include a degree in physical education and a minor in business subjects.

On June 10 this year I shall graduate from [School], where I did several things: played on the varsity basketball team, majored in physical education, and minored in business subjects. Several students and I also headed a three-week workshop on drug abuse; during that time we had outside speakers and two all-school convocations. If you are thinking about adding a special program on drug abuse, I will gladly give you my ideas about setting up such a program.

Three years of summer work have given me insights into the growing need for the kind of education needed by young people. My work with Opportunity Inc., Freedom Toys, and Mershon Investing added to my course work in physical education. Each of the above companies—after my work with them during the summer—contributed financially to the drug abuse seminar I mentioned above. Furthermore, my respective different positions in the above companies—handicap student assistant, product design assistant, and health care analysis assistant—developed my qualities of concern for young people

My student evaluations—summarized in the enclosed resume—suggest I have done well in teaching. So well that I have decided that grade school teaching will be my chosen career.

To discuss further your requirements and my qualifications, will you please grant me an interview? You can reach me during the evening hours at [Telephone] or during the day at [Fax]. Because your school district is within one day's driving distance, I could visit you at your convenience.

Sincerely,

John Bitar

Enclosure: Resume

Figure 18.5 A “cold call” job application letter to a school superintendent; this letter includes necessary information for a first-job application.

- Make the action easy.
- Be precise as to times you can be reached by phone.
- Include phone number, if you have an answering machine, and whether you are available by fax or E-mail.
- Suggest that it is possible for you to come to the employer's office.
- Ask for a local representative's name if the central office is extremely distant.

2039 Alhambra
Mt. Morris, MN 56099
January 29, 199-

Ms. Pauline Kwong, Senior Product Manager
Beverage Division
General Foods USA
250 North St.
White Plains, NY 10625

Dear Pauline:

Delightful is the way to describe our meeting of last week during our Finance Club mock interviews. Not only were your remarks to the club useful, but I personally got to speak with you about summer internship possibilities. Our discussion convinced me more than ever of my desire to pursue a career in product management.

As we discussed, my work with Wolverine Products (as an interim financial analyst) and at Stroh Brewery would allow me to make an immediate contribution. At Stroh's two other people and I were given the task of decreasing delivery costs over a four-state area. We were successful, decreasing costs by 2.8%.

Our school calendar suggests representatives from General Foods USA will be on campus in February. But because all places on your interview schedule have already been assigned via computer, I request inclusion on your closed interview list. At that time it would be a pleasure to meet your company's representative to go over my resume and to answer additional questions.

Please contact me if you need additional information. You can reach me at 507 123-4567 in the evenings, central time. I look forward to hearing from you soon.

Sincerely,

Michi Yamada

Figure 18.6 Sample of a job application letter written after an earlier contact was made. Letter is full block style.

Sample Letters of Application

The three application letters illustrated in Figures 18.5 through 18.7 apply suggestions made in this chapter. A description of each application letter is included below each figure.

SUMMARY

The first thing you should do in the job application process is pursue a self-assessment—that means knowing yourself. Take time to list your skills, accomplishments, and personal values as you and others see them.

Arnaud Desbans
Mühlacker Weg 2
6918 Neckarsteinach
Germany
12 April, 199-

Mr. Fritz Feuerstein, Senior Partner
Anderson Consulting
Am Seiteralle 6
4038 Frankfurt, Germany

Dear Mr. Feuerstein,

Are you looking for someone flexible enough to go from bartering chickens in a rural area of Borneo to conducting a market survey of Bulgaria for a leading Asian insurance company? If your response is yes, please consider adding me to your team of consultants helping to restructure industries in Eastern Europe.

Three years of developing and restructuring income generating products in Malaysia increased both my resourcefulness and perseverance. My largest hurdle was helping project participants understand both problems and solutions. Once that was understood, we were able to bring about change. While my world of work is in Asia, the problems facing former East block countries are more complex. Yet the dynamics of change are universal.

Consulting in Eastern Europe is the obvious career choice given my educational background, work experience, and personal interests. My degree will come from a top business school; my study in two languages (Chinese, German) will be used extensively; and my pioneering work in Malaysia will allow even more adaptability in the future.

Please refer to the accompanying documents for further details on my background. Please let me call you or contact you via Internet or fax during the week of April 22-26, 199-. If you desire to contact me prior to that time—in German or English—telephone (7-hour time difference) me evenings at 49 2345 678, fax 49 2134 456, or E-mail ades@neck.edu..

I look forward to your response.

Cordially,

Arnaud Desbans

Figure 18.7 A “cold call letter” in which the writer sought out the specific name of the foreign employer. Note the few uses of the first personal singular *I*, and the European accepted use of the “,” after the salutation. He also is considering a career change.

Thousands of companies and functional areas of work make up the world's workplace. Your school career counseling center or placement office is the place to start. Then move to reviewing some of the many written sources on careers and job information. Do not neglect to contact persons already in the field or persons who can likewise be helpful in landing a job.

■ Communication Probe

Casual studies abound as to what to include or exclude from resumes and cover letters to resumes. With the job market narrowing, what one includes in those two documents influences every employer, who according to some estimates, spends no more than 30 seconds on submitted documents. A recent summary of points to consider in the area of management accounting are the following: Apply to more than one company, use many avenues to search for job opportunity, lay out a strategy for your search, *give inordinate time to the resume and cover letter to make them error-free*, investigate the company thoroughly, establish rapport with a follow-up communication, search beyond the limits of your work experience, be flexible, and leave an interview with a positive and upbeat attitude.

Half, R. (1993, October). Managing your career. *Management Accounting*, 75, 12.

Edit, rewrite, review; have other persons look at the centerpiece of who you are: your resume. No agreed-upon organization for a resume and its content is forthcoming. Notwithstanding that comment, we recommend focusing on three central topics: a goal statement, education experience, and work experience.

Finally, this chapter focused on a second most important document: the cover letter to accompany your resume. Here too, edit, rewrite, review, and have other persons look at this piece of persuasive writing that seeks to obtain an interview for you. Likewise, give thought to three steps: the opening paragraph for getting favorable attention, the middle paragraphs for supply data and evidence, and the last paragraph for suggesting easy action.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. **Resume Comparisons.** This assignment demands contacting foreign students who are members of your classes. Its purpose is to suggest that there is no consistent way in which different cultures construct a resume—or what information is included. Before asking your foreign friends specific questions, have them review with you a traditional U.S. resume from your school. Then with several foreign students discuss and illustrate in writing answers to these questions:
 - Which information is included in resumes representative of their country?
 - What are the main headings of their resumes?
 - How important is personal information in those resumes?
2. **Cover Letter Comparisons.** As with the preceding assignment, this one too demands contact with several foreign students in your classes. Apply the

same three questions above to their cover letters to resumes. Again, bring in written examples for class discussion.

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Self-Assessment.** This assignment helps you structure your ideas for preparing both a resume and a cover letter to that resume. It forces thought on those qualities that make up your job search, similar to the topics noted in this chapter. (1) List your accomplishments under the headings of skills, accomplishments, interests, and personal values. (2) Insert a verb in front of each statement to give a high sense of action. For instance, “*Worked* toward meeting a B+ average in school classes in order to have a respectable average for college entrance.”
4. **Market Assessment.** This question seeks to have you analyze your potential interests in the job market. Use a similar structure to question 1, namely, headings of (1) functional areas in which you have a potential interest and (2) names or kinds of people who would be helpful to you in locating a job.
5. **Resume Preparation.** As an outgrowth of the two preceding questions, it is time to prepare a resume. Choose one of the organizational patterns discussed in this chapter in Figures 18.1 to 18.4. Your instructor may request that at least four different patterns occur for a comparison between them to be made. After the four patterns have been presented, which of the four do you find most persuasive and workable?
6. **Cover Letter Preparation.** Prepare the actual letter you would send to a prospective employer as based on the above resume. Assume that you will soon graduate; address is to the firm of your choice.
7. **Cover Letter Evaluations.** Following are two cover letters to go along with a resume. Explain orally in class which one is acceptable and would most likely get an interview. Which one is totally unacceptable?

Letter a. Application for a teaching job in history.

I'm graduating soon from college, where I majored in history. I like history and find that my career goals are in place to pursue that vocation.

I've learned that your school district is looking for history teachers, especially those students who majored in ancient history. I did. I enjoy it. I like the ancient world because some of the lessons from that day apply here as well.

My work experience is hard to relate to history, but I did spend my summers working in the school

library. There I catalogued books and worked at the sign-out desk. All that information is included on the enclosed resume.

I hope to hear from you soon. I know that my interests lie in the area of history and would fit into your school system. Please write me.

Letter b. Application for a product manager position.

Exercise bicycle. Step Master. Those two physical exercise machines were part of my last two summer's work here in [city]. Add that practical experience to my major in kinesiology and I feel I possess the qualifications you seek for an entry position in your company.

Your company reports suggest a continuing interest in and support for exercise equipment as a form of rehabilitative therapy. Both of the two machines above are currently extensively used in nursing homes and hospital exercise therapy units. And what makes the above statement more important is the fact that I demonstrated the exercise bicycle and Step Master at numerous health facilities. My resume suggests that physical exercise and overall well-being are a major part of my life-and will continue to be so.

Finally, my personal habits of meeting assignments on time while working outside of class can be verified by my teachers; they willingly would write letters on my behalf.

After you've reviewed this note and my enclosed resume, I would like to call you for an initial appointment during the week of October 21-25, 199-. Or, you could call me during the evenings at (313) 555-4567. My school has a fax in their placement department if you wish to send such a message: (313) 555-6789.

8. **Cold Call Letter.** Any cold call, verbally or in writing, is difficult. You have just a few seconds to capture the attention of your receiver. Go to your school library and locate an annual report of a company or one of their brochures, which may be in your placement office. Write a "cold call" letter inquiring about a possible job position.

The Job Application Process—Interviews and Follow-Up

I. Successful Preparation for the Job Interview

- A. Prior to the Interview
- B. Chronology of the Interview
- C. Activity During the Interview
- D. Answering or Asking Questions During the Interview

II. Successful Follow-Up Messages After the Interview

- A. Candidate to Employer (Eleven Sample Letters)
- B. Employer to Candidate (Seven Sample Letters)

III. Successful Negotiating

- A. Basic Preparation for Negotiating the Job Offer
- B. Basic Issues in Negotiating the Job Offer

IV. Summary

V. Exercises and Problems

VI. References

When Bonnie Dun, 20 years old, tried out for a teller's job at Great Western Bank in Chatsworth, California, she faced a lineup of big jerks.

One young woman sputtered contradictory instructions about depositing a check, then blew her top when the transaction wasn't handled fast enough. Another customer had an even shorter fuse. "You people are unbelievably slow," she said.

Both tough customers appeared on a computer screen, as part of a 20-minute job interview.¹

Some entry job positions are conducted electronically. Computers, some people argue, are not judgmental.

A computer interview? Yes, for some entry-level positions. Companies such as Nieman Marcus, Marriott, Corning, Foley's, American Express, and Walt Disney Company are among early users. Their argument: Computers are not judgmental; applicants are more honest with computers.

Need you as a graduate be fearful that your next interview will be conducted by a computer? We think not. At the managerial level there is less evidence that such electronic screening is extensively used. However, at the managerial level an electronic network of job announcements and job leads is growing nationally. Members of the three largest networks share information via an electronic mail system and published newsletters. Only after a contact is made with the listing company does the possibility of a face-to-face interview occur.²

This chapter discusses preparation before and behavior during an interview, follow-up messages to an interview from either the interviewee or interviewer, and preparation needed to successfully negotiate a job offer.

SUCCESSFUL PREPARATION FOR THE JOB INTERVIEW

Congratulations! Getting on the interview list of either an on-campus interviewer or at the company is an important first step. Your cover letter as a "sales" approach and your resume achieved their purpose. Now what?

Prior to the Interview

The following ideas from a New York Life Insurance Company booklet capture oft-repeated ideas on the significance of the interview.

The 20-30 minutes spent with an interviewer may determine the future course of one's life. Indeed, it is one of the most important events in the average person's experience. Strangely, some persons drift into interviews with scant preparation and only with the vaguest idea of what they are going to say. Too often the oral and nonverbal communication is "well, here I am."

Two other extremes also are present. On the one hand are those who are seemingly indifferent, casual, nonchalant, apathetic, detached, cool. Or, some are overprepared, overrehearsed, overnervous, overstimulated. Both may respond in a monotone, with monosyllables.

These marks of inexperience can destroy a promising interview. Some simple preparatory steps are in order.

Checklist 19.1 suggests 10 crucial points that can act as an initial guide to your prior-to-the interview preparation.

Chronology of the Interview

As with most communication instances, an interview also has an introductory period, a middle assessment period, and a concluding period.

There is no consistent pattern for job interviews; the following is typical. Also realize that many first interviews are just that: interviews to screen candidates for a possible second interview.

■ Checklist 19.1 Interview Preparation

1. *Know yourself.* Review the self-assessment document you created based on your skills, accomplishments, interests, and personal values.
2. *Know your resume.* Take at least two copies of your resume with you; know its contents cold.
3. *Know the company.* Review current CD-ROM databases, check either electronic or hard copy issues of the *Wall Street Journal*, *The New York Times*, *The Asian Wall Street Journal*, or other periodicals. What do you look for? Earnings, products, expansions, management changes, events—even problems.
4. *Know the position.* Prepare with your strongest qualifications if the job position is known. If the position is general, come with your personal qualifications well-rehearsed and known.
5. *Know some questions and answers.* Prepare some of your questions in advance. Try to anticipate some of your interviewer's questions—and your answers. A series of often-asked questions is on pages 536 and 537.
6. *Know that your nonverbal appearance communicates loudly.* This statement is not an overlooked mixed metaphor; it suggests that your clothing, your shoes, your jewelry, your lotion, your color choice, your grooming—all say something about you. When in doubt, be conservative in dress.
7. *Know that your oral delivery also communicates.* A monotone rarely holds attention. Oral variety in pitch, rate, and volume will help, as recommended in Chapter 14.
8. *Know the meeting place, time, and other details.* Arrive early; know the name of your interviewer.
9. *Know some basic salary ranges.* Avoid locked-in-stone positions on salary; initial interviews are not the place for negotiation sessions. But knowing possible salary ranges is advisable.
10. *Know that you must rehearse.* Mock interviews—with video playback—are recommended. Take advantage of your placement office's opportunity to rehearse, perhaps two times: for ideas, for oral and nonverbal appearance, for the first few minutes of the interview.

■ Communication Probe

One may make the best preparation possible for an interview. Yet, there are companies that search specifically for an employer-employee fit, that decision being made toward the end of the interview process—often at the end of the second interview. What interviewees must know, however, is that some search firms advise their clients to first consider internal candidates for job positions; that lowers the risk of a bad hire. The argument is made that all job candidates try to show themselves in a positive light; a company just knows more about an internal candidate than an outside one.

Adkins, C. L., Russell, C. J., & James, D. (1994, Autumn). Judgments of fit in the selection process: The role of work value congruence. *Personnel Psychology*, 47, 605–623; Overman, S. (1994, September). Hiring: The inside track. *HR Magazine*, 39, 54–57.

Introduction (about 2 to 5 minutes)

- Interviewer seeks to put candidate at ease: chitchat, casual talk about personal information on resume.
- Candidate tries to make positive up-front impression: smile, handshake, sense of enthusiasm.

Company Information (about 5 to 10 minutes)

- Interviewer may indicate type of positions available, some information about the company.
- Candidate suggests a high degree of interest in the company, in the position.

Candidate Assessment (about 10 to 20 minutes)

- Interviewer tries to assess the qualifications of the candidate: What are his or her strengths and weaknesses?
- Candidate employs data, evidence: via goals, skills, accomplishments, interests, and personal values. Relates these data to skills learned in school and the world of work.
- Questions: during this period a variety of questions, challenges, testing of the candidate occurs. Possible questions are on pages 536 and 537 of this chapter.

Conclusion (about 1 or 2 minutes)

- Interviewer determines ending to interview: suggests when an answer will be forthcoming.
- Candidate tries to: summarize his or her qualifications, reaffirm interest in the company and position, and express appreciation for the interview.

Activity During the Interview

Both oral and nonverbal cues are important in the early part of an interview.

Some points in the above chronology apply here. Significantly, the first few moments are critical. Make eye contact immediately, begin courteously, show en-

■ Checklist 19.2 Positive and Negative Behavior During an Interview

Positive, Desirable Behavior

1. *Show enthusiasm, vitality, interest.* You can do so by the alert way you sit and look, by facial expressions, by the questions you ask, and by the answers you give.
2. *Be honest.* State your data clearly, without exaggeration.
3. *Listen attentively, concentrate.* Do not interrupt. Let the interviewer finish. Then try to link your achievements with your answer.
4. *Keep answers brief.* The more answers you provide, the more varied the information you can give about yourself.
5. *Show interest in the company.* Here, too, tactfully relate your achievements to your future employer's needs.
6. *Show analytical skills.* Organize your answers, take time to comment on both pros and cons, short- and long-term benefits.

Negative Factors to Avoid

1. *Discourtesy.* Avoid first names, doodling, disinterest.
2. *Jargon, slang.* This is not the time to project an image that you are hip, cool, or tuned in to the jargon of youth.
3. *Overaggressive or cynical attitude.* Avoid the superiority complex and "know-it-all" attitude.
4. *Unfavorable comments.* Focus on the positive. Omit criticisms of former professors, colleagues, other employers.
5. *Disregard for positive factors.* If you put the words "failure to" before each of the six suggestions for positive behavior, you will have a total of 11 in this list of negatives to avoid.

thusiasm, give a firm handshake. To make the best impression—verbal and non-verbal—be aware of some commonsense positive and negative behavior as noted in Checklist 19.2.

Answering or Asking Questions During the Interview

It is hard to predict which questions will occur in your interview or even the time of day for your meeting. Each interviewer has a set of favorite questions, and the time of day may be set by the school or according to the convenience of the company. Time periods are as variable as the kinds of questions asked. Our list of 25 favorite questions and statements is a composite from many sources:

1. Where do you expect to be in 5 years?
2. Give me a list of your strengths and weaknesses.

■ Communication Probe

Interviewees should feel encouraged: In a study of over 800 employee performance interviews, there was no correlation between the time of day for the applications and the ratings of those applicants. Likert scales, used in the study, verified the conclusion noted above. And as other studies have noted, preparation on the part of the interviewee, regardless of the time of the day, is more important. For instance, one researcher suggests that financial management people will face these five tough questions: How can the candidate help the organization and increase its revenue? Which goals did the candidate set in the last job and how were they achieved? What opinion does the candidate have of a vice president who requests more money for employees? In which area is personal improvement still needed? How is the candidate preparing for impending reform in the industry?

Willihnganz, M. A., & Myers, L. S. (1993, Winter). Effects of time or day on interview performance. *Public Personnel Management*, 22(4), 545–550; Reticker, P. (1993, September). The five toughest interview questions. *Healthcare Financial Management*, 47(9), 82–84.

3. When have you successfully motivated others over whom you had no authority or power?
4. What do you think it takes to be successful in this position?
5. Why should we hire you rather than someone else?
6. Tell me about your work experience. What did you accomplish?
7. What typical role did you play in your school groups? What evidence do you have for that statement?
8. Give me three reasons why you are interested in our company.
9. How well do you work with teams and other people; what evidence do you have that you were successful in a group?
10. How is the job search going? Who else have you spoken with?
11. Which course did you like best? Least? Why?
12. If you were starting your schooling over, which courses would you add to your program?
13. Describe the kind of boss you prefer.
14. What personal characteristics are necessary for success in your field?
15. Give me an example of a situation which upset you in either your school or your place of work.
16. What do you know about our company?

17. Do you prefer working alone or with others?
18. Which of your college years was the most difficult?
19. Can you get recommendations from all your previous employers?
20. Do you like routine work?
21. Define cooperation for me.
22. Give me an example of an analytical mind.
23. What was the last book you read?
24. What is your major weakness?
25. What are the disadvantages of your chosen field?

Regardless of your preparation, there will be some unexpected questions. Pause, try to organize your answer, and then offer it with a high degree of confidence. You could also refer to your resume, using it as support for your oral comments.

“Bridging” Confrontational and Unfair Preemployment Questions

Be careful in handling questions that you feel border on being discriminatory or confrontational.

Most interviews—both the initial screening interview and a later follow-up with more people—will be direct. The questions will sincerely seek information related to the job. Occasionally, to test your poise under pressure, you may receive a confrontational question; you also may be asked an unfair preemployment inquiry that may be illegal if used for discrimination.

Confrontational Questions

Some interviewees have returned from interviews wilted. They allege that the interviews were confrontational, that the interviewers were abusive, abrupt, and discourteous. However, the interviewers may have been testing the applicants' confidence under pressure, how they handled a tense situation. Tough questions should not necessarily be considered a personal attack.

Preparing for some tough interview questions is similar to preparing for a TV interview. Leading executives spend considerable time and effort preparing for potentially hostile questions, using some of the same techniques you can use in your interview. Try to rehearse or hold a short mock interview for potentially negative questions. Try to bridge to a response that keeps you in control. The key word here is “bridge,” using terms such as the following to move from a confrontational question to a more positive response:

- “There may be some truth in that statement [*bridge*], but my data and information lead to a different conclusion.”
- “Certainly others have the right to their opinion [*bridge*]. My opinion is this . . .”
- “That’s an interesting comment [*bridge*]. A more complete analysis would include information discovered in my investigations.”

In each case, you bridge to information you wish to speak about, avoiding a direct confrontation with a potentially negative and hostile question. Here are a few other questions that require tactful, honest answers:

Question

“How come your grades are lower than average?”

“Some people feel M.B.A.s are arrogant and only concerned with the buck.”

“What’s your greatest weakness?”

Answer

“What the grades do not reflect are the nonclassroom leadership positions I held on several committees. Also, to help pay college expenses I worked on part-time jobs—as shown in my resume.”

“That attitude, I know, is held by some people, including the press. In my opinion we cannot put all M.B.A. degree candidates into the same mold. . . .”

“I approach everything I do with a great deal of enthusiasm. But out of my love for work comes a bit of impatience. May I give you a complete incident . . . ?”

Even with the negative, risky question about your weakness, you can focus on the positive—determination to improve your strong qualities further—or perhaps mention a non-job-related trait that needs improvement. It is desirable for you to try to turn a potentially negative situation into a positive one.

Unfair Preemployment Questions

Laws in the United States prohibit employment questions that discriminate on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, handicaps, and national origins. (Appendix C is a discussion of fair and unfair preemployment questions relating to 19 topics.) Nevertheless, if you are asked an “unfair preemployment question,” you

■ Communication Probe

As you have prepared for the interview, including both friendly and unfriendly questions, so too has your interviewer. Some interviewers come with a prepared list of questions. Some do the following: (1) They search for qualifiers, such as “knowledge of”; (2) they try not to read more into a resume than is there; and (3) they search for signs of self-reliance and initiative. Additionally, some interviewers actually write in advance the kind of answer to be expected from their questions; the authors call this an additional test of the candidate.

Hackney, M., & Kleiner, B. (1994, November). Conducting an effective selection interview. *Work Study*, 43, 8–13.

may answer it if doing so will not be disadvantageous to you. If your reply could hurt your chances of getting a job, tactfully decline answering.

Questioning the Interviewer

Preparing a few of your own questions in advance is a sure sign to the interviewer that you are organized and interested in the position.

A sure sign that the interview is coming to a close is when the interviewer asks if you have any questions. We recommend preparing several in advance. But it's your call what those specific questions might be, as for example:

- What kind of person fits in with your company?
- Give me a little information about why the last person in the position left.
- For a person who works effectively in this job, what is the next step in the advancement process?

And so on. One final comment. If you do not get a job offer, do not discuss salary or fringes. However, if you are offered a position on the spot, that is the time to discuss salary and fringes. We discuss the issue of negotiating beginning on page 552.

SUCCESSFUL FOLLOW-UP MESSAGES AFTER THE INTERVIEW

Following any interview, immediately jot down some notes of the meeting, for instance, in reference to some of the following:

- What were some significant facts you learned about the company?
- Which questions did you have trouble answering?
- Which of your own selling points did you leave out?
- How well do you feel you did in the interview?

Candidate to Employer (Eleven Sample Letters)

To improve your chances for securing the job for which you interviewed, we recommend you contact the interviewer in person, by letter, by phone, or E-mail. Of the three approaches, the letter is the most effective because employers analyze applicants' qualifications at their convenience. A well-written letter—if done successfully—can strengthen your chances of obtaining the position.

The Initial Follow-Up to an Interview

Regardless of how the interview went, it is courteous and in your interest to write the interviewer a note of thanks.

Remember that your interviewer may have spoken with many people; your task is to keep yourself, although out of sight, not out of mind. Within 2 to 5 days after the interview, send a thank-you note. Such a thank-you note is short, probably no longer than four paragraphs. See Checklist 19.3 for a summary of major points.

After reading the checklist, review the following two examples. Note the brevity of each, the careful attention to courtesy and politeness.

■ Communication Probe

An interesting ethical/legal issue arises when an interviewee desires to see some of the resumes of current employees. He or she may allege they have nothing but honorable intentions: to seek additional sources in order to make an informed decision as to whether to join a firm or not. Survey data suggest that one-half of the current managers had no problem with exposing their resumes to job seekers; others objected because they felt it was an invasion of their privacy. The researchers conclude that viewing resumes might give the job seekers a stronger negotiating position and help them decide on their job choice.

Pesek, J. G., & Fulmer, W. E. (1991, Summer). The flip side of recruitment, allow job candidates to view current employees' resumes. *Journal of Applied Business Research*, 7, (3), 1-7.

MESSAGE 1 Sample of a foreign student's response. *Note the subtle style (extreme courtesy) differences in this letter from western letters.*

Dear Mr. Salaam,

Attention opening

Informative, enjoyable exciting. Those words capture the pleasure I had yesterday in interviewing for the position of Construction Management Assistant in [company name]. Thank you for your personal courtesies.

Review of related job experience

My enthusiasm for the position and the company continues, today more than ever. As I reviewed your future strategic plan, there is no doubt that exploration for new deposits in Latin America will continue. That pleases me because my previous work in Indonesia-as you know for a gold mining firm-has parallels in difficulty and opportunities. My work background in my former field has prepared me well for work in your emerging and growing field.

Review of academic training

As my resume indicates, I went to college in the U.K. That preparation exposed me to the English language which I had to learn for six years in my grade school. I mention that because learning languages has been comfortable for me. Thus, learning Spanish seems like a small hurdle on the way to beginning a successful Construction Manager. With eagerness I would immediately begin my study of Spanish.

■ Checklist 19.3 Initial Follow-Up After an Interview

1. *Opening paragraph:* Express appreciation and gratitude for having been granted the interview.
2. *Middle paragraphs:* Any or all of the following ideas can be incorporated into the middle of the note.
 - a. State how you now feel about the position.
 - b. Add new material that may have been omitted or left out.
 - c. Include some new facts if you sensed the interviewer's concern about certain of your qualifications.
 - d. Mention your favorable reaction to some points mentioned in the interview.
 - e. Highlight the qualifications discussed in the interview.
3. *Last paragraph:*
 - a. Offer to send any additional information.
 - b. Suggest that you are willing to come to a second interview.
 - c. Indicate that you feel your qualifications fit the job requirements.
 - d. Mention you're looking forward to a favorable decision.

Courteous close

Mr. Salaam, you will find, I believe, that I can develop into one of your senior Construction Managers. That is my personal goal. With eagerness I would welcome that opportunity.

Yours Faithfully,

MESSAGE 2

A sample BBA letter after an interview. *The position here is for the position of a hospital's Senior Gift Coordinator.*

Dear Ms. Lawson:

Polite, direct opening

Your interview with me on February 2 regarding the position of Small Gifts Coordinator was appreciated. You also requested that I get two persons from my university to send a letter of support. I therefore have asked Professor Wayne Stume of our Accounting Department and Ms. Timmie Mead of the University's Donor's Office to send you a note within

■ Communication Probe

As U.S. colleges and universities more carefully prepare their students for more global interactions, there are more opportunities for those students to interview for jobs with foreign companies. Indeed, several years ago (1990) the U.S. Department of Labor estimated that foreign companies employed more than 4.7 million people in the United States. Thus, whether one will work for that foreign company abroad or in the United States requires—according to one researcher—raising issues such as the following: the company's motivations, the extent of travel, the goals of the foreign company in the United States. One of the best ways to determine the foreign company's motivations is to speak with Americans already working within that company.

Ellis, N. (1993, Fall). The American, an alien in a foreign country? *Baylor Business Review*, 11, 30–31.

the next few days. Both were eager to do so.

Addition of new facts

Omitted in our discussion was the fact that I also ushered at university fund-raising events. These occasions brought me into contact with many donors who have contributed to our various schools and colleges. There I learned from senior fund-raisers about organization, tact, politeness, all ingredients needed in your position of Small Gifts Coordinator.

Review of personal capabilities

With pleasure I noted that you mentioned the position demanded close contacts with the city. My Rotary Scholarship and my local church scholarship both demanded reports to several groups within the city. Both groups spoke highly of my presentations and both offered me financial support. My resume also indicates that I was born in this city; that fact along with my family's long ties here suggest my deep commitment to remaining in this area.

Polite, easy action ending

I look forward to your favorable decision. You will, I assure you, be pleased with my work.

Letters do get lost in the mails; feel free to inquire if you did not receive a response to your cover letter and resume.

The Inquiry About a Cover Letter and Resume

You are justified in sending a follow-up note if after 3 weeks you have received no response to a request or cold job application letter. Such a letter may have been lost, or it may be the intent of the receiver not to respond—as in some Pa-

cific Rim countries, where a forthright negative response is avoided. Regardless of the motivation, you have the right to inquire.

Such an inquiry letter is short. You simply ask, "Did you receive my letter and resume?" Of course you could include identification of the job, the date of your cover letter and accompanying resume, your continuing interest in the position, highlights of the previous letter, and your address, telephone, fax number, or E-mail. Both the following letters move deductively, the core idea occurring up front.

MESSAGE 3 Short inquiry about previously sent cover letter and resume. *This example identifies and reviews date of earlier communication.*

Dear Mr. Tong,

Direct request

My notes tell me that I sent you a letter and resume for the position of Account Executive on October 21, 199-. My interest in the position still remains strong. My inquiry is whether you received this material.

Willingness to send more data

If you do not have any of my material in your file, I will be pleased to send you additional and updated information. Certainly I could come in for an interview whenever you suggest.

MESSAGE 4 Short inquiry letter about earlier sent cover letter and resume. *This example reviews date of earlier communication and goes further by summarizing the qualifications of the applicant.*

Dear Ms. Steffie:

Opening gives precise dates

Things have a way of getting lost in the mails; perhaps that's what happened to my cover letter and resume sent you on July 25, 199-. My notes were in response to the vacancy of Executive Secretary posted in the *Tribune* of July 20, 199-.

In those materials I noted these points:

Summary of earlier note

- Knowledge of Word Perfect, Windows, and Multimate software packages.
- Work in several offices with several kinds of PCs.
- Employment as a staff secretary for a vice president at a local electric utility.
- Arranger of many private and public functions for executive officers and the Board of Directors.

Polite close

With those qualifications and others mentioned in my resume, I know I could fulfill the position of executive secretary. If you wish further information, I would be pleased to respond.

Other Follow-Up Messages from Applicant to Employer

MESSAGE 5 Request to keep information on file. *Such a note is usually sent when you are told there is no current vacancy for the position you seek.*

Dear Mr. Wilson:

**Polite request
for future opportunity**

Thank you for reviewing my credentials for the position of Food and Beverage Manager.

Please do this: keep my records on file. While I know there is currently no open position, there may be that opportunity in the future. At that time I would like to be considered.

Thank you for your courtesy.

MESSAGE 6 Reply to letter requesting additional information. *This example concerns a request for information about school records, especially the low grades in certain courses.*

Dear Ms. Lim:

Here is my response to your request as to why certain grades were lower than average in my courses in voice theory and music theory.

**Responses for
variances**

Enclosed with my explanation is a letter from my voice theory professor. She points out—as you will see in reading the letter—that only in one area of theory did I have a weakness, and that was corrected during a special make-up class during the summer. To be honest, I just blew the exam question when it was given. I knew that, and made quick arrangements for the special summer class.

Truthful**Additional explanation**

The class in music theory is another story. With honesty I must say that the semester in which I took the course, I came down with a severe case of mono. That sounds like a trivial excuse, but the illness took me out of school for two

weeks, with lingering effects for several weeks thereafter. Fortunately, other courses that followed that course, and that depended on music theory, were much improved.

In brief, in both instances I was aware of needed improvements—and took steps to achieve them. Such determination, I assure you, would continue in my desire to work in the music program of your school system.

MESSAGE 7 Follow-up letter if no reply occurs after interview. *Give an adequate amount of time (perhaps two weeks) for a response. But if you do not receive a response by a promised date, you can write.*

Polite reminder Two-and-a-half weeks have passed since my interview with you about the position of Small Business Loan Officer. At that time you said you'd notify me of your decision by [date].

Continued interest Sadly, I have not heard from you. In the meantime another savings institution has expressed deep interest in my joining their firm. Before giving them a response, I would like to know whether you have reached a decision on my candidacy for your position.

Continued interest My personal desire is to work for your savings institution. And I'd like a reply before [date]. You can reach me during the daytime at [number] and in the evenings at [number].

MESSAGE 8 Request to delay a decision. *Occasionally you need more time to accept or reject a job offer; be forthright in requesting a delay.*

Positive opening I'm honored that you have extended a job offer to me. Such a positive response has put excitement in my life, and certainly in our family.

Appeal to fairness Your request that I arrive at a job decision within the next two weeks is difficult for me. Forthrightly, I must say that promises to two other firms—made at the same time I agreed to meet with you—to interview with them makes it impossible to respond within your time frame. It would be unfair to all parties if my word cannot be trusted.

Precise action desired I ask for an extension of two weeks from your requested date. Please let me know if that extension of time is possible. I would be grateful for a positive response to my request.

MESSAGE 9 Acceptance of job offer. *Although this is an easy letter to write, keep in mind that certain details need to be mentioned: Identify the job you're accepting; give details about moving, about reporting to work; request any forms required for salary and benefits; end with a statement of pleasure in working for the firm. A follow-up phone call also verifies what is mentioned in the letter.*

Immediate decision statement With pleasure I accept the position of Sales Trainee in your [name] Department.

Details Since I graduate on June 6, 199-, my spouse and I plan to be in your city one month later, July 6, 199-. We plan to take a two-week vacation and to locate living accommodations in [city]. I will report to work on Monday, July 7. This note simply confirms what we discussed orally when I accepted your offer.

Agreement statement May I also confirm that our agreed-upon year's salary was \$[amount] and that additional health and insurance forms will be sent me at my address noted above.

Polite close With sincere pleasure I look forward to joining your company. Such a challenge is accepted with enthusiasm.

MESSAGE 10 Message of resignation from present position. *Ideally, your current employer would have been contacted prior to your sending any resignation letter. It is recommended to date the resignation letter at least two weeks before your departure.*

Early statement of decision This note confirms that I will be accepting the position of Assistant Engineer in International Products in [city]. My reporting date to that firm will be on September 4. Please consider my resignation to be effective as of August 16.

Positive details Certainly you can count on me to assist my successor in every way. And even after leaving the company, should there be any additional questions, I will be happy to reply.

Positive ending Personally, as I have told you, my wife and I have been pleased with [name of

company]. We have spent six fruitful years here; we leave with mixed feelings for our many friends. Thank you for your concern and interest over the years.

MESSAGE 11 Rejection of job offer. *Usually the organization of a rejection-of-job letter is buffer, explanation, refusal, and a positive ending. In the following example note the tactful tone, sincerity, positive approach, and genuine compliment to the firm.*

Dear Ms. Ong:

Buffer

You have been consistently helpful to me during the last series of interviews with your company. For that I'm personally grateful.

Buffer plus details

As you know, I've been speaking with other firms over the past couple of months. Fortunately, both you and another firm have offered me a job. Because my qualifications, interest, and background fit in more closely with the other job, I have sent them my acceptance.

Positive ending

In no way does my decision reflect a negative impression of you or your company. You took time to meet with me, and you were gracious in answering all my questions. I'll consistently think of you as a company where management is concerned with people.

Thank you for your consideration.

Employer to Candidate (Seven Sample Letters)

Employers or interviewers face similar decisions: What kind of communication to send the candidate after an interview.

There may be a time when you will be on the other side of the interviewing process: You will have to communicate with the interviewee. Several instances of such communication are now noted.

MESSAGE 1 Invitation to interviewee to visit company. *A major intent, clearly, of a request to interview is to make the reader feel he or she is desired for a personal interview.*

Dear Mr. Harris:

Clearly opening request

This note confirms my telephone call of Thursday, April 6, inviting you to visit

with us in our company facilities at our head office on April 15.

Details

In order for us to make arrangements for your visit and plans for meeting several other persons on the staff, we ask that you return the enclosed card or fax us a response at (313) 555-8824.

Details

Certainly you will receive reimbursement for all air travel to [city] and return, as well as for all incidental expenses. If you have questions, you can call my secretary (Ms. Jody Hannecker) at (313) 555-1277.

Courteous close

We sincerely look forward to your visit on April 15.

MESSAGE 2 Invitation for a company visit after initial campus interview. *In the popular language of campuses, these second requests for attending an interview are referred to as “fly backs.”*

Dear Arlene:

As you know, other members of my office and I were on your campus Thursday and Friday of last week.

Up-front request

With pleasure we invite you to visit with us at our company headquarters in [city] on Tuesday, June 16, to continue our discussions. Our initial plans would have you beginning your visit at 9:00 a.m. in my office to set out the agenda for the day.

Details

Such a plan means you would have to arrive by the evening of June 15. Therefore, we have reservations for you at the Park Plaza Hotel; all airport cabs know the location of that hotel.

Details

It's your decision whether you wish to return to your hometown after our meetings on June 16. Our plan is to conclude our meetings around 4:00 p.m. on that day.

We look forward to meeting with you.

These two letters illustrate the kinds of messages sent to candidates to visit the company, but there are five other kinds of notes you might write after an interview. As the candidate is polite in his or her notes, so too you must be polite in

requesting further information, offering a position, granting a time extension, rejecting a candidate, and replying to a candidate's acceptance.

MESSAGE 3 Request for further information. *Even though cover letters have been sent and resumes completed, additional questions may arise out of that printed information.*

Dear Marilyn:

Warm, courteous opening

Your resume was quite complete and we enjoyed the brief phone conversation. Still, there are a few questions to which we'd like some answers.

You can respond to the following two questions, either via fax or a brief note:

Precise listing of issues

-Tell us more about your summer visits to Argentina. Were these visits school-related? Work-related? Casual visits?
-We'd like to know some of the major topics discussed in your English Language Institute Training sessions. Were you the instructor or a member of the class?

We thank you for your continuing interest in [name of firm]; we look forward to hearing from you within the next week.

MESSAGE 4 Offer of a job. *Clearly, this is a comfortable letter to write: It brings good news. In the opening paragraph identify the job and state the salary. In later paragraphs, you might try to anticipate any questions the candidate might have. Also, you could leave the door open for the candidate to ask further questions (usually via phone) before making a decision. Be precise by when you need an answer.*

Dear Mr. Lipnick:

Positive first news

With pleasure we offer you the position of assistant legal counsel in our firm at a yearly starting salary of \$[amount], that position to begin November 1, 199-.

Elaboration of details

We will pay all moving expenses associated with your move, and a member of our Human Resources Department will assist you in locating housing.

Thank you for the interest you already have shown in our company. We hope you

will decide to make your career with us. If you or members of your family have questions concerning our offer or other questions, please call Ms. Dee Rant in our personnel office at (123) 555-4586. She, or a member of her staff, will respond to any further questions.

We sincerely hope you will join us for a rewarding career.

MESSAGE 5 Grant of a time extension. *Sound reasons are valid for you to consider in extending more time to consider an offer. Often such discussions are held over the phone. However, if you write a note, grant the request in the first paragraph, suggest the cutoff date, express interest in the candidate, and end on a friendly note.*

Dear Pauline:

**Early statement
granting re-
quest**

As you asked, we will grant you additional time to decide whether you want to accept our previous offer to work with us. We wish you to know, however, that you continue to be our most desired person to fulfill the position of Purchasing Manager.

**Precision on
date**

We need to know your decision as soon as possible. To be precise, we would like your response by June 15, just about three weeks from now.

Warm ending

Again, you are well qualified for our open position. Our management staff eagerly looks forward to your positive response.

Please call me at (123) 555-7899 if you have additional questions.

MESSAGE 6 Message conveying decision not to hire. *Here the tone of your refusal is important, for you do not wish the candidate to leave with a negative impression of the company. All candidates desire factual, straightforward answers; this is not the time for falsehoods or discourteous statements. Your organization is that of a bad-news letter. Begin with a buffer, suggest an explanation, state the refusal, and end with a wish for the candidate's success.*

Dear Mr. Slovack:

Buffer

Thank you for spending time with us at the on-campus interview and here at our company.

Buffer plus explanation

Your credentials are impressive, your educational background is first-rate, and your aptitude scores were high, along with the other candidates we interviewed. Our staff feels one of the other candidates' qualifications would more closely fit in with our requirements.

Positive comment

That preceding statement is not a negative. It simply suggests you have admirable qualifications, but at this time we need a closer fit between previous experience and the open position.

Courteous close

Please accept our gratitude for the time you spent with us. We sincerely wish you success in your chosen field.

MESSAGE 7 Reply to candidate's acceptance. *This is an easy note to write: It is all good news, it is all positive, it is short. It is a brief statement that allows for a paper trail, a legal recognition that you have received the candidate's acceptance letter.*

Dear Ulga:

Positive opening

Vielen Dank! All of us are pleased that you have agreed to join us in Rüsselsheim at the [name of foreign company].

Additional good news

One additional surprise: We have agreed to pay for a visit to Germany for you and your spouse in order that both of you can begin a housing search in this area. Ms. Helga Brewer-Special Assistant to our Aufsichtsrat will contact you by phone to make all those special arrangements.

We look forward to your joining us.

SUCCESSFUL NEGOTIATING

Being personally satisfied, being at ease with a compromise is a valuable lesson in negotiation.

As the following probe suggests, take time to review the salary and benefits package of comparable positions before you begin an interview. Most often on a college campus no financial details are confirmed in an initial meeting; that comes later, usually after a second interview and if you receive a job offer.

Most likely the individual who was the lead interviewer of the human resource manager will first make an oral offer. Remember, this is only the first step. Usually such a verbal (oral) offer mentions the starting salary, a signing bonus (if any), the job title, basic benefits, and possibly the person to whom you will report and a suggested starting date. The person making this initial verbal offer then has the responsibility of sending a formal, written description of the offer.

■ Communication Probe

As with preparing the cover letter, the resume, and the interview, similar effort must also go into the job negotiation process. To come in cold into an interview—with little preconception of salary or benefits—is to risk losing a position. Lawyers and law firms are especially adept at negotiation; they realize the value of research, facts, and investigation in order to prove and justify any decision. Such preparation is needed by everyone in the negotiation process. Several suggestions are recommended: Let the interviewer mention the salary issue first, be aware that a lower salary offer implies negotiation is in order, realize that benefits are a part of the salary package, and establish a firm date for resolving the salary issue. Furthermore, candidates should approach negotiation with a win-win attitude; they will have a better chance of success.

Estrin, C. (1992, May/June). Negotiating salaries: the undeclared war. *Legal Assistant Today*, 9, 136–139.

Basic Preparation for Negotiating the Job Offer

Spend time in gathering comparative financial and benefit information in order to present your most forceful arguments for your position.

The more data you possess prior to negotiating, the better equipped you will be for arriving at a package desirable to you—and acceptable to your new employer. Sources for your information will vary. We believe it is easier to locate information about job salaries in the United States than in other parts of the world where salary information is highly confidential. Word of mouth and frank talk with human resource personnel overseas can dislodge some hidden comparative salary and benefit information for Asia and Europe.

Regardless of your location, collect as much valid (not hearsay) information as possible before making a final decision. Sources to which you might turn include the following:

- 1. Alumni, fellow classmates. Be sure you have true evidence. Have a clear idea as to ranges for various positions.
- 2. Placement reports. Most large business schools publish employment data from the previous year's class. The following is simply a listing of major headings used in the University of Michigan's Business School Office of Career Development; headings are identical for a section on full-time positions and a section on internship positions:

The University of Michigan Business School 199- Overview

199- Michigan MBA Profile and Review

Acceptances by Industry (13 major service and manufacturing categories)

<u>Service</u>	<u>Median Salary</u> (\$ for each category)	<u>Salary Range</u> (\$ ranges for each category)
----------------	--	--

<u>Manufacturing</u>	<i>Median Salary</i> (\$ for each category)	<i>Salary Range</i> (\$ ranges for each category)
----------------------	--	--

Acceptances by Function (21 major categories)

<i>Median Salary</i>	<i>Salary Range</i>
----------------------	---------------------

Acceptances by Geographic Region (8 national/international locations)

<i>Median Salary</i>	<i>Salary Range</i>
----------------------	---------------------

Acceptances by Undergraduate Degree (7 major degree categories)

<i>Median Salary</i>	<i>Salary Range</i>
----------------------	---------------------

Companies Hiring 3 or more MBA Students

3. Your own resume. Be prepared to cite your own credentials for the position: Review your related work experience, your academic achievements relevant to the position, your special skills.
4. *National Business Employment Weekly*. Go to your library or your placement office and ask to see printed data for various sections of the country. Therein you will see headings as cost-of-living comparisons between various U.S. cities; city-by-city index of costs; local and state tax burdens; estimated major taxes for a family of four; and sources of articles relating to salaries in various functional areas.

The *National Business Employment Weekly* is a "must read" document prior to beginning a negotiating session.

Basic Issues in Negotiating the Job Offer

Unless some of the following issues were discussed in the interviews, you have every right to be clear on issues such as the following, depending on the level at which you enter the company:

1. Your total compensation package
 - a. Cash issues
 - Starting base pay and salary range of position
 - Bonus for signing (if any) and how paid
 - Stock options (if any) or profit sharing or other payments
 - Salary review schedule
 - Percent of salary matched by the firm
 - b. Fringe or other benefits issues
 - Vacation payments, length of vacations
 - Car, auto expenses
 - Club memberships
 - Health care issues: long-term disability, accident insurance, dental plan, death benefits, sick leave, health insurance, and persons covered by insurance
 - Discounts on purchase of employer products
 - Life insurance
 - Recreation programs

2. Your position

Extent of your authority, members of your staff
 Statement of your precise responsibilities
 Individual to whom you will report
 Range of your budget
 Title of the position

3. Your work environment

What is the precise location of my job?
 What are the expected hours of work during the day and week?
 What are the resources, supplies, facilities?
 What is the work culture of the company?
 What is the business language of the company? (More an issue if the company is located overseas)

4. Your beginning/ending work benefits

Starting date of the new position
 Housing assistance: disposal of former residence and acquiring another
 Relocating assistance from current to new location: travel, moving charges (highly important when working with an employer overseas)

If at all possible, carry out negotiations orally. Submitting something in writing is fine, but your oral and non-verbal behavior is also persuasive.

It is more desirable to carry out your negotiations orally rather than in writing. Doing so gives you the power of both oral and nonverbal persuasion to accompany your credentials. Some people would have you believe there is a set formula for negotiating success, but it is not that simple. Be fair; listen to the other side; come prepared with arguments for your position. Have your facts straight; know in advance your top or bottom final position.

■ Checklist 19.4 Successfully Negotiating a Job Offer

1. *Prepare carefully:* Gather information from alumni, friends, placement reports, your own resume, and national publications as *The National Business Employment Weekly*.
2. *Know specific data:* Collect reliable information about the median and range of salaries in your functional area, your industry, and even your geographic area of the country.
3. *Organize negotiating plan into four parts:*
 - a. Compensation issues as cash and fringe benefits
 - b. Position within the company
 - c. Environment of the company
 - d. Beginning and ending of work benefits

If you feel you are being hurried into a decision, negotiate immediately for an extension of time. It is better to delay a decision rather than to rush into one that you later will regret. Once a decision is made on the final offer, send your acceptance immediately.

SUMMARY

Of all the things you will experience in life, few surpass the importance of the job interview; a successful one can literally position you on a career path for the rest of your life. Remember these 10 points: Know yourself, your resume, the company, the job position, some questions and answers, the importance of both oral and nonverbal communication, the meeting details, basic salary ranges, and the need to rehearse.

After the interview, it is good policy to write a thank-you note. Later, if you have not had any response as based on the interview, you have every right to send a follow-up letter. Additionally, the chapter offered basic letters for reference: requesting a company to keep information on file, replying to questions for additional information, sending follow-up notes if there was no reply after an interview, asking for a delay in a job decision, accepting an offer, resigning from one's present position, and rejecting a job offer.

Employers also need to send follow-up messages to job candidates. These include invitations to visit a company for an initial interview, requests to visit the company on a "fly back" after a campus interview, inquiries to candidates for additional information, suggestions for the basic salary package along with the job, responses to a request for additional time in making a decision, agreements to a time extension, words that gracefully convey a decision not to hire someone, and replies to a candidate's acceptance.

If all your preparations for landing a job were successful, one final stage has to be realized: negotiating your final compensation package. Here—as in preparing your cover letter, writing your resume, or interviewing—prepare carefully. Know salary ranges, medians, benefits for your functional area, your industry, and your geographic area. Your data must be accurate when taken from alumni, placement reports, your own qualifications, and national publications.

EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS

Exercises Involving International Issues

1. *International Interview Comparisons.* Question 1, Chapter 18, suggested interviewing foreign students from your classes to determine differences in resume preparation. Question 1 here asks you to do something similar: Review with foreign students the process of interviewing as followed in the United States and then ask for their responses to the following questions:

- How are job candidates requested to come for an interview in the foreign students' homeland? Is this done by letter, a phone call, or the human resources office?
- What are some of the questions raised in the interview?

- Who conducts the interview?
- How are they informed about the results of the interview?

2. **Follow-Up Messages Comparison.** Western multinational companies in other parts of the world follow a similar interview and follow-up message pattern as in their home country. Search out a foreign student who interviewed with a nonwestern multinational company. Then ask him or her the following:

- What differences did they see in format, style, or substance in the kind of communication they received as compared with that in the United States?
- Do the similarities outweigh the differences between the U.S. method of replying with their home country?

Exercises of a General Nature

3. **Research into International or Local U.S. Firm Before Interview.** Choose a company with which you would like to interview. Then study as much material as you can about that company—from sources suggested in this chapter. Your goal is to be able to respond to many of the questions as cited on pages 536 and 537.

4. **Inquiry in Response to the Following Job Posting.** Here are the precise qualifications for the position of part-time editor at a local company. Write a cover letter to go with your resume as you apply for the position, which requires these qualifications:

- Extensive writing and editing experience
- Demonstrated ability to write for professional and lay audiences
- Knowledge of business issues and vocabulary
- Knowledge of the local library system
- Ability to work with little supervision

5. **Conducting a Mock Interview.** To do this assignment successfully requires two persons conducting research on the same company. Select a teammate; study as much information about a company as possible; hold a mock interview before the class with one student acting as the interviewer and the other the interviewee. Have the class critique the interview on criteria such as the following: courtesy toward one another, oral and nonverbal skills of each person, knowledge of the company, appropriateness of the questions, and other incidents noteworthy of comment.

6. **Follow-Up Letter(s) After an Interview.** Assume you were interviewed by a national company on your college campus. All went well—at least from your point of view. During the interview you discussed your qualifications, your interviewer mentioned the company's basic policies, the range of salaries for the open position, and other relevant information. Write a follow-up note for one (or each) of the following outcomes:

- a. At the end of the interview she told you she would notify you of her decision.

- b. At the end of the interview she said you should put down in writing the reasons why you feel you are qualified for the position.
 - c. At the end of the interview she said that your work experience gave her the impression you were overqualified for the position. Write her a note indicating how you would handle this negative observation.
7. ***Inquiry About Application Letter and Resume.*** Assume you mailed a response to the above job posting several weeks ago but have received no response. Send an inquiry to the company.
8. ***Your Acceptance and Refusal Letters.*** Assume you received two job offers for a career job.
 - a. Write the acceptance message to the firm of your choice.
 - b. Write the refusal letter to the other firm.
9. ***Rejection Letter from Employer to Candidate.*** You have made the decision to hire another person for the position of internal auditor. Five persons applied for the position; three have already been notified of their unacceptability based on lack of experience. One has been notified that she will be hired. You have a last letter to write; you do so based on the following brief notes taken during the interview:
 - Friendly and personable young man
 - Courteous, polite, well-groomed
 - Superior in oral communication skills
 - May not wish to move to [city].
 - Perhaps does not wish to continue in accounting work
 - Not quite clear as to his future
10. ***Negotiating a Job Offer.*** Assume you have received a written offer for a position for which you applied. The offer made to you was \$5,000 less than you had expected. In order to write an effective negotiation letter back to the company you must first (1) choose the city where the company is located; (2) choose the functional area in which you desire to work; (3) choose the industry in which your functional area is found. Then assemble as much information as the following in stating your cause in the form of a follow-up letter:
 - Median or average salary for persons of your experience
 - Median or average salary for the geographical area you have selected
 - Cost of living for the geographical area you have selected
 - Median or average salary for your selected industry
 - Median or average salary for your selected functional area.
11. ***Listing of Benefits to Consider When Negotiating a Position.*** This chapter gave you an initial idea as to various benefits possibly available with many job positions. Review the list of possible benefits on pages 554 and 555, and compile a rank-order list from 1 (high) to 10 (low) of those benefits you consider the most important. Defend your rankings before the class or compare how others have done for this exercise.

REFERENCES

1. Bulkeley, W. M. (1994, August 22). Replaced by technology: Job interviews. *Wall Street Journal*, pp. B1, B4.
2. Three large networks currently have the most members seeking new jobs: Exec-U-Net of Norwalk CT; the Search Bulletin of Great Falls VA; and NetShare of Novato CA. By subscribing to these networks you receive mailings from the service, which has several hundred job listings. Information included is job title, job description, salary, benefits, and other details. When in doubt about the listing, a potential respondent may call the job-search service to verify specific contact information. [See Lancaster, H. (1995, February 7). Managing your career.] When taking a tip from a job network, proceed with caution. *Wall Street Journal*, p. B4.

Appendixes

- A.** Visual Aids in Business Communication
- B.** Grammar, Punctuation, and Style
- C.** Business Communication and Legal Issues

Visual Aids in Business Communication

I. Graphics for Quantitative and Other Data

- A. Equipment
- B. Graphics Packages for Visual Aids

II. Sample Graphics for Quantitative and Other Data

- A. Outline Charts
- B. Tables
- C. Bar Graphs
- D. Pie Charts
- E. Line Graphs
- F. Area Graphs
- G. Pictograms
- H. Other Visual Aids

III. Checklist for Effective Visual Presentations

Visuals are a graphic representation of abstractions of reality, or symbols, as seen in words and figures. This comment suggests that visuals are applicable to both written and oral communication. Hence, this appendix is applicable to both.

To help improve the readability of your reports—or the illustrations you use in conjunction with an oral presentation—good communicators increasingly use more visuals. A steadfast charge given one of your authors by the chairperson of a board of directors was this: “We want consistency in all visuals brought to the board; we want the same consistency in the written reports that accompany those presentations.” In brief, they wanted visuals of similar format, even color.

Modern graphic packages for use on computers make creating visuals relatively simple, and easily amendable. It is uncomplicated to create handouts, 35mm slides, overheads, enlargements for flip charts, insertions in reports, desktop presentations, in color or in traditional black and white. Consequently, the following discussion is dominated by visuals, created on computers, under three headings: graphics for quantitative and other data, sample graphics for quantitative and other data, and a checklist for effective visuals.

GRAPHICS FOR QUANTITATIVE AND OTHER DATA

Equipment

It is not our task to recommend software packages for constructing graphic aids (also called *visual aids*, or *illustrations*) or any particular computer to drive that software. Some of the popular packages include *Harvard Graphics*, *Microsoft Powerpoint*, *Claris McPaint*, or a host of other options. Each system has its own variables for graphic display. Only your budget and current equipment are hindrances in selecting the equipment and software you desire. Additionally, we recommend the periodical *The Office*; it can keep you up to date on all the office equipment capable of handling the latest microcomputer graphic packages.

■ Communication Probe

Throughout this book, whether for written or oral communication, up-front preparation is mandatory—especially for visuals with oral presentations. Rehearsals with visuals are a must. A high-tech multimedia presentation may work well in your home office, but on the road inevitable glitches can occur. Foremost, says one author, discuss in advance with your client, prospect, or contact your needed equipment, plus the local technical support persons who will work with and for you.

Stella, P. (1995, June). The road to presentational hell: Tips for traveling presenters. *Presentations*, 9, 10–11.

Graphics Packages for Visual Aids

Get used to learning new jargon when you open the books associated with graphic packages. In *MacPaint* you will use such tools as *rectangle* (selects a rectangular portion of a picture), *lasso* (selects irregular shapes in a picture), *grabber* (permits scrolling within a picture), *paint bucket* (fills in patterns), *spray can* (applies spots of paint or continuously paints a pattern), *paintbrush* (determines the paint strokes within a current paint pattern), and numerous other variations.

A representative sample of what software packages can do to enhance your presentations is seen in the following list of *MacPaint*'s options:

- Draw straight lines and round circles and create precise shapes and intricate patterns.
- Add patterns to your pictures by “painting” with several sizes and shapes of brushes.
- Select any part of a picture and move, duplicate, rotate, flip, stretch, shrink, or invert it.
- Add text to a picture in a variety of fonts, font sizes, and font styles.
- Move in for close-up views of a picture—as if you had a magnifying glass—so you can do detail work.
- Enjoy the freedom to experiment, try new effects, undo what you do not like, create several versions of an idea, combine images from several different sources, and finally, put your work on paper.
- Create or edit pictures that you can “paste” into documents created with word processing or page-layout programs.
- Open up to nine documents at a time.
- Zoom in to magnify a picture 200, 400, or 800 percent.
- Draw ovals, circles, rectangles, and rounded rectangles from the center outward or from corner to corner.
- Take a snapshot of a picture, permitting later changes to that snapshot.

■ Communication Probe

One writer suggests that even the background color to one's visual is integral to the message. Single-color backgrounds do little to hold audience's attention. A main suggestion is to use gradient color. People's eyes are attracted to areas of highest contrast where foreground and background colors are high in contrast. Even the visual texture of a background should be considered, implying that one should wish to touch the surface of the visual. Moreover, western visuals read from left to right, or up and down. Adding the additional visual element of three dimensions further enhances attention of the reader or listener.

Meilach, D. (1955, June). Putting a new slant on visuals. *Training*, 32, 108; Cagle, K. (1995, June). Get in the mood with creative visuals. *Presentations*, 9, 56–60.

SAMPLE GRAPHICS FOR QUANTITATIVE AND OTHER DATA

Following are illustrations and brief explanations of the popular graphic forms that can enhance your written and oral presentations; each is capable of being created using a graphics package for your computer.

Outline Charts

Variously called *presentation outline*, or *speaker's notes*, or *outline of main points*, this format is perhaps the easiest to complete. Some packages suggest you begin with the title, then the body text, and then the conclusion. (See Figures A.1 and A.2.)

Some strengths and weaknesses are the following.

Strengths

- Readers, listeners can see outline of major points
- Writers, speakers must be highly organized in advance
- Authors can use regular outline format of Roman numerals, capitals, numbers
- Creators can use bullets or other visuals to separate ideas

Weaknesses

- Little deviation, little shifting from prepared outline
- Does not allow for up-to-date data or information
- Too brief, incomplete; reader/listener must be present to follow ideas
- Has a hint of the formal
- Too many lines of prose can be dull, uninteresting

Tables

In order of simplicity, tables follow outline formats. A table is a numbered list; here quantitative information or words, or a combination of the two, are pre-

Managing Cultural Diversity in a Multi-national Company

I. Power Distance

- A. Extent to which group accepts power distribution
- B. Various cultures vary in acceptance of power distance

II. Uncertainty Avoidance

- A. The lack of tolerance for ambiguity and uncertainty
- B. Various cultures vary in acceptance of uncertainty avoidance. . .

Based on Hofstede, G. (1994, January). Management Scientists are human. *Management Science*, 40, 4.

Figure A.1 Portion of outline chart.

Public Policies to Decrease Greenhouse Effect

- I. Definition of Greenhouse Effect
 - A. What is the greenhouse effect?
 - B. What actions taken to decrease greenhouse effect?
- II. Three Kinds of Public Policies
 - A. Traffic policies
 - 1. Japan
 - 2. Germany
 - B. Energy policies
 - 1. Use of solar batteries
 - 2. Cost of solar batteries
 - C. Waste disposal policies
- III. Conclusions and Recommendations

Figure A.2 Outline chart to three levels.

sented in rows and columns. Titles of the rows (horizontal lines) are usually called *stubs*, and the titles of the columns (vertical lines, sometimes called *variables*), are *captions*. (See Figure A.3.) Some strengths and weaknesses of tables are:

Strengths

- Permit precise figures to be used
- Make complete decimal detail possible
- Allow numeric data to be combined with nonnumeric information
- Allow reader to return for in-depth review

Weaknesses

- Do not visually show differences in data
- May be too detailed; with too many items, values may distract reader
- Are more useful in written than in oral presentations
- May be visually dull

Bar Graphs

Bar graphs, or bar charts, are among the most common and adaptable type of graphic presentations. Basically, you create individual cells that create columns (vertical, *y* axis) and rows (horizontal, *x* axis) of comparative data. Frequently the columns represent units of measure such as dollars, number of units, or population. The *x* axis generally explains the data classification or unit or dates being used. Four kinds of bar graphs are illustrated in the following figures, but we look first at a comparison of the strengths and weaknesses of bar graphs in general.

Acquired and Insured Properties					
		Captions			
		1996		1997	
Mortgagor's net effective monthly income		Properties acquired (%)	Total insured (%)	Properties acquired (%)	Total insured (%)
Stubs	Less than \$300	2.7	2.4	1.3	1.8
	\$300 to 399	25.8	19.2	23.7	16.9
	400 to 499	33.3	28.8	34.5	21.9
	500 to 599	20.5	21.8	21.4	25.3
	600 to 699	10.5	13.5	10.8	16.2
	700 to 799	2.5	7.4	4.3	9.4
	800 to 899	3.7	3.6	2.0	4.5
	900 to 999	0.2	1.5	1.5	1.9
	1,000 to 1,999	0.4	1.2	0.5	1.4
	2,000 or more	0.4	0.6	--	0.7
	Total	100.0	100.0	100.0	100.0

Table 3 percentages of properties acquired and insured, 1996 and 1997

Figure A.3 Illustration of a numbered table.

Strengths

- Comparisons or trends easily shown
- Main titles and subtitles for data easily added
- Oral presentations possible, if simple in form
- Color and cross-hatching add to visual appeal

Weaknesses

- Inclusion of too much detail may require lettering too small to read
- Precise distinctions between variables harder to see
- Not all headings consistent between graphs on *x* and *y* axes
- Visual impact may overwhelm content

Vertical Bar Graphs. When a time factor is considered, vertical bars are especially useful (see Figure A.4).

Stacked Vertical Bar Graphs. When two or more items or parts of a subject are being compared for the same year, a stacked vertical bar graph is helpful. Each item on a bar has different color or cross-hatching (Figure A.5).

Three-Dimensional, Stacked, Vertical Bar Graphs. With a software package for a microcomputer, labeling of variables and alteration of legends can be easily done. In fact, *Cricket Graph*, *MacDraw II*, *MacPaint*, and others permit

Chart 1. Comparison of Deposits

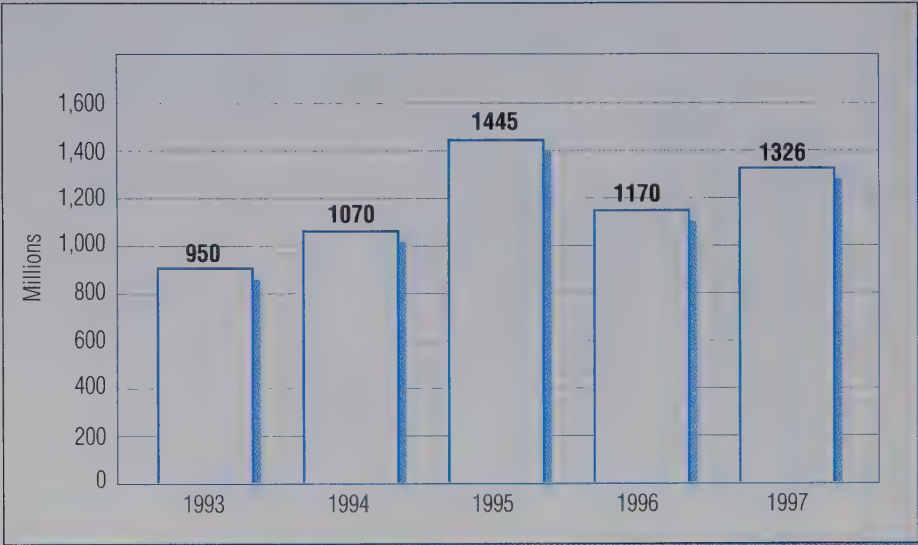


Figure A.4 A vertical bar graph.

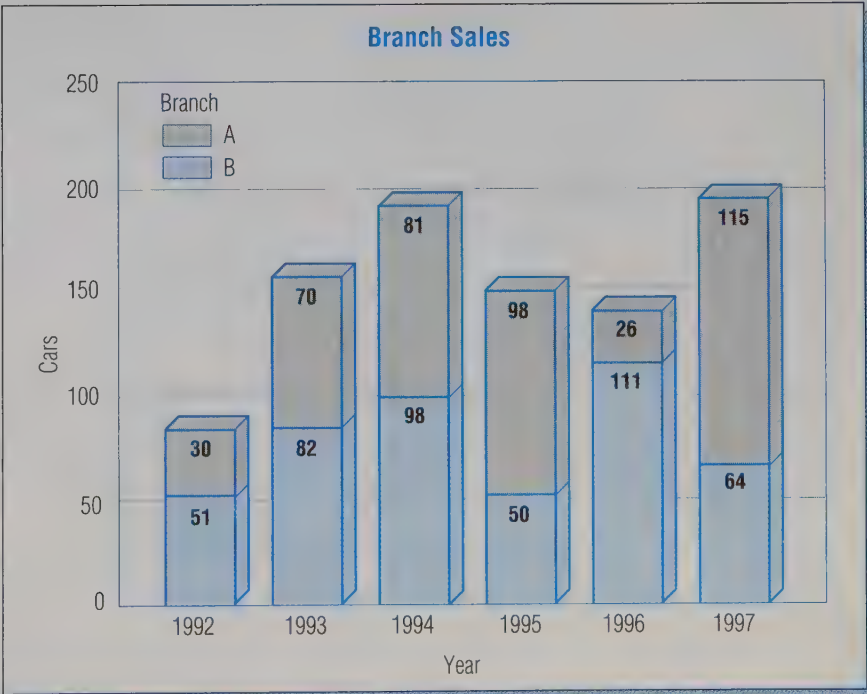


Figure A.5 A stacked vertical bar graph.

numerous variations to be added to the basic bar or column graph, including changing text, font, size, style, and orientation. Additionally, a graph can be redrawn in a three-dimensional stacked appearance, illustrated in Figure A.6. Adding depth further enhances the visual appearance of the bar graph and, for that matter, many other visuals.

Horizontal Bar Graphs. The information presented in a vertical bar graph may also be presented horizontally. Visual variations—to hold the attention of the reader—add interest to the presentation. Figure A.7 is an example of a three-dimensional horizontal bar graph that adds a “stacked” value.

Unlimited is a good term to describe the variations possible when using horizontal bar graphs. Suppose, for example, a report focuses on comparing the number of six- and eight-cylinder engines assembled over 7 years; you can use either the vertical version of that data (Figure A.6) or the horizontal version (Figure A.7). These are only two variations; many other options are also available. For example, for a different business, Figure A.8 illustrates a simple horizontal multiple bar graph comparing percent of associations that issue plastic cards for six different uses during two years. Notice that the categories (uses) are at the left, percentages are across the bottom of the bars, and the years are identified in the key. The *Wall Street Journal* frequently uses this format.

Pie Charts

When you wish to show relative sizes of various categories and the percent that each category adds to the whole, pie charts are the most popular and helpful. To make a comparison of facts easier, the pie segments (pieces) may be shown with percentages—all placed *consistently* either within a slice or outside but near it, as in Figure A.9.

Strengths and weaknesses of pie charts are as follows:

Strengths

- Segment of pie may be lifted out for visual emphasis
- Parts of a whole may be shown
- Values, headings, legends may be placed below, inside, or aside data
- Both oral and written presentations can use pie charts

Weaknesses

- Precise distinctions are not as visible when decimal distinctions are needed
- Use of too many parts and values may blur distinctions
- Distortions may occur if similar patterns are next to each other

As with bar graphs, you can “explode” or “drag out” a piece of the pie, thereby emphasizing that category. You can also add a three-dimensional variation, as seen in Figure A.9.

Typically, the legend contains the major category names for the pieces in the pie; preferably there should not be more than six. The names may be listed in a key, or inside each slice if space allows, or outside the pie near the percentages. The third method is shown in Figure A.9.

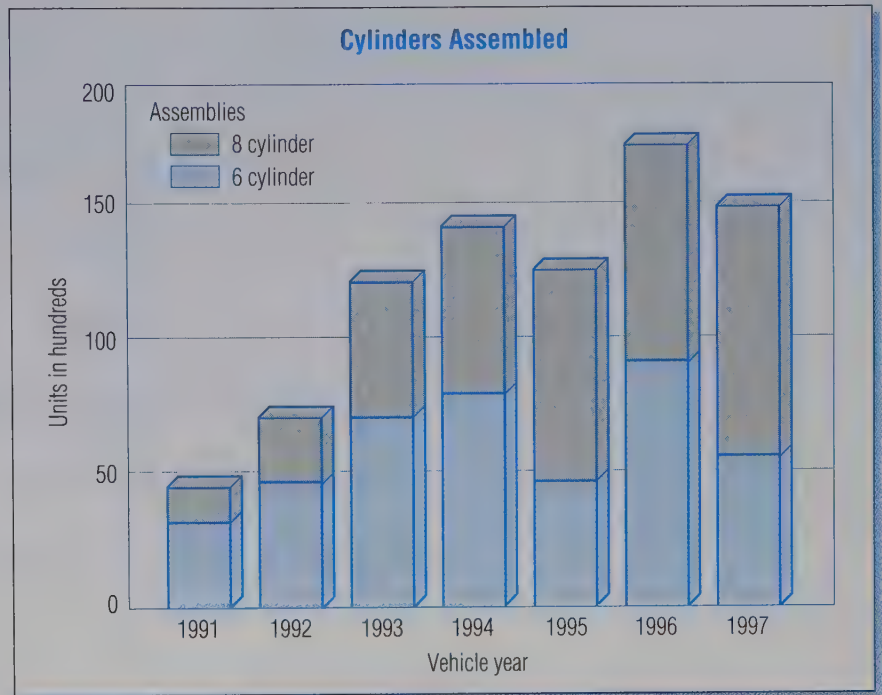


Figure A.6 Three-dimensional stacked vertical bar graph.

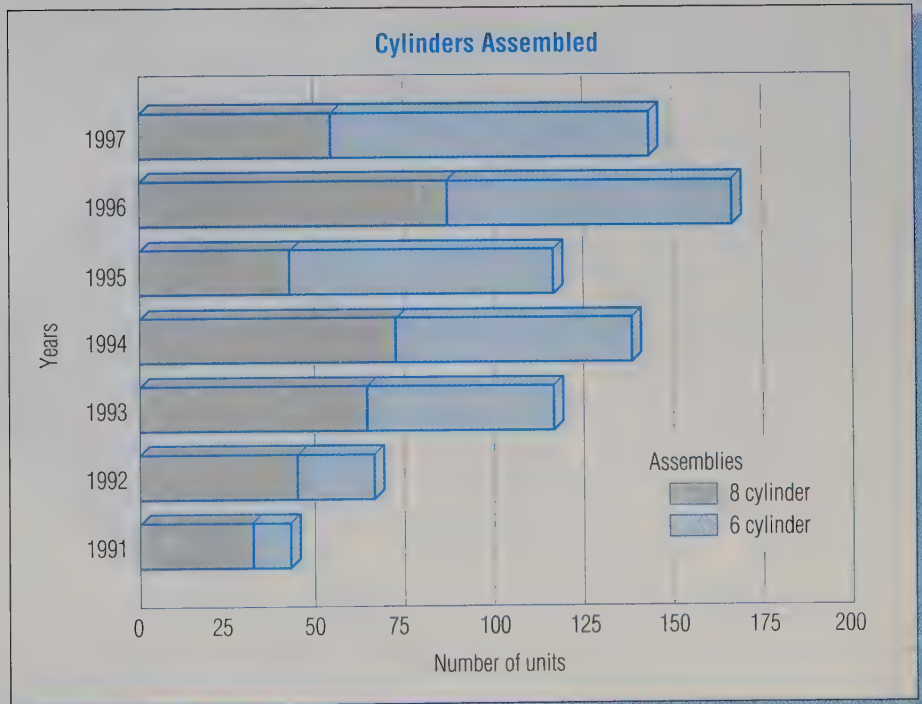


Figure A.7 Three-dimensional stacked horizontal bar graph.

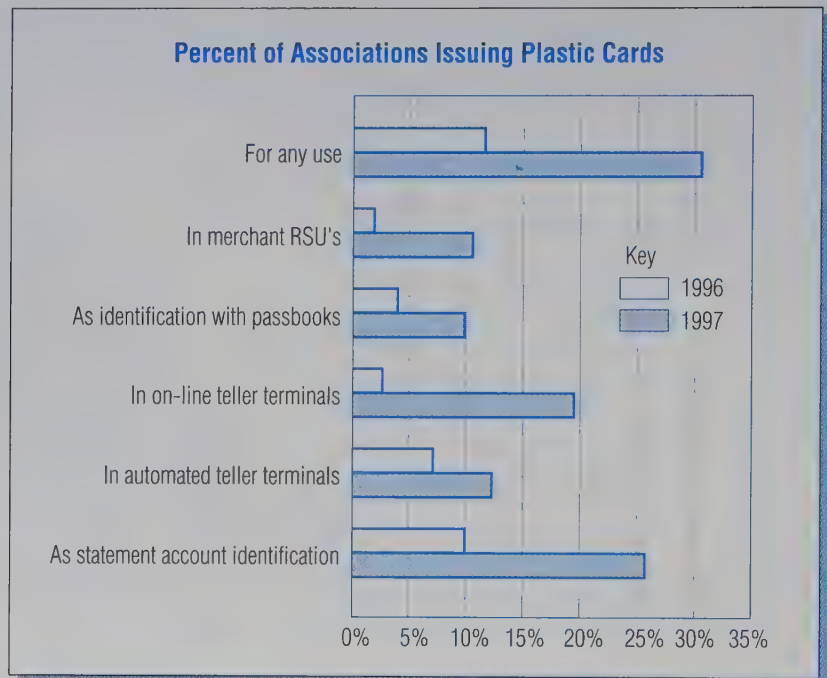


Figure A.8 A horizontal multiple-bar graph.

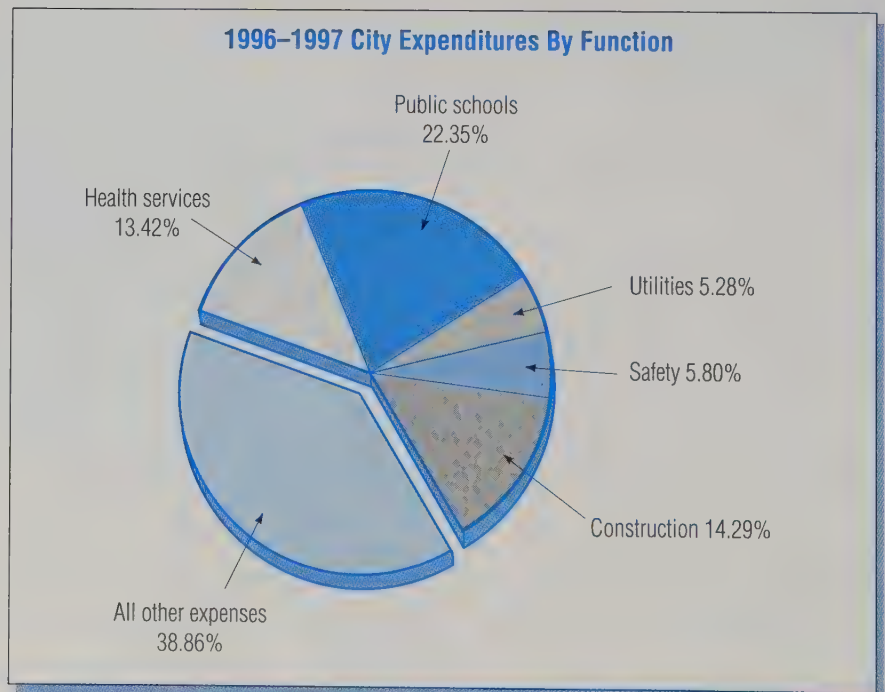


Figure A.9 Three-dimensional pie chart with exploded section, total of a whole, or 100%.

Line Graphs

Indicating trends over time is a central purpose for the line graph. So too is the wish to compare the distribution of one variable with another, over time. As in our preceding discussions, the line graph may be constructed using a computer software package or drawn with the aid of a drawing board. Several types of graphs involving lines, to indicate changes over time, are available in various software packages: Line and area graphs are some of the most common. Line graphs have the following strengths and weaknesses:

Strengths

- Trends over time, for several variables, permit comparisons
- Tick marks indicate increments between values
- Symbols on lines aid clarity

Weaknesses

- Too many variables and too many dates clutter information
- Fine, precise distinctions are difficult to determine
- Inconsistency for heading on x and y axes may confuse the reader, viewer

In a line graph the time increments are usually along the bottom, or x axis, and the magnitudes are along the side, or y axis. Some software packages, for instance, *Cricket Graph*, accept only figures along the y axis.

One feature of a line graph is that the various date points along the lines may each be marked with a small circle or square, and with figures that show totals, as in Figure A.10.

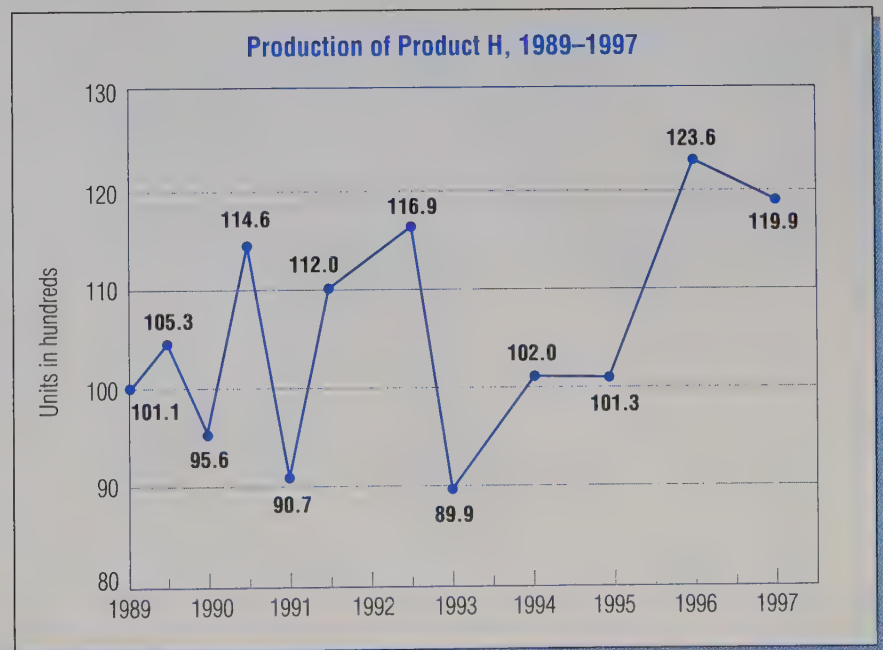


Figure A.10 A single-line graph with marked peaks and valleys.

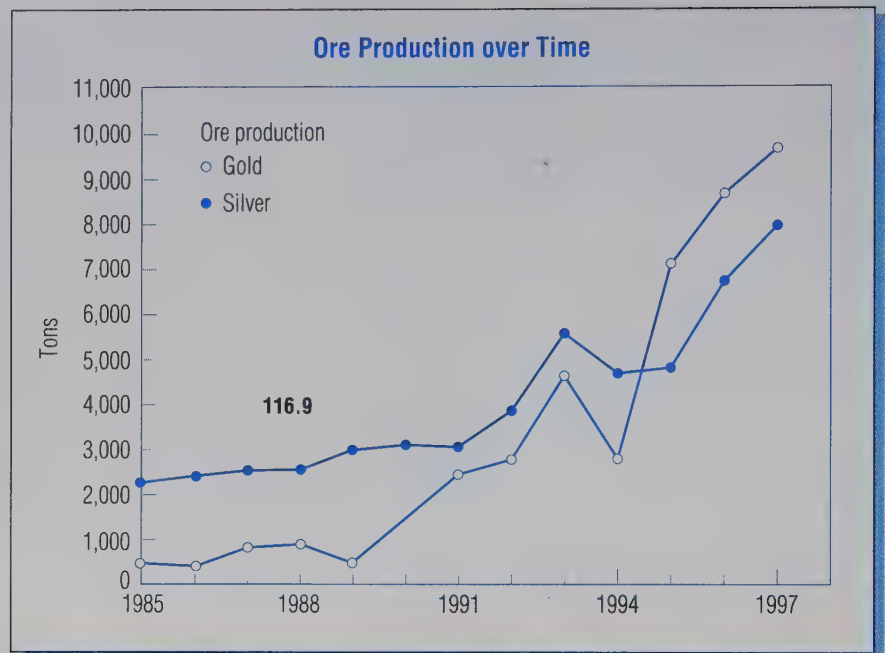


Figure A.11 Line graph with two variables.

In Figure A.11 the line graph compares two categories. To distinguish them from each other, one has small squares; the other, circles. Some graphs may use a different color for each line.

Area Graphs

You will see that there is a high similarity between a line graph and an area graph. The major difference in an area graph is that the space or area under the line is filled in. When additional categories are entered the graph shows, through colors, hues, and other variations, the differences between the categories. Figure A.12 illustrates how such a graph might look with two variables. It is easily constructed with a graphic software package. Area graphs have the following strengths and weaknesses:

Strengths

- Simple, one-variable changes in volume emphasis aid clarity
- Multiple sets of data, in different configurations, can be instantly visible

Weaknesses

- Small changes in data may be concealed
- Dramatic shifts in data are not handled well

Pictograms

Data may also be presented in the form of small pictures (pictograms, or icons). They may be arranged in various ways. When used on vertical or horizontal bar

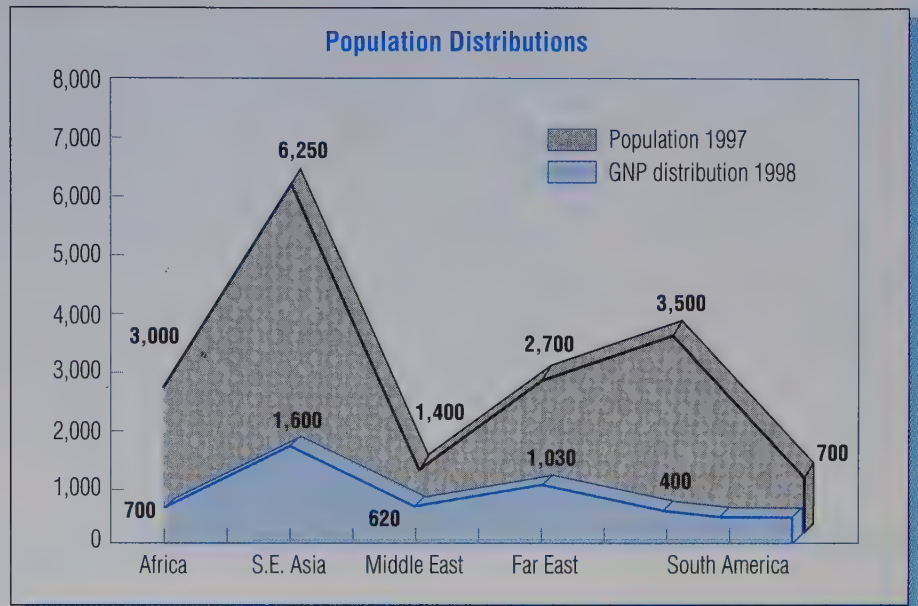


Figure A.12 Area graph.

graphs, the small pictures—instead of lines—can form the bar rectangles. Depending on your subject matter, these miniature pictures may be created from scratch on a drafting table, taken from a bank of software designs, or formed freehand on a computer. While formal business reports may not make extensive use of pictograms, reports to the general public in annual reports to stockholders, company advertising booklets, and desktop publishing may include numerous inventive pictograms such as people, houses, and cars:

All the preceding visual aids may be created on software programs on microcomputers, or if you have the patience, by using drafting materials. Slides and overhead transparencies of any of the preceding visuals can also be rapidly produced.

Other Visual Aids

A wide variety of additional visual aids can be used to help enliven the appearance of a report or an oral presentation. Among them are maps, cutaway drawings (like those showing parts of a machine), organizational charts, flowcharts, polar graphs, scattergrams, photographs, and various design sketches.

Maps help reveal geographic facts and comparisons. They can show locations of natural resources—as in Figure A.13—or company offices, transportation routes, environmental or weather patterns, quantities of products sold in certain areas, and various other data. To mark locations of pertinent data, you can use small squares, triangles, crosses, circles, cross-hatching, colors, designs,

■ Communication Probe

Full-scale presentations, both written and oral, are the norm for informative or persuasive presentations in the business world. Research suggests that not enough effort is given to the visual delivery of the message. One criterion for a good visual is consistency—noted in our later visual presentation checklist—along with the following summary suggestions: choose a consistent format, invest in slide production software, give thought to a graphic artist, make use of the corporate logo, use larger fonts, blend text in with graphics, employ photographs to hold attention, take slides with you, position projector carefully, give effort to all advance logistics, and use a versatile background—or template—that could be used in future presentations.

Martin, L. (1995, Spring). The fate of business often comes down to the quality of the presentation. *Public Relations Quarterly*, 40, 44–47; O'Meara, F. (1995, May). The trouble with transparencies. *Training*, 32, 36–41.1

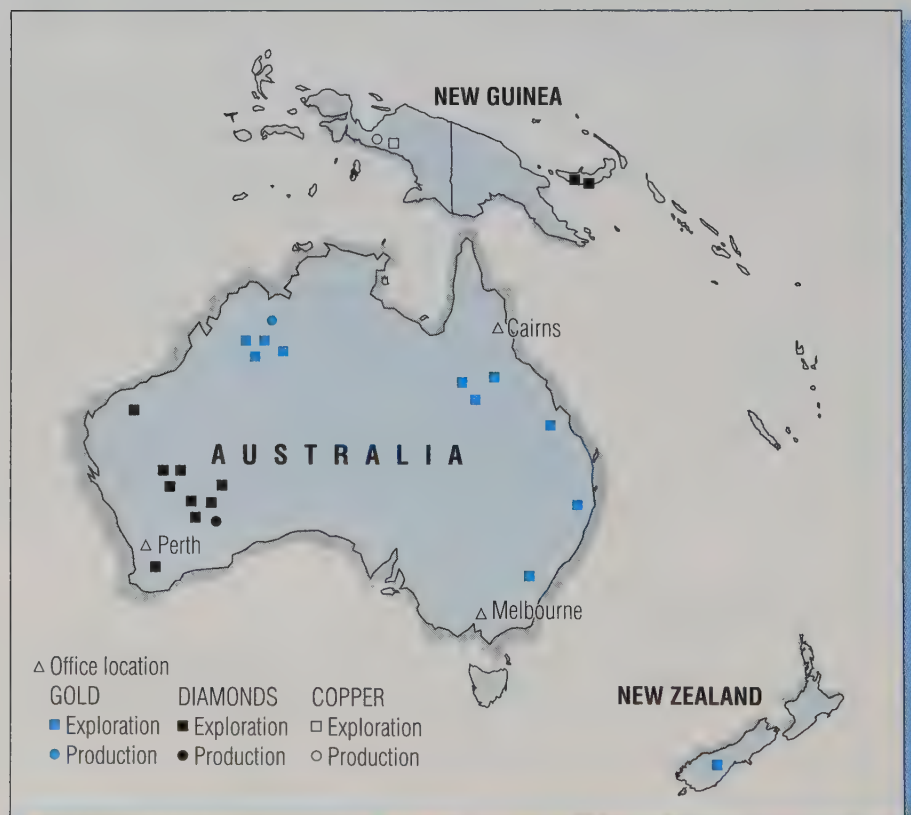


Figure A.13 A map showing locations of gold, diamond, and copper resources.

numbers, sketches, or small pictures. Gold mining companies, for example, find these maps useful.

Drawings of maps can be easily made into transparencies or pages in reports. If you work in a highly technical industry, software packages permit drawings of machines and processes, thus helping to clarify an idea or process.

CHECKLIST FOR EFFECTIVE VISUAL PRESENTATIONS

Throughout this appendix we included many suggestions for improving visual aids, including pragmatic citations in the three Communication Probes. Literally hundreds of additional sources can be cited. It is extremely important, however, that you become familiar with the software book accompanying your graphic package. For the most part, many of the comments there parallel the suggestions summarized in Checklist A.1.

■ Checklist A.1 Guidelines for Effective Visuals

1. *Placement.* When completing a written report, put the visual as close to the paragraph in which the subject is discussed. In like manner, introduce the visual at the related thought in an oral presentation.
2. *Introduction and interpretation.* Introducing the visual is usually brief, unless you wish to build a little suspense by withholding the visual for another page or later in your speech.
3. *Simplicity.* Avoid more than eight lines on an outline chart, six to eight categories in a bar chart and pie chart, and three to four lines on a line graph. Limit the use of terms and titles within the visual.
4. *Emphasis.* Graphic packages allow an unlimited variety of visual techniques; use them sparingly, but with planned effect. Select consistency in colors, scales, patterns, and titles or logos for all your visuals.
5. *Humor.* Clip art also enhances visuals. Select with reference to the formality or informality of the reader/listener. Creative merging of content and the visual will help hold the attention of the reader or audience.
6. *Expression of figures.* Round off figures. Percentages as values is a common way of noting differences in variations.
7. *Graphic choices.* Outlines give prose overviews; bar charts compare two or more variables; pie charts often view a single category broken down into various parts, often totaling 100%; line graphs show changes over time.
8. *Size.* Visuals should be large enough to be read anywhere in the room.

Grammar, Punctuation, and Style

I. Grammar

- A. Dangling Modifiers
- B. Coherence
- C. Parallel Structure

II. Punctuation

- A. Period
- B. Comma
- C. Semicolon
- D. Colon
- E. Dash
- F. Hyphen
- G. Exclamation Mark
- H. Question Mark
- I. Quotation Marks
- J. Ellipsis
- K. Apostrophe
- L. Slash

III. Style

- A. Abbreviations
- B. Numbers as Numerals or Words
- C. Word Choice

Appendix B focuses on a few of the common types of mechanical mistakes and areas in which care must be taken to maintain appropriate business communications. Grammatical issues include dangling modifiers, document coherence, and parallel structure. Punctuation is also covered as well as style details, such as abbreviations, numbers, and word choice.

GRAMMAR

Questions of grammar include items to do with the structure of sentences and clauses. The Seven C's of Effective Communication in Chapter 2 deals with specific grammatical constructions and recommended usage for business documents.

Dangling Modifiers

Any modifier, which is a word that qualifies in some way another word in the sentence, must clearly relate to the word it modifies. A modifier that is separated from the word it relates to is called a *dangling modifier*. Modifiers can dangle at the beginning of the sentence, within the sentence as a subordinate clause in which some elements are not expressed, or at the end of the sentence. Note the following examples.

At the beginning of a sentence:

Unclear: Expecting an important E-mail message, my computer stayed on all afternoon.

Clear: Expecting an important E-mail message, I checked my mail often during the afternoon.

Explanation: The first example suggests that the computer was expecting the message. Changing the subject of the main clause to "I" removes the dangling modifier.

Unclear: Upset by the team's performance, the arena began to empty.

Clear: Upset by the team's performance, the fans began to leave the arena.

Explanation: The first example suggests the arena was upset by the team's performance. Changing the subject of the main clause to "the fans" corrects the error.

Within the sentence:

Unclear: When only five, my mother taught me how to read.

Clear: When I was only five, my mother taught me how to read.

Explanation: The missing words in the first example (a dangling elliptical clause) make the sentence confusing. The simplest way to correct a dangling elliptical clause is to supply the missing words.

At the end of a sentence:

Unclear: Every member of the project team worked conscientiously, thus producing a project overwhelmingly approved of by the board of directors.

Clear: Because every member of the project team worked conscientiously, we produced a project overwhelmingly approved of by the board of directors.

Explanation: A modifier following the main clause should refer to a definite noun or noun phrase, not to the general idea expressed by the clause.

Coherence

Certain words and phrases help tie sentences together and help make the document coherent. The following chart provides categories and examples of these connecting words and phrases:

Category	Examples
Addition (and)	Also, furthermore, in addition, additionally
Contrast, concession, dismissal, replacement (but)	However, nevertheless, in contrast, conversely, on the other hand, though, even so, still/yet, in spite of, despite, regardless of this, in any case
Reason (for)	For this reason, because of, in view of, with this in mind
Result, effect (so)	Therefore, thus, as a result, consequently, as a consequence, in consequence, hence, accordingly
Consequence	Then, if so, if not, in that case, in that event, under these circumstances, otherwise
Illustration	For example, for instance, namely, in particular, for one thing, as an illustration
Similarity	Similarly, likewise, in the same way, by the same token

Clarification, identification	In other words, to put it another way, specifically, namely, that is to say
Sequence	First, first of all, at first, firstly, to begin with, second, secondly, next, then, subsequently, afterward, later, meanwhile, to conclude, finally, eventually, at last, lastly, in the end, last but not least
Summation	In conclusion, in sum, to summarize, in short, briefly, to be brief, in a word
Review	As was previously mentioned/ stated/pointed out, as I have said
Generalization	In general, overall, on the whole, all in all
Changing the subject	By the way, incidentally, to change the subject
Returning to the subject	Anyway, at any rate, to return to the point

Parallel Structure

Parallel structure is the use of the same grammatical form or structure for equal ideas in a list or comparison. The balance of equal elements in a sentence helps show the relationship between ideas. Often the equal elements repeat words or sounds.

Parallel	The instructor carefully explained <u>how to start the engine</u> and <u>how to shift gears</u> .
Not parallel	The instructor carefully explained <u>how to start the engine</u> and <u>shifting gears</u> .
Parallel	Joseph liked <u>reading</u> , <u>writing</u> , and <u>driving his car</u> .
Not parallel	Joseph liked <u>reading</u> , <u>writing</u> , and <u>to drive his car</u> .

The following structures call for parallelism:

both . . . and . . . Both *by the way she dressed* and *by her casual attitude*, it was clear that she was a relaxed person.

either . . . or . . .

neither . . . nor . . .

not only . . . but also . . .

whether . . . or . . .

■ Communication Probe

According to most linguists, the words in the above chart are more related to cohesion than to *coherence*. Cohesion refers to the actual links in the text between one word or phrase and another. Coherence, on the other hand, is the quality that makes a text comprehensible and includes issues of semantics and the overall worldview of the communicators. If you have clear lexical and grammatical links in your written document, it is generally coherent, but not always. To illustrate the larger issues involved in coherence, consider this example:

I'm wearing a green hat. In addition, "hats off" means to salute a person or thing. However, things aren't always as they seem. But you have things to do.

Even though the above statements have grammatically correct linking words, the passage makes no sense. Something else is needed for coherence. Sometimes a message is coherent even without overt linking words, as in the following example:

Two-minute warning. The quarterback races the ball down the field. Twenty-five yards to go. Field goal? Offense lines up. No! Touchdown! The crowd roars approval.

The second passage, choppy though it is, makes perfect sense to those who know American football. Keep in mind that coherence is more complex than simply using connective words.

Enkvist, N. E. (1990). Seven problems in the study of coherence and interpretability. In *Coherence in writing: Research and pedagogical perspectives* (pp. 11–15). Connor, U., & John, A. (eds.). Alexandria, VA: Teachers of English to Speakers of Other Languages.

PUNCTUATION

A change in punctuation can change the meaning of a sentence. The following punctuation forms are reviewed: period, comma, semicolon, colon, dash, hyphen, exclamation mark, question mark, quotation marks, ellipsis, and apostrophe.

Period

Periods signal the end point of a statement. Periods were formerly called “stops” to signal the end of the idea expressed. Many Asians call a period a “full stop.” Use a period in the following cases:

1. To end a complete sentence.

The company operates several divisions throughout the world.

2. To indicate abbreviations. (However, omit the period after acronyms for organizations or government agencies and some companies.)

Dr., Mr., Ms., a.m., p.m., H. M. Murphy, NATO,
AT&T

3. For decimal signs and after tabulated numbers.

15.2%, \$45.75, 1. 2. 3. (only one space after
the period in listed numbers)

Comma

Use a comma in the following situations:

1. To separate items in a series.

The police chief said the explosion could have been caused by defective wiring, misplaced chemicals, a careless match, or spontaneous combustion.

When the last item in a series is connected by a coordinating conjunction (and, or, but, not, for, yet, so), the comma can be omitted before that conjunction if the meaning is clear without it. In this book we are consistent: We use a comma after the last conjunction in a series of three or more.

2. To separate two independent clauses connected by a coordinating conjunction, as long as these clauses don't contain much internal punctuation.

Five divisions of XYZ Corporation were sold yesterday, and rumor has it that more will be on the block soon.

An independent clause can stand alone as a complete sentence. A sentence with two or more verbs that serve the same subject (compound predicate) does not need a comma because it is part of the same clause.

Jon Simms performed an audit of XYZ Corporation and reported that everything looked in order.

If both independent clauses are short, you can sometimes drop the comma.

3. To set off long introductory clauses and phrases and some shorter clauses and phrases that would be confusing without the comma.

Just as Cheryl Davis entered the building, the fire alarm went off.

Each day, many people visit the Eiffel Tower.
To Dick Johnson, Addison Ford is a mentor.

4. To set off nonrestrictive (nonessential) clauses, phrases, and modifiers from the rest of the sentence.

- a. *Restrictive (essential)*. These clauses and phrases are integral to the meaning of the sentence and must not be set off.

An elderly couple who sought refuge in a small shed died when the tornado slammed into the building.

(The subordinate clause "who sought . . ." limits the meaning of the sentence.)

- b. *Nonrestrictive (nonessential)*. These clauses and phrases do need commas because they are nonessential, or incidental, to the sentence.

Claudio Venturini, who won the gold medal for downhill skiing at the 1994 Olympics, recently toured several U.S. ski resorts.

5. To separate descriptive modifiers of equal rank.

When a noun is preceded by several adjectives, if you can use the adjectives interchangeably and can insert the conjunction *and* between them, they are coordinate and require a comma.

Meteorologists predicted another cold, dreary Michigan winter.

But no comma is appropriate in:

Meteorologists predicted another cold Michigan winter.

6. To set off parenthetical expressions or when you address the reader directly.

At the last meeting, you may recall, we decided to implement the new plan.

Please let me know, Ms. Hardy, when you will be arriving.

7. In dates and places.

On September 16, 1997, John Harris started to work for XYZ corporation.
Chicago, Illinois, is called the Windy City.

8. To set off participial phrases that modify some part of the independent clause.

Having seen the article in question, I knew what you were referring to.

The Senate adjourned today, having passed a number of controversial bills.

9. When two verbs come together; when two numbers come together.

Whatever will be, will be.

In 1997, 200 people from the company will be eligible for retirement.

10. When a sentence contains a quotation.

"Mr. Jonas," he said, "has been chosen department manager."

11. When the absence of a comma would cause confusion or misreading.

Ever since, we have looked forward to visiting your country.

12. To separate two independent clauses that are not joined by a coordinating conjunction. Violating this rule results in a run-on sentence or comma splice as in:

Inflation rates stayed steady employment rates rose.

Do not use a comma in the following situations:

- *To introduce a subordinate clause.* Using a comma before *because* is one of the biggest offenders. The conjunction *because* introduces a dependent clause. It is not a coordinating conjunction and does not join clauses of equal rank.

The mayor decided to visit the plant site because she needed to speak to the company management.

- *To separate a noun or pronoun from its reflexive.* A reflexive is any one of the "self" pronouns used to accent the noun or pronoun preceding it.

The CEO himself gave the opening address.

- *To precede a partial quotation.*

The candidate for Congress charged that the incumbent was "not listening to her constituency."

Semicolon

More formal than the comma, the semicolon is a half comma, half period. It has three main uses:

1. To join independent clauses not connected by a coordinating conjunction.

Howard launched a shot from the field goal area for a three-point play; it brushed the backboard and fell through the net just as the buzzer sounded.

■ Communication Probe

In early books printed in England, the only punctuation marks found are the slash (/), the colon (:), and the period, called a full stop (.). By the mid-sixteenth century, the comma began to replace the slash. Additional punctuation marks appeared as written English developed as a system rather than as a mere representation of spoken English. The colon changed from representing a pause of medium length to a mark of announcement. Semicolons developed to fill the gap left by the original colons.

Question marks and exclamation points did not become common until the seventeenth century. Apostrophes were originally phonetic, marking the omission of a sound. Only later did they become markers for the possessive case. The latter usage became obligatory by the eighteenth century.

Gorlach, M. (1991). *Introduction to Early Modern English* (pp. 58–60). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Note: Words such as *however*, *moreover*, *nevertheless*, and *therefore* are conjunctive adverbs, not coordinating conjunctions. When one of them separates two independent clauses, a semicolon is required.

This budget is tentative; however, I believe that it should be accepted immediately.

2. To separate internally punctuated independent clauses joined by a coordinating conjunction.

The group, known as the Environmental Caretakers, visited three toxic waste sites; but they were not able to gather the evidence they wanted.

3. To set off parts of a series that also contain commas.

Attending the conference were Aaron Smithson, professor of corporate strategy at the University of Utah; Janet Jones, consultant for GOE Industries; and Marjorie Jesson, professor of communication at the University of Michigan.

Colon

Colons announce. They may announce complete sentences, lists, quotations or dialogue. They are used in the following situations:

1. To introduce a lengthy quotation, list, or table after such words as *the following*, *as follows*, *as these*, *this*.

Several things were found in the victim's purse: a comb, wallet, pen, checkbook, and credit cards.

2. To separate hours and minutes.

5:30 a.m. 3:15 p.m.

3. To introduce quotations longer than one sentence and to end paragraphs that introduce quotations in the next paragraph.

Here is the text of Congressman Evans' speech:
"Good evening, my fellow Americans . . ."

4. After the salutation in U.S. business letters. Numerous foreign writers, particularly in Asia, use a comma after an individual's name.

Dear Ms. Addison:
Dear Mr. Son, (Asia and other parts of the
world)

Dash

Dashes emphasize a word or phrase within the sentence or set off a series within the sentence.

1. To emphasize.

Congress today voted in a bill to decrease government spending—a bill with dramatic consequences for many programs.

2. To set off a series within the sentence.

Several people—Jon Smithson, Sue Beacon, and Fred Tipple, among others—have asked to go on the trip.

Hyphen

The dash sets words apart; the hyphen brings them together. Use the hyphen in the following ways:

1. To join compound modifiers that precede a noun unless the modifier is preceded by *very* or an *-ly* adverb.

a good-natured person
a slowly moving object (not slowly-moving object)

2. For certain prefix and suffix words. Prefixes that usually take a hyphen include *all-*, *ex-*, *non-*, and *pro-*. There are exceptions; check a dictionary or stylebook to be sure.

extra-attentive, ex-president, re-cover (cover again)

3. In numbers 21 through 99 when spelled out.

sixty-six, eighty-seven, one hundred seventy-five

4. To break a word at the end of a line.

sub-
stantial

con-
sideration

Exclamation Mark

To indicate strong emotion, use an exclamation mark.

How terrible! What a problem!

Question Mark

Use to:

1. Ask a direct question.

Have you researched the problem?

2. Show doubt.

In 199- (?), the company sold two divisions.

Quotation Marks

Use them in the following situations:

1. Around a direct quotation.
2. Around unusual, substandard, or inexact terms.
3. Around titles of magazines articles and book chapters (but not titles of magazines, books, and pamphlets).
4. Around words to be set off.

The "please" in a request serves to . . .

Punctuation within quotation marks should follow these guidelines:

- All periods and commas go inside the quotation marks.
- Semicolons and colons go outside the quotation marks.
- Question marks, exclamation marks, and dashes
 1. go outside the quotes when they punctuate the entire sentence.
 2. go inside the quotes when they punctuate only the quoted matter.

Ellipsis

Use the ellipsis mark (. . .) to alert the reader that something has been removed from the quoted material, that the speaker has hesitated, or that there is more material than is cited.

"There are many good sports, such as racquetball, swimming, jogging, . . . that help your cardiovascular system."

Apostrophe

Three main uses for the apostrophe:

1. To show possession.

woman's, man's, Kevin's, someone else's

2. To show omission of a letter or number.

We'll, don't, can't, o'clock, it's, earthquake of '95

3. To show plurals of numbers, letters, or words used as words.

How many 10's do you have?

Watch your p's and q's.

You have used too many "the's" in this paper.

Slash

Also known as virgule or slant line, the slash is often used to separate words or to show omission. Along with the period, the slash is the oldest of punctuation marks, historically indicating a short stop (/) or a longer stop (//). The period indicated a full stop. The slash is used more often in informal writing than in formal. Three main uses for the slash today are the following:

1. To separate words.

Ms. Jennifer Tyler/225b Rosemary Ct./Nashville, TN

2. To show omission.

c/o for "in care of"

days/week for "days per week"

3. To indicate numbers.

3/4 indicating fractions

10/2/99 indicating dates (informal)

STYLE

Several chapters in this book include suggestions on style, especially the chapter that covers the seven C's (Chapter 2). This section reviews additional style questions, including abbreviations, numbers as figures or words, and word choice.

Abbreviations

In business letters and reports, abbreviations are appropriate for the following:

1. *Titles:* Mr., Mrs., Ms., Dr., Messrs. (as for a law firm of Messrs. Berry, Moorman, King, & Hudson).
2. *Descriptors:* Jr., Sr., Mt. (Mount), St. (Saint), Inc., Ltd., D.C. (District of Columbia, NW (Northwest)).
3. *Professional degrees:* B.B.A., Ph.D., M.D., C.P.A.

The following words should usually be spelled out: *president, superintendent, honorable, reverend, professor, building, association, department*. City names should be spelled out. A good rule is "When in doubt, spell it out." The U.S. Postal Service has its own rules for abbreviations. The following chart shows the recommended abbreviations for states and for other words used in addresses.

Standard State Abbreviations

AL Alabama	KY Kentucky	OH Ohio
AK Alaska	LA Louisiana	OK Oklahoma
AZ Arizona	ME Maine	OR Oregon
AR Arkansas	MD Maryland	PA Pennsylvania
CA California	MA Massachusetts	PR Puerto Rico
CO Colorado	MI Michigan	RI Rhode Island
CT Connecticut	MN Minnesota	SC South Carolina
DE Delaware	MS Mississippi	SD South Dakota
DC District of Columbia	MO Missouri	TN Tennessee
FL Florida	MT Montana	TX Texas
GA Georgia	NE Nebraska	UT Utah
HI Hawaii	NV Nevada	VT Vermont
ID Idaho	NH New Hampshire	VA Virginia
IL Illinois	NJ New Jersey	WA Washington
IN Indiana	NM New Mexico	WV West Virginia
IA Iowa	NY New York	WI Wisconsin
KA Kansas	NC North Carolina	WY Wyoming
	ND North Dakota	

General Abbreviations

Apt. Apartment	Ln. Lane	Rm. Room
Ave. Avenue	N. North	S. South
Cir. Circle	Pl. Place	Ste. Suite
Dr. Drive	Rd. Road	W. West
E. East		

Numbers as Numerals or Words

In general, use the numeral instead of the word because it's easier to understand, especially for those whose first language is not English. In letters and reports,

use the rule of 10: spell out numbers 1 to 9; use numerals for numbers 10 or higher) except for amounts of money and for certain situations as the following:

1. If a sentence begins with a number, express the number in words. If the number standing first in the sentence is followed by another number, express both in words.

Seventy or seventy-five should be enough.

2. When a sentence contains one series of numbers, express all units of the series in numerals unless they are all below 10.

Last month, we entertained 15 applicants from Michigan, 25 from New York, and 8 from California.

3. When a sentence contains two series of numbers, express one series in words and the other in numerals. Following this rule will avoid confusion because of too many sets of numbers.

Four members received \$100 each, nine received \$25, and twenty got \$10.

4. When one number immediately precedes another number of different context, express one in words and the other in numerals.

I wish to place an order for fifteen 4-inch paintbrushes.

5. When a numerical quantity contains more than three digits, each group of three digits should be set off by a comma, starting at the right. This rule does not apply to dates, street numbers, serial numbers, or page numbers.

3,400,627 50,000 200,000

6. Express amounts of money in numerals. When the money is dollars and cents, always express the amount in numerals. The dollar sign precedes the amount, unless in a tabulated column.

Your total cost is only \$395.95.

If the amount is only in dollars, you can omit the double zero unless you are listing amounts in a column that includes both dollars and cents.

I owe you \$125.

If the amount is only in cents, you can use any of the following:

\$.25 25¢ 25 cents

7. Express the following numbers in numerals unless otherwise indicated:

a. Dates January 10, 1998

b. House or room numbers, except
number one: 13112 White Street

- c. Numerical names of streets (over 10): East 73rd Street
(under 10): 324 Fifth Street
- d. Numbered items such as pages, chapters, tables, charts, telephone numbers:
Page 10 Chapter 16 Chart 39 Figure XI
Policy #44221
- e. Decimals: 4.25 5.75
- f. Dimensions and age: 15' X 23' 25 years old
- g. Time: 6 a.m. or six in the morning or six o'clock
- h. Percentage: 40% 25% or six percent
- i. Fractions: 1/3 4/5 or three-fifths

Word Choice

Trends in business writing continue to move in the direction of less rather than more formal word choices and sentence constructions. Formerly, you might see many legal words and phrases; however, even the language of the law has simplified to some extent. The following phrases are not currently used in the most effective business messages, and when used, create a stilted tone:

attached please find
enclosed please find
party (when you mean person)
we transmit herewith
assuring you of our prompt attention, we remain
in reply I wish to state
attached hereto
kindly (when you mean please)
please be advised that
this writer (when referring to yourself)

Although many textbooks give lists of words considered "incorrect," most of the words chosen have a long history of usage. Language changes continually, and English itself has a rich word hoard that can be used with pleasure to create meaning. There are, however, a few pairs of words that are sometimes confusing. A quick reference to some of these follows:

<i>accept</i>	<i>approve, receive</i>
<i>except</i>	<i>exclude, make exception to</i>
<i>advice</i>	<i>guidance (noun)</i>
<i>advise</i>	<i>to counsel (verb)</i>

<i>affect</i>	<i>to influence (verb)</i>
<i>effect</i>	<i>result (usually a noun)</i>
<i>eminent</i>	<i>distinguished</i>
<i>imminent</i>	<i>about to happen</i>
<i>lay</i>	<i>to set down a thing</i>
<i>lie</i>	<i>to recline (yourself)</i>
<i>precede</i>	<i>to go ahead of</i>
<i>proceed</i>	<i>to go forward</i>
<i>principal</i>	<i>main</i>
<i>principle</i>	<i>truth, tenet</i>
<i>stationary</i>	<i>in a fixed position</i>
<i>stationery</i>	<i>writing paper</i>

■ Communication Probe

Many textbook writers disapprove of certain words for business purposes, even though the words in question are used by many people. One such word is *prioritize*, which means “to give priority to” or “to establish priorities.” Its first use was by T. H. White in his 1972 book *The Making of the President*. University of Michigan English language expert Richard W. Bailey calls it “A word that at present sits uneasily in the language.” However, many business people use it often and effectively.

Another word often questioned is *input* used as a verb. Language purists accept this word as a noun but not as a verb. However, *input*, meaning “to put in” has been used since the sixteenth century; its present sense “to feed in data” has been in the language since the mid-1940s. Since language is continually developing and changing, it’s probably more productive to think of words as choices rather than constraints.

Simpson, J. A., & Weiner, E. S. C. (eds.). (1989). *Oxford English dictionary* (2d ed.) Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Business Communication and Legal Issues

I. Defamation

- A. Publication
- B. Privilege
- C. Defamatory Terms

II. Invasion of Privacy

- A. An Employee's Personal Disabilities
- B. An Employee's Personal Identity and Private Facts
- C. An Employee's Records, Reports, Letters, and Electronic Data

III. Misrepresentation and Fraud

- A. Innocent Misrepresentation
- B. Fraudulent Misrepresentation
- C. Sales Warranties
- D. Frauds

IV. Laws Regarding Employment, Credit, and Collections

- A. Employment—and Preemployment Inquiries
- B. Credit and Collections

V. Other Areas of Caution in Business Communication

- A. Copyrights
- B. Computer Data Security

Business communication is affected by terms emanating from both federal and state courts of law; each term is both a warning flag and a potential communication issue: E-mail privacy, hackers, electronic monitoring, copyrights, discrimination, Civil Rights Act, disability testing, reasonable accommodation, fraud, libel, falsehoods, warranties, defamation, access, and a host of others. In short, simply sending a letter, a memorandum, a fax, or an Internet message, or making a cellular phone call demands your vigilance. Because of our litigious society, we must be more careful than ever to avoid being taken to court.

Up front we make this assertion: No single appendix or chapter is able to review the thousands of situations covering the legal interpretations applied to business communication. Our central goal is to heighten your awareness of the risks and complications in communicating information (making information public) that may be considered private. Ignorance of the law excuses no one. Thus, for specific questions you should consult an attorney in your organization. Our statement here is introductory only; no guarantee is made for its completeness.

This chapter focuses on several areas of concern affecting both your communication within and outside an organization:

- Defamation
- Invasion of privacy
- Misrepresentation and fraud
- Laws regarding employment, credit, and collections
- Other areas of caution in business communication

DEFAMATION

There exists a patchwork of opinions and interpretations as to the boundaries of defamation. Simply stated, defamation is a communication made public that

■ Communication Probe

U.S. companies—as they grow—consistently hire in-house attorneys to complete the necessary legal work. This appendix is thus limited to legal views applicable to the United States. And, those in-house attorneys are governed by the same ethical and disciplinary rules applicable to other attorneys. However, companies with increased globalization or people working with some European companies, for instance, will find that European Community (EC) attorneys operate under a different set of guidelines. In Europe, attorneys are not members of the bar, and attorney-client privileges do not exist. A caution: In dealing with EC attorneys, be alert to differences that could impact communication between the U.S. and EC companies.

Hill, A. (1995, Winter). A problem of privilege: In-house counsel and the attorney-client privilege in the United States and the European Community. *Case Western Reserve Journal of International Law*, 2, 7145–194.

tends to be false or harmful to an individual's character, reputation, or fame. Oral defamation is *slander*. Written defamation is *libel*. Quite often a company "defames" an individual by making public to another organization a job applicant's background and references. Four suggestions are in order:

- Establish a company policy for handling information regarding both present and former employees.
- Resist making public any information unless it is required by public policy.
- Keep a "paper trail," a record of released information.
- Avoid making any subjective statements in the released material.

Note that a key element in defamation is making certain information public. That statement leads to understanding two legal terms: *publication* and *privilege*. We discuss these two terms and conclude this section noting some defamatory terms.

Publication

To "publish" defamatory material about a person is to make public that information to a third party. Any means of communication (fax, letter, memo, circular, picture, newspaper, radio, television, E-mail, and others) by which a third party learns of alleged defamatory material makes that material public.

A private one-to-one discussion wherein you tell an employee that he is incompetent, lazy, disorganized, unreliable is within your rights. Only you and the other person have heard those statements. But as soon as you make that information available to another person or to others who are not "privileged" (defined later), you risk serious consequences. Note that the derogatory qualities that make a statement defamatory are the same for both libel (written) and slander (oral). However, because the libel statement is more permanent, different levels of proof are required.

Be careful even in sending a sealed letter wherein you accuse the recipient. Should the letter be read by a third person (a secretary for instance), you may be liable for "publishing" defamatory material. Some suggestions:

- Seal the envelope.
- Mark the envelope personal and confidential.
- Wrap the enclosed message with opaque material to further screen the material from possible readers.

The preceding suggestions also apply to unfavorable information about a person or organization and collection messages about past-due payments.

Accidental communications to third-party persons (unauthorized readers, eavesdroppers, casual room attendants) are not actionable unless you knew or should have foreseen such possibilities. Conversely, most authorities consider dictating defamatory material to a secretary a form of publication.

■ Communication Probe

A study sought to determine the willingness of businesses to respond to requests for information about previous employees. That is, the underlying assumption was that failure to control responses could increase the number of suits alleging defamation of character. Conclusions from the study suggested that smaller firms—fewer than 100 employees—generally did not employ human resource managers to oversee responses to outside requests for preemployment information. In contrast, firms with over 100 employees often had human resource managers to monitor and oversee released former employee information. A major suggestion was this: Appoint one person to handle all employee references; this person would be aware of the potential defamation allegations.

Fenton, J. W., Jr., & Lawrimore, K. W. (1992, October). Employment reference checking, firm size, and defamation liability. *Journal of Small Business Management*, 30(4), 88–95.

Privilege

There are times when defamatory information may be made public.

Absolute Privilege

Absolute privilege is possible in three circumstances: judicial proceedings, legislative proceedings, and the actions of important government officials.

Courts of law are places where defamatory statements may be made. Thus juries, attorneys, witnesses, and other participants in judicial or quasi-judicial proceedings are *absolutely privileged* to make defamatory statements, either orally or in writing. However, if you—as a potential member of a legal investigation—make public accusatory or defamatory statements outside the judicial proceedings, you are liable for those statements.

Similarly, government officials are *absolutely privileged* to make defamatory statements in the performance of their duties.

Finally, newspapers—or for that matter employee newsletters—continually run the risk of being accused of libel statements concerning public persons. But a Supreme Court decision in 1964 concerning the *New York Times*—pertaining to public persons—lessened the risk of liability for criticism. Under the *Times* ruling, public officials cannot recover libel damages unless actual malice is proved. Criticism or comment about the public conduct or fitness for office of public officials and statements about the public conduct of other voluntary public officials are privileged. A significant caveat is this: Even erroneous material—unless there was actual knowledge of falsity or reckless disregard as to whether the material was true or false—is considered privileged.

■ Communication Probe

Overt intent to defame another person is difficult to prove. And as courts consider the concept of “libel by impression,” there is a court tendency not to award damages to persons who feel that a conscious attempt was made to defame them. Thus, a plaintiff must prove that even judges and police officers intended to libel them—again, a difficult task to achieve. And in the process of reporting there is also the possibility of hyperbole, exaggerating via language certain things about a person or a group. Here too courts have resisted awards to individuals who feel they were defamed. Additionally, inadvertent disclosure, via electronic means, appears to be increasing exponentially. The caution is obvious: Handle confidential information with care.

Joffe, M., & Rice, E., Jr. (1995, July). Oops! Can I take that back? *Defense Counsel Journal*, 62, 450–452; Stein, M. L. (1992, November). Rhetorical hyperbole is OK; defamation is not. *Editor and Publisher*, 125(46), 37; McDonald, M. P. (1991, June). “We never intended to suggest . . .”: the press, the courts, and libel by impression. *Communications and the Law*, 13(2), 17–42.

Conditional (Qualified) Privilege

Fear of lawsuits should not hamper communicating in good faith. Thus, at times within business when the writer may have *conditional privileges* during business communications. Defamatory statements made in ordinary commercial activity are *qualifiedly privileged*, whether those statements are made within the company or without—as long as the recipient has a lawful interest in the topic of discussion.

Of the business situations allowing *conditional privileged* communication, two actions should be foremost in your mind: responding to requests for information concerning a former or current employee and requesting recommendations from others.

Responding to Requests for Information. You as a manager and others outside an organization most likely will be asked to write a recommendation letter. Within the business world you may also be asked about the credit record of a customer. *Avoid malice or deceit*; this is the strongest admonition we can give.

Thus, whenever you reply to an inquirer (potential employer, credit reference, or the U.S. government, for instance, who might suffer a loss if an unworthy applicant is employed), reply in good faith, tell the truth, and include no malice. If you carelessly or intentionally mislead the inquirer who seeks information about another person, you could be sued for damages. Your reply should not mislead the recipient into hiring or lending to an unworthy applicant. Conversely, you should not maliciously prevent a worthy applicant from being considered fairly for employment or credit. Several suggestions:

- Appoint one individual to respond to all requests for information concerning individuals within your company.
- Demand that reference requests be submitted in writing.
- Accept, if possible, a release from the former employee absolving the company from future liability.
- Double-check that all statements about former employees are true and precise.

Avoid the belief that all conversations concerning former employees are “off the record.”

Requesting Recommendations. On numerous evaluation forms given to professors or other references, students and others have the opportunity to check a box indicating that they desire to not see the recommendation. Additionally, the requester often promises to hold the response in confidence. Thus, more safeguards are being put in place to protect the reference writer. And as is more and more the case, phone calls to former employers and other references are occurring to replace the written response.

What the preceding paragraph suggests is that when you request information from another person about a former student or employee, be clear in showing that you will protect the received information and keep it confidential. Bear in mind that more and more employees are filing defamation claims against current or former employers, particularly in the following areas:

- Publication of unfavorable evaluations
- Publication of disciplinary action
- Publication of unfavorable references
- Publication of reasons for termination

■ Communication Probe

Consistently the courts have held that disseminating truthful and accurate information to those with a legitimate interest in knowing it is valid. While that principle refers to reference letters, it also applies to exposing credit information. Federal antitrust laws do not discriminate against exchanging historical credit information concerning a person, with a legitimate third party. In short, and as noted in the prose section of this chapter, disseminating accurate and truthful credit information is recognized by law. On the other hand, disseminating false information or disseminating such credit information to persons with no legitimate interest in knowing it can be the basis for malice, in which case the privilege to communicate defamatory information is lost.

Panaro, G. (1993, November–December). Avoiding business credit reporting pitfalls. *Business Credit*, 95(10), 38–39.

Remember one suggestion we made earlier: Have one person check the comments made in a reference letter—probably a member of the human resources department. Likewise, this same office could be solely responsible for asking others to send the company a reference letter about a current employee or an outside candidate for an open position.

Defamatory Terms

Before reading the following list of terms judged libelous, jot down a few terms you feel are objectionable to you. Then compare your list with the one that follows. Of course the following sample is just that: an incomplete series of words that should be either avoided or used with caution when referring to a person or organization.

adultery	faker	kept woman	shyster
agnostic	falsified	kickbacks	simpleton
alcoholic	forgery	lovemate	slacker
altered records	fraud (fraudulent)	mental illness	sneak
atheist	gay	misappropriation	subversive
bad moral character	gouged money	misconduct	swindler
bankrupt	grafter	misrepresentation	thief
blackmailer	hypocrite	perjurer	unchaste
cheats	illegitimate	plagiarist	unethical
communist	incompetent	price cutter	unmarried
corrupt	inferior	profiteer	mother
crook	infidel	quack	unprofessional
deadbeat	informer	racketeer	unreliable
dishonest	insolvent	rascal	unworthy of credit
disreputable	intolerance	scandalmonger	villain
drug addict	Jekyll-Hyde personality	sharp dealing	worthless

Entirely unacceptable are words that suggest an individual has

- An undesirable disease
- A conviction for committing a crime, or words falsely charging arrest, or an indictment for or confession of a crime
- An anti-Semitic attitude or other prejudices based on race, creed, color, or sexual orientation
- A tendency to lie
- A life of squalor or poverty
- An unwillingness or refusal to pay a debt or evasion of payment of a debt

Truth is usually a defense in a libel suit in which there is no conditional privilege, especially if there is no evidence of malice. Traditionally, legal malice has meant spite, ill will, or a desire to do harm for harm's sake. A quotation from a

Supreme Court decision of Alabama, 1989, captures its desire of what the plaintiff must establish:

“Plaintiff must prove to your satisfaction from the evidence the following things: . . . that the employee of the [name of company] who made the defamatory statement knew at the time said statement was made that it was false and that it was defamatory.”

Supreme Court of Alabama, 1989 Ala.; June 16, 1989.

INVASION OF PRIVACY

Each worker has the expectation that one's personal work area is free from invasion by others. When there is an unconsented, unprivileged, or unreasonable intrusion into the private life of an individual, it is called *invasion of privacy*. Note that in this definition, privacy can be violated although no publication to a third party occurs. In fact, the concept of privacy is analogous to that of trespass, which gives one the right to keep unwarranted intruders off one's land.

This section discusses an employee's personal disabilities, personal identity and private facts, and personal records, reports, letters, and electronic data.

An Employee's Personal Disabilities

With the increase in drug use, companies are uncomfortable in acting under the guidelines of the Americans with Disabilities Act. Many sections of that act have yet to be clarified. Thus, some employees object to drug tests because they allege that such a test is an invasion of their privacy. Court cases suggest (*Third Circuit US Court of Appeals in Borse v. Piece Goods Shop*) that the plaintiff must prove that the tests or searches are highly offensive to the reasonable person.

In the case above, the court relied on the legal precedent that drug testing could constitute an invasion of privacy in two ways: If the methods of use fail to give due regard to the privacy of the employee and if the results disclose private facts of an employee, such as an illness.

Anytime you as an employee must deal with private health matters, you must keep that information private, measuring the health issues against the job requirements. Opinions and decisions on this complex health issue are undergoing change; we suggest that any communications in this area be reviewed by your company's human resource department, in addition to keeping up with decisions in the *Employee Relations Law Journal*.

An Employee's Personal Identity and Private Facts

You cannot use a person's name, photograph, or other identification for commercial benefit without permission. Awards have been given for publishing x rays, medical pictures, or even records of delinquent debt.

Furthermore, the personal information customers give when applying for credit (insurance, medical care, jobs) should be kept confidential. Unfortunately,

■ Communication Probe

Shrill have been the cries against employers who leniently interpret privacy laws. Indeed, as electronic communication increases and as demands for more investigation of the health of employees increases, states have devoted much time to those issues. California, for instance, insists that the company establish a compelling reason for testing of any sort; however, a recent decision by the California Supreme Court in *Hill v. the National Collegiate Athletic Association* (1994) was a watershed decision that lowered the legal protection afforded to the right of privacy; here the court held that the plaintiff has the burden of proof to establish three things:

- A legally protected privacy interest
- A reasonable expectation of privacy
- A serious invasion of privacy

Such a decision shifts to the defendant the burden of establishing a competing interest to justify the privacy intrusion.

Meyers, J. F. (1994, Summer). *Hill v. NCAA*: California adopts a new standard for invasion of privacy. *Employee Relations Law Journal*, 20(1), 73-84.

in some cases the customer's permission has not been obtained; lawsuits have resulted. Keep credit application material confidential.

An Employee's Records, Reports, Letters, and Electronic Data

An employee's right to privacy will be violated if private records, reports, letters, and, more recently, electronic mail are read by persons not entitled to examine them.

Two recent court decisions add emphasis to the above statement:

"(The historical judgment which the Fourth Amendment accepts, is that unreviewed executive discretion may yield too readily to pressures to obtain incriminating evidence and overlook potential invasions of privacy and protected speech.) Petitioners would have been forced to articulate their exact reasons for the search and to specify the items in Dr. [name] office they sought, which would have prevented the general rummaging through the doctor's office, desk, and file cabinets."

Supreme Court of the United States, 480 U.S. 709; 107 S. Ct 1492; 1987 U.S.; 94 L. Ed.2d 714; 55 U.S. L. W. 4405; 42 Empl. Prac. Dec. (CCH), P36,891; 1 BNA IER CAS 1617, March 31, 1987.

"However, the federal courts have not yet recognized such a 'principle,' and we fear the potential effect . . . on the long accepted, and vitally important, axiom that the sender of a letter retains an expectation of *privacy* protected by the fourth amendment in the contents of the letter after it is sent."

United States Court of Appeals for the Eighth Circuit, 853 F. 2d 1479; 1988 U.S. App.; August 12, 1988.

■ Communication Probe

Results of a recent survey concerning eavesdropping in over 300 businesses:

- One out of five companies eavesdrops on its employees.
- Seventy percent use some form of electronic eavesdropping.

In other words, as the electronic world proliferates in business, the question of employee privacy will be tested even more. In question, say the researchers, is the legal minefield of disciplinary action as a result of determining an employee's sexual orientation, marital status, or social life. In short, they feel that regulations for legitimate monitoring and illegal snooping must be more clearly established. Invasion of privacy issues demand that both the employer and the employee be alert to this fast-changing area of internal communication.

Webster, G. (1995, May). Internal-communication issues. *Association Management*, 47, 150–153; Jacobs, D. L. (1994, February). The perils of policing employees. *Small Business Reports*, 19(2), 22–26.

Yet to be finalized are the rights of the employee regarding privacy of personal electronic mail. Those guidelines are still being formed, but indications suggest that one's E-mail is also considered an issue of privacy.

MISREPRESENTATION AND FRAUD

Innocent Misrepresentation

Innocent representation is a “communication not in accordance with the facts, but which the communicator thought or merely assumed to be true.” To be legally significant the misrepresentation must be relied upon by the person to whom it is made.

Fraudulent Misrepresentation

A *fraudulent misrepresentation (or fraud)* occurs when the communicator knows the representation is not true and the person to whom it was made relies on it to his or her disadvantage.

Sales Warranties

In most *sales contracts*, the seller undertakes certain obligations concerning the nature, title, and quality of the goods or services being sold. When these obligations are expressly stated or implied and when they actually induce the sale, the obligations are called *warranties*. Warranties are of two types.

Express Warranties

Express warranties are created by a seller's specific statements about a product: its characteristics, or its performance, which affect the buyer's decision to buy. (Some consumer surveys suggest that only 10 percent of consumers say a warranty has a bearing on their decision to buy.) Regardless, to achieve a sale the seller may include a description, grade labeling, use a sample or model, or include statements or pictures in advertisements. Such a promise becomes the basis for a contract even though the term *warranty* or *guarantee* is not used. Be careful in your communication: The buyer can sue a company or you to recover damages for certain kinds of injuries arising out of the express warranty.

Implied Warranties

Implied warranties of the Uniform Commercial Code (UCC) apply only to the sale of goods; it means the warranties are part of the bargain even though the parties themselves say nothing about them. Consumers have four years from the time the good or services were delivered to take legal action, if they feel a contract has been breached. In cases where a service has been provided, the claimant must show negligence.

Frauds

Fraud occurs when one party acts on the basis of a material presentation and consequently suffers as a result of that representation. Be aware of these communication possibilities:

- A deceitful silence
- A desire to actively conceal
- A misrepresentation via a third party
- A misrepresentation of intentions

An organization called the National Fraud Information Center (NFIC) receives hundreds of calls daily from victims of phone, voice mail, or mail fraud. So too does the U.S. Postmaster General. Avoid involving yourself in schemes with fake contests, false charity appeals, missing-heir schemes, false business opportunities, worthless medical cures, and others.

Computer fraud is also on the increase via computer hackers who have managed to infiltrate private databases. Often the approach is this: One or more persons devise a deceptive scheme, the deceptive scheme injures another, and there is direct intention to defraud.

The following sample quotations from court cases illustrate judicial use of the terms misrepresentation and fraud:

"The investor/plaintiffs allege the FDIC acquired their notes with actual knowledge of the fraudulent misrepresentations and omissions and without good faith. Specifically, the investor/plaintiffs allege the FDIC had full knowledge of the financial con-

dition of the bank and of the material misstatements made to the plaintiffs by FPD officers and employees.”

United States District Court for the Eastern District of Louisiana, 661F. Supp. 163; 1987 U.S. Dist.: February 27, 1987.

“The sales contract, which was negotiated in the United States, England, and Germany, signed in Austria, and closed in Switzerland, contained express *warranties* by petitioner that the trademarks were unencumbered and a clause providing that ‘any controversy or claim [that] shall arise out of this agreement or the breach thereof’ would be referred to arbitration before the international Chamber of Commerce in Paris, France, . . .”

United States District Court for the District of New Jersey, 713 F. Supp. 737; 1989 U.S. Dist.; May 11, 1989.

LAWS REGARDING EMPLOYMENT, CREDIT, AND COLLECTIONS

Employment—and Preemployment Inquiries

Chapters 18 and 19 alluded to some of the concerns both the interviewer and interviewee must address in a job search. Here we add a few more legal issues.

Title VII of the Civil Rights Act of 1964 prohibits discrimination in employment as to hiring, firing, compensation, termination, and conditions of privileges of employment on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, or national origin. The above law forbids discrimination, not the asking of certain questions. However, some questions may be unfair or risky to ask because they may appear discriminatory and may serve as the basis for later legal action.

A representative checklist is in order. Note that the following preemployment questions in Checklist C.1 are in line with the Uniform Guidelines on Employee Selection Procedures. Some states, as well as cities and counties—even universities—may have stricter regulations regarding a few of the preemployment questions. Thus, it is advisable to check your own local and state laws or consult a member of your human resources staff.

Credit and Collections

Many federal and state laws are in place to protect the consumer. And because state statutes vary, you will need to investigate those in your state. We note just some of the more important statutes.

1. **Equal Credit Opportunity Act**—Requires financial institutions and others engaged in credit extension to make credit equally available to all creditworthy customers without regard to sex, marital status, race, color, religion, national origin, or age. In turn, some lenders are turning to a credit scoring system to protect themselves from lawsuit.
2. **Fair Credit Billing Act**—Aims to protect the consumer against inaccurate and unfair credit card practices.

Checklist C.1 Preemployment Inquiries

Subject

Age

Fair Preemployment Inquiries

Inquiries as to birthdate are permitted in some states; in others, only whether applicant is of legal age.

Arrests (see also Convictions)

None. (Law enforcement agencies are exempt from this rule.)

Citizenship

Whether applicant is prevented from lawfully becoming employed in this country because of visa or immigration status. Whether applicant can provide proof of citizenship, visa, or alien registration number after being hired.

Convictions
(see also Arrests)

Inquiries concerning specified convictions that relate reasonably to fitness to perform particular job being applied for, provided that such inquiries be limited to convictions for which date of conviction or of prison release is within seven years of job application date. All general conviction inquiries must be accompanied by a disclaimer informing the applicant that a conviction record will not necessarily bar him or her from employment.

Family

Whether applicant can meet specified work schedules or has activities, commitments, or responsibilities that may prevent meeting work attendance requirements.

Handicap

Whether applicant has certain specified sensory, mental, or physical handicaps that relate reasonably to fitness to perform particular job. Whether applicant has any handicaps or health problems that may affect work performance or that employer should take into account in determining job placement.

Height and weight

Inquiries as to ability to perform actual job requirements. Being of a certain height or weight will not be considered to be a job requirement unless the employer can show that no employee with the ineligible height or weight could do the work.

Marital status
(see also Name and Family)

None.

Unfair Preemployment Inquiries

Any inquiry that implies discrimination (without job-related justification).

All inquiries relating to arrests.

Whether applicant is citizen. Requirement before hiring to present birth certificate, naturalization papers, or baptismal record. Any inquiry that would divulge lineage, ancestry, national origin, descent, or birthplace.

Any inquiry that does not meet the requirements for fair preemployment inquiries.

Specific inquiries concerning spouse, spouse's employment or salary, children, child care arrangements, or dependents.

Overly general inquiries (e.g., "Do you have any handicaps?") that would tend to divulge handicaps or health conditions that do not relate reasonably to fitness to perform the job.

Any inquiry that is not based on actual job requirements.

Whether applicant is married, single, divorced, separated, engaged, widowed, etc.; whether Mr., Mrs., Miss, Ms.

Checklist C.1 Preemployment Inquiries (*Continued*)

Subject	Fair Preemployment Inquiries	Unfair Preemployment Inquiries
Military	Inquiries concerning education, training, or work experience in the armed forces of the United States.	Type of condition of military discharge. Experience in other than U.S. armed forces. Request for discharge papers.
Name	Whether applicant worked for this firm or a competitor under a different name; if so, what name. Name under which applicant is known to references if different from present name.	Inquiry into original name and whether it has been changed by court order or marriage. Inquiries about name that would divulge marital status, lineage, ancestry, national origin, or descent.
National origin	Inquiries into applicant's ability to read, write, and speak foreign languages, when such inquiries are based on job requirements.	Inquiries into applicant's lineage, ancestry, national origin, descent, birthplace, or mother tongue. National origin of parents or spouse.
Organizations	Inquiry into organization memberships, excluding any organization the name or character of which indicates race, color, creed, sex, marital status, religion, or national origin or ancestry of its members.	Requirement that applicant list all organizations, club, societies, and lodges to which he or she belongs.
Photographs	May be requested <i>after</i> hiring, for identification purposes.	Request that applicant submit photo, mandatorily or optionally, before hiring.
Pregnancy (see also Handicap)	Inquiries as to duration of stay on job or anticipated absences that are made to males and females alike.	All questions as to pregnancy, and medical history concerning pregnancy and related matters.
Race or color	None.	Any inquiry concerning race or color of skin, hair, eyes, etc.
Relatives	Names of relatives already employed by this company or by any competitor.	Name and addresses of any relative other than those listed as proper.
Religion or creed	None.	Inquiries about applicant's religious denominator or affiliations, church, pastor, parish, religious holidays.
Residence	Inquiries about address to the extent needed to facilitate contacting the applicant.	Names or relationship of persons with whom applicant resides. Whether applicant owns or rents home.
Sex	None.	Any inquiry.

3. Fair Credit Reporting Act—Demands that consumer reporting agencies (credit bureaus; investigative, detective, and collection agencies; computerized information-reporting firms; lenders' exchanges) should make a firm offer of credit to each consumer whose name appears on a final prescreening list. Additionally, the institution will only use the information to extend a credit offer. The basic intent of the law is to protect consumers from erroneous information that could ruin their credit rating.

4. Fair Debt Collection Practices Act—Addresses abuses of consumers by unethical debt collectors. The bill basically states what bill collectors (other than creditors and attorneys) can and cannot do.
5. Federal Truth in Lending Act—Concerns meaningful disclosure of interest rates so that consumers may compare more readily the charges different credit sources make. Recent widespread errors in the calculation and disclosure of interest rates under adjustable rate mortgage loans (ARMS) have increased the number of lawsuits.
6. False Claims Act—Seeks to protect the federal government from fraudulent claims.
7. Uniform Commercial Code—Set up guidelines concerning, among many other things, product specifications and untruthful statements about a product or service.

OTHER AREAS OF CAUTION IN BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Copyrights

Electronic transmission of documents is on the rise. And with this increase everyone from publishers to document suppliers to end users is concerned with protecting private interests. Basic copyright law applies: You cannot copy copyrighted material without permission of the copyright owner. Exceptions include “fair use” privileges and single copies made for noncommercial purposes. There are strict conditions with which designated libraries must comply.

As you can see, multimedia products stress content over technology. Such content—with which you will work in business—includes text, sound, artwork, animation, photography, film clips, and other forms of copyrighted material. When in doubt, *ask for legal advice* before using copyrighted material.

Computer Data Security

Each of us is concerned about privacy—as is the organization for which you work or will work—because of the increasing dependence on electronic data storage and transmission. Can a company or can you maintain privacy over private materials? Legislative proposals are in the works to address the privacy issue. Regardless of whether another employer intrudes into your private database or not, a core question must be answered: Does an employer monitor a worker’s electronic files to gather private information about the employee, or is the information gathered to improve production within the organization? There exists a fine line between what is considered private and workforce production information. Such were the concerns—in addition to national security—surrounding the Clipper Chip (embedding in all computers a chip that would allow only federal security agencies, after securing legal permission, to access certain computers). At the moment such a suggestion has been withdrawn.

■ Communication Probe

Workplace electronic control systems are generally used for three purposes: to measure performance, prevent internal theft, and enforce laws and workplace rules. To support those purposes, and others, the federal government enacted The Federal Electronic Communication Privacy Act of 1986 to protect all electronic communication systems from outside intruders and protect the privacy of certain messages in transmission over public service E-mail systems. A study of one company with 151 employees found that feedback sign, feedback frequency, and supervisor consideration were positively related to computer-monitoring satisfaction. Procedural fairness was central to employer satisfaction with a workplace electronic control system.

Kidwell, R. E., Jr., & Bennett, N. (1994, June). Employee reactions to electronic control systems: The role of procedural fairness. *Group & Organization Management*, 19(2), 203–218; Shannon, J. H., & Rosenthal, D. A. (1993, Winter/Spring). Electronic mail and privacy: Can the conflicts be resolved? *Business Forum*, 18(1,2), 31–34.

Surfing the electronic Internet and the cellular network is becoming serious business. Scanners already can be adapted to monitor cellular conversations, and the Internet is an ever-evolving frontier. Both these areas are protected from outside infringement, but invasions of those communication systems continue. You, as an employee, must be alert to possible intrusions into your private business communication.

■ Communication Probe

Long reports (Chapter 12) and proposals (Chapter 13) may include as an appendix a contract. Companies and private persons use the Internet to send contracts, along with a report, along with a signature. Inevitably this kind of electronic communication will increase, and it is being used extensively. Thus the question: What are the current legal principles governing the sending of a contract via the Internet or E-mail? Answers are not clear. What is clear is that three additional legal-communication questions must be answered: When is a deal really a deal? If a deal actually exists, when and where is it made? And which jurisdiction's laws should govern, especially when parties in different jurisdictions use third-party network services? Again, there is need for awareness when sending a contract as a form of electronic communication.

Woolford, D., & Chester, S. (1995, April). When is a deal really a deal? *International Corporate Law*, 18–22.

Index

- Abbreviations, unnecessary, 590
- ABI/Inform, 326
- Abstracts, 19
- Abstracting, 19–20
- Abstracts, 19
 - for proposals, 357
 - for reports, 324–328
- Accountability, social, 6
- Acknowledgments:
 - of first or repeat orders, 193–194
 - of incomplete orders, 227
 - of job acceptance, 195
 - of orders you can't fill, 227–230
 - refusing job offers, 548
- Action closing, checklist for, 147–150
(*See also* Closing paragraphs)
- Action verbs, and present tense in, 46, 512–513
- Active voice, 46
- Activities, achievements, awards, 513
- Addresses:
 - E-mail, 123
 - on envelopes, 157
 - inside, 157–163
 - postal state abbreviations for, 590
- Adjustments:
 - asking for, in claims and complaints, 187–188
 - granting requests for, 182–188
 - refusing requests for, 222–227
- AIDA plan:
 - in persuasive requests, 254–262
 - in sales letters, 266–271
- "Allness" fallacy, 22
- America Online, 122
- American Psychological Association (APA), 329–330
- AMS simplified letter style, 170
- Analytical letter reports, 309–310
- Analytical memo reports, 295–302
- Announcements:
 - activities of people, 199
 - events, 197
 - favorable and good-news, 197
 - honors, 199
 - neutral messages, 197
 - procedures, 198
 - resignation, 547–548
 - responsibilities, 198
 - sales, 197
- Annual reports, 293
- Apologizing, 212
- Apostrophe, 589
- Appearance:
 - effect on oral messages, 23
 - effect on written messages, 22
 - elements of, in business letters, 157
 - of envelopes, 157
 - in interviews, 534
 - of memos, 168–175
 - of person, 23
 - of proposals, 375
 - of reports, 335
 - of speaker, 394–398
 - of surroundings, 23
- Appendix, 333
- Application:
 - letter of, 517–525
 - samples of, 517–525
 - (*See also* Job)
- Appraisal, letters of, 184–185
- Approaches:
 - direct, 142
 - indirect, 143
- Appreciation, letters of, 196
- Assessment:
 - market, 507–509
 - self-, 504–507
- Association for Business Communication, 7
- Attention (*see* Opening paragraphs)
- Attention line, in letters, 164–165
- Attitude:
 - in bad-news messages, 212
 - developing right, 10
 - for granting adjustments, 212
 - you- and we-, 40–41
- Audience analysis, 140, 141, 421–424
 - for agree-disagree, 181, 213
 - for all messages, 40–41
 - checklist for reports, 319
 - for speeches, 386, 421–422
 - hostile, 212
 - in sales letters, 267, 268
- Authorization, letter of, 321–322
- Back-order acknowledgment, 228
- Bad-news messages, 211–247
 - about prices, services, 232, 233
 - checklist, 244–247
 - claims and complaints, refusing, 222
 - credit refusal, 222, 223
 - invitations and favors, declining, 231
 - negative replies to requests, 218
 - nonsales inquiries when information undesirable, 218
 - plans for, 213–217
 - right attitude, 212
 - unfavorable unsolicited messages, 232
 - unfilled order acknowledgment, 227
 - (*See also* Direct plan of organization; Indirect plan of organization)
- Beginnings and endings, 144–150
- Benefits of communication in career, 7–9
- Benefits, to reader:
 - in announcements, 41–42
 - in job cover letter, 515–522
 - in persuasive requests, 252–254
 - in showing consideration, 41–42
- Body of speech, 387
- Budget in proposal, 360
- Buffers, 213
 - in bad-news messages, 146–147
- Business, effective communication in, 4–11
- Business letters, 157–168
- C's, seven, 31–65
- Capsule checklist (*see* Checklists)
- Career information, 508–509
- CD-ROM databases, 126, 127
- Certified Management Accountants, 8
- Characteristics of oral and written media, 13
- Checklists:
 - Aids in Overcoming Communication Problems (1.2), 22
 - Analysis of Audience and Locale (15.3), 426
 - Analytical Memorandum Reports (11.4), 306
 - Avoiding Negative Words in Performance Letter (10.1), 262
 - Basic Preparation for Writing Proposal (13.1), 359
 - Bibliographic Citations (12.4), 332
 - Capsule Checklists for Bad-News Messages, 244–247
 - Capsule Checklists for Good-News and Neutral Messages, 205–207
 - Capsule Checklists for Persuasive Requests, 276–277
 - Clarity (2.5), 52
 - Closing paragraphs (6.4), 149
 - Completeness (2.1), 35
 - Components of Communication (1.1), 15
 - Correctness (2.7), 60
 - Conciseness (2.2), 40
 - Concreteness (2.4), 47
 - Consideration (2.3), 43
 - Courtesy (2.6), 57
 - Cover Letter to Resume (18.3), 525
 - Cross-Cultural Ethical Guidelines (4.2), 106
 - Deciding Whether to Inform or Persuade (15.1), 414
 - Decreasing Stage Fright (14.4), 400
 - Developing Main Sections of Short Reports (11.1), 283
 - Direct (Deductive) Organizational Plans (6.1), 143
 - E-Mail Acronyms and Abbreviations (5.1), 125
 - Emoticons (5.2), 125
 - Enhancing Your Nonverbal Communication (14.3), 398
 - Ethical Guidelines for Advertising (4.3), 108
 - Executive Summary (12.3), 326
 - Five Cautions Regarding Headings and Subheadings (11.2), 286
 - Follow-Up After Job Interview (16.4), 457
 - Guidelines for Company Spokesperson (5.5), 132
 - Guidelines for Effective Visuals (A.1), 577
 - Guidelines for Ethical Spoken and Written Messages (4.1), 105

Checklists (*Cont.*):

- Guidelines for Starting a Group (17.1), 472
- How to Be Good Leader During and After Meeting (17.4), 490
- How to Be Good Participant During Meeting (17.5) 494
- How to Begin Problem-Solving Meeting (17.3), 487
- How to Work for Improving Listening (14.5), 404
- Indirect (Inductive) Organizational Plans (6.1), 144
- Individual Cultural Variables Between Your Country and Your Host Country (3.2), 86
- Information Reports (11.3), 294
- Initial Follow-Up After Interview (19.3), 542
- Interpersonal Disclosures in Interpersonal Communication (16.1), 454
- Interview Preparation (19.1), 534
- Interviewer Preparation Before Interview (16.5), 458
- Leadership Procedures Before Meeting (17.2), 486
- Message Receiver's Guidelines (16.8), 462
- National Cultural Variables Between Your Country and Your Host Country (3.1), 80
- Nonverbal Communication: Differences Between Your Country and Your Host Country (3.4), 88
- Opening paragraphs (6.3), 146
- Points to Consider in International Telephoning (16.6), 462
- Positive and Negative Behavior During Interview (19.2), 536
- Preemployment Inquiries (C.1), 606–607
- Prefatory Sections of Long Report (12.2), 325
- Preparation Before Job Interview (16.2), 456
- Preparing Effective Oral Messages (14.1), 389
- Press Kits (5.4), 130
- Procedures During Job Interview (16.3), 456
- Questions to Determine Whether Your Story Is Newsworthy (5.3), 129
- Request for Proposal (RFP) Communication (13.2), 369
- Responding to Solicited Letters (10.2), 267
- Review of Major Sections of Resume (18.2), 514
- Selecting Evidence for Your Speech (15.4), 440
- Self-Assessment (18.1), 507
- Sender's Preparation Prior to Phone Call (16.7), 463
- Striving for Oral Vocal Variety (14.2), 394
- Submitting Proposals to Government (13.3), 371
- Successfully Negotiating Job Offer (19.4), 555
- Suggestions for Approaching Hostile Group (15.2), 425
- Verbal Communication: Differences Between Your Country and Your Host Country (3.3), 87
- What to Do First When Asked to Complete Report (12.1), 319
- Claims letter, 187, 258
- Clarity:
 - checklist, 52
 - essentials of, 48–52
- Closed mind:
 - effect on written messages, 23
 - appearance, 25
- Closing paragraphs:
 - for bad news, 216
 - common essentials of, in letters and memos, 147–150
 - for direct requests, 249
 - for favor requests, 182, 183
 - for good news, 182–184
 - for indirect requests, 183, 184
 - for job application letters, 524
 - for memorandum reports, 288–291
 - for other persuasive nonroutine requests, 255–259
 - for sales letters, 266–271
- Coherence, as aid to clarity, 50–51
- Communication:
 - adequate preparation, 10
 - body language, 23–24
 - career benefits, 7–8
 - components of, 11–15
 - concepts and problems in, 15–21
 - context, 11–12
 - costs of, 6–7
 - crisis, 132
 - heritage of, 4
 - importance of, 4–9
 - nonverbal, 21–24
 - oral, comparison of, 13
 - written, comparison of, 13
 - career, 7–9
- Communication process:
 - elements of, 11–15
 - general concepts and problems in, 11–15
 - nonverbal, 87–88
- Communication skills:
 - developing right attitude, 10
 - in job position, 7
 - or promotion, 8
 - time spent by managers, 8
- Communication triangle, 17
- Comparisons, 47
- Complaints, 219
- Completeness:
 - checklist for, 35
 - essentials of, 32–35
- Components of communication, 11–15
- Composing message, 150–152
- CompuServe, 122
- Computer data security, 608
- Concepts of time, 26
- Conciseness:
 - checklist, 40
 - essentials of, 36–40
- Conclusions in reports (*see* Terminal section)
- Concreteness:
 - checklist, 47
 - essentials of, 43–48
- Conferences (*see* Meetings)
- Confrontal questions, 538–539
- Congratulations, 54
- Connotations:
 - defined, 18
 - reactions to, 18
- Consideration:
 - checklist, 43
 - essentials of, 40–43
- Conventions of meaning, 16–18
- Conviction (*see* Desire and conviction)
- Copy notation:
 - in letters, 164, 167
 - in memo, 172
 - in memo report, 172
- Copyrights, 608
- Correctness:
 - checklist, 60
 - essentials of, 57–60
- Costs, of messages, 6
- Courtesy:
 - checklist for, 57
 - essentials of, 52–57
- Courtesy endings, 163
- Courtesy title and name, 162
- Cover, for reports, 319–320
- Cover letter to resume, 515–522

Credibility, 21

Credit:

- approving, 191
- laws about, 605–608
- persuasively requesting, 259
- refusing requests for, 222–224

Crisis communication, 132, 133

Cultural differences, 26

Culture:

- checklists, 82, 86, 87, 88
- concept of, 70–71
- and decision making, 85
- and dress, 84
- and economics, 79
- and education, 76–78
- and food, 84
- and language, 81–82
- and law, 79
- and manners, 84–85
- and maxims, 88–89
- model of, 72–76
- and nonverbal communication, 87–88
- and politics, 79–80
- and regulations, 79
- and religion, 81
- and social norms, 81
- and space, 83–84
- and tact, 53
- and time, 82–83
- variables in, 76–88
- and verbal communication, 85–87

Data:

- for accuracy, 58
 - as support, 436–440
- Data sheet (*see* Resume)
- Declining job, order, requests (*see* Refusals)
- Decoder, definition of, 13–14
- Deductive plan of organization (*see* Direct plan of organization)
- Defamation, 595–596
- Definition of terms, in reports (glossary), 333
- Denotations, 18, 43
- Desire and conviction:
 - in job application letters, 524
 - in sales messages, 252, 253
- Dictation:
 - example, 462
 - suggestions for, 462
- Direct approach to message, 142
- Direct approach in good news, 181
- Direct plan of organization (deductive, psychological), 181
 - for bad news, 216, 217
 - for good news, 181
 - for persuasive requests, 249
 - for routine requests, 256
 - for short reports, 302
- Direct requests,
 - to customers, employees, others, 257, 261
 - in invitations, orders, reservations, 254–262
 - to persons outside and within organization, 256–258
 - to references, 262
- Diversity,
 - in culture, 71
 - in ethnic groups, 76
- Donations, asking for, 254
- Dyadic communication, 448–451
- Dyadic communication relationships, 450
- Editing, for reports, 334
- Education:
 - in application letters, 522–523

- in Asia, 76
- in intercultural variables, 76–79
- in resumes, 512
- Electronic mail (E-mail):
 - acronyms and abbreviations, 125
 - defining, 120
 - emoticons, 126
 - etiquette, 123
 - file transfer protocol (FTO), 123
 - security, 124
 - signs and symbols, 125, 126
 - understanding, 122
 - using, 121
- Ellipses, 588–589
- E-mail (*see* Electronic mail)
- Emoticons, checklist, 126
- Employment, laws regarding questions, 539–540
 - (*See also* Application, letter of; Follow-up messages; Interviews; Resume)
- Enclosures, notation of, 165–167
- Encoder, 12
- Encryption, 125
- Envelopes, 157
- Ethics:
 - in communication:
 - legal issues, 103
 - key areas, 104, 105
 - organizational responsibilities, 107
 - ethical contexts, 96
 - communication issues, 97
 - corporations, 98
 - situations, 96
 - personal, 99
 - culture, 101
 - law, 102
 - people, 99
 - philosophy, 101
 - religion, 102
- Euphemisms, 18
- Evaluation:
 - and conclusions from examples, 438
 - of interview information, 459
- Evidence (*see* Supports)
- Executive summary, 324–328
 - checklists, 326
- Extemporaneous speaking, 389
- External communication, 13
- Facial expressions, 24, 397–398
- Facsimile machines, 127
- Facsimiles (Faxes), 127
- Favorable replies, 182–191
- Feedback:
 - instructions for, 17
 - problems of, 16
- Figurative language, 47–48
- Figures (*see* Numbers)
- File Transfer Protocol (FTP), 123
- Five W's, 32–33
- "Flaming," in E-mail, 124
- Flexibility, 10–11
- Follow-up messages:
 - candidate-to-employer, 540–548
 - accepting offer, 547
 - inquiring about letter and resume, 543–545
 - rejecting offer, 548
 - requesting more time, 546–547
 - sending additional information, 545–546
 - writing after interview, 540–543
 - employer-to-candidate, 548–552
 - granting time extension, 551
 - inviting to company interview, 548–549
 - notifying of campus visit, 548–549
 - offering job, 550–551
 - refusing job, 551–552
 - replying to candidate's acceptance, 552
 - requesting further information, 550
- Footnotes:
 - explanatory, 330–331
 - source, 331–333
- Formal language, 57–58
- Formal report:
 - abstract, 324–327
 - appendix in, 333
 - authorization letter, 321–322
 - bibliography in, 329–330
 - cover and title, 319–320
 - deductive organization, 322
 - editing, 334
 - executive summary, 324–327
 - example of pages from, 337–346
 - footnotes, 330–333
 - glossary in, 333
 - headings, 324
 - index in, 333
 - introduction to, 334
 - margins, 335–336
 - pagination, 336–337
 - prefatory parts, 318–324
 - proposals, 354–376
 - qualities of well-written, 318
 - revising, 334
 - spacing, 335
 - supplemental parts, 328–333
 - table of contents, 324
 - table of tables, 324
 - title fly, 321
 - title page, 319–320, 338
 - transmittal letter, memorandum, 321–323
 - typing, 334
 - visual aids in, 324
 - (*See also* Appendix A)
 - writing first draft, 334
- Fraud, 603–605
- Freenet, 122
- Full-block letter style, 166
- Gestures, 396–397
- Global market, challenge of communication in, 70
- Globalization, 70
- Glossary in reports, 333
- Good-news and neutral messages,
 - about job applications, 262
 - (*See also* Direct plan of organization)
- Goodwill messages, 195
- Gopher, 123
- Grammar, 579–593
- Granting requests, 187
- Graphic presentation for quantitative data (*see* Visual aids)
- Groups, 470–472
 - definition of, 470
 - formal, 470
 - formation of, 471
 - informal, 470
- Hackers, 125
- Headings, 282
 - checklist, 286
 - levels of, 284
 - parallelism in, 285
 - placing and typing of, 282
- Heritage of communication principles, 4
- Honesty, in resumes, 510
 - (*See also* Integrity)
- Hostile groups, checklist, 425
- Humor, good or doubtful, 54, 55
- Impromptu seeking, 390
- Inadequate or incorrect information, 21
- Independent clause, 583
- Index, in reports, 333
- Indirect plan of organization (inductive):
 - for bad news, 213
 - for complex topics, 475
 - for executive summaries, 324–328
 - for persuasive requests, 249
 - for reports, 282
- Inductive plan of organization (*see* Indirect plan of organization)
- Inferences, 19–20
 - desirable, 20
 - necessary, 20
 - reliable, 20
 - risks of, 20
- Infinitive phrases:
 - in informative speeches, 409
 - in persuasive speeches, 413
 - in recommendation report, 302
- Informal language, 57–58
- Information, managing in workplace, 118
- Information superhighway, 122, 123
- Information sources for careers and jobs, 507–509
- Informational letter reports, 305
- Informational meetings, 472
- Informational memo reports, 288
- Informative speaking (*see* Speaking, informative)
- Inquiries:
 - to customers, employees, and others, 182
 - favorable replies to, 182
 - about persons, 182–187
 - about products or services, 182–187
 - unfavorable replies to, 218–232
- Inside address, in letters, 162
- Instructions, giving oral, 416
- Integrity, and ethics, 99–110
- Intercultural communication:
 - individual cultural variables, 82–88
 - decision-making, 85
 - dress, 84
 - food, 84
 - manners, 84–85
 - space, 83–84
 - time, 82–83
 - national cultural variables, 76–81
 - economics, 79
 - education, 76–78
 - language, 81–82
 - law and regulations, 79
 - politics, 79–80
 - religion, 81
 - social norms, 81
- Internal communication, 5–6, 13
- International communication (*see* Intercultural communication)
- Internet, 122
- Interpersonal communication, 447–467
- Interpersonal disclosure, 447
 - checklist, 454
- Interview:
 - assessments of, 459
 - behavior during, 535–540
 - chronology of, 534–535
 - follow-up after, 540–552
 - functions and purposes of, 455
 - interviewee's responsibilities for, 455
 - interviewer's responsibilities, 457
 - letters after, 540–552

- Interview (*Cont.*):
 preparation for, 458
 questions and methods during, 458, 459
- Introduction:
 eleven elements in report, 283
 for informative speaking, 414–416
 for persuasive speaking, 417
 in short reports, 287
- Invasion of privacy, 601–603
- Invitations, 231
- Irritating, discourteous expressions, 54
- Jargon, 356, 393
- Job application messages:
 follow-up messages (*See* Follow-up messages)
 job interview, 540–548
- Job presentation, 504–525
 job application letter, 515–525
 market assessment, 507–509
 resume (*see* Resume)
 self-assessment, 504–507
- Jobs:
 accepting, 195
 finding and applying for, 508–509
 follow-up, 540–552
 interviewing for, 534–540
 refusing, 548
 resigning from, 547–548
- Journal of Accountancy, 8
- Justification reports, 302
- Language:
 cultural, 80–81
 defamatory, 600–601
 familiar, 48–50
 figurative, 47–48
 levels of, 57–58
 pretentious, 49
 substandard, 58
 unfamiliar, 48–50
- Layout:
 electronic mail, 175
 envelopes, 157
 letters, 162
 memorandums, 169
 telegrams, Mailgrams, telexes, 176
- Leadership in meetings, 480
- Legal aspects:
 business communications, 595–609
 computer data, 608–609
 copyrights, 608
 defamation, 595–601
 employee's personal disabilities, 601
 employee's personal identity, 601–602
 employee's records, 602–603
 invasion of privacy, 601–603
 misrepresentation and fraud, 603–605
 preemployment inquiries, 605
 publication, 596–597
 privilege, 597–604
 recommendations, 598–599
 warranties, 603–604
- Length:
 executive summary, 327
 report introduction, 334
 report text, 287–300
 reports and parts, 287–300
 resume and job application letters, 513
 sentences and paragraphs, 50
- Letters:
 acceptance of job, 195
 adjustment, 187
 AMS simplified, 168
 appearance of, 157–168
 application (*See* Application, letter of)
 appreciation, 196
 attention line, 164
 basic organization plans (*see* Direct plan of organization; Indirect plan of organization)
 body of, 163
 business, 157–168
 claims, 258
 complaint, 258
 complimentary close, 163
 condolence, 196
 congratulations, 196
 "covering," 515–522
 credit approval, 191
 definition of, 157
 design of, 157–163
 editor, letters to, 131
 endings (*see* Closing paragraphs)
 envelopes, 157
 full-block style, 168
 job application, 540–552
 inside address, 158
 layout and styles, 168
 modified block, 168
 notion, 165
 copy, 167
 enclosures, 165
 file, 167
 mail, 167
 postscript, 167
 openings (*see* Opening paragraphs)
 optional parts, 164
 parts of, 160–168
 placement tips, 168
 punctuation in, 167
 recommendation, 183, 262–265
 reference, 167
 reports, 305
 resale, 226
 resignation, 547–548
 resume cover letter, 515–522
 sales (*see* Sales letters)
 sales promotion, 226
 signature, 163
 subject line in, 165
 titles in, 162
- Letterhead, 157
- Levels of language, 57–58
- Libel, privilege as defense against, 597–598
- Listening, 399–404
 checklist, 404
 faults of, 400–401
 purposes of, 402–403
 results of good listening, 403–404
- Mailboxes, E-mail, 122
- Mail notations, 167
- Man words, 55–57
- Managing information within organizations, 118
- Manuscript-reading speaking, 389–390
- Margins:
 letters, 167
 memos, 174
 reports, 335–336
- Market research, for jobs, 508–509
- Mechanics and style:
 abbreviations, 590
 connecting words, 580–581
 dangling participles, 579–580
 numbers, 590–592
 punctuation, 582–589
 trite words, 592–593
- Medium, 12–13
 oral, 13
 written, 13
- Meetings:
 leader in, 480
 agenda, 483
 authoritarian leadership, 480
 checklists for, 486, 487
 democratic leadership, 481
 follow-up after, 490
 leaderless leadership, 481
 planning before, 481
 procedures during, 486
 minutes of, 490
 participant in, 487
 preparation, 481
 roles, 487
 conciliator, 493
 critical tester, 492
 energizer, 492
 helper of others, 493
 idea creator, 492
 organizer, 491
 questioner, 491
 purposes and kinds of, 472
 informational, 472
 problem-solving, 474
 suggested-solution, 478
 solving problems in, 475
 background analysis, 476
 choice of action, 479
 committee authorization, 474
 solution discovery, 477
 solution evaluation, 478
- Memorandums (Memos):
 layout of, 174
 memorandum of request (MOR), 318
 parts of, 171
 subject line in, 172
- Memorizing a speech, 390
- Mental filter, 140
- Message:
 composing, 150
 designing, 140–152
 drafting, 150
 editing, 151
 organizing, 142–145
 preparing effective, 141–152
 analyze audience, 140
 choose ideas, 141
 collect data, 142
 identify purpose, 140
 organize message, 142
 proofreading, 151
 revising, 151
- Message receiver (decoder):
 checklist, 454
 importance of, 12
 in interpersonal communication, 447–450
- Message sender (encoder), 12
- Messages:
 goodwill, 195
 unfavorable, 212–247
- Minutes of meetings, 490
- Misrepresentations and fraud, 603–605
- MLA (Modern Language Association), 329, 603–605
- Modified-block style of letter, 168
- National Business Employment Weekly, 7
- Negative ideas, words, factors:
 in credit grants, 42–43
 in letters, 53–54

- Negative replies (*see* Replies)
- Negotiating, 552–556
 - basic issues in, 554–556
 - checklist, 555
 - preparation for, 553–554
- Neutral messages, 197–200
- News:
 - checklist for, 130
 - hard, 128
 - media, 128
 - newsworthiness, 129
 - press kit, 130
 - press releases, 129
 - soft, 128
- “No comment” attitude, 132
- Nondiscriminatory expressions, 55–57
- Nonroutine requests (*see* Persuasive requests)
- Nonverbal communication, 21–26, 394–398
 - appearance, 23, 398
 - facial expressions, 24, 397–398
 - gestures, 24, 396–397
 - movement, 24, 395–396
 - posture, 24, 394–395
 - smell and touch, 25
 - silence, time, and space, 26
- Notation in letters, 165–167
- Numbers:
 - for concreteness, 44
 - as figures or words, 590–592
 - with visual aids, 324
- Offensive humor, 54, 55
- Opening paragraphs:
 - adjustment (claim) letters, 219
 - application letters, 517–522
 - bad-news messages, 214
 - cover letters to resumes, 517–522
 - direct requests, 249
 - letter reports, 306
 - persuasive requests, 254
 - resume, 515
- Opening section in cover letter to resume, 517–522
- Optional parts of letters, 164
- Oral communication (*see* Speaking)
- Oral presentations:
 - kinds of, 385–386
 - steps for preparing effective, 384–388
 - ways of delivery of, 389–390
 (*See also* Speaking)
- Order acknowledgment, 193
- Organization patterns:
 - chronological, 430
 - topical, 430
- Organization plans:
 - bad news, 213
 - direct requests, 249
 - good news, 181
 - indirect requests, 249
 - informative speeches, 426
 - letters and memos, 213–216
 - persuasive requests, 249
 - persuasive speeches, 426
 - reports, 282
 - resume, 509–515
 - resume/cover letter, 515–522
 - solving problems in meetings, 475
 (*See also* Direct plan of organization; Indirect plan of organization)
- Outlining, for reports, 282
- Pagination, in reports, 336–337
- PAL:
 - Porch, 426
- informative speaking, 426
- persuasive speaking, 426
- recommendation reports, 302
- reports, 302, 426
- Aim (purpose), 428
 - in informative speaking, 428
 - memos, 428
 - persuasive speaking, 428
 - reports, 302
- Layout, 428
 - informative speaking, 428
 - memos, 428
 - persuasive speaking, 428
 - reports, 302
- Paragraphs:
 - last, 147
 - main idea, for 50–52
 - middle, 148
 - opening (*see* Opening paragraphs)
 - unity, coherence, emphasis in, 150
- Paralanguage, 25
- Parallelism:
 - in headings, 285
 - in table of contents, 324
- Participant in meetings (*see* Meetings, participant in)
- Parts and layout:
 - inform/persuade speeches, 426–430
 - letters and memos, 157–170
 - report, checklist, 283
- Passive verbs, 45–46
- Penalizing, 235
- Perceptions of reality, 18–20
- Personal perceptions, 447–450
- Personal data in resume, 513–514
- Persuasive requests, 254–266
 - for favors, 195, 254
 - for job applications, 195
 - organizational plan for, 249
 - for products or services, 256
 - for requesting changes in policy, 260
 - for requesting credit, 259
 - in sales letters, 266
- Persuasive speaking, 385–386, 409–445
- Plagiarizing, 608–609
- Planning steps:
 - communicating effectively, 140
 - dictation, 462
 - group meetings, 475
 - oral presentation, 384–388
 - persuasive requests, 250, 251
 - reports, 318
 - written job presentation, 504
- Policy, changes in, 260
- Positive, pleasant facts, accenting, 42–43
- Positive words:
 - from employee to reference, 264
 - from employer to reference, 262
- Postal service requirements for addresses, 157–161
- Postscript, 167
- Preemployment inquiries, checklist, 606–607
- Preemployment interview questions, 536–538, 606–607
- Prefatory parts of reports, 318–328
- Press releases:
 - conferences, 130
 - editor, letters to, 131
 - interviews, 130
 - op-ed, 130
- Privacy, invasion of, 601–603
- Privilege as defense against libel, 597–599
- Problem-solving meetings, 474
- Product analysis, evaluating self, 504–507
- Progress reports, 291
- Proof, evidence:
 - informative speaking, 437
 - persuasive speaking, 437
 - sales letters, 268
- Proofreading, 151
- Proposals:
 - appendix in, 361
 - background in, 359
 - budget in, 360
 - chronology of, 369–370
 - draft contract in, 357
 - equipment and facilities in, 359
 - examples of, 371–375
 - executive summary in, 357
 - introduction in, 357–358
 - kinds of:
 - business, 356
 - research, 355–356
 - long, formal, 367–375
 - personnel in, 359
 - procedures in, 359
 - purposes of, 354–355
 - request for, 367–368
 - request for (RFP), checklist, 369
 - short, 361–367
 - table of contents in, 357
 - title page in, 357
 - U.S. government, 355–356, 370–371
 - writing style and appearance for, 375
- Punctuation, 582–589
- Questions:
 - answering:
 - in letters, 32–33
 - in reply to inquiry, 33
 - asked during job interview, 536–540
 - confrontational, 538–539
 - forms of support, 436
 - checklist, 440
 - fact, 421
 - value, 417
 - policy, 418
 - of interviewee, 455
 - of interviewer, 457
 - unfair preemployment, 539–540
 - types of, 437
- Reactions, to denotations, connotations, euphemisms, 18
- Reality, perception of, 18–19
- Recommendations:
 - adjustment, 187
 - on claims and complaints, 219
 - legal, 595–607
 - non-sales-related, 194, 218
 - writing, 183
- Recommendation letters, 183–185
- Recommendations in reference letters, 599–610
- Recommendations, legal concerns, 598–599
- Reference section in letters, 164
- References:
 - checklists, 332
 - and endnotes, 330–333
 - list of:
 - in reports, 329
 - in resumes, 514–515
 - requests to, 514–515
- Refusals:
 - claims and complaints, 219
 - of credit, 222, 223
 - of job offers, 548
- Rehearsing speech, 388

- Relationships:
 - functional, 450
 - types, 450
- Relevant material, 38–39
- Repetition for emphasis, 39–40
- Replies:
 - to requests, 182
 - unfavorable, 218
- Reports:
 - abstracts for, 324–328
 - appendix in, 333
 - authorized, 321–322
 - bibliography in, 329–330
 - checklist, analytical memo, 306
 - checklist, informational, 294
 - conclusion, 334
 - conference, 288
 - contents, table of, 324, 340
 - cover for, 319–320
 - documentation in, 329–333
 - executive summary, 324–328, 341
 - footnotes, 330–332
 - formal (*see* Formal report)
 - glossary, 333
 - headings, 282–284
 - index, 333
 - informational memo, 288
 - introduction in, 287
 - justification, 302
 - margins, 335–336
 - organization of, 302, 318
 - (*See also* Direct plan of organization; Indirect plan of organization)
 - outlining of, 284
 - pagination in, 336–337
 - parts and layout of, 318–333
 - periodic, 293
 - prefatory parts, checklist, 319
 - progress, 291
 - qualities of well-written, checklist, 283
 - recommendations in, 302
 - references in, 329–333
 - revising and proofreading, 334–337
 - short, 283–316
 - spacing, 335
 - subject line in, 286
 - title fly, 321
 - title, internal, 321, 338
 - transmittal with, 321–324, 339
 - types of, 288–310
 - typing, 335–337
 - visual aids in, 324
 - wording of title, 319–321
- Requests (*see* Direct requests; Granting requests; Persuasive requests)
- Resale, in bad news, 226
- Resignation from job, 548
- Responsibility:
 - legal, 185
 - in writing, 185
- Resume:
 - achievements, awards, service in, 513
 - checklists for, 514
 - cover letter to:
 - last paragraph, 524
 - middle paragraphs, 522–524
 - opening, 517–522
 - education in, 512
 - opening section of, 510–511
 - personal data in, 513–514
 - references, in 514–515
 - samples of, 516–520
 - work experience in, 512–513
- Revising and proofreading:
 - proposals, 375
 - reports, 334–337
- Sales letters:
 - proof in, 268–270
 - solicited, 266
 - unsolicited, 267
 - regaining lost customers, 267
 - suggestions for writing AIDA plans, 250
- Salutations:
 - in letters, 162
 - in resume letters, 162
- Sentences:
 - average length, 50
 - coherence in, 50–51
 - emphasis in, 51–52
 - main idea, 51–52
 - unity in, 50
- Services, announcing good/bad news about, 222
- Seven C's, 32–60
- Short, familiar words for clarity, 48–50
- Short reports:
 - analytical letter, 305
 - analytical memo, 295
 - justification-recommendation, 302
 - informational memo, 288
 - conference, 288
 - periodic, 293
 - progress, 291
 - suggestions for, 282
- Signature area in letter, 163
- Slanted statements, 19
- Social accountability, 6
- Software, 126
- Solicited messages:
 - checklist in responding to, 205–207
 - favorable replies to inquiries, 182
- Solution meetings, 475
- Sources of information:
 - evidence, data, in speaking, 437
 - for jobs, 507–509
- Space, cultural concept of, 26, 83–84
- Spacing, of page numbers, 336–337
- Speaking:
 - informative, 385, 409
 - audience analysis in, 421
 - general, 409
 - kinds of, 414
 - organization of, 426
 - cause to effect, 430
 - chronological, 430
 - problem-solution, 432
 - topical, 430
 - purposes, 385–386, 409
 - specific, 409
 - support methods for, 438–440
 - analogies, 439
 - definitions, 439
 - examples, 438
 - illustrations, 438
 - questioning of, 440
 - quotations, 438
 - statistics, 438
 - supports, checklist, 440
 - delivery, methods of:
 - extemporaneous, 389
 - impromptu, 390
 - manuscript-reading, 384–390
 - memorization, 390
 - delivery:
 - checklists, nonverbal, 398
 - checklists, oral, 394
 - nonverbal behavior in:
 - checklist, 398
 - facial expression, 397–398
 - gestures, 396–397
 - movement, 394–396
 - posture, 394–395
 - visual aids for, 564–577
 - vocal behavior in:
 - checklist, 394
 - pitch, 391
 - pronunciation, 392–394
 - rate, 391
 - vocal quality, 392
 - volume, 392
 - (*See also* Oral presentations)
 - persuasive, 409–445
 - audience analysis in, 421–426
 - kinds of, 414–421
 - organization of, 426–431
 - purposes of, 409
 - support methods for, 436
 - analogies, 439
 - definitions, 439
 - examples, 438
 - illustrations, 438
 - questioning of, 480
 - quotations, 438
 - statistics, 438
- Spokesperson, company, 131
- Stage fright, control of, 398–399
 - checklist, stage fright, 401
- Statements, slanted, 19
- State, abbreviations for, 590
- Stationery for letters and memos, 157
- Style, abbreviations, 590
- Styles, of business letters, 168
 - and mechanics (*see* Mechanics and style)
- Subject line:
 - in letter reports, 308–310
 - in letters, 165
 - in memos, 172
 - in short reports, 286
 - verbs in, 173
- Substandard language, 58
- Summary (*see* Terminal section)
- Supplemental parts of report, 328–333
- Supports, evidence, data:
 - factual, 437
 - for informative speeches, 436
 - for persuasive speeches, 436
 - for resume letters, 515
- Symbols in marking letters, memos, reports, 27
- Sympathy, conveying, 196
- Synopsis, 324–328
- Table:
 - of contents, 324, 340
 - of tables, 324
- Tact in writing, 53–54
- Talk shows, radio, TV, 131
- Technical jargon, 49
- Technology:
 - business, summary of, 119
 - challenge of new, 120
- Technological developments:
 - defining, 120
 - understanding, 122
 - using, 121
- Teleconferences, 127
- Telegrams, 176

- Telephoning:
 international, checklist, 462
 message receiver, checklist, 463
 national, checklist, 463
 suggestions for, 462
- Telex, 176
- Terminal section:
 of letter or memorandum of transmittal, 323
 of report, 334
 of talk, 387-388
- Text, body:
 of report, 298
 of talk, 429
- Time savers:
 dictating, 462
 E-mail, 120, 175
 mailgrams, 176
 modern technology, 120
 telecommunications, 127
 telegrams, 176
 telexes, 176
 video conferences and videotapes, 127, 176
- Title:
 business and courtesy, in letters, 162
 wording of:
 in reports, 319-321, 338
 speeches, 409-413
- Title fly, 321
- Title page, 319-321, 338
- Tone:
 in adjustment granting messages, 188
 of message, 188
 of words, 53-56
- Transitional words and phrases, 580
- Transmittal letters and memos, 321-324, 339
- Transmittal with report, 321-324, 339
- Trite expressions, 37
- Types of reports, 288-310
- Unfavorable messages, 218-237
- Unity in sentences and paragraphs, 50
- Unsolicited messages, direct-request, 267-272
- Vague versus vivid or concrete words, 48-50
- Verbs:
 action, and present tense in, 45-46
 passive, 45-46
 skills expressed in, 512-513
- Video conferences and videotapes, 127, 176
- Visual aids:
 area graphs, 574
 bar graphs, 567-570
 checklist for, 577
 equipment for, 564
 graphic packages, 565
 line graphs, 573-574
 maps and other, 575-576
 microcomputer graphs, 565
 outline charts, 566
 pictograms, 574-575
 pie charts, 570-572
 in reports, 287
 in speeches, 564-577
 tables, 566-567
- Vita (*see* Resume)
- Voice in speaking, 390-394
- Voice mail, 125
- W's, five, 32-33
- Warranties, 603-604
- Words:
 for clarity, 48-50
 for conciseness, 36-38
 correct usage of, 57-60
 formal, 57-58
 informal, 57-58
 irritating, 54
 nondiscriminatory, 55-56
 often confused, 59-60
 positive, 42-43
 specific instead of general, 43
 tactful, 53-54
 transitional, 580
 trite, 37
 verbs, 45-46
 vivid, 46-47
- Wordy expressions, 36-38
- Work experience:
 in cover letter to resume, 523
 in resumes, 512-513
- You and consideration, 40-41
- You attitude, 40-41



Irwin/McGraw-Hill

A Division of The McGraw-Hill Companies

ISBN 0-07-114507-9



9 780071 145077

90000



KN-848-329